



**THE OXUS SOCIETY FOR
CENTRAL ASIAN AFFAIRS**



THE ARMED FORCES OF CENTRAL ASIA

CHAPTER IV: UZBEKISTAN

VERSION 2.2



IV: UZBEKISTAN

About the Authors:

Michael Hilliard:

Director of Defence and Security Analysis for the Oxus Society for Central Asian Affairs

Michael S. Coffey:

Assistant Professor of History and Political Science at the College of Southern Maryland

About the Editors:

Michael S. Coffey:

Assistant Professor of History and Political Science at the College of Southern Maryland

Mitchell Polman:

Independent Researcher and Political Analyst Specialising in Post-Soviet National Politics

Edward Lemon:

President of the Oxus Society for Central Asian Affairs

Graphics and Illustrations by:

Michael Hilliard:

Director of Defence and Security Analysis for the Oxus Society for Central Asian Affairs

Publisher:

*The Oxus Society for Central Asian Affairs
2039 New Hampshire Ave NW, #306
Washington, DC
20009-3414 United States
michaelhilliard@theoxussociety.org*



About the Oxus Society for Central Asian Affairs:

The Oxus Society for Central Asian Affairs, a DC-based nonprofit organisation, is dedicated to fostering academic exchange between Central Asia and the global community. The Oxus Society compiles original datasets and develops analytical tools to enhance understanding of the latest developments in the region. Furthermore, it organises events for scholars and the public, provides resources for educators and researchers, and conducts workshops focused on research ethics, methods, data analysis, and publishing for researchers working on Central Asia.

Major Partners of the Project:



Forecast International:

The Most Reliable Source for Aerospace & Defence Market Forecasting and Analysis.



Military Periscope:

Developed by the United States Naval Institute in 1986, Military Periscope has become the world's easiest-to-use, most up-to-date, open-source military database.

Special Thanks To:

- *Carnegie Endowment for International Peace*
- *Center for Strategic & International Studies*
- *Central Eurasian Studies Society*
- *The Diplomat*
- *The George Washington University*
- *The International Institute for Strategic Studies*
- *Janes Information Services*
- *The Journal of Slavic Military Studies*
- *Nazarbayev University*
- *Organisation for Security and Cooperation in Europe*
- *Radio Free Europe/Radio Liberty*
- *The Red Line*
- *Turan University*
- *United States Institute of Peace*
- *University of Southern California*

Additional Thanks To:

- Adam Kalyniuk
- Anna Jordanova
- Ben Dalton
- Bruce Pannier
- Catherine Putz
- Daniel Darling
- Derek Bisaccio
- Edward Lemon
- Eric Rudenshiold
- Francisco Olmos
- Franz J. Marty
- Joanna Lillis
- Juan Carlos Pastor Gómez
- Matthew Stein
- Michael S. Coffey
- Mitchell Ploman
- Nick Thompson
- Raffaello Pantucci
- Richard Wietz
- Slavomir Horik
- Steve Swerdlow
- Wilder Alejandro Sanchez
- Zhanibek Arynov

Several other names have also been omitted from the acknowledgements section of this report, at the request of the contributors, either due to confidentiality concerns or to ensure the safety of family and friends still residing in some of the countries discussed in this report. We also extend our sincere gratitude to these contributors and researchers for their valuable input and efforts.

The following is a single chapter of a wider report examining the Armed Forces of Central Asia, with each chapter examining one of the five Central Asian states. For access to the full interactive maps or the accompanying miniseries, links and information are available in the appendices of this chapter.

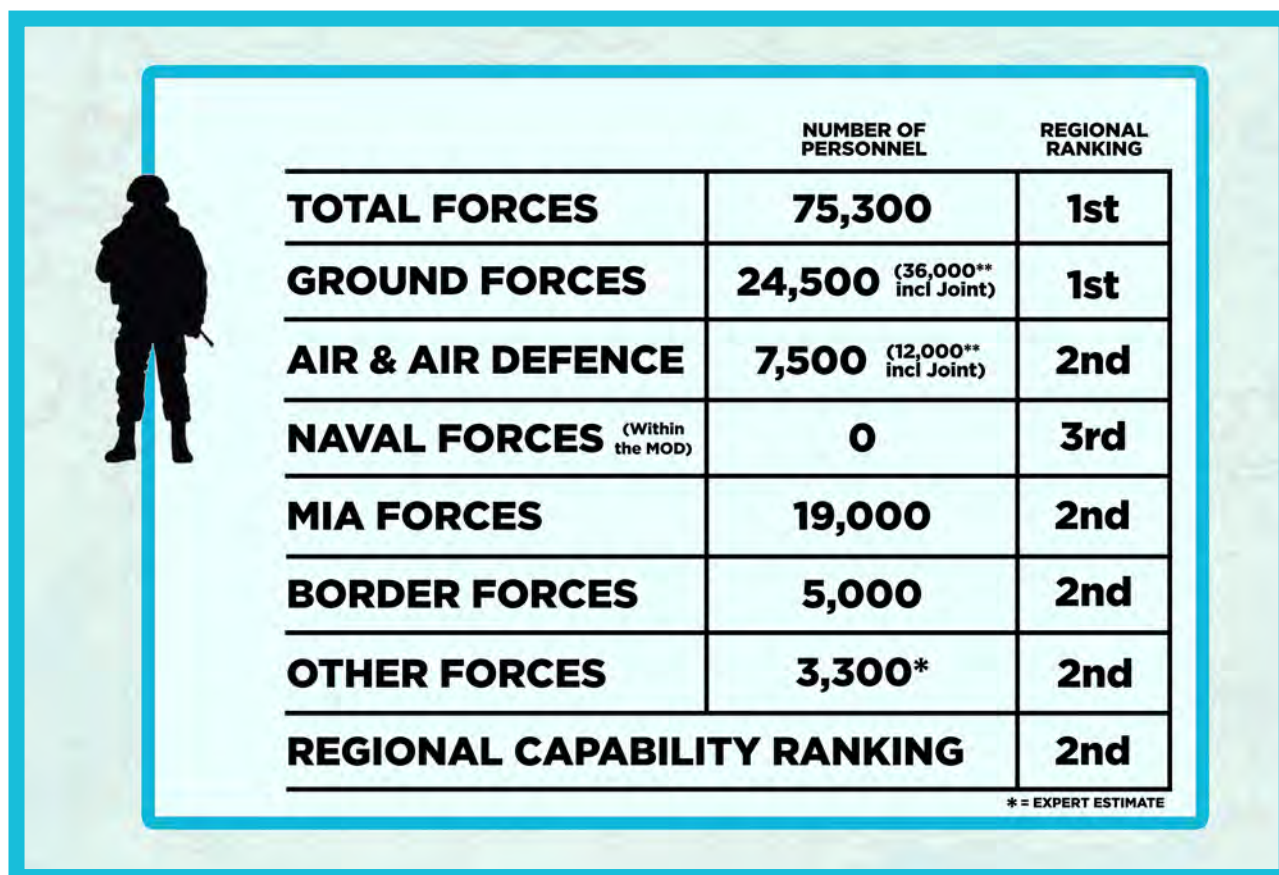
CONTENTS

CHAPTER IV. UZBEKISTAN

4.1: OVERVIEW	334
4.2: SHAPING THE DEFENCE DOCTRINE	338
4.2.1: <i>Independence and the Rise of Karimov (1989 - 2005)</i>	338
4.2.2: <i>Lessons Learned at Andijan (2005)</i>	339
4.2.3: <i>External Concerns, Past and Present (1992 - 2024)</i>	342
4.3: THE COMMAND STRUCTURE	346
4.3.1: <i>Overall Command Structure</i>	346
4.3.2: <i>The President</i>	346
4.3.3: <i>National Security Council</i>	347
4.3.4: <i>Cabinet Level Leadership</i>	348
4.4: THE GROUND FORCES	351
4.4.1: <i>Military Districts and Commands</i>	352
4.4.2: <i>Equipment and Unit Types</i>	360
4.4.3: <i>Unit Modernisation</i>	364
4.4.4: <i>Weaknesses</i>	365
4.5: THE AIR AND AIR DEFENCE FORCES	367
4.5.1: <i>Operational Capacity</i>	368
4.5.2: <i>Command and Branch Structure</i>	371
4.5.3: <i>Unit Modernisation</i>	371
4.5.4: <i>Weaknesses</i>	373
4.6: PARAMILITARY AND SPECIAL FORCES	376
4.6.1: <i>National Guard</i>	377
4.6.2: <i>Presidential Security Service</i>	378
4.6.3: <i>Internal Troops</i>	379
4.6.4: <i>Frontier Service</i>	380
4.7: PROCUREMENT AND DEFENCE BUDGETS	382
4.7.1: <i>Defence Budgets and the Economy</i>	383
4.7.2: <i>Procurement Preferences</i>	389
4.7.3: <i>Vehicles and Ordnance Procurement</i>	390
4.7.4: <i>Aircraft and Air Defence Procurement</i>	390
4.8: ALLIANCES AND FOREIGN DEPLOYMENTS	391
4.8.1: <i>Alliances and Partnerships</i>	392
4.8.2: <i>Foreign Deployments by Uzbekistan</i>	395
4.8.3: <i>Foreign Deployments into Uzbekistan</i>	395

4.9: POTENTIAL FLASHPOINTS	396
<i>4.9.1: Islamic State Incursion into Southern Uzbekistan</i>	<i>396</i>
<i>4.9.2: An Uzbek Invasion of Tajikistan</i>	<i>413</i>
4.10: CONCLUSION	443
4.11: USEFUL MAPS AND CHARTS	444
 APPENDIX:	 797
SECTION 1: GLOSSARY	798
SECTION 2: SYMBOLOGY	812
SECTION 3: MAP GUIDE	831
SECTION 4: WARGAME OUTCOME SCALE	836
SECTION 5: REFERENCES	839

4.1: OVERVIEW



(Figure 4.1.1: Overview chart of Uzbekistan's force totals. The above rankings provide a comparative evaluation of the number of personnel in each branch of the Uzbek military relative to the personnel in the corresponding branches of other Central Asian states; overall, this positions Uzbekistan in 2nd place in the region, only behind Kazakhstan)

With a population exceeding 34 million, Uzbekistan holds an important geographical and political role within Central Asia. Uzbekistan not only borders all of the other Central Asian nations, but also accounts for approximately 50 per cent of the region's total population. Historically, Uzbekistan has positioned itself as the primary military power within the region, boasting the largest military budget and the most substantial standing army. However, at present, Uzbekistan now appears to be retreating from this position, arguably slipping into second place in total force numbers and ranking second or third in technological and strategic innovation, with Kazakhstan surpassing Uzbekistan in several key military categories. While this retreat by Uzbekistan can be partly attributed to Kazakhstan's recent armament efforts, it can also be partly blamed on Tashkent's repeated military spending cutbacks and budgetary erosion, as its currency continues to lose ground in terms of purchasing power. Military capability projections not only indicate that this gap between Tashkent and Astana is only set to widen, but also suggest Kazakhstan is likely to overtake Uzbekistan in absolute military spending within the next few years. In such an event, Tashkent will be forced to navigate shifting power dynamics against a backdrop of increasingly complex regional geopolitics, while also possessing a declining military budget that will only compound the growing security threats.



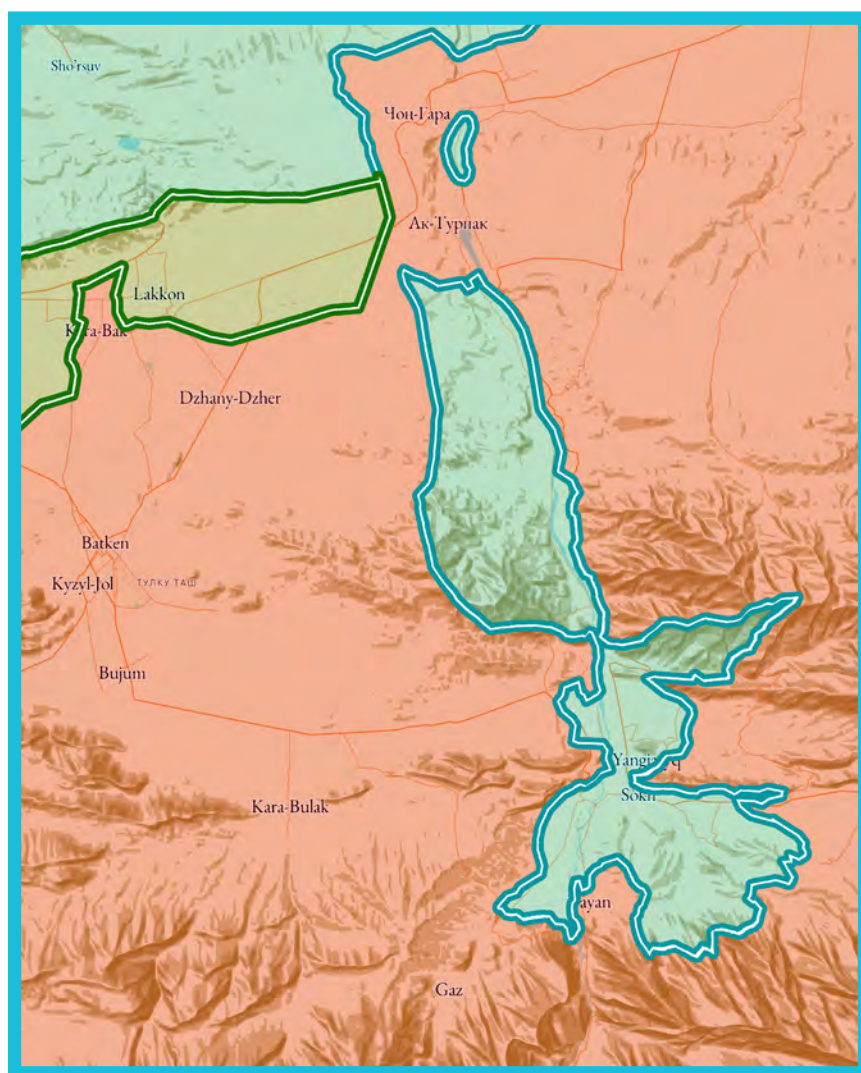
(Figure 4.1.2: Political map of Uzbekistan (cyan) and its surrounding states)

The strategic challenges faced by Uzbekistan often ultimately stem from its geography, so much so, that should Uzbekistan find itself in a conflict with any of its neighbours, its borders, terrain, and chokepoints will serve to significantly complicate operations, rather than aid in the national defence, even before considering the country's issues surrounding logistics, finances, and command and control (C2) structures. It is also because of Uzbekistan's varied terrain and climates that Tashkent is forced to maintain a much more versatile military, capable of functioning across a diverse range of environments. Tashkent has to maintain an armed force capable of not only operating in the vast desert expanses of the western regions, but also the tight, jagged mountain passes and valleys of the east, as well as the rolling rocky foothills and plains of the south.

However, Uzbekistan faces additional challenges beyond geography, particularly in its easternmost territories within the Fergana Valley. As unlike most countries, where valleys and mountain chains often provide easily delineable and defensible national boundaries, the officially recognised borders of the Fergana Valley often do not follow natural geographic features, instead appearing as a hotch-potch of poorly delineated markers and signposts. This not only results in frequent border disputes among the region's various ethnic groups, but also perpetuates a constant level of political uncertainty for Tashkent regarding the region's ethnic and political stability.

*(Figure 4.1.3:
A political map of
the Fergana Valley,
with Uzbekistan
(cyan), Kyrgyzstan
(red), and Tajikistan
(green) and their
interlocking
geography)*





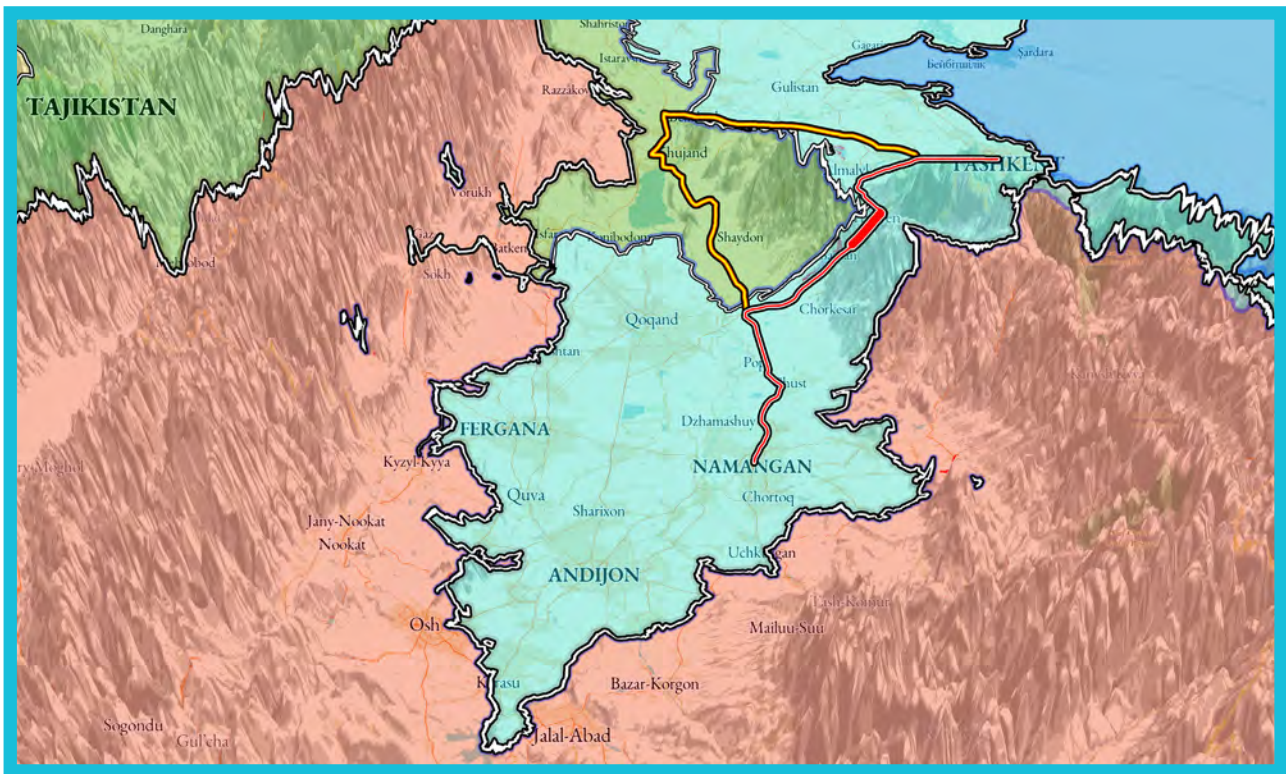
As an example of just how confusing these borders can be, the Sokh exclave, depicted in Figure 4.1.4, is administered and recognised as a territory of Uzbekistan despite being entirely surrounded by Kyrgyzstan and populated predominantly by ethnic Tajiks.

However, these politically charged land issues and precarious situations are just part of the problem for Tashkent. As although the valley comprises only a tiny percentage of Uzbekistan's total land area, it contains 30 per cent of the country's total population, the majority of its arable farmland, and the primary trade routes connecting Tashkent and the West of the country to places like Osh and Isfara.

The Fergana Valley is essential to Uzbekistan for financial, political, and strategic reasons. However, to Tashkent's detriment, the valley is almost entirely geographically isolated from the rest of the country by the imposing Qurama Mountains.

(Figure 4.1.4: Map of the Uzbek Sokh exclave in eastern Uzbekistan, with Uzbek territory (cyan), Tajik territory (green), and Kyrgyz territory (red) depicted; also visible is Uzbekistan's small Chon-Gara exclave just to the north of Sokh)

The Qurama Mountains form a natural barrier, isolating the Fergana Valley from Tashkent and the rest of Uzbekistan's landmass, creating a significant divide that has helped shape Uzbekistan's modern security and defence doctrine. This separation underscores the critical importance Uzbekistan's military has placed on maintaining the security of the Kamchiq Pass, as before the expansion of this pass, Tashkent's alternate route into the valley detoured south around the mountain chain, passing through what is now Tajikistan for part of the journey. While this route was unproblematic during the Soviet era, post-independence, it posed a significant strategic vulnerability for Tashkent. As without control of the Kamchiq Pass, Tashkent would likely be forced to rely upon the goodwill of Dushanbe to be able to unilaterally maintain its land connection with the rest of the Uzbek population within the valley. So as to avoid becoming too reliant on Dushanbe, over the decades, Uzbekistan has invested significant military and political effort into maintaining guaranteed control over this crucial mountain pass.



(Figure 4.1.5: A political and topographic map illustrating the two major routes connecting the capital Tashkent to Namangan, the largest Uzbek city within the Fergana Valley. The map shows Uzbekistan (cyan), Kazakhstan (blue), Kyrgyzstan (red) and Tajikistan (green). As illustrated in the diagram, if Uzbekistan loses access to the Kamchiq Pass (the thick red line), the alternate route requires travelling to the southern end of the mountains and then transiting through Tajik territory (the yellow line), detouring through Khujand and Konibodom)

However, despite Tashkent's anxiety around the pass, most regional defence experts would argue that the likelihood of a conventional military invasion by one of Uzbekistan's neighbours towards this region still remains incredibly low. As at present, most of the Central Asian states lack the desire and the ability to carry out such an expeditionary operation, and all of these states currently benefit far more from the increased goods and services transiting in and out of the valley than they would from any sort of conflict aimed at adjusting borders. Instead, the genuine concern for Uzbek policymakers appears to be increasingly driven by non-traditional security challenges, such as internal unrest, religious extremism, narcotics trafficking, and organised crime-related activities.

In particular, religious extremist groups appear to be the primary concern for Uzbek defence policy. In the past, groups like the Islamic Movement of Uzbekistan (IMU) caused significant security concerns for the Uzbek government, as during the 1990s, the IMU rapidly expanded its militant activities throughout Uzbekistan, notably culminating in a series of bombings across Tashkent in 1999, multiple different Islamic groups subsequently using the valley to engage in a prolonged campaign of kidnappings, attacks, and calls for violence against the administration throughout the following years. Today, it could be said that these concerns around religious extremism, as well as fear of movements pushing for regional separatism in the valley, have resulted in most of Tashkent's domestic military attention now being focused toward just three areas of the country: the capital, the southern border area with Afghanistan, and the entirety of the Fergana Valley.

4.2: SHAPING THE DEFENCE DOCTRINE

Uzbekistan's modern strategic thinking and defence doctrine have been primarily shaped by a handful of key historical events. Undoubtedly, other external factors have also played a role in shaping the views of Tashkent's leadership, but this analysis will focus on a small selection of key turning points. These events include the breakup of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) and the establishment of the modern Uzbek army; the uprisings in Andijan and the government's disastrous response; the emergence of transnational threats like the IMU, and then later the Islamic State Khorasan Province (ISKP); and, the emergence of renewed border tensions that the remote Soviet leadership could no longer resolve. This section will provide an overview of how these events have shaped Uzbekistan's modern defence doctrine:

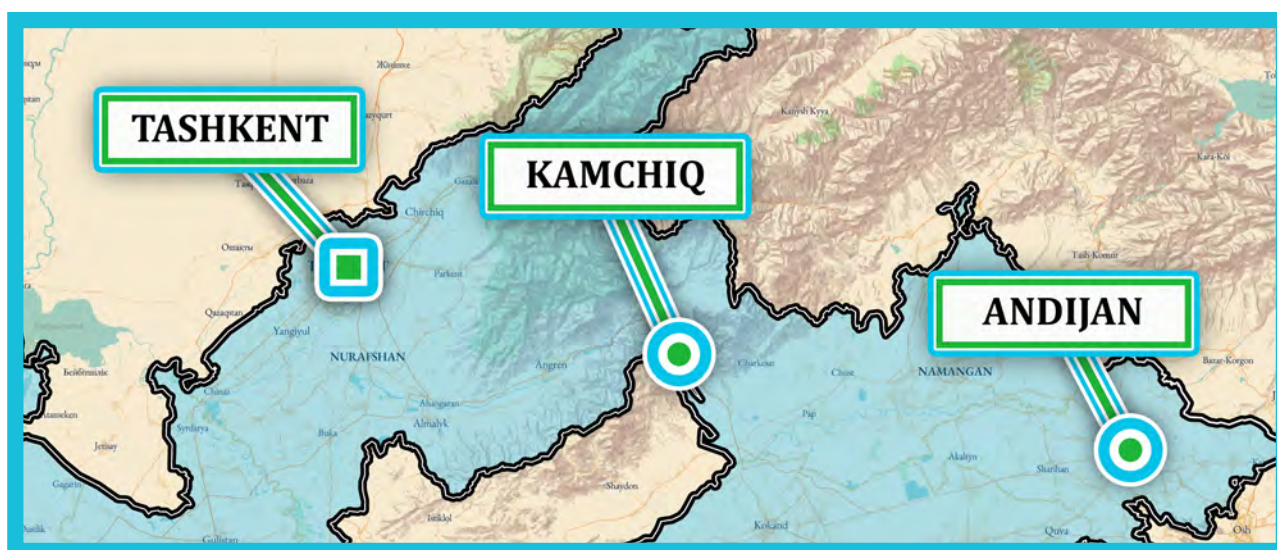
4.2.1 - Independence and the Rise of Karimov (1989 - 2005)

During the rule of USSR General Secretary Leonid Brezhnev (1964 - 1982), Moscow adopted a policy towards the Central Asian republics that prioritised national stability and governmental continuity, regardless of the impact on individual citizens. As a result, Moscow placed its support behind Sharaf Rashidov, who served as the first secretary of the Communist Party of Uzbekistan from 1959 to 1983. Under Rashidov, the country witnessed significant economic and political consolidation, as well as the formalisation of many of the institutional structures that hold up the Uzbek state today. Rashidov used his time in office to become increasingly powerful within the republic, often forming personal patronage networks through the reallocation and diversion of substantial state resources. As a result, Rashidov was able to purchase the loyalty of various factions and maintain his dominance over both the Samarkand clan and the republic's political landscape throughout his 24-year tenure.

By the time of Rashidov's death in 1983, Uzbekistan's national leadership had become undeniably corrupt, even by Soviet standards, with much of the nation's industry now serving to generate personal slush funds for the political actors favoured by Rashidov. However, with the corruption now becoming so overt, public discontent towards the administration also began to grow. So, in an effort to address the growing domestic dissatisfaction, Moscow attempted to curb the cronyism in the Uzbek SSR by appointing the comparatively technocratic Inomjon Usmonxo'jayev, and then later, Rafiq Nishonov, to oversee the republic. However, both leaders' credibility would be severely undercut by the Samarkand clan's networks that still effectively controlled most of the levers of power, even after Rashidov's death, and the system never truly underwent the desired reforms. So when Islam Karimov, a fellow member of the Samarkand clan, became First Secretary of the Communist Party of Uzbekistan in 1989, he was able to quickly wield the entrenched and interwoven patronage networks created years earlier by Rashidov. With these powers, Karimov would reverse much of the insufficient decentralisation efforts that Usmonxo'jayev and Nishonov had attempted to introduce during their terms and instead Karimov's next significant consolidation of power occurred after Uzbekistan gained independence, during the drafting of the 1992 Uzbek Constitution. While overseeing the drafting of the constitution, Karimov would shape the new republic's system of government in a way that served to not only legitimise the

president's supremacy over the executive, legislative, and judicial branches, but also significantly strengthened the nation's security apparatus, granting it widespread and nearly unrestricted powers across the state, and in exchange for granting these services such powers, Karimov demanded these agencies' complete loyalty. For many, this period ushered in an era of pervasive fear within Uzbekistan, where anyone opposing Karimov quickly became a target of the security services. With these services now also being equipped with broad powers that exceeded even those of the KGB (the Committee for State Security) during the USSR, Karimov and the executive branch were able to collude together to weaken any alternative centres of power within the country, including unaligned military commanders, oligarchs, and regional elites, resulting in Karimov ruling the country until his passing in 2016. As a side effect of this prioritisation of the security services though, the traditional armed forces received much less attention and funding during these early years of Karimov's presidency, with large portions of the nation's defence resources, elite troops, and equipment being redirected towards domestic law enforcement agencies and maintaining internal control. These decisions resulted in Karimov placing minimal emphasis on the upkeep of an operationally capable air fleet, a robust rapid response force, or any diversified mobile units, a decision that would later prove highly problematic just a few years later.

4.2.2 - Lessons Learned at Andijan (2005)

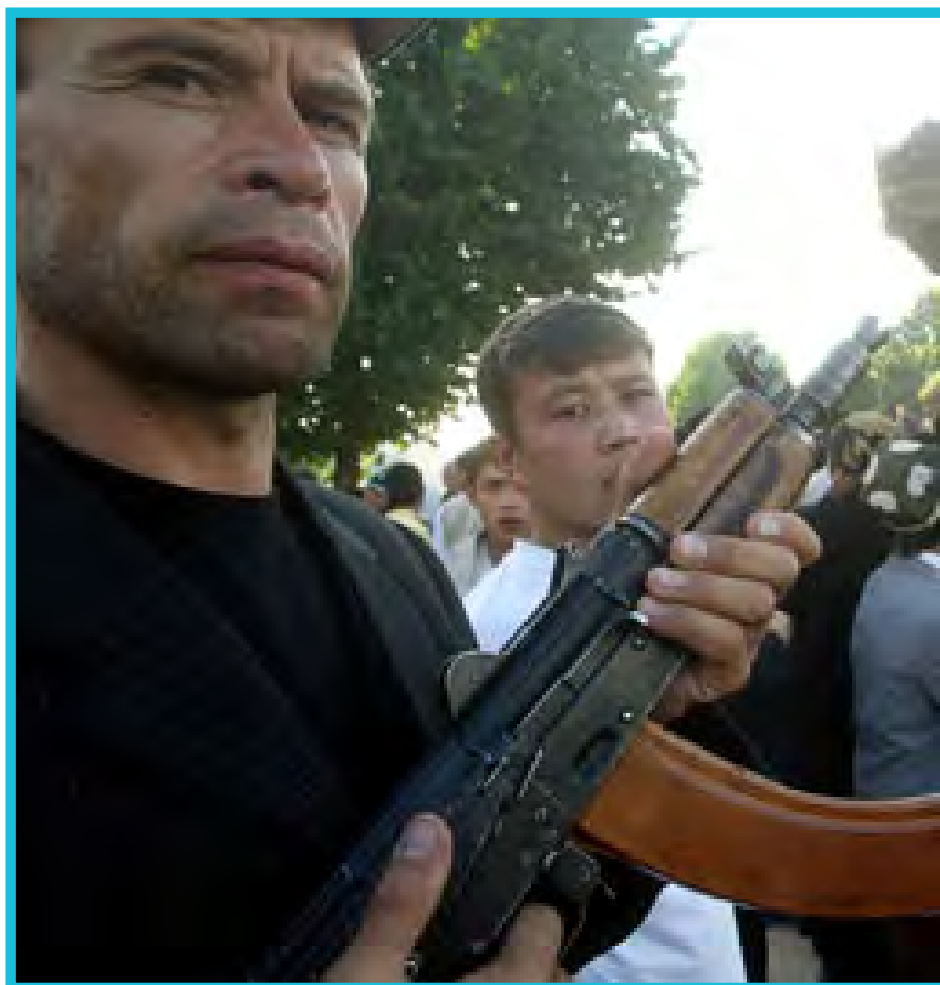


(Figure 4.2.1: Map of eastern Uzbekistan (cyan) highlighting the locations of the capital Tashkent, the Kamchiq Pass, and the eastern city of Andijan)

Leading up to the Andijan riots of 2005, Uzbekistan faced growing discontent among various segments of its population, particularly from those residing within the Fergana Valley. Where, following IMU attacks on Tashkent in 1999, Karimov, along with his key ally and head of the National Security Service, Rustam Inoyatov, initiated a series of heavyhanded and repressive measures throughout the valley. By 2005, these actions had contributed to widespread poverty, high unemployment, and a significant rollback in civil and religious liberties throughout the region, all of which exacerbated the local population's animosity towards the central government. This resentment towards Tashkent would subsequently reach a boiling point when the security services in Andijan arrested 23 local businessmen without substantial evidence in June of 2004, dismissively accusing them of Islamic extremism.

In response, a group of armed locals launched a reprisal attack on the Ministry of Internal Affairs (MIA) administration building in Andijan, swiftly overwhelming and capturing both the building and its law enforcement personnel. Surprised by the success of their initial attack, the protesters then expanded their objectives, now moving to capture the nearby base of the Uzbek 34th Motor Rifle Brigade (MRB), with the protesters managing to catch most of the soldiers inside by surprise, overwhelming and occupying the military facility. With the base now under their control, the protestors pressed their luck further, seizing the garrison's weapons and ammunition, and distributing the arms to local citizens sympathetic to their cause.

Buoyed by the lack of immediate government response, the insurgents expanded their uprising by taking control of several local administration buildings, including the liberation of the Andijan prison. Upon capturing the penitentiary, the protesters would release around 500 of its inmates, many of whom would join the growing revolt, further increasing the protestor's momentum. By the early morning of May 13th, all of these actions then culminated in the capture of the oblast (province) administration centre and the taking of 38 government hostages. These now well-armed protesters had successfully taken over a major Uzbek city in a very short period of time, only encountering minimal resistance from the low-morale and disorganised local garrisons. While the protesters' tactical boldness undoubtedly contributed to the rapid fall of the city, the local garrison's poor defence and communications were likely the main cause of the government's collapse, with the government's shortfalls being exacerbated by Tashkent's continuous reprioritisation of defence funding away from the Ground Forces and towards the security services.



*(Figure 4.2.2:
Protesters in
downtown Andijan.
Source: Committee
to Protect
Journalists)*

Consequently, the underfunded garrisons within the city were primarily prepared for individual civilian arrests rather than engaging in firefights against numerous adversaries or heavily armed insurgents. This debacle made the regional government appear weak in the eyes of the public, subsequently prompting many more citizens of Andijan to feel emboldened enough to join the protesters and allowing the events to spiral well out of control. The entire incident was incredibly embarrassing for the Uzbek administration, with Karimov reportedly furious at the series of failures that allowed protesters to seize control of an entire city within just a few hours. In response, Karimov ordered a heavy crackdown on the protesters, directing the army to gather up weapons and move to recapture the city. However, the neglected and decrepit state of the armed forces meant it took far longer for them to mobilise and reach the city than Tashkent had anticipated, with every additional hour of delay only further emboldening the protesters. Eventually though, government troops would arrive in force, with Tashkent mobilising 12,500 military servicemen for the recapture of Andijan.

These forces entered the city equipped with heavy weaponry and armoured vehicles, establishing a perimeter around the central square where the protesters had gathered. Token attempts at negotiations were made, but the military soon unleashed indiscriminate gunfire into the densely packed crowds of protesters, resulting in significant civilian casualties. As the crowds began to flee from the square, government forces continued to deploy tear gas and live ammunition to eliminate any remaining local resistance and regain control of the city. In the ensuing chaos, many protesters attempted to escape the area but reportedly found themselves pursued and punished by security troops. While the precise number of casualties remains disputed, testimony from Ikrom Yakubov, a former major in the Uzbek National Security Service, suggests that the death toll could even exceed 1,500, almost all of which would have occurred within the first few hours of the government crackdown. The domestic fallout from the Andijan events led to heightened repression and a severe clampdown on civil liberties throughout the country, with Uzbekistan soon attaining the lowest freedom score of any nation in the region. From Tashkent's perspective though, the Andijan incident represented a significant and worrisome threat to the stability of the Karimov government, instilling concern among senior administration members that they might not survive a second such uprising. These fears prompted Karimov to implement significant defence reforms, hoping to ensure that such a situation would never occur again. These reforms included actions like abolishing the Ministry of Internal Affairs' Internal Troops and redistributing their functions between the Ministry of Defence and the National Security Service (although the Internal Troops were later reinstated under the MIA after Karimov's death). Additionally, there was also a significant bolstering of Uzbekistan's rapid-response, air assault, and special forces troops, particularly among units stationed within the Fergana Valley, aiming to ensure a much quicker response next time.

Tashkent would also restructure C2 chains, bringing a portion of the Ground Forces troops stationed within the valley now under the direct control of either the Tashkent Operational Command or the Fergana-based Mobile forces command. After 2005, the Uzbek armed forces also began conducting frequent exercises simulating a rapid mobilisation and redeployment into the valley, aiming to improve on the previously sluggish deployment times seen during the Andijan events, and as a result, today, Uzbek troops can often arrive in the valley from Tashkent or elsewhere in under half the time it took the Ground Forces in 2005. The initial belated response by security and armed forces highlighted significant deficiencies in mobility and responsiveness within the Uzbek defence apparatus, and in such, prompted Tashkent to undertake substantial strategic reevaluations, many of which now form the basis of the Uzbek armed forces' contemporary doctrine, command structure, and modern deployment patterns.

4.2.3 - External Concerns, Past and Present (1992 - 2024)

Despite formally characterising its military doctrine as fundamentally defensive, Uzbekistan has historically demonstrated the capacity and willingness to deploy military forces beyond its own borders in certain circumstances. The general aversion to expeditionary deployments likely stems from the fact that Tashkent has consistently viewed its principal strategic security threats as internal uprisings or revolutions rather than any conventional invasion by a foreign power. However, evolving regional threats along Uzbekistan's borders have occasionally necessitated a more serious consideration of and response to external security problems.

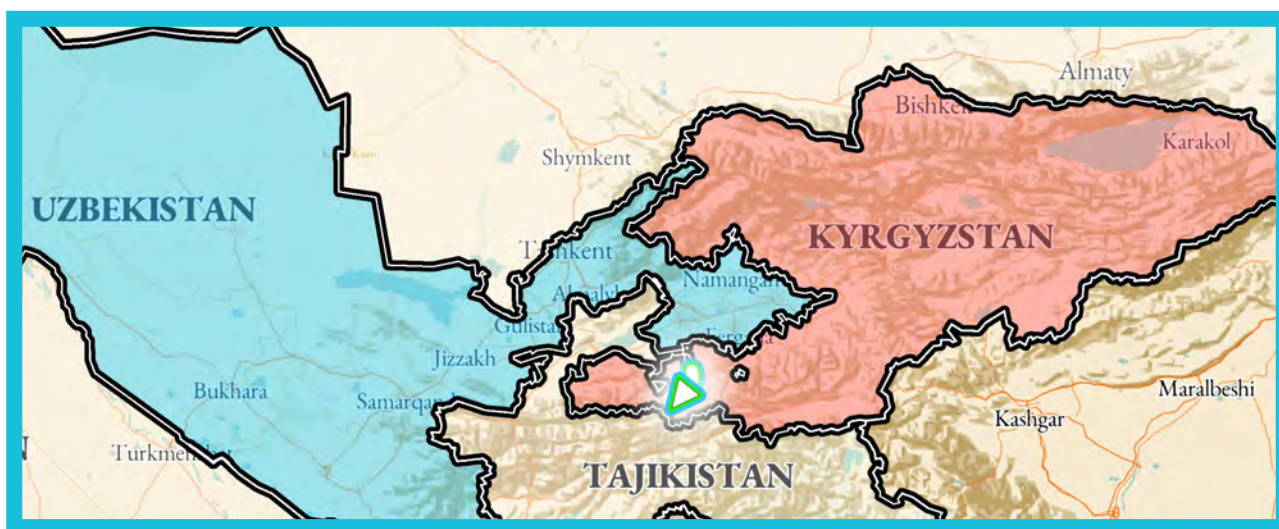
To date, there have been only a handful of occasions when Tashkent has been willing to use force beyond its borders, the most notable being its intervention during the Tajik Civil War (1992 - 1997). The decision to intervene in the conflict was primarily driven by the fact that Islamic militant groups were leading the opposition forces, with the groups aiming to establish a more religiously inclined government in Dushanbe. Actors in Tashkent were concerned that a successful overthrow of the government in Tajikistan might then inspire groups with similar ideologies in Uzbekistan to attempt the same. In response, Uzbekistan, along with Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Russia, intervened in the civil war on behalf of the Dushanbe government. Tashkent, more than the other Central Asian republics, played a key role in supporting Dushanbe's campaign, including providing air support, supplies, and logistical assistance to the beleaguered government forces.



(Figure 4.2.3: Regional map illustrating the main thrusts of Uzbekistan's (cyan) intervention into Tajikistan (green) during the Tajik Civil War)

However, as soon as Dushanbe's position in the war appeared stable, Uzbekistan promptly scaled down its support for the war, leaving Russia to assume the role of Dushanbe's primary security guarantor throughout the remainder of the conflict. For the subsequent decade, Tashkent would essentially abstain from involving itself in any other regional conflicts or military affairs until 2010, when Uzbekistan launched a rare cross-border incursion from its exclave of Sokh into the southern Batken region of Kyrgyzstan.

During a period of escalating ethnic violence between Kyrgyz and Uzbek communities in 2010, Tashkent greenlit a brief intervention by Uzbek forces into southern Kyrgyzstan. The stated aim of this incursion was to stabilise the region and protect the ethnic Uzbek population from further atrocities, as there had been widespread violence against Uzbeks occurring in cities like Osh. Upon stabilising the situation though, Uzbek soldiers quickly withdrew back into Uzbek territory, and both governments actively worked to end the hostilities and avoid further escalation. Despite the limited scale of this action, it did signal to other regional actors that Uzbekistan was once again willing to employ its military power in the region, for political or security purposes, something it had not done throughout the entirety of the previous decade.



(Figure 4.2.4: Regional map illustrating the rough location of Uzbekistan's intervention into the southern Kyrgyz oblast of Batken)

Overall, these two interventions are outliers in what has predominantly been a relatively peaceful era for Uzbekistan. Even today, the current administration in Tashkent consistently prioritises policies of peaceful engagement and mutually beneficial regional cooperation as the way forward for the country. However, this does not mean that Uzbekistan lacks tensions or concerns regarding the states it shares borders with. As an example, to the southwest, there are some concerns in Tashkent about the long-term stability of the Turkmen government, with Tashkent closely monitoring the situation in preparation for any possible instability or refugee crises spilling over into southern Uzbekistan should that government collapse.



(Figure 4.2.5: Regional map illustrating a hypothetical route for Turkmen refugees fleeing into Uzbekistan)

To the north, Tashkent is closely watching Kazakhstan's rapid growth in military capabilities, with Astana now appearing to overtake Uzbekistan to become the leading military power in Central Asia. While relations are cooperative now, any future deterioration could pose a significant strategic risk to Uzbekistan's regional influence.



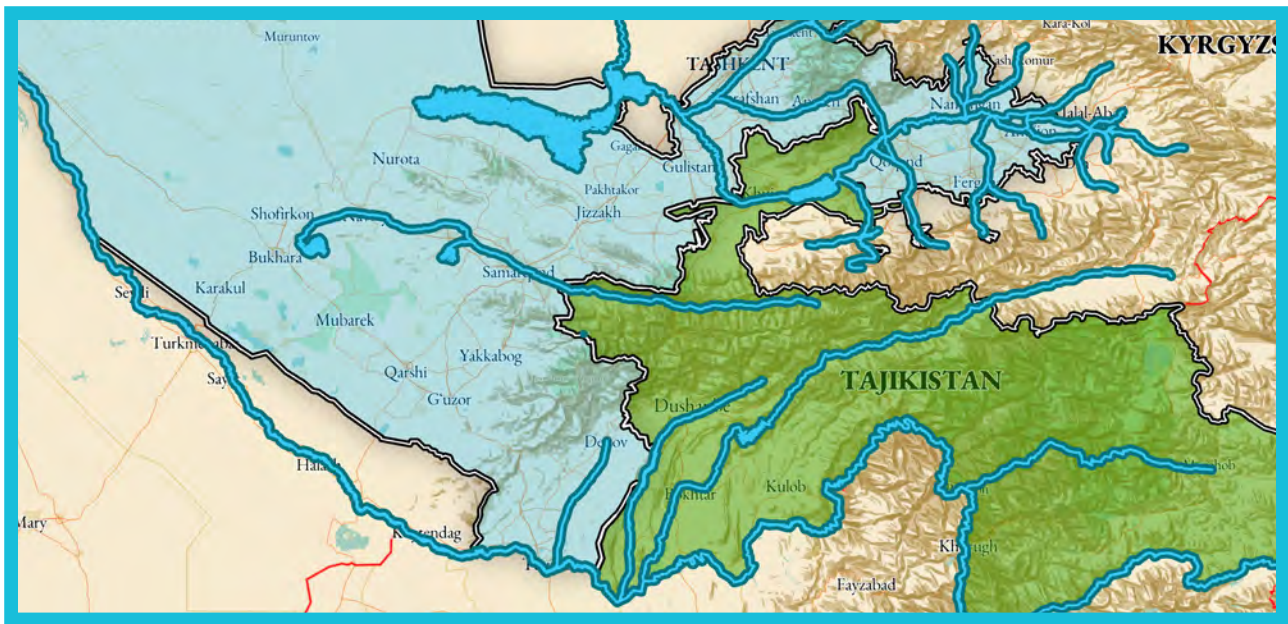
(Figure 4.2.6: Regional map illustrating a hypothetical invasion route for Kazakh (blue) forces sortieing into Uzbekistan (cyan))

To the east, Kyrgyzstan is also undergoing a substantial rearmament phase, with its defence spending as a percentage of GDP now even surpassing Uzbekistan's. The concern here is that, although the Kyrgyz military remains relatively small compared to Uzbekistan's, they may no longer be the strategic pushovers they once were, likely causing some unease among the Uzbek garrison commanders stationed inside Uzbek exclaves surrounded by Kyrgyzstan.



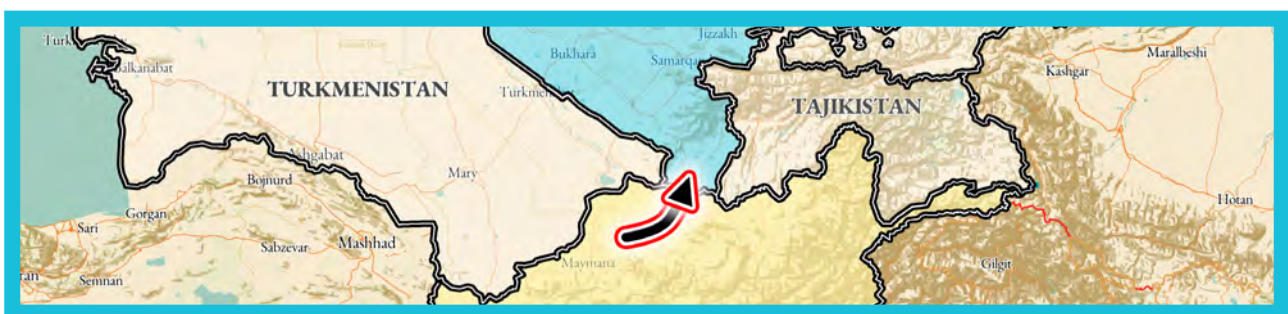
(Figure 4.2.7: Regional map illustrating a hypothetical invasion route for Kyrgyz forces invading Sokh)

To the southeast, Tajikistan remains a concern for Uzbekistan for two primary reasons. The first being that a large portion of Uzbekistan's water resources originates in Tajik territory, creating a strategic vulnerability should relations between the two deteriorate, and in a worst-case scenario, Tajikistan could potentially use its dams to restrict the flow of water downstream to Uzbek cotton fields. This issue has been a longstanding point of contention between the two countries, with past tensions escalating to the point where Uzbekistan threatened military action over proposed infrastructure projects in Tajikistan. While these concerns have somewhat diminished post-Karimov, currently, both sides appear to be cooperating on these water issues, with Uzbekistan providing gas and electricity subsidies to Tajikistan in exchange for a steady water supply into Uzbekistan. However, Tashkent remains concerned that this cooperation is contingent on there being an adequate water flow to satisfy both nations' needs, with some policymakers expressing concern that if water volumes in Tajikistan were to decrease to a point where there isn't enough to supply both countries, that Dushanbe would prioritise its own domestic needs, and Tashkent may need to potentially reconsider military options to assure downstream water flows.



(Figure 4.2.8: Map of the major cross-border river systems (blue) that feed into the Syr Darya and Amu Darya river systems between Uzbekistan (cyan) and Tajikistan (green))

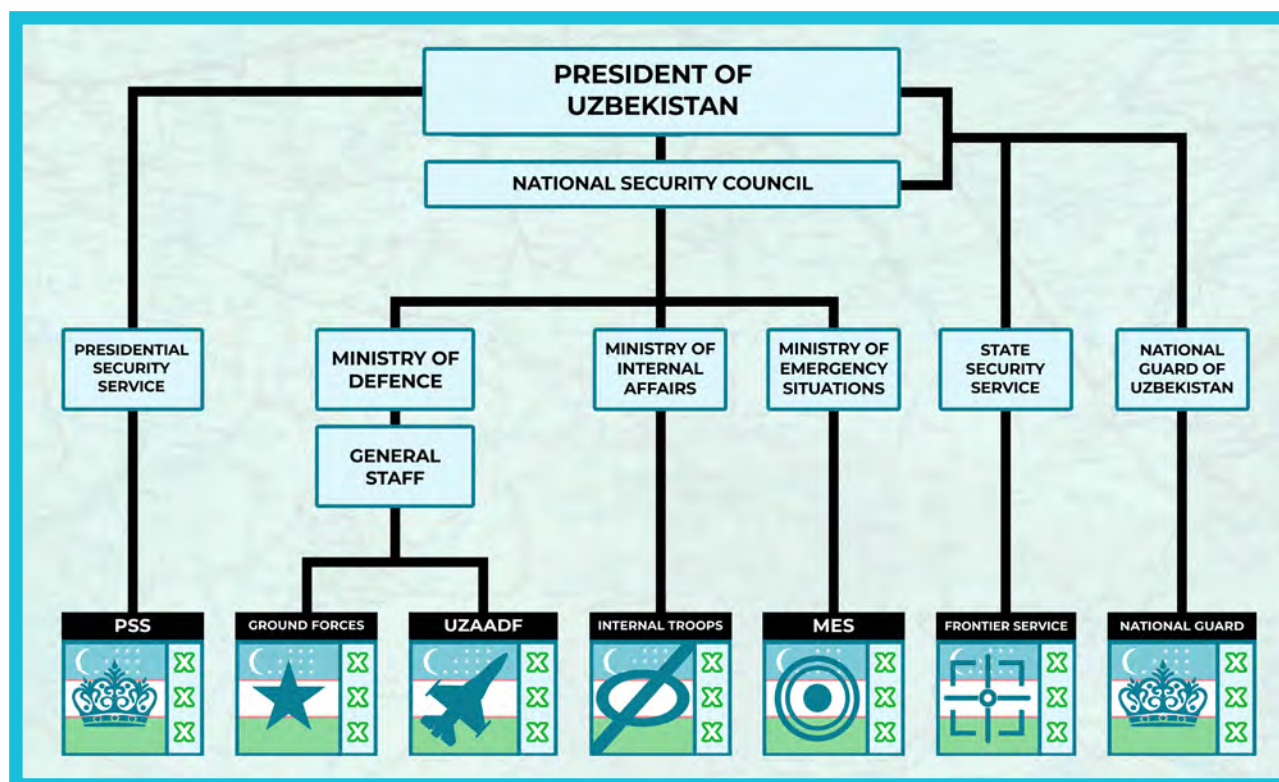
The second external issue concerning Uzbekistan, emanates from its 144 km border with Afghanistan, consisting of barbed wire, watchtowers, and a heavily patrolled security zone to prevent unauthorised crossings. In recent years the border has also been further reinforced by a multi-layered defence system, including landmines in certain areas and electronic surveillance, reflecting Tashkent's long-standing concerns over smuggling, terrorism, and instability from northern Afghanistan. At present, Kabul presents little conventional threat to Tashkent, but the threat of terrorism and Islamic extremism is a significant concern for planners in Tashkent. As in recent years, Uzbekistan has seen an increase in the scale and intensity of violent attacks from groups like IS and ISKP, with the groups even launching rockets into southern Uzbekistan as recently as 2022. With ISKP and ideologically similar groups also regularly calling for the overthrow of the administration, there are concerns that if left unchecked, these efforts against Tashkent may continue to intensify.



(Figure 4.2.9: Regional map illustrating the area of Uzbekistan that recently came under fire from ISKP rockets launched from Afghanistan)

Considering Tashkent's concerns about regional separatism in the Fergana Valley, the recent uprisings in the autonomous republic of Karakalpakstan in the west, growing inequality in several peripheral regions, and various emerging economic crises, it is clear that Tashkent's defensive strategy must be prepared to counter both internal and external threats.

4.3: THE COMMAND STRUCTURE



(Figure 4.3.1: Organisational flowchart outlining the formal structure of Uzbekistan's military chain of command)

4.3.1 - Overall Command Structure

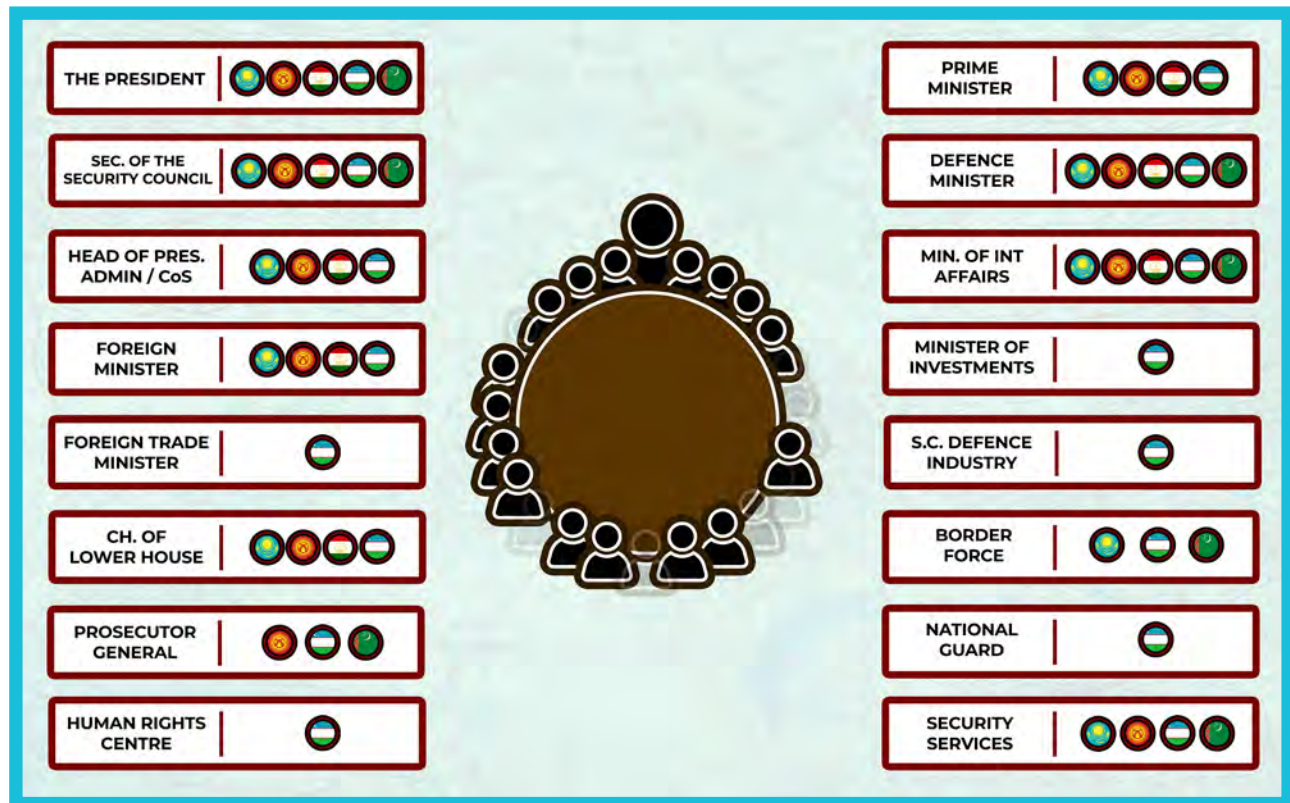
While Uzbekistan's chain of command is similar to other Central Asian military structures, it also has some unique characteristics that reveal a great deal about the current administration's internal priorities and alliances. However, particularly at the top of the command chain, a significant amount of authority is still centralised under the president's purview, a structure established under the Karimov administration.

4.3.2 - The President

The president of Uzbekistan holds a highly centralised role within the national command structure, particularly following Karimov's reforms of the 1990s. As commander-in-chief of the armed forces, the president not only oversees all military operations and strategic defence initiatives but also appoints most key figures in the defence, security, and law enforcement sectors. These appointments include a number of key positions such as the heads of the State Security Service, the secretary of the National Security Council, and the prosecutor general.

Additionally, the president has the sole authority to unilaterally alter national foreign policy, impose a state of emergency, or even declare war, with no official impeachment or veto mechanism in place to prevent these actions. However, even though the president is not strictly required to do so, he does consult with and receive advice from the National Security Council before making final decisions on defence and security matters.

4.3.3 - The Security Council Under the President



(Figure 4.3.2: A chart illustrating which Uzbek government officials currently hold seats on the country's Security Council, alongside a comparative breakdown of which equivalent roles are granted seats on the national security councils of the four other Central Asian states)

The Security Council Under the President (NSC) under the president of Uzbekistan, functions as the highest defence and security advisory body to both the president and the nation. While all five Central Asian republics maintain similar security councils, Uzbekistan's NSC stands out as the largest in the region, with unique inclusions like the foreign trade minister, the head of the National Human Rights Centre, and the minister of investments. While all of these positions are arguably crucial to national defence, they are excluded from any of the other regional counterparts' councils. The NSC's core membership consists primarily of high-ranking civilian officials, including the president, prime minister, head of the Uzbek legislature (the Oliy Majlis), the prosecutor general, and the ministers of foreign affairs, internal affairs and foreign trade and investments. It also includes several committee chiefs, such as the heads of the State Committee for Defence Industry, the National Human Rights Centre, and the Committee for State Border Protection of the National Security Service. Notably, the only military officers permanently seated on the council are the commander of the National Guard and the head of the Presidential State Security Service, as the role of defence minister is sometimes held by a civilian or a member of the security services.

NSC meetings are generally held quarterly, with extraordinary sessions convened upon requirement. Decisions made by the council are usually reached behind closed doors, before then being formalised through presidential orders, and then subsequently carried out by the various ministries. As with all security councils in Central Asia, the Uzbek NSC affords the president the final say on all decisions, so while the NSC can directly issue orders to the ministries, committees, and armed forces, it can only offer suggestions to the president.

4.3.4 - Cabinet Level Leadership

Once directives are approved by the NSC and ratified by the president, they are then conveyed to each relevant ministry, committee, or department of the Uzbek military for execution. While the Uzbek armed forces provide assistance and collaborate with a range of national departments and committees, the core national military structure comprises the Ministry of Defence, the Ministry of Internal Affairs, the Ministry of Emergency Situations, and the State Security Service, with each of these entities jointly managing a variety of essential operations:

i) - The Ministry of Defence



The Ministry of Defence of the Republic of (EN:MOD/UZ:OMV/RU:MOU) oversees the administration and strategic direction of the majority of the Uzbek armed forces. While the MOD's primary responsibility is maintaining the armed forces and safeguarding the nation against strategic threats, it leaves the majority of the country's internal counterterrorism and law enforcement matters to other committees and ministries. In the Uzbek command structure, the MOD relays orders and directives from the NSC, allocates the necessary resources and funding to execute these directives, and then passes orders to the General Staff. While the MOD handles the

administration and transmission of strategic orders, the execution of those orders and the operations and tactics employed to achieve them, are wholly the responsibility of the General Staff and lower-level commanders.

(Figure 4.3.3: Emblem of the Ministry of Defence of the Republic of Uzbekistan)

ii) - The General Staff

The Uzbek General Staff (EN:UZGS/UZ:BSOR/RU:GSRU) which provides a central command structure for the Operational Commands, the Ground Forces, and the nation's Air and Air Defence Forces (UZAADF), is staffed with commanders from the various branches, while being led by the chief of the General Staff (COGS). The UZGS is responsible for all operational and strategic planning for these branches, with most of the high-level decisions and meetings held at the National Defence Management Centre in Tashkent. This structure, much in the same way it functioned during the Uzbek SSR, aims to reduce operational overlap.

iii) - The Ministry of Internal Affairs



The Ministry of Internal Affairs (*EN:MIA/UZ:IIV/RU:MVD*) primarily focuses on the domestic security of the country, integrating the nation's broader law enforcement agencies with its largest paramilitary force. The department is responsible for a wide range of activities, spanning traditional policing tasks and highway patrols, to guarding prisons, and targeted counterterrorism operations and maintaining public order during crises. In addition to overseeing most of the nation's law enforcement, the MIA also commands several specialised tactical units, as well as the Uzbek Internal Troops (UIT), a standing force of approximately 19,000.

(Figure 4.3.4: Emblem of the Ministry of Internal Affairs of the Republic of Uzbekistan)

iv) - The State Security Service (SSS)



The State Security Service (*EN:SSS/UZ:DXX/RU:SGB*) has historically been the most powerful intelligence and law enforcement entity in the country. While the agency has a broad spectrum of responsibilities, it primarily focuses on intelligence gathering, counterintelligence efforts, and conducting investigations for the administration's benefit. The chairman of the SSS wields significant power within the Uzbek state, being able to investigate and arrest almost any citizen of the country, and in practice, is only accountable to the president. While the agency is not as powerful as it once was, the SSS still oversees the country's primary intelligence apparatus, the nation's Frontier Service, and the Uzbek Riverine Flotilla.

From 1995 until his dismissal in January 2018, the SSS was led by Rustam Inoyatov, who accumulated considerable power and influence throughout his tenure. By the time of Inoyatov's removal, the agency had reportedly evolved into a formidable "state within a state", exerting a level of influence across all governmental spheres second only to the president, with Inoyatov's removal as chair of the SSS coming only after the death of his close ally, President Karimov. While several reasons are given for Inoyatov's dismissal, the most likely is that Mirziyoyev, upon beginning his presidency, was understandably concerned about the significant concentration of power within the SSS and wanted to reduce its influence and competition. He achieved this by removing Inoyatov and redistributing many of the SSS's forces and powers among other branches of the military. However, despite these reductions, the SSS retained the core of its original forces and continues to exert significant influence over the country's executive, legislative, and judicial branches. Even today, the agency still remains highly secretive about its day-to-day operations, with many in the country still viewing the organisation with the same fear and apprehension as before.

(Figure 4.3.5: Emblem of the State Security Service of the Republic of Uzbekistan)

v) - The Ministry of Emergency Situations (MES)



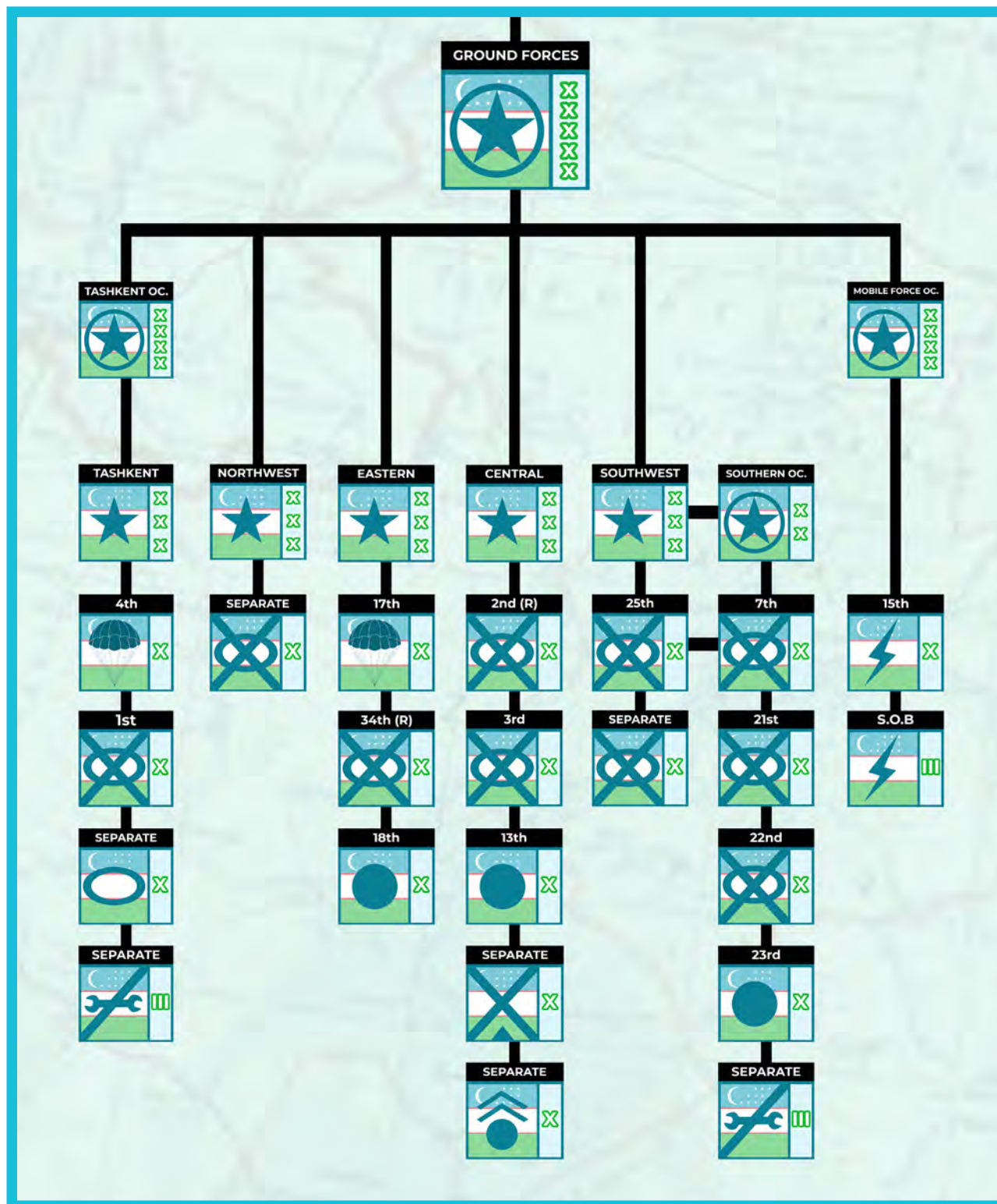
The Ministry of Emergency Situations (*EN:MES/UZ:FVV/RU:MCHS*) is also technically structured under the umbrella of the Uzbek military command, even though it does not field any offensive military forces and still relies on the MOD to supply most of its equipment. The ministry is tasked with managing and providing the initial response to various emergencies and natural disasters within the country. However, when crises escalate beyond the agency's permanent capacity, the ministry often seeks additional logistical and personnel support from other military bodies, such as the MOD and MIA.

(Figure 4.3.6: Emblem of the Ministry of Emergency Situations of the Republic of Uzbekistan)



(Figure 4.3.7: Uzbek Soldiers on parade in Tashkent, 2022. Source: Wikimedia Commons)

4.4: THE GROUND FORCES



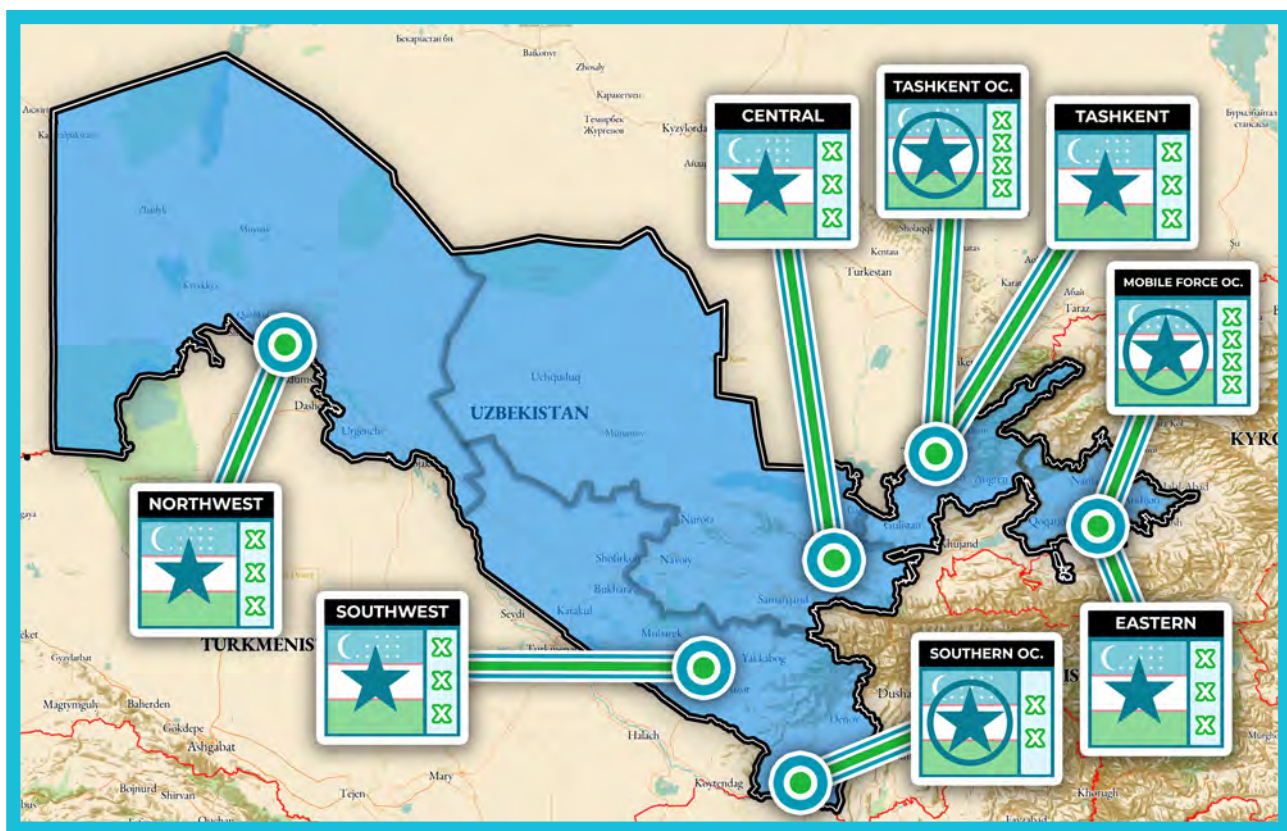
(Figure 4.4.1: Order of battle for the Uzbek Ground Forces)

Uzbekistan's Ground Forces, having initially inherited a Soviet-era force structure, equipment inventory, and doctrinal framework, have undertaken a deliberate modernisation and professionalisation initiative aimed at enhancing combat effectiveness and operational flexibility. The ongoing reforms emphasise force mobility, precision-strike capabilities, and the integration of modernised assets and technology into the Ground Forces functions.

4.4.1 - Military Districts and Commands

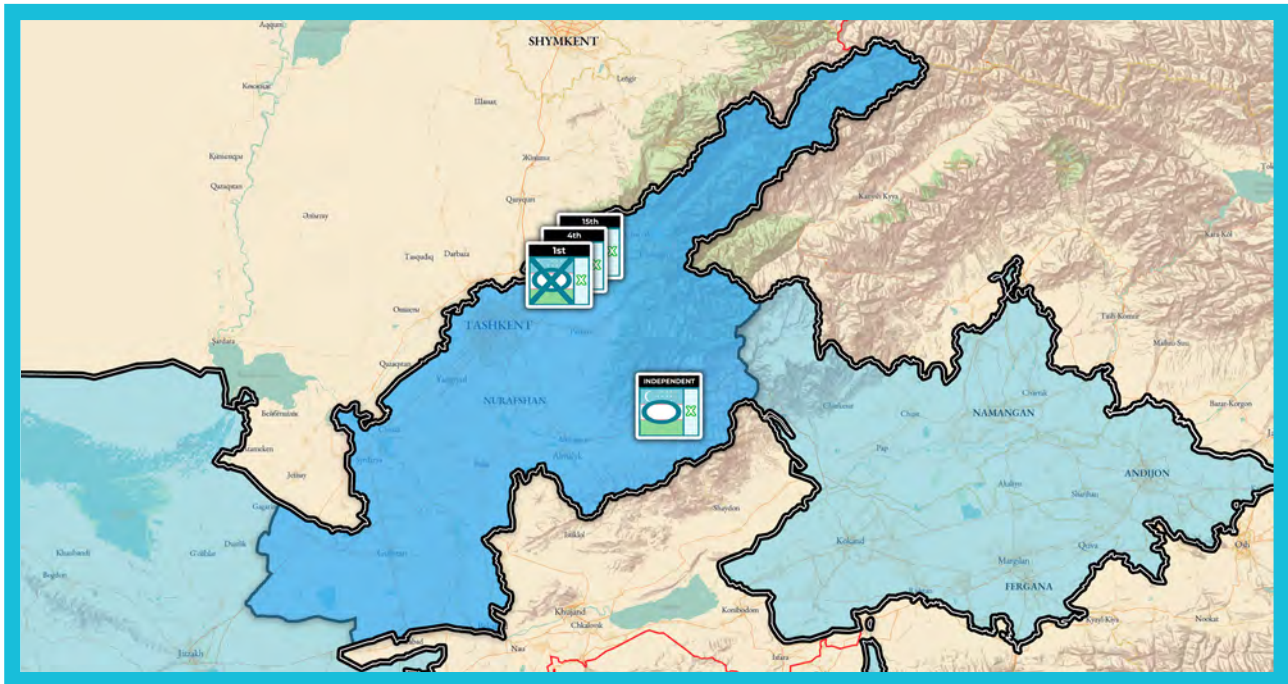
Uzbekistan's Ground Forces (UGF) operate under a three-tiered command structure, designed to enhance interoperability across multiple branches and security formations. At the highest level, the General Staff and various ministries exercise operational control over all regular units, special operations forces (SOF), and paramilitary formations.

The General Staff and relevant ministries being responsible for strategic oversight, force deployment, and overall operational control of all military and security units. Below this would be the Uzbek's Operational Commands (OCs) which, when required, can coordinate a select number of SOF units and specialised military formations stationed right across the country. The third tier being the Ground Forces Military Districts (MDs), which provide a more regionally focused approach to force management and deployment. Under the system, each of the UGF's Five Military Districts (MDs) has its own commander and staff, who oversee all Ground Forces operations within their respective geographic territories. These MD commanders, along with their Operational Command (OC) counterparts, then report directly to the National Joint Command Centre in Tashkent.

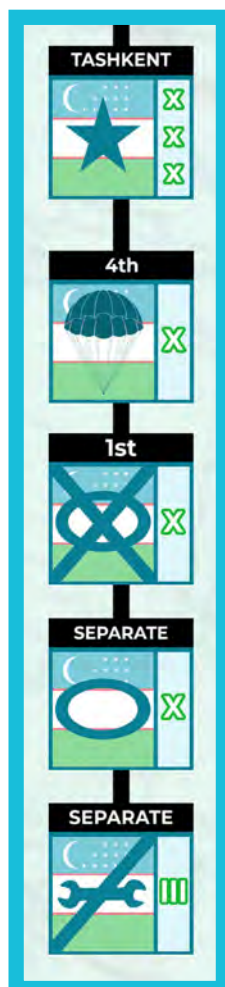


(Figure 4.4.2: Map illustrating the locations of the five military districts and three operational commands and the locations of their respective headquarters)

i) - Tashkent Operational Command



(Figure 4.4.3: A map of the Ground Forces units stationed within the Tashkent Operational Command; with the area covered by the Tashkent Military District highlighted in dark blue)



Headquarters: Tashkent

Operational command headquarters: Tashkent

Regions covered: Sirdaryo and Tashkent

Headquartered in Tashkent, the Tashkent Operational Command (TOC) exercises day-to-day control over all Ministry-of-Defence formations stationed in the Tashkent Military District, with the standing exception of units reassigned to the Mobile Forces Command. However, when a presidential mobilisation order is issued, the TOC also assumes control of all MIA and SSS detachments, creating a single, highly centralised headquarters for the capital's defence.

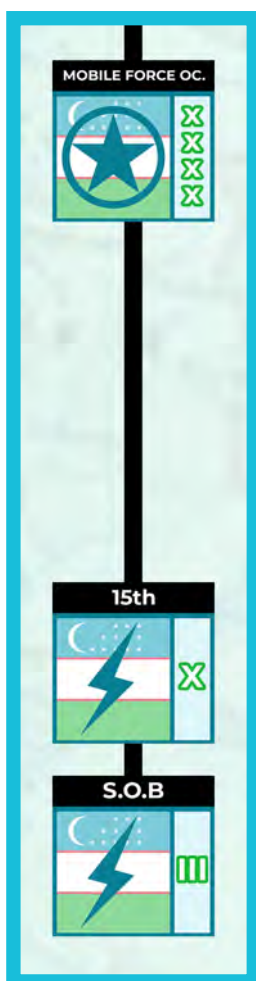
As a result, the district carries what is arguably the most sensitive mission set in the Uzbek command architecture, tasked with protecting the seat of government, securing most of the major crossing points into northern Tajikistan, and guarding the western approaches to the Kamchiq Tunnel. Although formally confined to just Tashkent and the two regions, the TOC's political weight and proximity to the General Staff allow it to arguably reach across service lines far more readily than any other military district, ensuring that, in a crisis, every available ground, air and internal-security element can be folded into one centrally directed defence of the capital.

(Figure 4.4.4: Order of battle for the Ground Forces of the TOC)

ii) - Mobile Forces Operational Command



(Figure 4.4.5: Map of the Mobile Forces Operational Command and its likely subordinate units)



Headquarters: Fergana

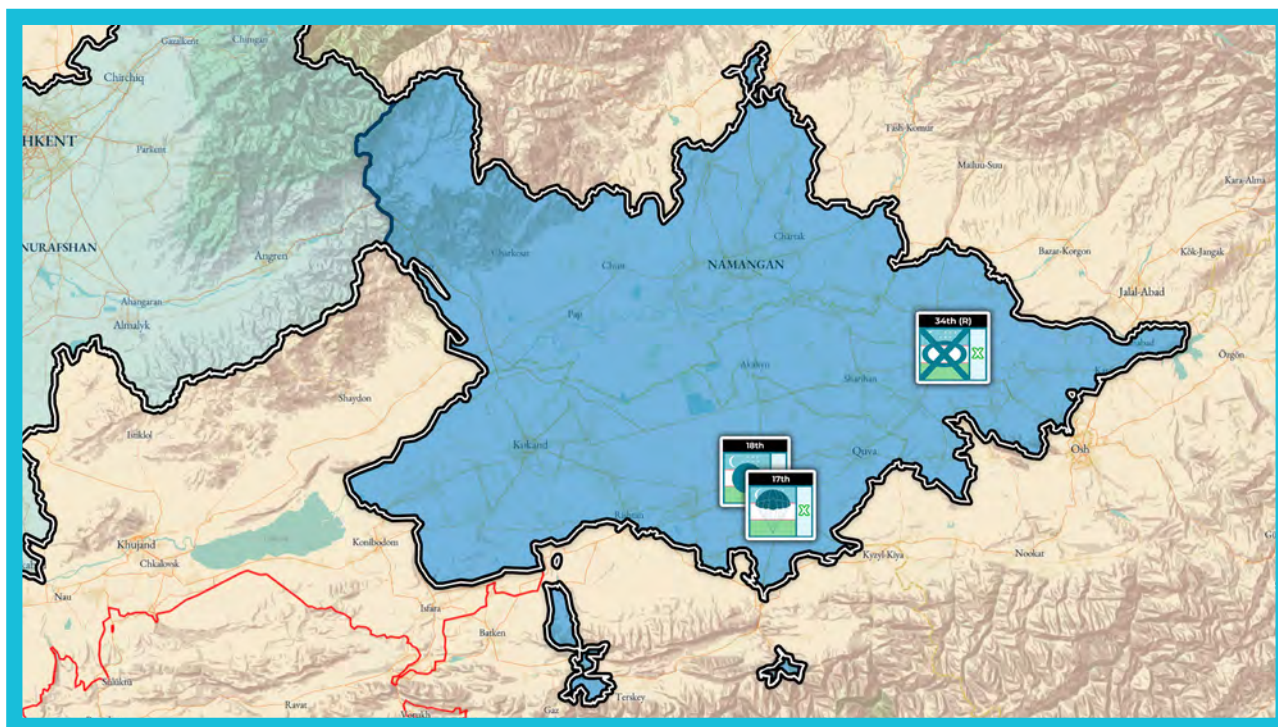
Regions covered: Uzbekistan, countrywide

Headquartered in Fergana, the Mobile Forces Operational Command (MFOC) permanently oversees a small cadre of specialised airborne and special-operations units, planning and directing missions that cut across the country's military-district boundaries. While day-to-day administrative control of these units still rests with their respective Military Districts, the MFOC retains operational authority. When ordered, it can assume command of its core SOF formations and additional paramilitary, air-assault, airborne and artillery elements, employing them as needed to fulfil tasks assigned by higher headquarters.

This arrangement reflects the MFOC's principal purpose as Uzbekistan's first-response headquarters, poised to counter border probes, quell large-scale unrest or reinforce threatened sectors at short notice. By pooling elite formations under a single, compartmentalised chain of command and drawing air-lift and fire-support assets from the wider force as required, the MFOC can mount a coherent, nationwide response to most scenarios within hours, cementing its reputation as the Republic's premier rapid-intervention arm.

(Figure 4.4.6: Order of battle for the Mobile Forces Operational Command)

iii) - Eastern Military District



(Figure 4.4.7: Map of the Eastern Military District and its subordinate units)



Headquarters: Fergana

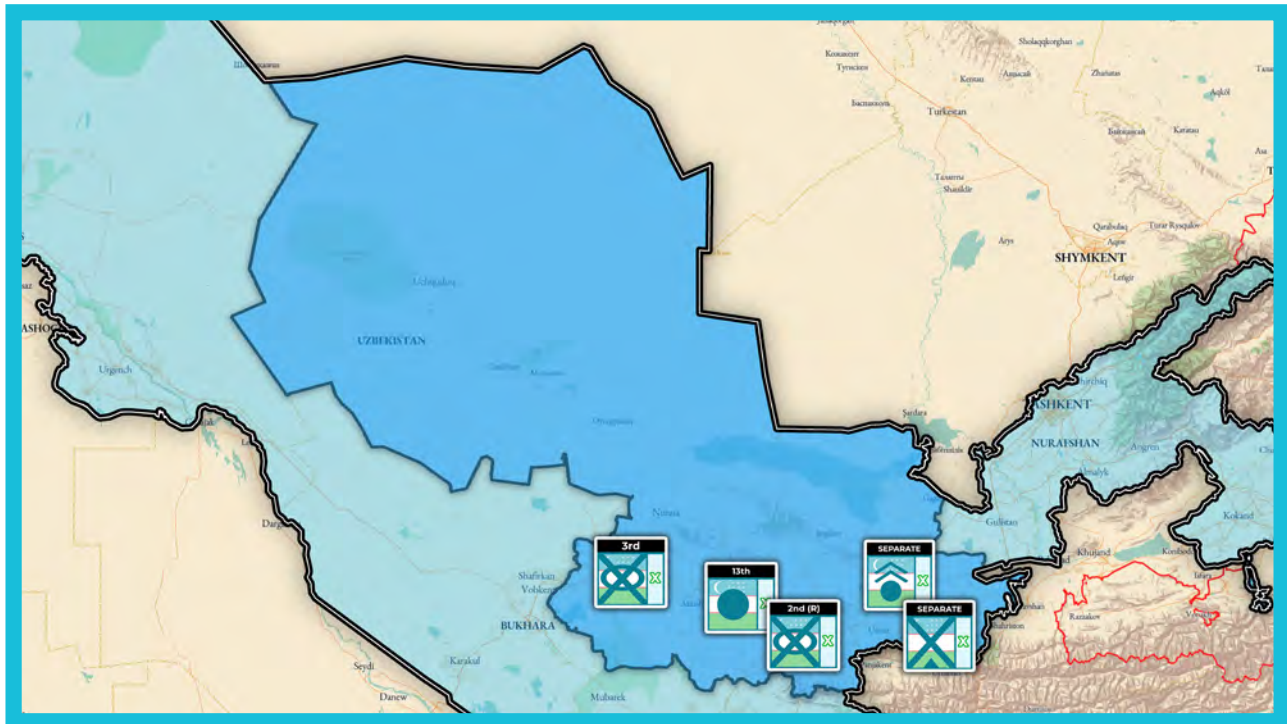
Regions covered: Andijan, Fergana, and Namangan

Headquartered in Fergana, the Eastern Military District is responsible for the entire Uzbek stretch of the Fergana Valley, from the eastern approaches to the Kamchiq Pass through to the Sokh and Shokhimardon exclaves encircled by Kyrgyz territory. Despite the strategic importance of this area, the district's command exercises full control over only a handful of units, with most troops in the valley reporting to either the MIA, the SSS, or, if ordered, MFOC.

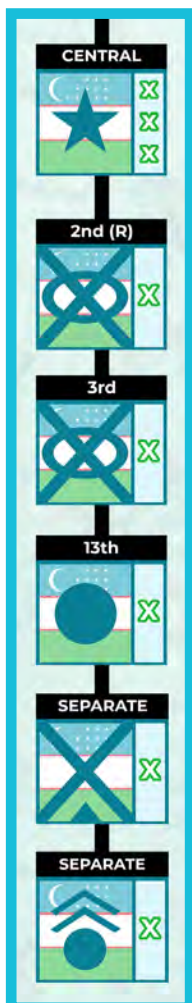
While this distribution arguably allows for a broader range of tailored tactical responses, it also provides the national command with a significant political advantage during crises. By design, this arrangement ensures that Tashkent maintains a force strong enough to deter or defeat local contingencies, while simultaneously preserving multiple, centrally controlled chains of command that can be weighted, or withheld, as the situation demands. As a result, this structure effectively prevents any single headquarters from monopolising combat power in a region that has historically served as a flashpoint for ethnic tensions and border disputes. By calibrating military strength across overlapping authorities, the capital maintains both operational flexibility and political oversight in the Valley.

(Figure 4.4.8: Order of battle for the Ground Forces of the Eastern Military District)

iv) - Central Military District



(Figure 4.4.9: Map of the Central Military District and its subordinate units)



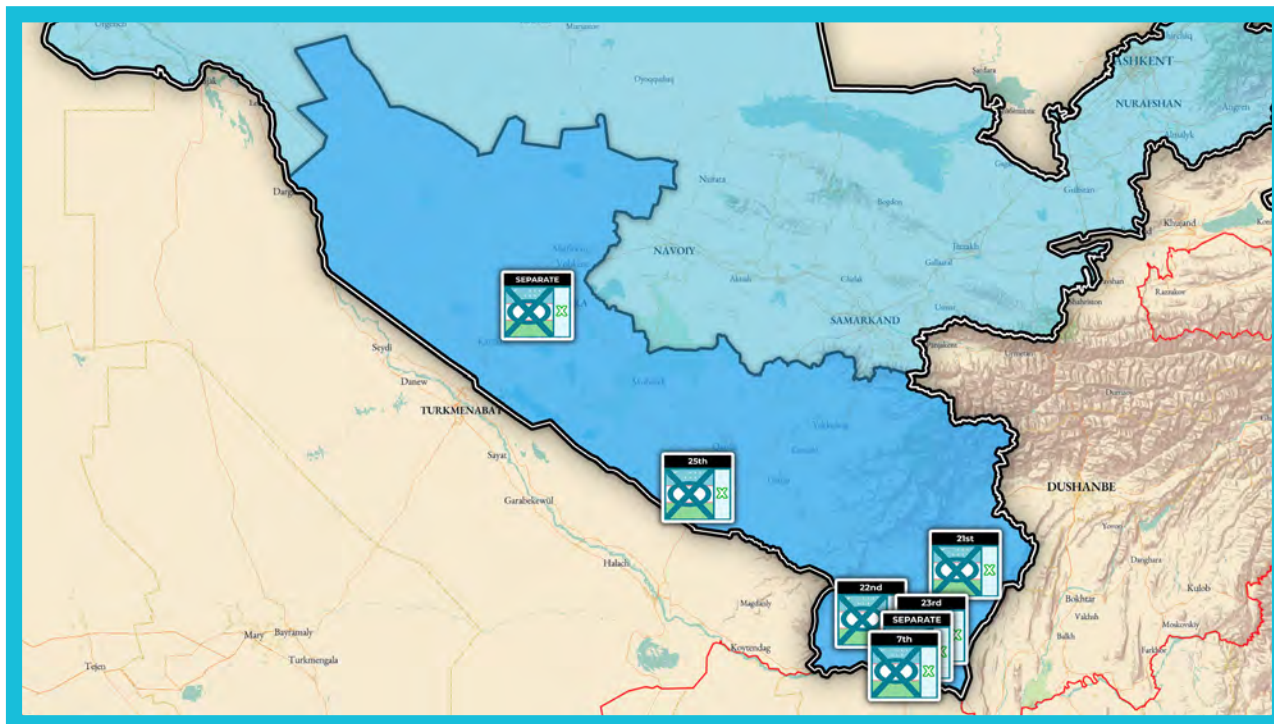
Headquarters: Jizzakh

Regions covered: Jizzakh, Navoiy, and Samarkand

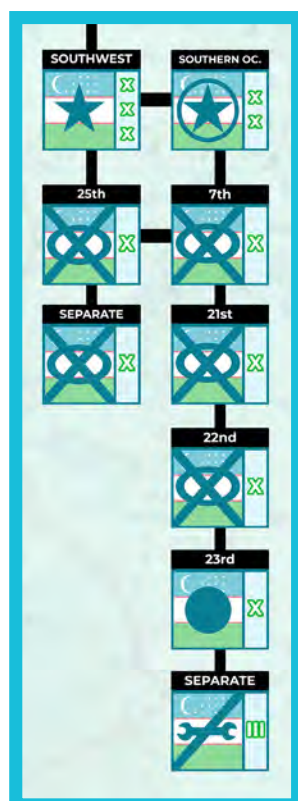
Headquartered in Jizzakh, the units stationed here form a highly robust and responsive force capable of swiftly addressing a wide range of security events across central Uzbekistan. While considered one of the less critical military districts during peacetime, their geographic position during a hypothetical conflict would make them one of the most important, as the forces stationed within the central district are likely to be charged with defending the nation's inner geographic crossroads and securing the crucial railway and highway connections linking hubs like Tashkent, Qarshi, and Termez.

(Figure 4.4.10: Order of battle for the Ground Forces of the Central Military District)

v) - Southwest Special Military District



(Figure 4.4.11: Map of the Southwest Special Military District and its subordinate units)



Military district headquarters: Qarshi

Operational command headquarters: Termez

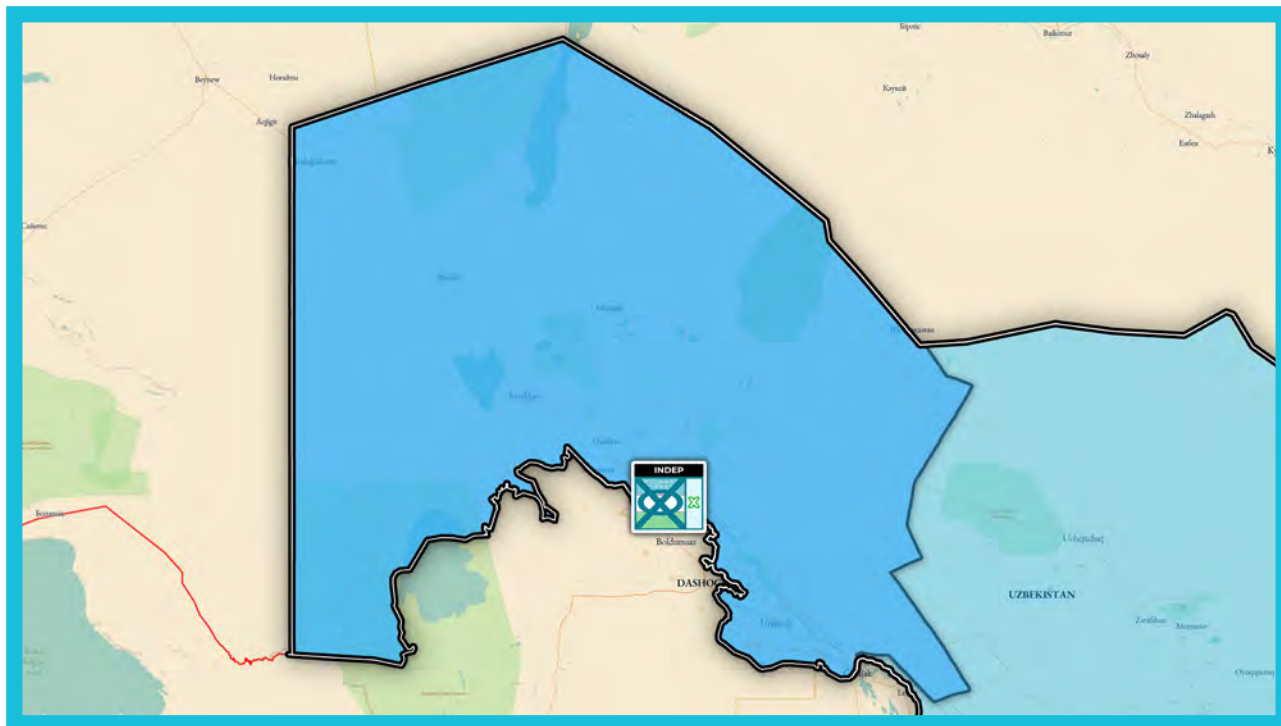
Regions covered: Bukhara, Qashqadaryo, and Surxondaryo

Headquartered in Qarshi, the Southwest Special Military District (SWMD) is responsible for defending some of Uzbekistan's most strategically sensitive and operationally demanding territory. Stretching from southern Karakalpakstan to the western edge of Tajikistan, the district covers a vast and often volatile frontier zone, including key sections of the Afghan and Tajik borders. To meet these demands, the SWMD is equipped with a larger concentration of vehicles, heavy weaponry, and logistical support assets than almost any other military district. Its structure also includes a unique command feature, the Southern Operational Command (SOC), a subordinate entity focused entirely on the Surxondaryo region and its surroundings. In peacetime, the SOC primarily coordinates the special operations and reconnaissance units here in the south. However, if activated during a crisis, it could be elevated to serve as a localised operational headquarters, essentially a theatre command, being tasked with directing the majority of the multi-branch forces in the region. While the SOC remains limited in scope under normal conditions, its presence within the SWMD reflects a broader strategic intent to ensure that Uzbekistan's most vulnerable

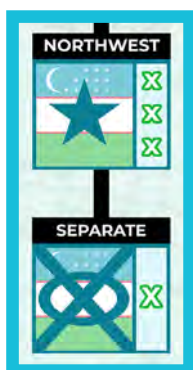
borders are supported not only with elevated levels of manpower and equipment, but also with a potentially flexible, decentralised command infrastructure.

(Figure 4.4.12: The potential wartime Order of battle for the SWMD's Ground Forces)

vi) - Northwest Military District



(Figure 4.4.13: Map of the Northwest Military District and its subordinate units)



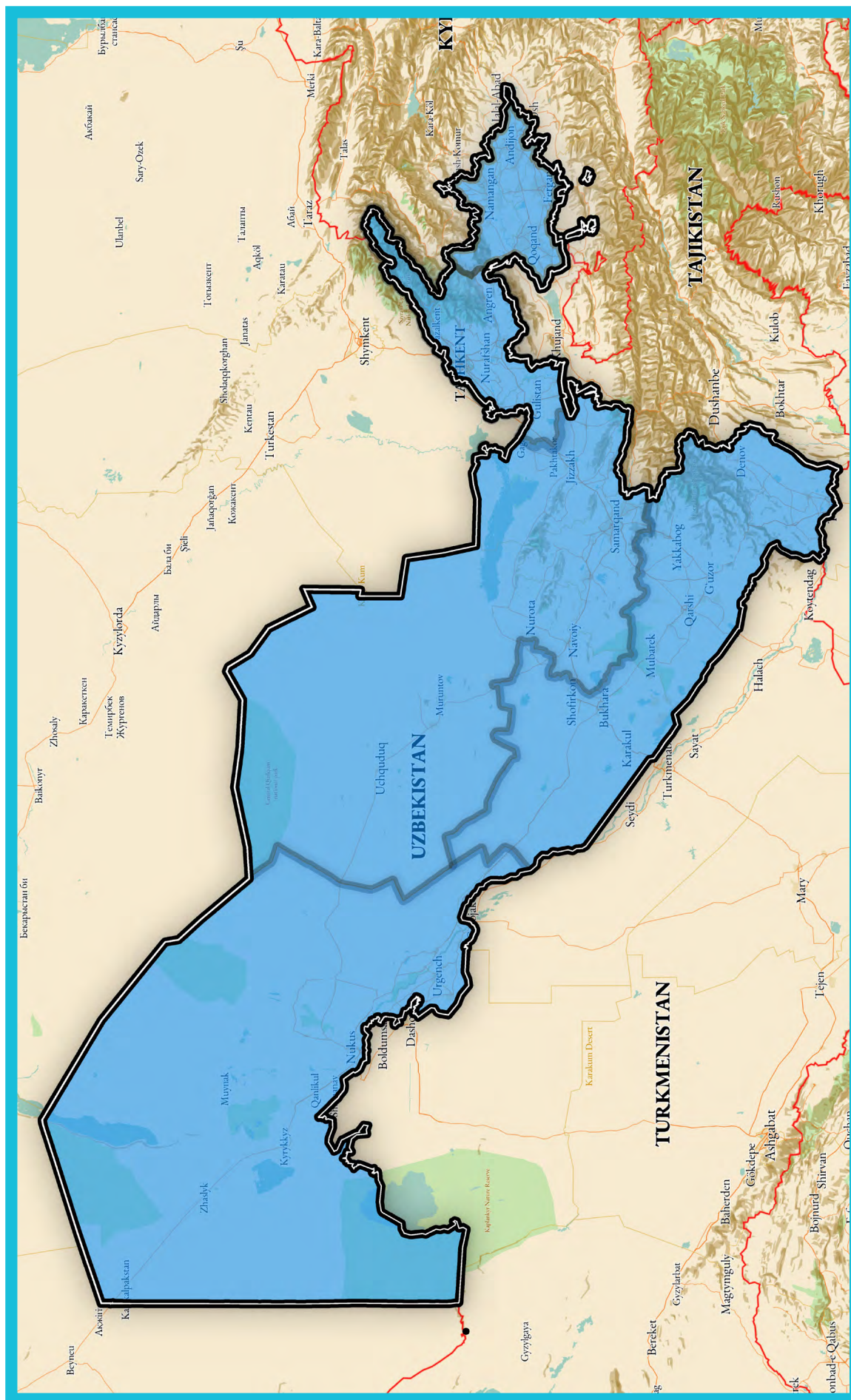
Headquarters: Nukus

Regions covered: Karakalpakstan and Xorazm

Headquartered in Nukus, the Northwest Military District contains the smallest MOD garrison of Uzbekistan's five MD's. Forces stationed here have two crucial responsibilities. Firstly, they serve as an initial response unit against any potential military aggression encroaching from the western frontier, and secondly, they act as a well-armed permanent reserve force for any MIA, UNG, and UFS units deployed in the region. This latter role gaining increased significance following the 2022 protests in Nukus, where widespread demonstrations erupted against proposed changes to the constitution that were seen as infringing on Karakalpak identity and Karakalpakstan's autonomy.

The situation in 2022, escalated beyond the control of the local forces, compelling Tashkent to ultimately retract the proposed constitutional change, a rare political retreat for this government. In response, the government moved to reinforce its security footprint in the region, but rather than expanding conventional military deployments, the state prioritised the deployment of paramilitary formations, UNG units, and additional security forces as the primary response elements for future unrest. This deliberate shift in force allocation suggests that Uzbekistan's leadership views domestic stability in Karakalpakstan as primarily a law enforcement challenge, rather than a conventional military concern. Consequently, the NWMD maintains a comparatively limited presence of regular armed forces, with an emphasis on internal security operations led by non-MOD agencies.

(Figure 4.4.14: Order of battle for the Ground Forces of the Northwest Military District)



(Figure 4.4.15: Map of the five Uzbek military districts)

4.4.2 - Equipment and Unit Types

The Uzbek Ground Forces possess one of the largest stockpiles of Russian and Soviet military equipment outside of Russia, and while the military did inherit a Soviet force structure, it has since begun implementing programs to reorganise its forces around lighter mobile and special forces units. The Uzbek Ground Forces (UGF) are the single largest branch of the military, possessing the majority of the state's tanks, artillery, and heavy vehicles. While the overarching structure remains somewhat outdated, each of the branch's components has been undergoing various levels of modernisation and refitting throughout the last few years.

i) - Standard infantry



The standard equipment for Uzbekistan's contract soldiers and conscripts still somewhat resembles the typical military kit of the late Uzbek SSR era. The outfitting is likely a symptom of the UGF's continual reliance on Russian-supplied weaponry and equipment, as well as the ongoing utilisation of inherited military stockpiles in order to maintain operational readiness. The standard issue for an Uzbek infantryman typically includes either the AKM or AK-74 assault rifle as the primary weapon, with the Makarov PM or Fort-12 pistol serving as the standard secondary firearm. To adapt to

various operational contexts, personnel are also issued fragmentation, smoke grenades, and basic communication gear. Selected cadre members are then additionally equipped with squad automatic weapons, such as the RPK light machinegun or the PKM general-purpose machinegun. For roles also requiring specific tactical capabilities, specialised operatives can be armed with shoulder-fired missile weapons or recoilless rifles for engagements against lightly armoured targets and vehicles.

The more combat-ready units are also occasionally equipped with man-portable air defence systems (MANPADS) like the QW-18, and the 9K32 Strela-2, providing these groups of soldiers with a light, rapidly deployable anti-aircraft capability. While there are purely infantry formations at the lower subordinate levels, the Uzbek Ground Forces are predominantly oriented around brigade-strength, vehicle-dependent structures, namely motor rifle, air assault, and artillery formations. This organisation ensures that the bulk of the force benefits from integrated motorised support, enhancing mobility and flexibility across a spectrum of military operations.

(Figure 4.4.16: Symbol for the Uzbek 1st Motor Rifle Brigade based in Chirchik)

ii) - Armoured and motorised units

Within the Uzbek Ground Forces, the armoured and motorised units serve as the primary workhorse in overall ground operations. Most motor rifle units possess a range of infantry fighting vehicles (IFVs), armoured personnel carriers (APCs), self-propelled artillery units (SPAs), infantry mobility vehicles (IMVs), utility and service vehicles (USVs), and a small number of main battle tanks (MBTs). In contrast to the standard motor rifle brigade, a dedicated tank brigade will have a similar structure but with a much higher ratio of MBTs and USVs to other vehicle types. Usually in conjunction with artillery and air support units, these tank brigades (and motor rifles brigades, MRBs) are primarily used at the forefront of offensive operations,

ideally spearheading assaults and breaking through enemy defensive lines. The units' MBTs will provide heavier firepower, while the IFVs and APCs will primarily serve in lighter fire-support roles and frontline transportation for infantry. These MRB units are incredibly versatile, often tasked with carrying out everything from leading assaults, to reconnaissance, logistical support, and even integrated fire-support roles.

Currently, Uzbekistan's entire tank fleet consists of stock acquired before the country gained independence, with many of these vehicles being lower-quality units relocated to Uzbekistan for storage during the drawdown of forces in Europe in the final years of the Cold War. While the more advanced tanks in Uzbekistan's inventory include Soviet-era T-80BVs and T-72s (encompassing A, AV, B, and B1 variants), the bulk of the fleet is composed of T-64s (A, B1, B1UZ, and MZ variants) and T-62s (M, MV, and MUZ variants). Among these, the T-62 stands out as particularly antiquated, having first entered service in 1961. Unsurprisingly, much of Uzbekistan's tank stock is considered outdated, even by regional standards, lagging behind both Kazakhstan and Turkmenistan in overall quantity and technological advancement, possibly raising concerns about these tank units' operational readiness. Uzbekistan also falls behind Kazakhstan and Turkmenistan in terms of IFVs and APCs, with Uzbekistan currently maintaining a fleet of 1,000 vehicles, predominantly comprising older models like the BTR-80 (APC), BRDM-2 (combat reconnaissance vehicle), and BMP-2 (IFV). While these vehicles still possess some serviceable fighting qualities, as evidenced by their use in the ongoing conflict in Ukraine, they are likely to fare poorly against more modern ATGMs (antitank guided missiles), drones, Western tanks and IFVs. However, for Uzbekistan, these units are primarily oriented toward border and internal security operations, where they are far more likely to be deployed against lightly armed insurgents, unarmed demonstrators, or other dismounted adversaries rather than engaging a modern conventional force. While the current equipment and force composition of Uzbekistan's security forces are assessed to be adequate for their primary operational roles, concerns persist regarding the readiness and mechanical reliability of their armoured vehicle fleet. Testimonies and open-source reporting indicate potential issues with vehicle operability, raising questions as to whether the entire inventory is capable of achieving combat readiness, sustaining prolonged operational use, or even consistently starting up when required. The majority of these vehicles were manufactured in the Soviet Union during the 1960s, 1970s, and 1980s, with only a limited fraction undergoing full modernisation, system upgrades, or extensive mechanical overhauls since their initial production. As a result, ageing components, lack of standardisation in maintenance cycles, and potential spare parts shortages may significantly impact the operational availability and battlefield effectiveness of these assets in any sustained engagement.

*(Figure 4.4.17:
An Uzbek T-64B1.
Source: The Uzbek
Ministry of Defence)*



iii) - Artillery and rocket units



The Ground Forces also possess an array of ageing artillery and rocket forces. The primary tasks of these units include achieving and maintaining fire superiority, disrupting enemy formations, targeting command, control, and electronic warfare systems, and eliminating enemy infrastructure and logistical networks. They also play a crucial role in isolating enemy reinforcements, countering armoured vehicles, and supporting other units' defensive positions. Much like the MRBs of this service branch, Uzbekistan's artillery units have also been slowly implementing modernisation programmes to enhance their real-time target engagement and overall firing range capabilities. These modern artillery units maintain a combination of towed, rocket, and self-propelled artillery platforms, most of which were also inherited from the USSR. However, unlike the Uzbek SSR's military structure, which heavily focused on massed artillery concentrations, the modern Uzbek artillery forces play a more secondary role in the state's contemporary operations.

While Uzbekistan's artillery platforms like the D-30, MT-12, and BM-21 Grad all provide long-range and mobile rapid-fire capabilities, the stockpiled munitions for these units are also reportedly either alarmingly antiquated or well below the readiness level required for a prolonged regional conflict. However, subject matter experts consulted for this study noted that while many of these artillery systems have surpassed their intended operational lifespan, and were operating with worn-out barrels and internal damage, in recent years the UGF have undertaken substantial efforts to refurbish and upgrade some of its key artillery units and systems. Nevertheless, as more of these ageing artillery systems continue to degrade and maintenance and operating costs continue to rise, Tashkent will likely face the necessity of either replacing significant portions of its remaining inventory or shifting its artillery forces toward a greater reliance on multiple launch rocket systems (MLRS), which offer cheaper barrel production and simpler maintenance. In terms of self-propelled artillery, the Uzbek Ground Forces primarily operate platforms such as the 2S1 Gvozdika, 2S3 Akatsiya, and 2S7 Pion, all of which were designed and manufactured by the USSR. Despite having a military budget more than twice the size of Turkmenistan's, Uzbekistan still ranks third in the regional artillery category, above Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan but well behind its peers in Kazakhstan and Turkmenistan.

(Figure 4.4.18: (top) Symbolology for the Uzbek 13th Artillery Brigade based in Kattakurgan)

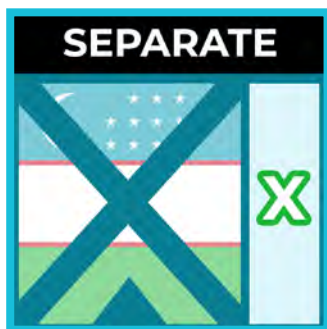
(Figure 4.4.19: An Uzbek D-30 (bottom left). Source: Uzbek Ministry of Defence)

(Figure 4.4.20: An Uzbek BTR-D on parade with air assault forces (bottom right).

Source: Uzbek Ministry of Defence)



iv) - Mountain infantry



Mountain infantry units are specifically trained and equipped to operate in Uzbekistan's eastern regions' rugged and mountainous theatres. While these units are primarily armed with standard small arms, including AKM and AK-74 assault rifles, Dragunov SVD sniper rifles, and RPK-74 squad automatic weapons, they have also been equipped with improved communication systems and navigation equipment. These units are also usually afforded the capability to deploy light and mobile artillery platforms, including portable mortars and lightweight howitzers, both of which can be transported across and set up in difficult mountain terrain.

(Figure 4.4.21: Symbolology for the Uzbek Separate Light Mountain Infantry Brigade (above) based in the Jizzakh region)

v) - Air assault and airborne



Air assault brigades provide the Uzbek Ground Forces with rapid deployment capabilities, enabling swift responses to emerging threats wherever they may occur across the country. However, it should also be noted that Uzbekistan's air assault troops operate quite differently from conventional airborne units in Western military structures. The Uzbek's Airborne units will rarely be deployed by air, primarily due to Uzbekistan not possessing the required airlift and logistical capacity to be able to operate their airborne and air assault forces in the manner that the American and British militaries do. So, at present, the deployment of these

brigades relies heavily on the more modernised elements of the Uzbek armoured vehicle stocks, as well as parts of the Uzbek rotary wing assets.

During combat operations, these units are often tasked with capturing and securing key strategic points, including airfields, essential infrastructure, and vital geographic points quickly, and holding these points until heavy weaponry and supply lines can catch up. Domestically though, their speed and tactical mobility also make them particularly valuable for rapidly securing key administrative centres during significant protests or potential military uprisings. The 17th Air Assault Brigade, in particular, was utilised for this purpose during the crackdown in Andijan, as these troops were seen as being better trained and equipped than most. The 17th, in particular, being used to quickly overwhelm most of the protester's key strongpoints, and break up the resistance during the government's reclamation of the city. Whether being used in domestic or foreign operations, the Uzbek's Air assault brigades are often seen as the tip of the spear for the Uzbek Ground Forces, with their personnel being given access to the more modern military equipment, the best-equipped light reconnaissance vehicles, and the most extensive military training programmes outside of the smaller SOF units. These troops are also often placed in higher esteem by the Uzbek public, with Tashkent often sending the Air-Assault units out to participate in international military exercises and national parades.

(Figure 4.4.22: Symbolology for the Uzbek 17th Airborne Assault Brigade (above) based in Fergana)

4.4.3 - Unit Modernisation

The Uzbek Ground Forces have begun a gradual strategic shift from a Soviet legacy force that was conscript-based and centred on artillery and armour to one that now increasingly emphasises speed, manoeuvrability, aerial support, motorisation, and specialisation. As part of this transformation, the Uzbek military has even incorporated certain Western military management methodologies into their command and training systems. Notably, they have recently bolstered the importance of the noncommissioned officer (NCO) role within their command hierarchy and granted greater tactical decision-making authority to NCOs during battlefield operations. These changes somewhat mirror the reforms seen in the Russian military following the 2008 war with Georgia, albeit without the comprehensive logistical overhaul that accompanied the Russian reforms. Although even with Moscow's much larger military budget, this transition was never fully completed across the entirety of the Russian armed forces. While the Uzbek Ground Forces possess commendable operational capabilities within their regional sphere, they are still primarily optimised for internal security and handling localised border confrontations rather than large conventional battles. The current force structure is not ideally suited for extensive cross-border military campaigns or prolonged, attritional engagements against neighbouring countries, with this limitation mainly due to the Ground Forces' underdeveloped logistical support framework, which lacks the robustness required to sustain these sorts of extended military operations.

As part of the modernisation programmes already underway, the Ground Forces have aimed to address their operational shortfalls through the purchase of vehicles and tactical support equipment, the installation of platform upgrade kits, and a renewal of skills through various training programmes, but they are still likely a far way off being ready to carry out any sort of prolonged military campaign. In addition to larger acquisitions, the country has also invested in limited quantities of modernised infantry equipment, including improved personal protective gear, higher quality personal weapons, and night-vision devices. However, most of these new purchases are being directed towards the nation's special forces, air assault units, and counterterrorism groups, and it may still be some time before the standard recruit has guaranteed access to such equipment. However, one of the more notable aspects of Uzbekistan's modernisation programmes has been the state's BM-21 MK programme, with the BM-21 being a commonly used MLRS system that has been a staple of the Uzbek arsenal for decades. The Uzbek stockpiles of these systems are now undergoing refurbishment to improve their effectiveness and accuracy, with the enhancements focused on introducing newer rockets for use with these platforms, extending the rocket's fire range up to 45 km. While this significantly increases the BM-21's operational range, subject matter experts estimate that the quantities of these new rockets being purchased are still fairly minimal for the time being.

Given Uzbekistan's strategic emphasis on proactive counterterrorism operations, the priority procurement focus is expected to remain on equipment optimised for rapid response and counterinsurgency missions. In the short term, the acquisition of advanced communication and reconnaissance systems will likely continue to be a primary concern for the Uzbek Ground Forces (UGF). To address these capability requirements, Tashkent has so far pursued the procurement of modern tactical communication systems, including the U.S.-manufactured Falcon II, alongside a range of small and large unmanned aerial systems (UAS) to enhance real-time situational awareness and force coordination. However, current assessments indicate that the quantity of these systems being acquired still remains insufficient to effectively cover all operationally sensitive regions.



(Figure 4.4.23: Three Uzbek BM-21K Grad's. Source: Uzbek Ministry of Defence)

4.4.4 - Weaknesses

Beyond the obvious issues, like the need to allocate most of their budget to wages and staffing with little left for procurement, the most significant obstacle confronting the Uzbek Ground Forces is the desperate need for additional modern and robust logistical support systems, combined with a way to address the country's limited indigenous production capacity adequately. Logistical capabilities serve as the foundation of military effectiveness, ensuring the sustained movement of personnel, materiel, and critical resources across the operational battlespace. However, Uzbekistan's current deficiencies in logistical transport, mobile repair and refuelling stations, domestic maintenance and replacement infrastructure, and broader support frameworks create significant vulnerabilities. These shortfalls leave Uzbek forces highly susceptible to disruptions in ammunition, rations, and fuel supplies during prolonged operations, severely constraining the feasibility of any sustained military campaign. Without either substantial external support from a major power or unprecedented stockpiling efforts in the prelude to hostilities, Uzbekistan would struggle to maintain the operational tempo necessary for protracted engagements.

Currently, Uzbekistan also does not produce enough ammunition and supplies to meet its basic peacetime requirements and remains largely reliant on nations like Russia to keep its forces operational. Coupled with the nation's limited domestic defence manufacturing capacity, it presents several strategic vulnerabilities and limitations to the Uzbek forces. For one, if Russia enters a conflict, its arms production is inevitably diverted towards its own war effort, rather than the export market, which in turn then pushes up the price of Russian arms and munitions and results in shortages, delays, and deprioritisation of exports for the Uzbek defence sector. This overreliance on Russian calibre arms complicates Uzbekistan's strategic options, particularly for potential armed confrontations against nations within Central Asia. For example, if Uzbekistan were to go to war with Kyrgyzstan or Tajikistan, Russia would likely be the largest arms supplier to both sides, affording Moscow the ability to either prolong the conflict, thereby profiting from both sides or simply cut off arms to one side in order to bolster its preferred combatant. In addition to these equipment and local production challenges, Uzbekistan's transport infrastructure also poses a significant bottleneck for military movements, with the country's road and rail networks often lacking redundancy in many key operational areas. This, combined with the absence of widespread dedicated railway support units, could create significant issues if Tashkent were attempting to move large amounts of manpower or supplies into key battlespaces, such as the approaches toward Dushanbe or the Fergana Valley.

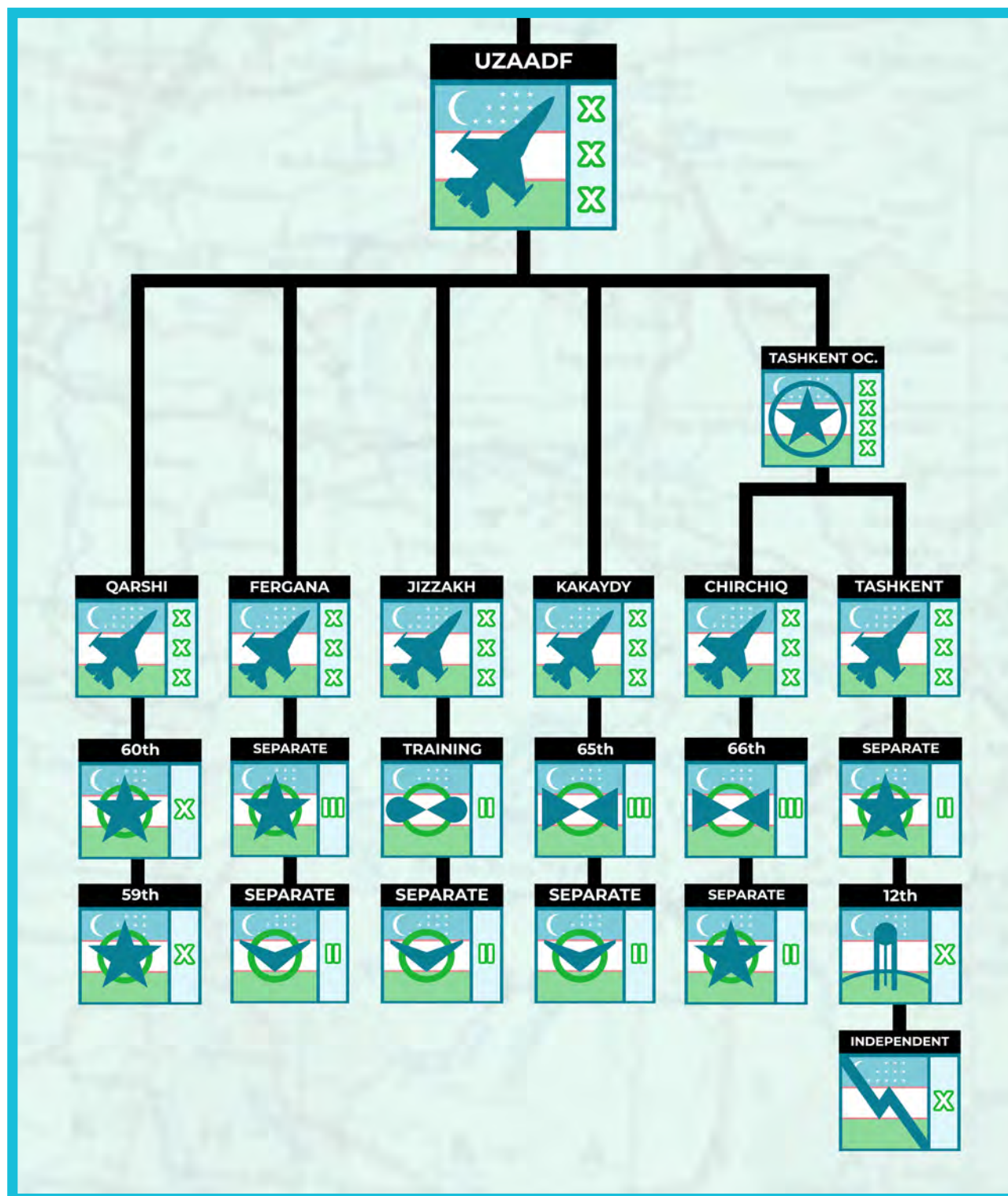


(Figure 4.4.25: Map of Uzbekistan and its current rail network (brown))

In the event of a large-scale conflict, Tashkent would be forced to requisition a significant portion of Uzbekistan's civilian rail stock to sustain military logistics and force mobility. This dependence raises two primary concerns: the time required to mobilise and repurpose these assets and the economic ramifications of diverting critical infrastructure from commercial use. Without the development of dedicated rapid loading and unloading facilities or the establishment of specialised rail logistics brigades within the armed forces, Uzbekistan is unlikely to achieve efficient military rail operations at scale. During a conflict, such dedicated infrastructure and personnel would be essential for sustaining large-scale military operations, ensuring that critical supplies and munitions can be rapidly transported and deployed at a pace that supports sustained offensive operations. Having these sorts of personnel would also be incredibly useful for quickly repairing sabotaged or damaged rail sections, as well as the unloading and reloading of strategic assets such as MBTs, fuel, and high-explosive ordnance.

Addressing these systemic deficiencies will require significant investment in logistics infrastructure and support equipment, including increased procurement of military transport aircraft, heavy-lift trucks, and refuelling assets. The other key purchases likely required to resolve these issues would be the acquisition of upgraded dedicated military communication networks and the enhancement of support vehicle fleets to facilitate supply chain continuity. As outlined in Section 4.9.2, during a hypothetical invasion of Tajikistan, while Uzbek forces would be able to readily transport fuel and ammunition via rail from its northern stockpiles toward supply caches in the south, significant supply deficits and delays would rapidly accumulate when fuel and munitions need to be offloaded in Termez and then transported another 250 km by truck.

4.5: THE AIR AND AIR DEFENCE FORCES



(Figure 4.5.1: The Order of battle for the Uzbek Air and Air Defence Forces)

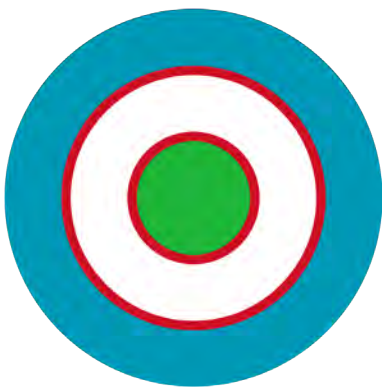
4.5.1 - Operational Capacity

With approximately 12,000 personnel, the Uzbek Air and Air Defence Forces (UZAADF) operate numerous airbases and air defence installations nationwide. Integrated within Uzbekistan's unified armed forces, the UZAADF is tasked with ensuring control of national airspace, providing air support for ground operations, and delivering credible deterrence against aerial threats.



(Figure 4.5.2: Map of Uzbekistan's operational military airfields)

i) - The Air force



Since inheriting the bulk of its air assets following the collapse of the Soviet Union, the Uzbek Air and Air Defence Forces (UZAADF) have undertaken a gradual process of modernisation and capability expansion. In the years following independence, the force grappled with critical challenges, including a shortage of experienced pilots and skilled maintenance personnel, which hindered operational effectiveness. However, recent efforts have focused on addressing these deficiencies, improving training programs, and enhancing overall force readiness to sustain a more capable and responsive air force. The UZAADF maintain a fixed-wing inventory comprising Soviet, Russian,

American, Brazilian, Czech, Spanish, and French aircraft, with Russian-built platforms dominating. The UZAADF's attack aircraft inventory primarily includes Russian-made Su-27 (standard and UB variants), Su-25 (standard, BM, and UB variants), MiG-29 (standard and UB variants), and Su-24 (currently in storage). These are supplemented by Czech-built L-39 trainers (standard and C variants). Given the advancing age of these aircraft, Uzbekistan is actively seeking more modern replacements, with the Russian Su-30 and the Chinese J-17 currently identified as the leading contenders.

(Figure 4.5.3: Roundel of the Uzbek Air Force)



(Figure 4.5.4: An Uzbek MiG-29 (left) operating over southern Uzbekistan. Source: Uzbek Ministry of Defence)

These are not the only new platforms Tashkent has acquired in recent years, as Uzbekistan has also expanded its fixed-wing capabilities through the procurement and domestic production of various drones. While most of these drones are currently being operated by other service branches, Uzbekistan's national drone fleet currently includes the Turkish-made Bayraktar TB2 and TAI Anka-S, the Russian-produced Orlan-10 and ZALA 421-16E, the Chinese-built Wing Loong, the US-made RQ-11 and RQ-20B, the Israeli-manufactured SkyStriker, and the domestically produced Lochin. These fixed-wing platforms operate alongside various rotary-wing drones, including Chinese-made DJI Mavic systems and other consumer-grade surveillance UAVs. In addition to these drones, the UZAADF also maintains the largest (and perhaps most eclectic) fleet of rotary aircraft in Central Asia. This fleet includes Soviet and Russian-manufactured helicopters such as the Mi-35, Mi-26, Mi-24, Mi-8, and Mi-6, as well as the European-made EC145s, AS550s, AS532s, AS350s, and AS332s, with all of this being rounded out with a small number of US-made Sikorsky H-60s. It should be noted though, that these H-60s were not acquired directly from the US, but instead were acquired by Tashkent when the Afghan Air Force fled into Uzbekistan during the Taliban's capture of Afghanistan. Despite demands from the Taliban government to return these helicopters back to Afghanistan, Tashkent has recently opted to export these helicopters back to the US. Ironically, Tashkent had attempted to purchase the H-60 previously, sometime around 2013, but the procurement was blocked by the US. Due to concerns about Tashkent's human rights abuses in the country. For transport planes, the UZAADF employs Soviet TU-134s, TU-154s, IL-76s, and Yak-52s, as well as Russian An-12s and An-26s. The Uzbek fleet also includes US-made C-208s, Spanish C-295s, Brazilian KC/C-390s and Swiss-produced PC-12s.

ii) - The Air Defence Force

The UZAADF has also embarked on an ambitious initiative to upgrade most of its now arguably obsolete air defence capabilities, through the purchase of new and refurbished air defence systems, as well as the modernisation of some of its existing platforms. However, despite these advancements, Uzbekistan's air defence framework still faces significant challenges in achieving the desired level of operational security. During the Soviet era, most of the Turkestan military district's air defence coordination and batteries were coordinated out of Samarkand, as Samarkand became the air defence hub for the Uzbek and Turkmen SSRs. Today though, the 12th Antiaircraft Missile Brigade has been relocated and rebased in Tashkent, so as to bring the Air Force and Air Defence headquarters closer together and to prioritise the defence of the Tashkent area with its limited platforms.



(Figure 4.5.5: Satellite imagery of an Uzbek air defence battery, southwest of Tashkent)

Uzbekistan's air defence network remains structured around a combination of legacy Soviet-era platforms and newer Chinese acquisitions, with the majority of its more capable surface-to-air missile (SAM) systems concentrated within a limited number of defensive complexes. Excluding man-portable air defence systems (MANPADS), these assets are now primarily distributed across four major air defence complexes assigned to the protection of Tashkent, an additional complex along the Afghan-Uzbek border in Surxondaryo Oblast, and one positioned near Nukus in the northwest, which is frequently used for system testing and evaluation.

At present, the core of Uzbekistan's air defence forces remains reliant on Russian and Soviet-produced S-75 and S-125 systems, supplemented by a limited number of S-200 launchers, most of which are now largely kept in storage due to obsolescence. Many of these ageing systems have long exceeded their expected service life, presenting Tashkent with the logistical and financial burden of either continuing costly maintenance and modernisation programs or committing to the outright replacement of these systems. In an effort to address these deficiencies, Uzbekistan initiated a procurement program for more modern long-range SAM systems, including the Chinese-manufactured FD-2000, HQ-12 and KS-1C, as well as the shoulder-fired QW-12. However, the pace of these acquisitions has slowed in recent years, reflecting potential constraints related to defence expenditures, system integration challenges, or supplier diversification strategies. In parallel with these SAM acquisitions, the UZAADF have also increasingly prioritised the procurement of modern radar systems to improve situational awareness and early warning capabilities. The current inventory consists of older Russian systems, including the P-18, P-37, and NRZ-4P, alongside a growing number of Chinese radar platforms, such as the HT-233 and HTK-JM2. This gradual shift toward Chinese technology aligns with a broader trend in Uzbekistan's defence procurement strategy, which has seen Beijing emerge as the country's primary supplier of new air defence assets.

In November 2018, Uzbekistan publicly showcased its first FD-2000 acquisition, following which three additional batteries and their associated radar systems were purchased in subsequent years. While this suggests a clear intent to integrate Chinese platforms into Uzbekistan's broader air defence network, these four batteries alone are insufficient to fully replace existing Russian-made systems or to meet Uzbekistan's comprehensive air defence requirements. Despite an initial commitment to Chinese-made systems, Uzbekistan has yet to fully transition toward reliance on Beijing's defence industry, with several practical constraints limiting the pace of this shift. The high cost of FD-2000 systems, combined with the existing logistical and operational integration of Soviet-era platforms, suggests that Uzbekistan is not yet in a position to entirely phase out its Russian-built air defence systems. Instead, Tashkent appears to be pursuing a hybrid approach, combining selective procurement of new systems with the upgrading and refurbishment of older Soviet platforms, with reports from *Novaya Gazeta* and *Izvestia* suggesting that Uzbekistan's S-125 systems will be the first to receive these upgrade packages from Russia.

4.5.2 - Command and Branch Structure

Like the Ground Forces, the UZAADF is centrally coordinated from its headquarters in Tashkent, under the leadership of the UZAADF commander. Once decisions are made in Tashkent, the various airbases and air wings receive their orders through one of two channels. For airbases in Chirchik and Tashkent, directives are routed via the TOC, following their transmission from the MOD to the General Staff. For airbases outside the TOC, such as those in Qarshi, Jizzakh, and Kakaydy, orders are typically passed from the General Staff directly to the UZAADF commander, who then disseminates those orders to the heads of these airbases. These orders are then subsequently relayed to the commanders of each squadron, battery, and air wing, ensuring a structured and efficient chain of command.

4.5.3 - Unit Modernisation

The UZAADF's modernisation efforts have largely been driven by procurement programs involving Russia, Turkey, and Belarus. Central to these efforts are the acquisition of advanced combat aircraft, transport aircraft, and modernised helicopters, alongside comprehensive airframe repair and upgrade packages aimed at revitalising Uzbekistan's ageing Soviet-era fleet. The more notable programs and initiatives currently underway include:

i) - Combat Aircraft

To address the growing obsolescence of its combat aircraft fleet, Uzbekistan has sought to acquire more modern fighter aircraft. While Moscow has historically been Tashkent's primary defence supplier, recent developments indicate that Uzbekistan have been exploring alternative suppliers to diversify its procurement sources. As an example, leaked contract negotiations revealed that the UZAADF had been evaluating the acquisition of South Korean KAI T-50 aircraft, with the proposed deal valued at approximately \$400 million. However, this procurement was subsequently blocked by the United States, citing concerns over technology leakage, as the T-50 platform integrates proprietary systems developed in collaboration with Lockheed Martin.

Following the collapse of the KAI T-50 negotiations, Uzbekistan was forced to re-engage with Russia for its airframe acquisitions, with the Uzbek MOD initiating discussions with

Moscow for the procurement of 12 Su-30SM multirole fighter jets, mirroring Kazakhstan's earlier acquisitions of the same platform. The negotiations appeared to be going well, with Uzbek defence officials even conducting site visits to Russian aircraft production facilities. Moscow also expressed its open support for the deal, offering Uzbekistan highly favourable loans, pricing, and terms typically reserved only for Russia's closest defence partners. Despite all this though, the contract is still yet to be fulfilled. Russian reports allege that the first of these aircraft arrived in Uzbekistan in 2021, but to date, there have been no public appearances of the Su-30SM, and most analysts are sceptical that they have arrived into Uzbekistan. The remaining delivery schedule also remains uncertain, largely due to Sukhoi's redirection of manufacturing capacity to support Russia's ongoing war effort. However, should the full contract be continued, Uzbekistan is anticipated to procure between 10-12 Su-30SMs, with the long-term maintenance and overhaul services likely being done in Russia and Belarus.

As a part of these initial Su-30SM negotiations, discussions were held regarding the potential establishment of aircraft maintenance facilities within Uzbekistan. This being important for Tashkent, as historically, Uzbekistan had developed extensive aircraft manufacturing and repair capabilities during the late Soviet period, but following the collapse of the USSR, many of the country's senior aviation technicians and defence enterprises relocated to Russia, Ukraine, and Belarus. This mass exodus of specialised personnel and industry expertise left Uzbekistan with a severe technical skills shortage, limiting its ability to perform anything beyond basic aircraft maintenance. Even today, Uzbekistan remains highly reliant on Belarusian defence facilities for major overhauls and modernisation programs.

Over the past several years, Belarusian facilities have completed extensive refurbishments on at least four MiG-29s and four Su-25s for the UZAADF, with Belarusian President Alexander Lukashenko expressing strong interest in expanding military-industrial collaboration with Uzbekistan and other Central Asian air forces. Mirziyoyev has actively sought to secure Belarusian cooperation in the establishment of aircraft repair and modernisation facilities within Uzbekistan. However, the war in Ukraine and Russia's immediate operational demands have resulted in delays in both new aircraft deliveries and the expansion of Belarusian aviation repair infrastructure. Despite these setbacks, as recently as February 2024, Lukashenko and Mirziyoyev have resumed negotiations on joint aircraft production and repair facilities being established in Uzbekistan, with the two leaders touring potential factory sites in Tashkent, signalling continued interest in long-term defence industrial cooperation.

ii) - Helicopters

Recognising the critical importance of maintaining a robust helicopter fleet for rapid frontline support and ground attack capabilities, Uzbekistan was prioritising the modernisation of its rotary wing assets above almost all other UZAADF projects. These helicopters are essential for operations against insurgents and less technologically advanced adversaries, both of which are currently far more likely combatants for the UZAADF than peer armed forces. This modernisation includes acquiring advanced multirole combat helicopters from Russia, as well as upgrades for several existing helicopters sourced from Russia, France, and Afghanistan. For now though, Tashkent continues to rely on Moscow for the majority of its attack, transportation, and heavy-lift helicopters, as Russia offers relatively cheap modernisation packages for its existing fleet and highly competitive loans for new purchases. By 2019, the first batch of four new Mi-35s purchased under these favourable loan terms had arrived in Uzbekistan, with an additional eight helicopter deliveries in mid-2020.

Despite Uzbekistan's position as the operator of the largest helicopter fleet in Central Asia, the rising prominence of drones in modern warfare is likely to prompt a significant strategic shift within the UZAADF. UZAADF commanders have already indicated an increasing prioritisation and integration of these unmanned aerial systems, both within the UZAADF and for the border service, with Uzbekistan already making the decision to procure drones from several different suppliers. Consequently, these newly acquired Russian helicopters, along with the helicopter fleet commandeered from the fleeing Afghan army, are likely to represent the last significant rotary-wing procurements for the foreseeable future. Moving forward, Uzbekistan appears to be aligning itself with the broader regional trend of embracing aerial drones, redirecting substantial capital towards establishing a comparatively cost-effective drone fleet.

4.5.4 - Weaknesses

Among the myriad of challenges faced by the UZAADF, the most pressing being the increasing obsolescence of its majority of aircraft fleet, coupled with the escalating costs of maintaining its ageing airframes. As at present, over half of Uzbekistan's current fleet of fixed-wing aircraft were acquired during the dissolution of the USSR, rendering them up to two generations behind some of the region's other air forces.



(Figure 4.5.6: Satellite imagery of the northwestern quarter of Qarshi Airbase)

The age of these aircraft and the dwindling number of nations still using some of these older platforms, like the MIG-29, also make acquiring parts to keep these planes operational increasingly difficult, with each subsequent overhaul of these platforms becoming successively more extensive and costly. Reports from knowledgeable military sources also indicate that these aircraft are already plagued by maintenance issues, prompting the UZAADF to either increasingly place these platforms into long-term storage or drastically limit their flight hours, in order to try and curb maintenance and upkeep costs. While these reduced air missions do save the UZAADF money, they also reduce pilots' flight hours and training time, calling wartime flying abilities somewhat into question. However, with the increasing reliance on drones, and the current geopolitical threats Uzbekistan is faced with, the prioritisation of lowering repair costs over the maintenance of pilot flight time hours does make some financial sense.



(Figure 4.5.7: Satellite imagery of Chirchik Airbase)

Another critical issue for the UZAADF is the shortage of experienced pilots and maintenance staff currently working within the country. As while Uzbekistan used to be a hub for flight operations and aircraft repairs within the USSR, past de-Russification policies led to the exodus of many skilled personnel, and created a significant expertise gap that Uzbekistan has been unable to fill ever since. Thirty-plus years after the collapse of the USSR, and despite continuing to operate the once-impressive Chirchik Aircraft Repair Plant, Uzbekistan has struggled to recruit and train enough qualified personnel to offset the losses suffered in the 1990s. Much of the blame for this being attributed to the Uzbek state placing minimal effort into local training and recruitment programs, and being unable to offer competitive incentives to attract experienced foreign nationals.

Additionally, the UZAADF lags behind other regional actors in both modern air defence systems and advanced radar capabilities, even falling short of what Kazakhstan and Turkmenistan both possess in terms of quality and quantity. While the technological gap between these three remains relatively small, these shortfalls become more significant in the event that Uzbekistan were to find itself up against any air force equipped with stealth aircraft or aircraft armed with later-generation, or longer-ranged missiles. In such cases, Tashkent will likely find itself at a significant disadvantage, as at present, it probably wouldn't be able to guarantee the safety of its own airspace.

The overarching concern here being that with the UZAADF's budget being stretched by maintenance, and increasingly diverted toward the procurement of new drone wings rather than air defence, these deficiencies are also unlikely to be resolved anytime soon. If Tashkent aims to establish a region-leading aerial combat and repair network, achieving these goals would require significant capital investment across a wide range of sectors, even just to reestablish the basics and bring the programme back up to a level required for self-sufficiency. At a minimum, this would require large additional purchases of modern aircraft, enhanced training programmes, and the procurement of a greater quantity of advanced air defence systems to protect all of this new infrastructure. However, given the current budgetary constraints, these ambitions are likely to remain distant goals for the UZAADF.

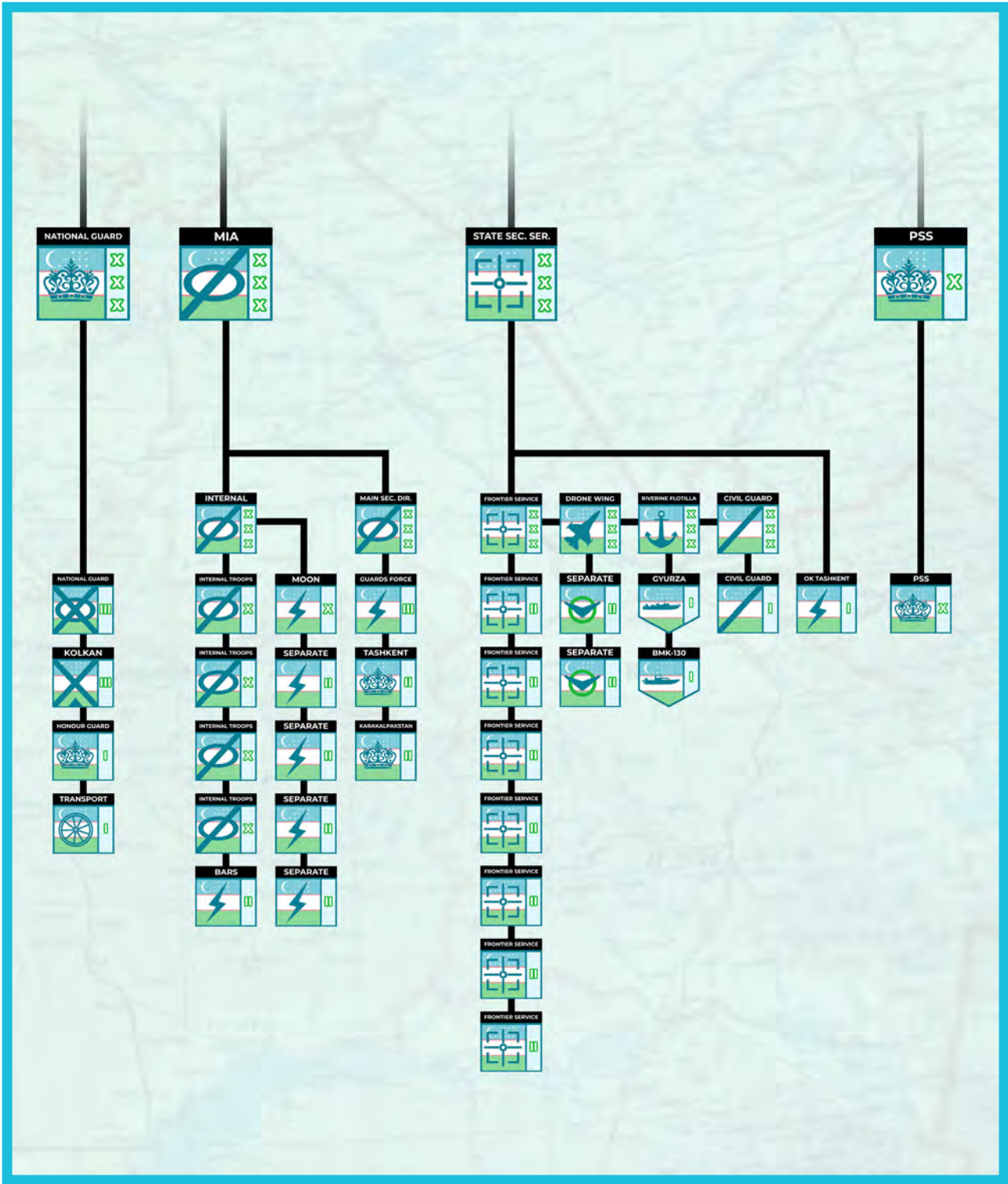


*(Figure 4.5.8:
Satellite
imagery (left)
of the helicopter
fleet at Kakaydy
Airbase)*



(Figure 4.5.9: Satellite imagery of Fergana Airbase)

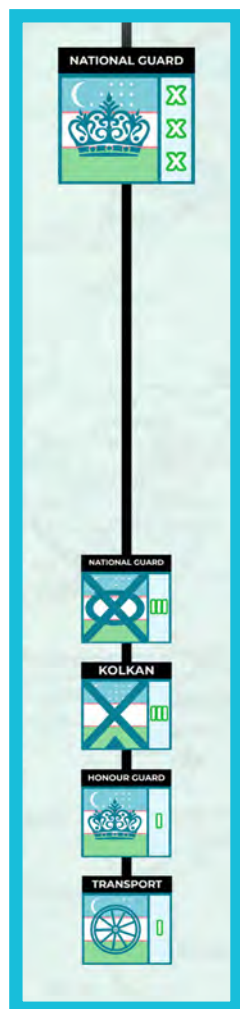
4.6: PARAMILITARY AND SPECIAL FORCES



(Figure 4.6.1: Order of battle for Uzbekistan's paramilitary forces)

Uzbekistan's paramilitary and gendarmerie forces are primarily used to maintain domestic internal security, provide some reserve and support services to the conventional armed forces, and independently operate specialised strike forces. These forces often operate with completely separate command and supply chains, as well as alternative operational mechanisms from the conventional armed forces. While the Ground Forces and UZAADF possess around 48,000 armed personnel, the paramilitary forces are not far behind, with approximately 25,500 armed personnel across the MIA, SSS, Internal Troops, National Guard, Frontier Service, and Presidential Security Service. With each of these services being armed, trained, and structured to carry out specialised tasks.

4.6.1 - The National Guard



Headquarters: Tashkent

Commanded by: The Security Council Under the President

Force number: 1,000

From its beginning's as an SOF battalion with the security services, the Uzbek National Guard (UNG) has now emerged as one of the most combat-ready units within the Uzbek armed forces. In the early 1990s, the UNG was a small elite force operating under the SSS (then the NSS), serving as bodyguards for Karimov and other key political figures. However, this changed in 2017 when Mirziyoyev announced a series of administrative reshuffles among the security services. As part of this restructuring, the UNG was established as its own independent branch of the armed forces, answering directly to the NSC. The force, being seen as particularly loyal to Mirziyoyev, received a further boost two years later, with significantly increased funding and broader powers. In 2019, the UNG received specialist training from the Russian National Guard and absorbed a regiment of special forces units known as the Main Guard Directorate, which had been reassigned from the SSS to the MIA just two years earlier, although this unit would be transferred back to the MIA in 2025. During that previous growth phase, the UNG was also granted the authority to conduct pretrial investigations, detain suspects, and maintain custody of individuals at any of their regional headquarters. The UNG's duties would then be expanded again, to include counterterror operations and discretionary limited strikes, all while it continued to serve as the personal protection force to the president. This series of elevations made the UNG a central and powerful apparatus within the Uzbek military structure. However, a few months later, Mirziyoyev reshuffled the organisation again,

removing the UNG's independence and placing it under the command of the President and the NSC. Two years later, he would then reorganise the force again, splitting off its presidential protection duties and creating the PSS. These changes demonstrate the very direct role the president takes in determining defence policies and the powers possessed by these paramilitary organisations, as under MOD command, the UNG has now somewhat transitioned from having an incredibly broad range of capabilities, to now serving as a smaller elite strike force at the discretion of the NSC and the executive branch.

(Figure 4.6.2: Order of battle for the Uzbek National Guard)

4.6.2 - The Presidential Security Service



Headquarters: Tashkent

Commanded by: The President of Uzbekistan

Force number: 500

Given the very recent establishment of the Presidential Security Service (PSS) in 2021 and the administration's secrecy regarding its internal organisation, public information on its exact numbers and budgeting structures is currently very limited. However, based on interviews conducted with members of the Uzbek defence community familiar with the organisation, the Uzbek PSS appears to be closely modelled in parts after the Russian Federal Protective Service (a larger organisation) and the Russian Presidential Security Service (a smaller, subordinate organ).

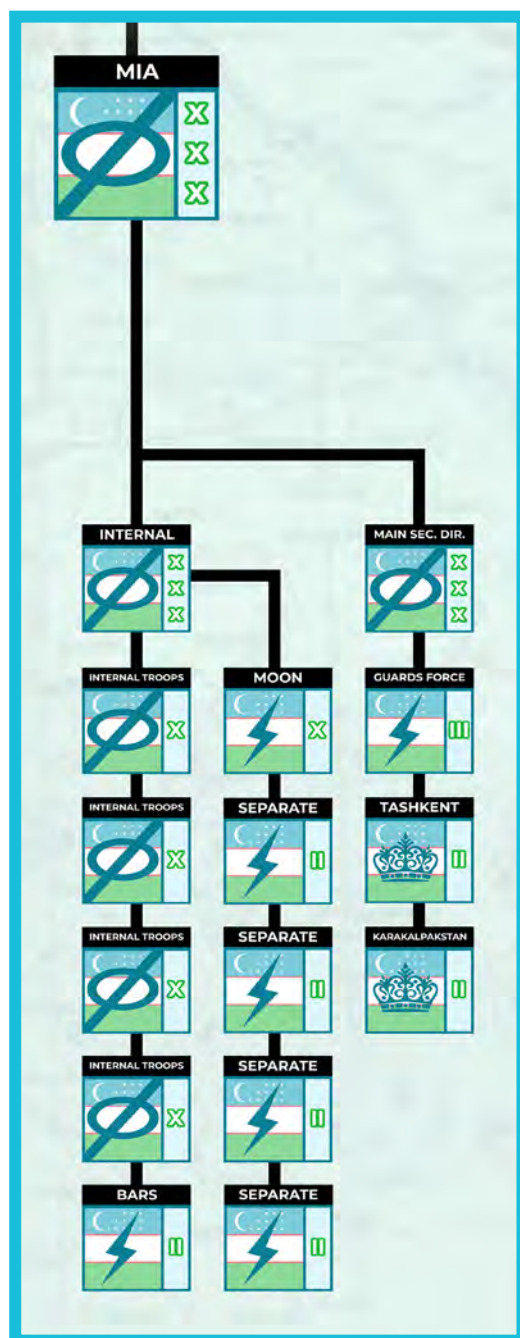
These Russian agencies are federal government bodies responsible for protecting high-ranking state officials, including the president, his family, and certain federal properties. In addition to their protective functions, they also have the authority to secure areas scheduled for presidential visits and to investigate any organisation, business, or individual on behalf of the president. For Uzbekistan and its own PSS, these same broad investigative powers enable national leaders to not only feel more secure when travelling across the country, but also offer them a way to monitor the daily activities of key oligarchs or military personnel within the country. While the PSS maintains a relatively small contingent of armed personnel compared to other military branches, its close ties to the president significantly amplify its influence within the Uzbek system. A notable example of this proximity to the president is the current de facto head of the service, Otabek Umarov, who in addition to his role as the head of the PSS, is also the president's son-in-law. This proximity to the president, coupled with the service's extensive investigative powers, renders it a disproportionately powerful entity.



(Figure 4.6.3: Order of battle (top) for the Uzbek Presidential Security Service)

(Figure 4.6.4: Mirziyoyev (bottom), visiting the Almazar and Sergeli Districts of Tashkent while surrounded by members of the PSS. Source: The Press Service of the President)

4.6.3 - The Internal Troops



Headquarters: Tashkent

Commanded by: The Ministry of Internal Affairs

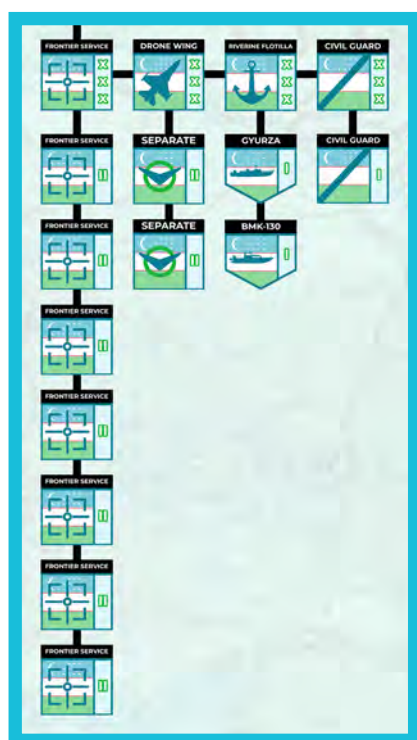
Force number: 19,000

The Uzbek Internal Troops (UIT), operating under the Ministry of Internal Affairs (MIA), are a paramilitary force tasked with maintaining public order, ensuring internal security, and responding to emergencies such as riots, natural disasters, prison protection, and terrorist threats. They also support law enforcement agencies, secure critical infrastructure, and protect key government facilities. These UIT forces are stationed inside most of the nation's major cities, enabling rapid riot suppression and crowd control across the country. Similar to other states of the former Soviet Union, their operational command structure is entirely independent of other military branches, receiving orders solely from the MIA. Unlike the MOD's forces, which are typically deployed in larger contingents, concentrated within a handful of bases, the Internal Troops are deployed into smaller garrisons, across more numerous locations. This widespread presence can ensure a quicker initial response to any crisis or uprising, regardless of location within the country. Currently, the UIT maintains a permanent strength of approximately 19,000 personnel, making Uzbekistan's Internal Troops the second largest MIA force in the region. These Internal Troops are often equipped with secondhand or thirdhand military equipment, and outside the branches SOF and rapid response formations, the majority of these troops are also usually trained and maintained to a lower standard than most of the other branches.

However, despite their lack of offensive equipment outside of APCs, IMVs, and electronic warfare gear, the UIT holds an incredibly important position within the Uzbek armed forces. This importance stemming from their ability to respond, isolate, and quash any growing domestic insurrections while they are still small and manageable, rather than having to wait for MOD's airborne troops or UNG Rapid Response units to arrive, as after the events of Andijan, Tashkent places high priority on being able to respond to such situations long before a protest movement has the time to gain momentum. In the eyes of the administration, the UIT effectively serves not only as a counterweight to the MOD, UNG and SSS, but also as a first line of defence against another disaster like Andijan.

(Figure 4.6.5: Order of battle for the Internal Troops)

4.6.4 - The Frontier Service



Headquarters: Tashkent

Commanded by: The State Security Service

Force number: 5,000

The Committee for State Border Protection of the State Security Service, more commonly referred to as the Uzbek Frontier Service (UFS), operates as an independent border force under the SSS. Like other border forces in Central Asia, it is responsible for safeguarding the country's borders and acts as the first line of defence against cross-border terrorism, insurgency, and contraband. Their duties include preventing illegal crossings, smuggling, and trafficking of goods and persons; conducting surveillance and patrol operations along Uzbekistan's extensive land borders; as well as detecting and deterring potential security threats. While the UFS is not as strong as it was under Karimov, it still maintains significant military capabilities. In addition to the thousands of armed border troops stationed across numerous small peripheral outposts, the UFS also commands the nation's navy, otherwise known as the Uzbek Riverine

Flotilla (URF), as well as the Uzbek Civil Guard (UCG). While the URF functions much like any other national navy, the UCG serves as a mechanism for the UFS to recruit citizens between the ages of 18 and 60 living near state borders during times of need. The UCG is not a permanent fixture but serves as a stopgap, ramping up personnel numbers in times of crisis. The UFS remains primarily composed of conscripts and minimally trained personnel, many of whom are deployed far from their home regions or major urban centers. These border troops are frequently tasked with patrolling some of Uzbekistan's most remote and inhospitable areas, where extreme isolation can leave units without assured communication links or reliable support from regional headquarters, or even Tashkent itself. Given these operational challenges, permanent UFS personnel are granted a far broader set of rules of engagement (ROE) than other branches of the armed forces. Unlike conventional military units, UFS troops are authorised to engage enemy combatants without requiring prior authorisation from headquarters or needing to be fired upon first. While this enhances reaction times and allows for a more immediate response to border incursions, it also introduces significant risks of miscalculation and escalation, particularly in contested or poorly demarcated border regions. This risk is then further compounded by the fact that most of Uzbekistan's neighbouring states grant similarly flexible ROE to their own border forces. While strong bilateral border mechanisms can mitigate tensions, the potential for rapid, unintended escalation remains high in disputed or sensitive areas. For example, UFS personnel often struggle to establish contact with their counterparts on the Turkmen side of the border, increasing the likelihood of accidental misidentification and engagements. Similarly, during periods of heightened tension with Tajikistan, where both sides tend to increase their border patrols, the two forces have a higher risk of encountering each other, and opening fire on one and other. Under this current system, cross-border skirmishes can erupt, and the situation can escalate into significant firefights, all without either side's central command being fully aware of the events unfolding in the field.

(Figure 4.6.6: Order of battle for the Frontier Service)

i) - Uzbek Riverine Flotilla

Headquarters: Termez

Commanded by: The Uzbek Frontier Service

Force number: 550



As one of the only two double-landlocked countries in the world, Uzbekistan has historically placed minimal emphasis on developing its naval capabilities. Despite this limited investment though, the Uzbek Riverine Flotilla (URF) plays a crucial role in protecting the nation's borders, and acting as the most significant naval power along this section of the river. The URF is tasked with combating drug trafficking, contraband smuggling, and unauthorised border crossings from Afghanistan into southern Uzbekistan.

The majority of the flotilla's arsenal is made up of smaller ships, including ten Project 1606 class tugboats and four BMK-130 class small border patrol boats, likely constructed in the Russian SFSR shipyard in Rybinsk. However, the pride of the fleet are its two Project 58150 Gyurza-class border patrol ships, funded by the United States and built in the Lenin's Forge shipyard in Kyiv, with these patrol boats basic armaments still outclassing most ships outside of the Caspian. Despite its relatively limited capabilities compared to larger naval entities in Central Asia, the URF's capabilities on the Amu Darya River make it a key component of Tashkent's southern security strategy, as demonstrated in section 4.10.1.

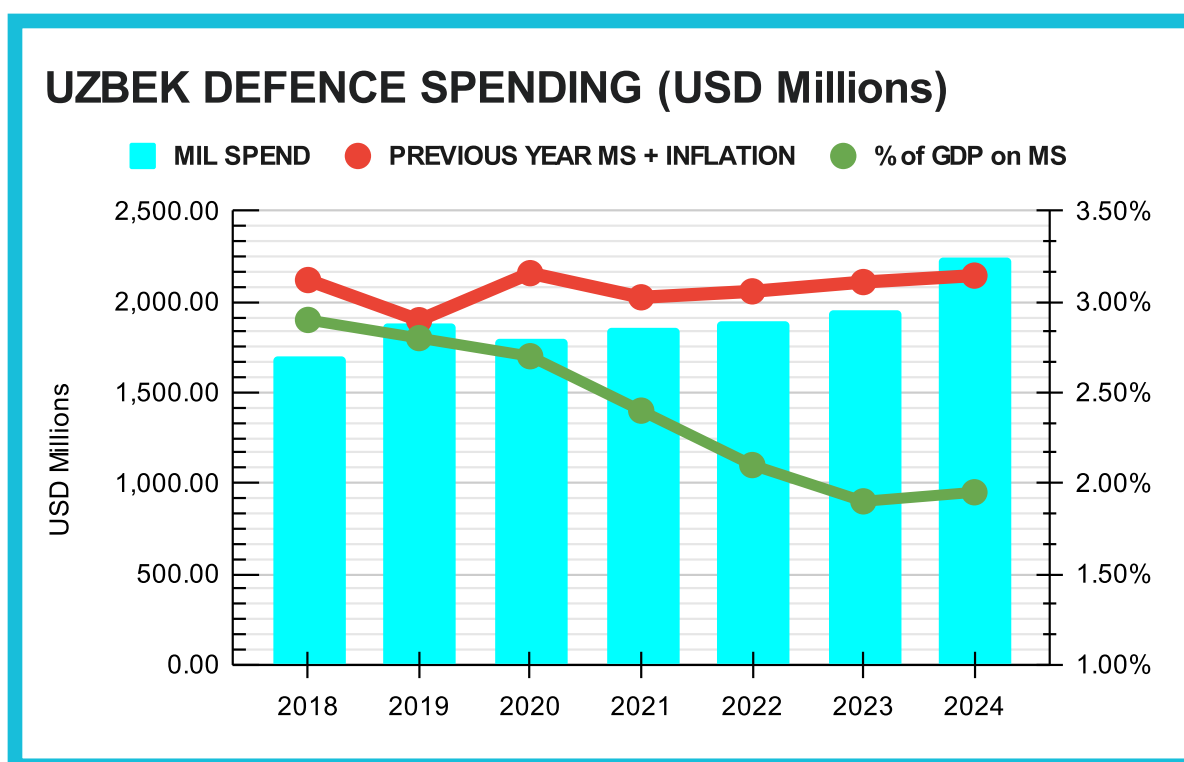
(Figure 4.6.7: Photo (top) of the Gyurza-class Saikhun on patrol near Termez.

Source: Naval Analyses)

(Figure 4.6.8: Satellite imagery (bottom) of the Riverine Naval Base in southern Termez)



4.7: PROCUREMENT AND DEFENCE BUDGETS



(Figure 4.7.1: A graph depicting Uzbek defence budgets over time in millions of US dollars. The cyan columns illustrate Uzbekistan's total military spending, the green line illustrates that defence spending as a percentage of national GDP, and the red line illustrates the amount of spending required to maintain the previous year's expenditure when adjusted for inflation)

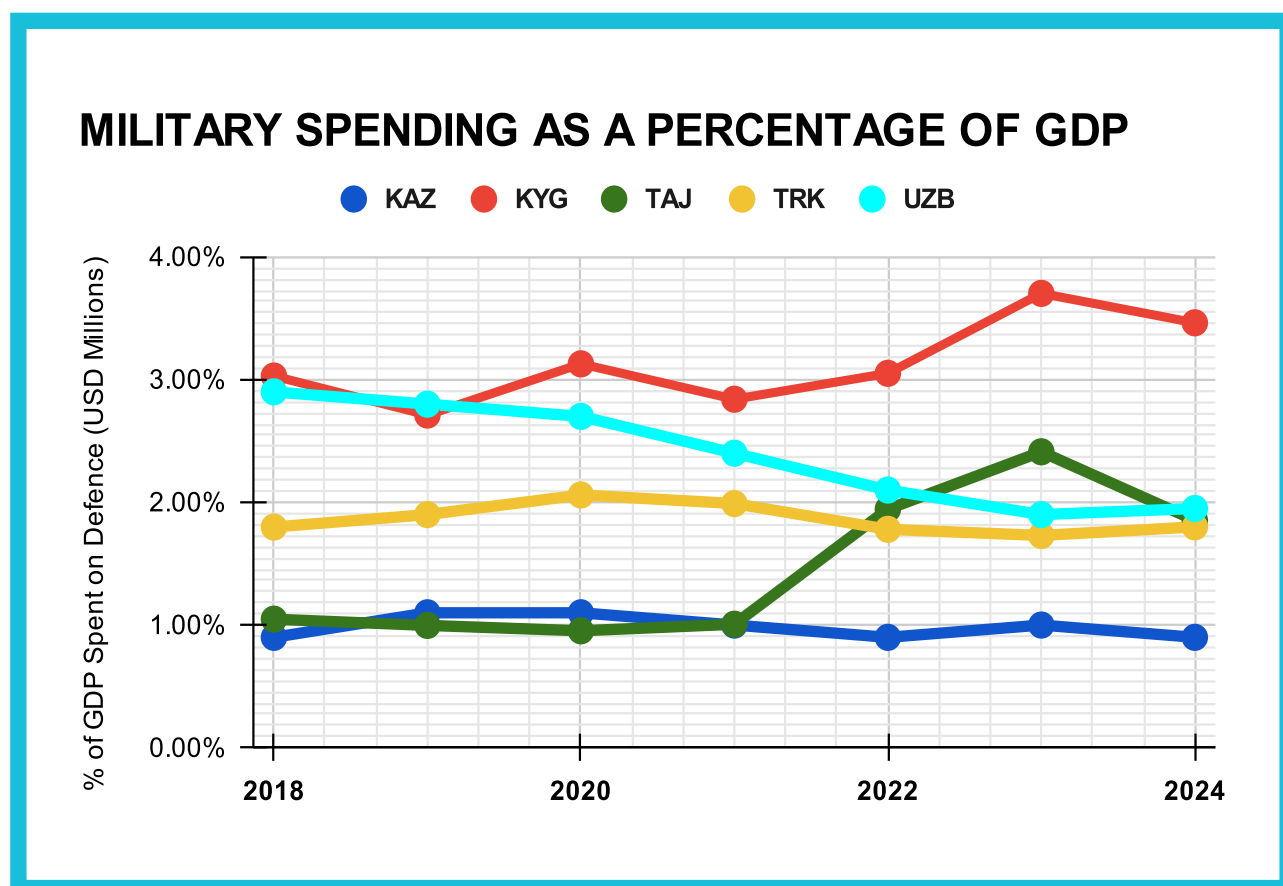
Coming into 2017, Uzbekistan enacted a substantial increase in defence spending to help stabilise the country during its first presidential transition. Since then, the defence budget has continued to rise, albeit more slowly than the wider economy. This level of spending remains significant by regional standards, but as a percentage of Uzbek GDP, it is a step down from the post-transition peak. When assessing these figures, it is also important to note that while Tashkent's nominal outlays are likely to keep growing over the next decade, this trajectory should be assessed against the country's persistent 9–15 per cent inflation and the rising sustainment burden that comes from maintaining so much legacy inventory. As Figure 4.7.1 indicates, Uzbekistan's absolute defence spending (cyan) must at least meet the "prior-year outlays + inflation" reference line (red) in order to just maintain the military's real purchasing power, but Uzbekistan has rarely reached this benchmark since 2019.

A SPECIAL THANKS TO OUR PARTNERS AT FORECAST INTERNATIONAL FOR THEIR INVALUABLE ASSISTANCE IN SOURCING FINANCIAL DATA AND OFFICIAL BUDGETARY FIGURES FOR THIS CHAPTER.

FORECAST
INTERNATIONAL

4.7.1 - Defence Budgets and the Economy

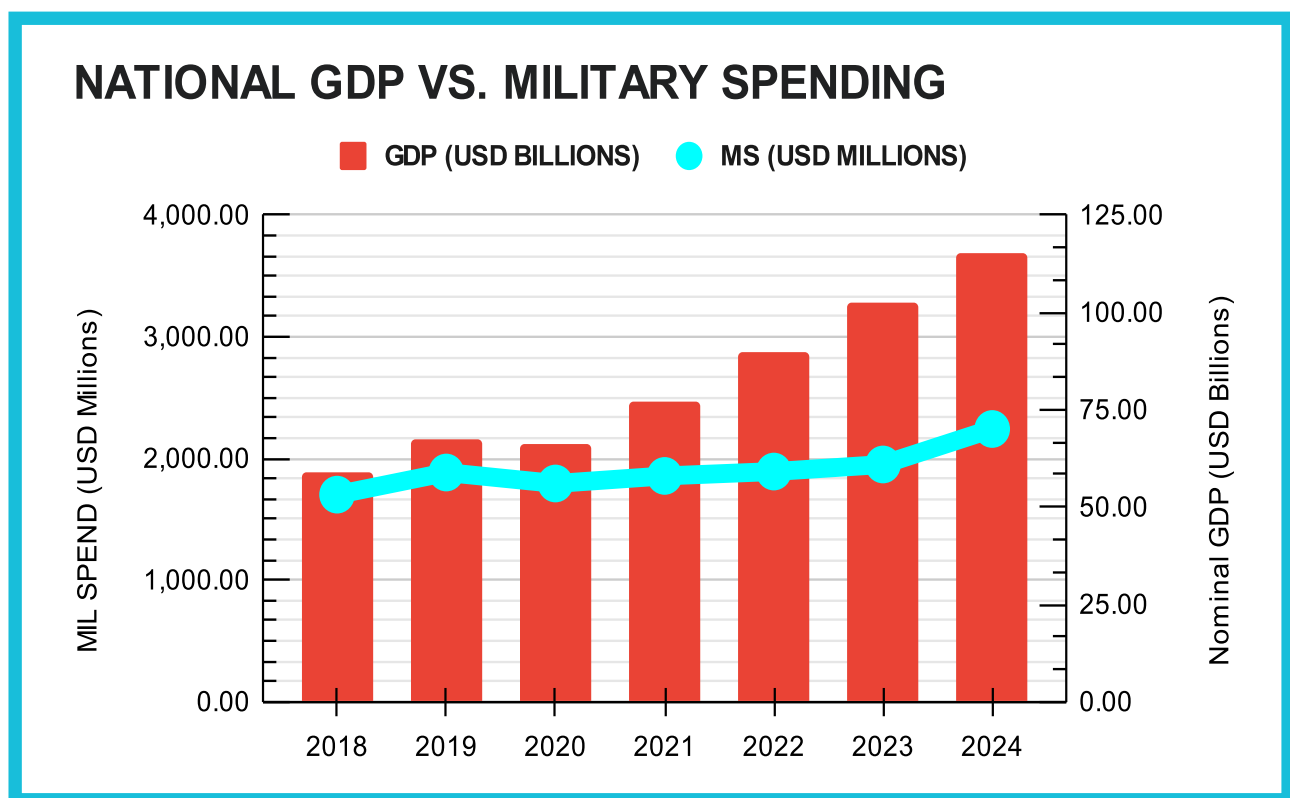
As expected, defence spending in Uzbekistan is highly opaque and difficult to quantify, with the country classifying its entire military spending under the “other expenditures” line item in the national budget. However, through an aggregation of export contracts with more transparent countries, government announcements, and credible estimates from subject matter experts, it appears that Uzbekistan now typically dedicates approximately 2-3 per cent of its GDP to defence-related activities annually. This rate of spending places Tashkent in close competition with Kazakhstan for the region’s highest overall defence expenditure in most years and usually ranks Uzbekistan within the top three in terms of the percentage of GDP spent on defence.



(Figure 4.7.2: A comparative graph for defence spending as a percentage of national GDP across the countries of Central Asia between 2018 and 2024)

However, while Uzbekistan had maintained similar levels of defence spending as Kazakhstan from 2018 – 2022, this spending has arguably failed to translate into corresponding levels of military capabilities within its armed forces. As even during this period, Kazakhstan continued to hold a notable capability edge over Uzbekistan in several key areas like air defence, logistics, and technology integration. This disparity between the two states is also likely to widen as time goes on, with Kazakhstan undergoing a large jump in military spending from 2022–2024, increasing its spending to a point where it now outspends Uzbekistan by 10–15 per cent. Particularly when accounting for realised spending and fluctuations in PPP, these figures and trends illustrate a gradual erosion of Uzbekistan’s comparative strategic posture in the region, where while Tashkent will likely remain well ahead of the bottom three, it is slowly conceding its near-parity position at the top with Kazakhstan.

Despite the country achieving a nominal GDP growth of 95.86 per cent over this same period, Uzbekistan's defence outlays have failed to keep pace with this growth, and have instead remained broadly flat, only growing by 31 per cent from 2018 - 2024. Ordinarily, such an expansion in the national economy would usually be matched by commensurate increases in the military budget; yet, as Figure 4.7.1 indicates, spending was essentially steady. Had Tashkent permitted defence spending to remain at the 2018 level of spending as a percentage of GDP, the 2024 allocation would have placed Uzbekistan 30 per cent above Kazakhstan, rather than the reality where they are falling 10 - 15 per cent behind. In practice, the Uzbek government has instead channelled most of these additional funds toward other areas like law enforcement, social programmes, infrastructure, and industrial policy, an allocation that is fairly defensible given the current period of relative domestic stability within the country.

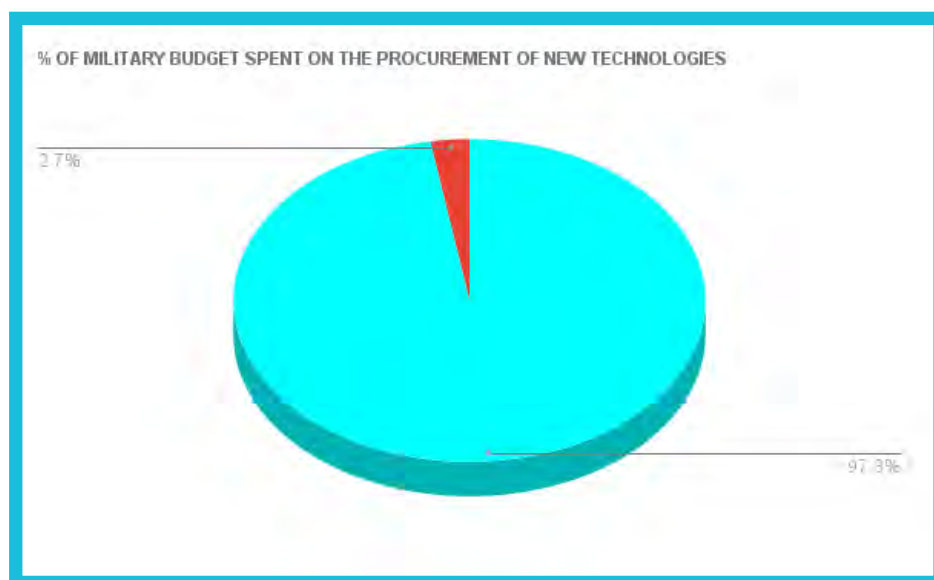


(Figure 4.7.3: A comparative graph comparing national GDP (red) and annual military spending (cyan), illustrating the much steeper growth within the wider economy, illustrating that economic growth has outpaced increases in the defence budget over this same period)

This diversion of funds away from the military has further constrained capability though, with most of the remaining military budget still being expended on line items like personnel costs (wages and pensions), sustaining their “top-heavy” officer corps, and preserving the nation’s mobilisation structures, regardless of the low probability that nationwide mobilisation would ever be required. To mitigate some of these structural constraints, Tashkent is pursuing a number of flagship reforms. One of which being the further professionalisation of the force to try and reduce the fiscal burden that comes with maintaining an oversized conscript base. Another reform being an attempt to improve some of the nation’s military procurement by prioritising lower-cost, high-utility platforms, such as UAVs and MLRS’, over previous priorities such as capital-intensive fighter fleets and heavy artillery brigades.

These reforms are regularly cited in official remarks, but largely remain in an early stage and, so far, are confined to limited pockets of the force. A good example of why these reforms continue to face delays is illustrated in Figure 4.7.4, where at present, Uzbekistan only allocates around 5 per cent of its military budget toward the procurement of new technologies and platforms for the military. The bulk of procurement funds is instead being spent on modest quantities of modernisation kits, essential consumables, and spare parts for ageing platforms and infrastructure. There have been some notable modernisation projects like the Uzbek's Lochin program, or the release of their prototype for a modernised T-64, but these have so far only been produced as prototypes or in small quantities.

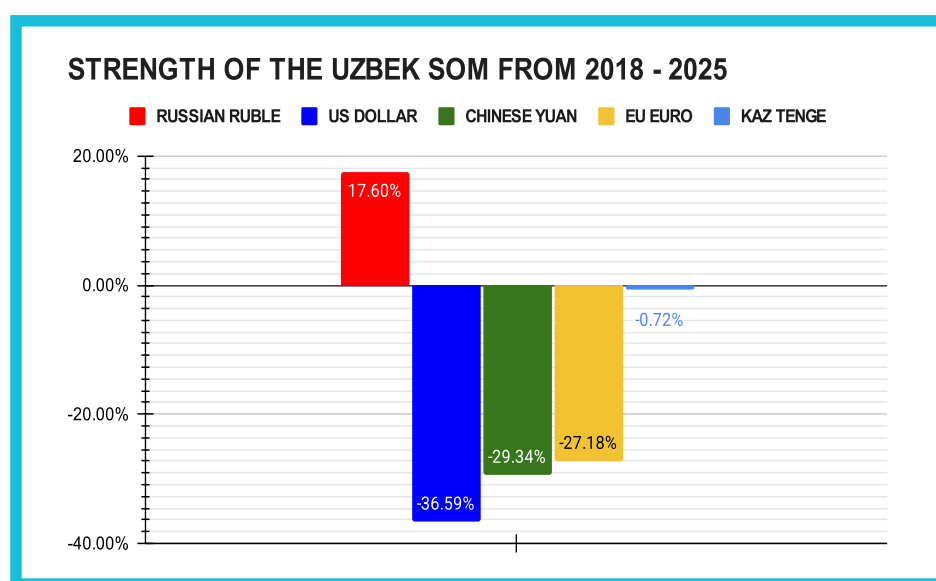
*(Figure 4.7.4:
A pie chart
illustrating the share
of the Uzbek military
budget allocated
for the acquisition
of new technologies
and platforms in
2021 (red) against
the rest of the
defence budget
(cyan))*



At some levels, Tashkent is also seeking to diversify more of its procurement needs away from Russia, and toward nations like China and Turkey. Some of these purchases, like the FD-2000, or the Bayraktar TB2, have both provided significant capabilities to Uzbekistan within those roles. However, while helping to reduce the country's reliance on Russia, it should be noted, that this shift toward diversified procurement is proving to be far more expensive and operationally difficult than many outside commentators assumed it would be. Reportedly, Tashkent has found that many of these non-Russian platforms not only carry higher upfront prices and tighter export-control compliance, but in the short-medium term, they also impose substantial integration, training, and sustainment burdens on the Uzbek's legacy logistics and systems. Financing terms for these programmes also shape some of the decision-making here as well, with the Uzbek military often opting to stick with Russia, over China or Turkey, in order to minimise their immediate maintenance outlays, rather than committing the significant capital required to overhaul the force's current inventory. As a result, many Uzbek commanders appear to be choosing to delay these expenditures by simply ignoring the issues, cannibalising older platforms for spare parts, or extending existing platforms' service lives with low-cost modernisation kits. Moscow has sought to capitalise on this spending aversion by offering Tashkent soft credit and resource-linked barter for defence materials. By contrast, Western and Chinese vendors typically require hard-currency payments in dollars, euros, or yuan, with fewer concessional features and limited offsets for most military purchases. The net result of these discounts from Moscow has been limited purchases from these alternative countries, and Russia remaining the primary arms supplier for Uzbekistan going forward into the short-medium term.

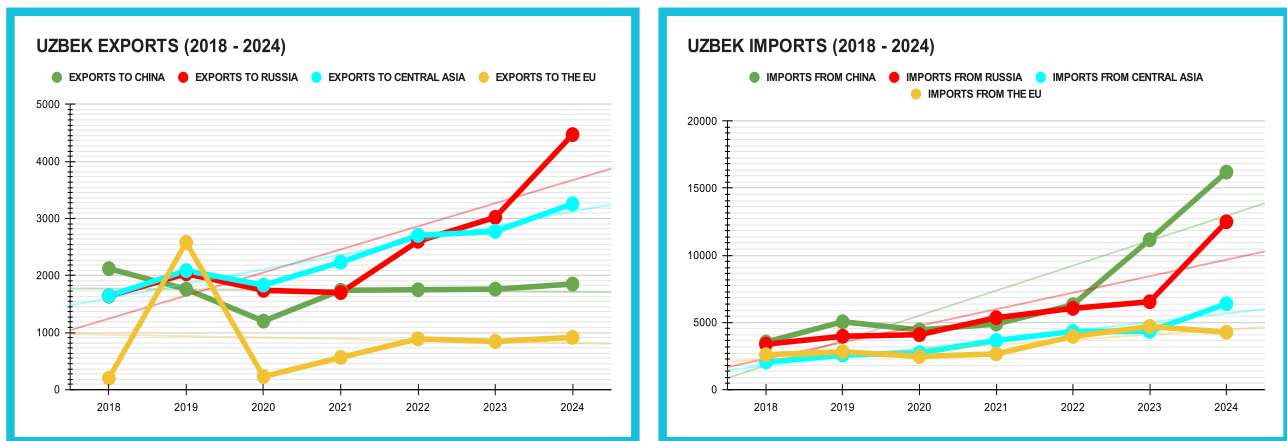
These slower reforms, along with Uzbekistan's continued dependence on Russian arms sales, have already created complications for Tashkent in recent years. To begin with, Russia's invasion of Ukraine introduced severe shortages of incoming consumables within the Uzbek military, predominantly due to the strain placed on Russia's domestic arms manufacturing capacity by the war, with nearly all of Russia's output being prioritised toward either the war effort, rather than the export market. The ongoing war in Ukraine has significantly impacted all of the countries that continue to rely on Russian-made equipment, as when these shortages of Russian stock hit the market back in early 2022, all of these usual purchasers now faced much more intense competition for the limited remaining supply of Russian arms available on the export market. For Uzbekistan to secure the same amount of materials as before, this would have required Tashkent to drastically increase their procurement budgets in order to outbid nations like India, China and Kazakhstan. Instead, Tashkent chose to avoid these price rises where possible, purchasing fewer materials from Russia. Consequently, from early 2022 to mid-2024, only minimal quantities of critical ammunition, weapons, and replacement parts were exported to Tashkent, resulting in prolonged delays and extended repair schedules for Uzbekistan's platforms. While there has since been some stabilisation in the Russian arms market, with Russia's production capacity expanding to a point where it can now somewhat meet both its wartime and export demands for basic military consumables.

Discounted loans, and increased Russian supply aren't the only factors keeping Tashkent militarily reliant on Russia though. Another concerning factor for Uzbekistan being the weakening of the Uzbek som against several major world currencies. In 2023 alone, the som lost 8.8 per cent of its value against the US dollar, 12 per cent against the euro, 6 per cent against the yuan, and 10 per cent against the Kazakh tenge, and while it has gained some strength back against the Tenge in 2025, the som is still significantly down from its 2021 positions against the dollar and yuan. This depreciation of the som means that purchasing equipment or technology from these alternative powers has become significantly more expensive for Uzbekistan. The only major currency the som has really held its value with over that same period was the Russian ruble, with the som having remained in a relatively stable position against the ruble since 2018. This weakening of the som against all of these non-ruble currencies not only increases the real-term prices of Chinese and Western arms, but also helps to perpetuate a vicious cycle for Uzbek procurement, where Tashkent becomes increasingly financially incentivised to save money by purchasing more of its equipment from Russia.



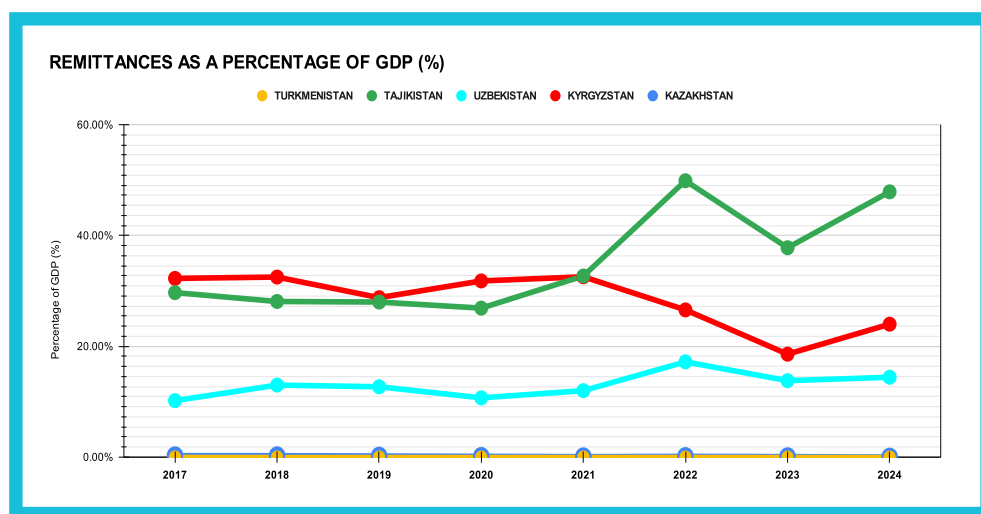
(Figure 4.7.5: A graph illustrating the changes in the bilateral exchange rates for the Uzbek som from January 2018–January 2025, with the Som gaining strength against the ruble, and losing strength against the US dollar, yuan, euro, and tenge)

These dynamics pushing Uzbekistan toward Russia are also taking place within other sectors of the economy as well, as since the beginning of the pandemic, the Uzbek economy has experienced a growing uptick in the amount of incoming remittances from Uzbek workers in Russia as a percentage of its national GDP. Uzbekistan's heavy reliance on these Russia-sourced remittances not only creates a deep structural vulnerability and a channel for coercive leverage by Moscow, but these inflows, which are predominantly denominated in roubles, result in Uzbek households and the wider state facing elevated FX and convertibility risk as the rouble depreciates and settlement frictions rise. The resulting ruble–som co-movement also encourages currency substitution and increased amounts of Uzbek expenditure being nudged toward Russian goods and services, again deepening Tashkent's reliance on Moscow for trade, sustinment, and wider security dependencies.



(Figure 4.7.6: (top-left) A comparative graph showing the value of goods exported by Uzbekistan and their destinations between 2018 and 2022, with exports to Russia (red), the other four Central Asian republics (cyan), China (green), and the EU (yellow))

(Figure 4.7.7: (top-right) A comparative graph showing the value of goods imported by Uzbekistan and their destinations between 2018 and 2022, with imports from Russia (red), the other four Central Asian republics (cyan), China (green), and the EU (yellow))



(Figure 4.7.8: A graph illustrating the percetage of national GDP made up by remittances from (2018 - 2024), with Uzbekistan (cyan), Kazakhstan (blue), Kyrgyzstan (red), Tajikistan (green) and Turkmenistan (yellow))

To put these currency issues into simpler terms, if a hypothetical Uzbek family paid 10,000 som for a loaf of bread in 2023, due to domestic inflation, that same loaf now costs 11,055 som in 2024. However, if the family were to instead go online and order a similar loaf of bread from Russia, the weakened ruble would mean they would only pay the equivalent of 9,333 som, making it cheaper to buy from Russia, and therefore, driving up the demand for Russian bread. Conversely, if the Uzbek family were to instead try and avoid purchasing from Russia, and instead choose to buy their bread from the United States, the som's weakening against the dollar would result in the bread costing 11,372 som, making the US option 21.84 per cent more expensive than the Russian one. This means that even with the Uzbek's increasing reliance on Russia causing the som to lose ground against all of the other global currencies, market forces are still encouraging Uzbek consumers to continue compounding their trade with Moscow.



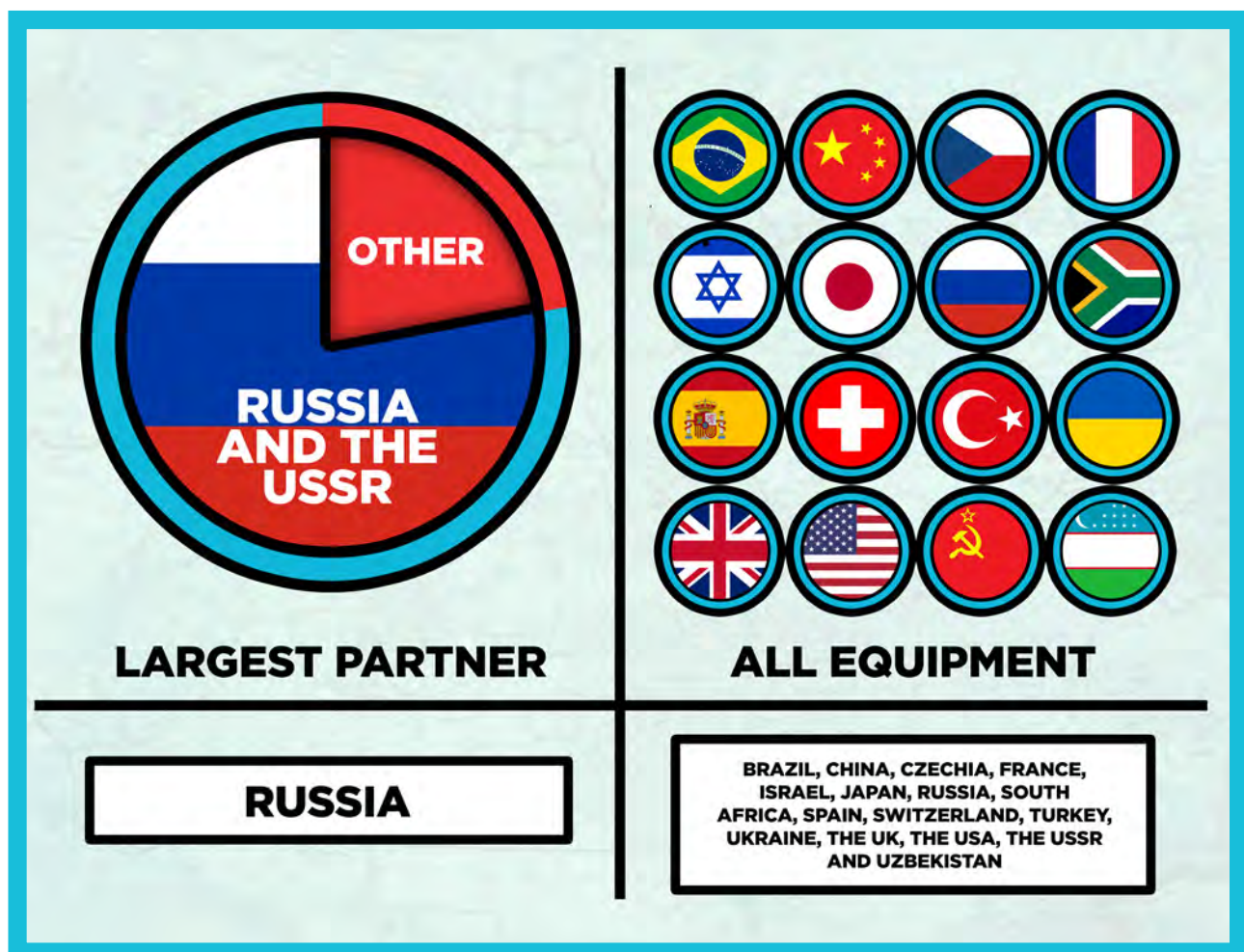
(Figure 4.7.9: A chart illustrating the price differences for a theoretical Uzbek shopper purchasing a generic good (bread being our example) from various markets. For simplicity, we assume that all stores were selling the same good at the equivalent price of 10,000 som in 2023, with no additional costs for importing the bread into Uzbekistan. As illustrated in the diagram, by 2024, domestic inflation will raise the price at the Uzbek bakery by 10.55 per cent. However, due to their lower inflation and comparatively stronger dollar, the Uzbek buyer will see the price at the US bakery increase 13.55 per cent. While the price at the Russian bakery, who has comparatively lower inflation, slower wage growth, and a substantially weakened ruble, makes it cheaper for Uzbek buyers to purchase their bread from Russia, with the real price for the bread falling 15.67 per cent compared to 2023)

These market-led shifts in household spending toward Russian goods, reinforced by the rising share of rouble-denominated remittances coming into Uzbekistan's GDP, only further amplify many of Uzbekistan's existing macroeconomic pressures. These shifts also widen the current-account deficit, increase foreign exchange (FX) pass-through into prices, and help sustain some of the elevated inflation seen in the country. Uzbekistan's recent growth has largely been underpinned by commodity exports like gas, cotton, and precious metals, but these favourable terms-of-trade that helped drive that growth are also likely cyclical rather than structural. As a result, any subsequent downturn in these markets would both depress non-rouble FX inflows and likely push more Uzbeks to seek work in Russia, which in turn would then only further increase exposure to rouble cash transfers. The net result is deeper dependence on Russian financial channels and supply chains, a more fragile external position, and less strategic freedom for Tashkent.

4.7.2 - Procurement Preferences

Historically, Uzbekistan's military procurement patterns have closely aligned with its foreign policy stances. For instance, from the mid-1990s until the early 2000s, Uzbekistan exhibited an increasing preference for Western military technologies, with this shift further solidifying after the US invasion of Afghanistan. It was also during this period that Uzbekistan formed a strategic partnership with Washington and Berlin, resulting in nearly \$75 million worth of military assistance being donated by Washington toward the Uzbek armed forces, including several of the key recapitalisation projects still in use today.

However, the relationship with the US became strained after 2005 when the George W. Bush administration openly criticised the Karimov government for its handling of the events at Andijan. This subsequent breakdown in relations, coupled with the US' growing preference for using the transit hub at Manas (in Kyrgyzstan), prompted Karimov to turn away from the US and back towards the more politically flexible Russia. Now, nearly two decades on, Russia remains the primary supplier for most of Uzbekistan's arms and platforms. However, given the financial and manufacturing constraints of the Russian defence industry, the Uzbeks have been forced to more seriously pursue external procurement partners for a select number of key items such as drones, MRAPs (mine-resistant, ambush-protected vehicles), and SAM systems.



(Figure 4.7.10: A chart illustrating the countries from which Uzbekistan's military platforms have been procured or manufactured (right), alongside a pie chart showing the proportion of these platforms that were produced in either Russia or the former Soviet Union (left).

4.7.3 - Vehicles and Ordnance Procurement

Tashkent are actively pursuing the integration of several new systems and platforms within its military and security services. According to a report by *Izvestia* in July 2019, the Uzbek arms procurement market was poised for significant growth, with projections suggesting that the overall market value of the Uzbek defence market could reach as high as \$7 billion by 2029, provided the right products align with Tashkent's defence requirements. This is all coming about as Russia has been eager to boost arms sales with its existing partners in an attempt to offset the loss of several nations that cancelled their military contracts following Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine. In its dealings with Uzbekistan, Russia has even relaxed its policy of requiring arms transfers to be paid for in hard currency, reportedly permitting Uzbekistan to purchase weapons using cotton and natural gas as payment. Consequently, Uzbekistan has been able to acquire a substantial number of armoured vehicles and upgrade kits from Russian suppliers for a price well below what they would have paid before 2022. Beyond these modernisation kits and upgrades being purchased from Russia, the majority of newly purchased vehicles appear to be various IMVs and MRAPs. The justification being that these fast-moving armoured vehicles are not only relatively cheap to maintain and supply, but these vehicles are also becoming increasingly prevalent across multiple branches of the Uzbek forces. To further bolster its inventory of such vehicles, Tashkent has been encouraging the signing of memorandums of understanding (MOUs) between the Turkish firm Nurol Makina and the Uzbek company UzAuto, with these agreements allowing Uzbekistan to domestically produce the Yalçın III vehicles under a Turkish licence. Under this deal, it is anticipated that Uzbekistan will manufacture approximately 1,000 of these vehicles locally, with the indigenous version of the vehicle being produced under the name Tarlon.

(Figure 4.7.11: An Uzbek Tarlon. Source: Defence Hub)

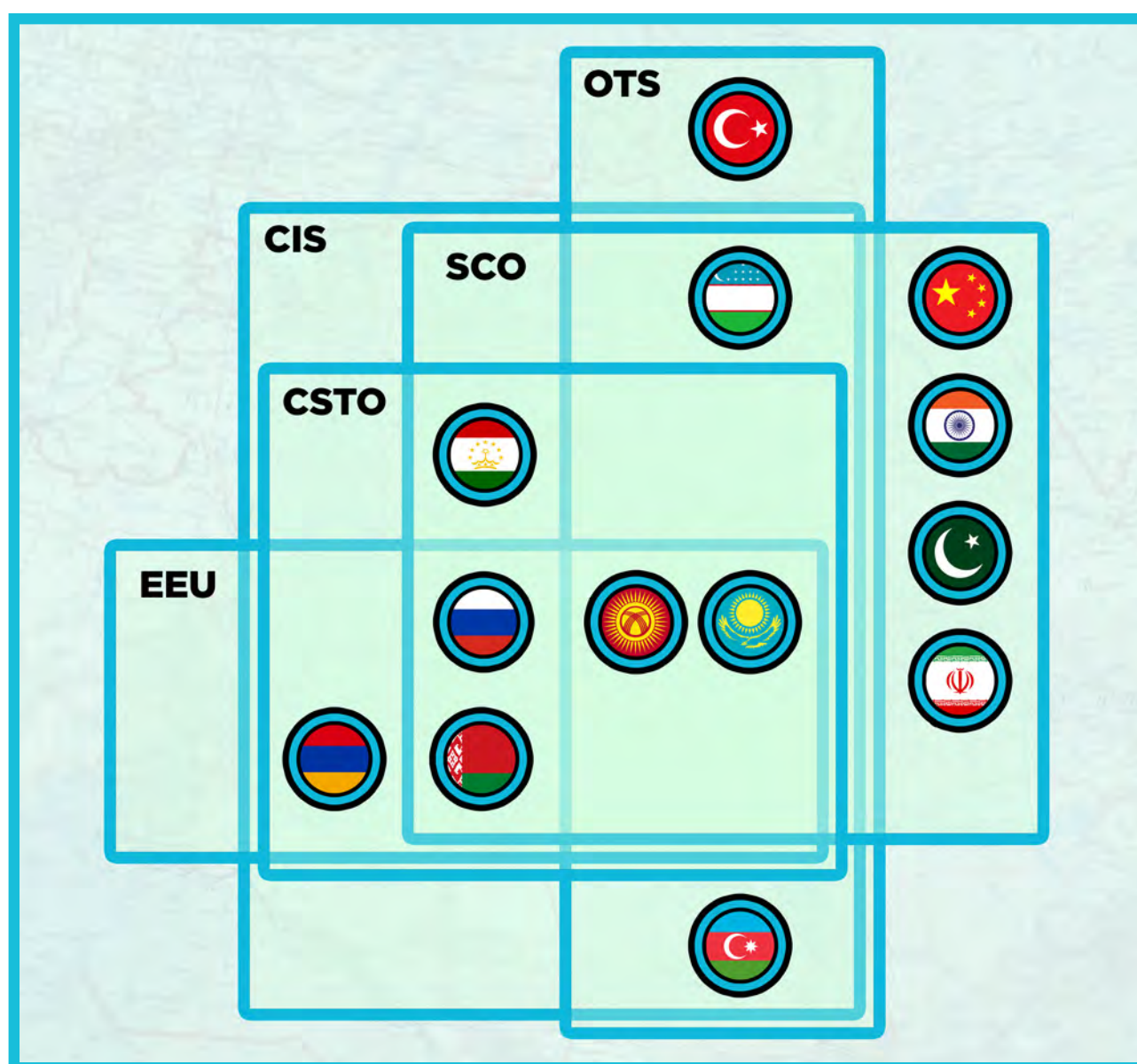


4.7.4 - Aircraft and Air Defence Procurement

As discussed in section 4.5, the real competition in the region lies within the intensifying market for drones, with drones being domestically built in four of the five Central Asian states, and all five beginning to purchase increasingly larger fleets for their militaries. To date, Uzbekistan has purchased drones from suppliers in the US, Turkey, China, Russia, and Israel, with these drones having already entered into service with the UZAADF and the SSS. More importantly though, Uzbekistan is now working with Turkish suppliers to manufacture its own domestic UAV's, the Lochin, a prototype of which was unveiled in January 2022. This move places Uzbekistan near the forefront of the regional arms race in drone technology, alongside Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan, all of whom are producing their own variants of Turkish or Iranian drones. With Tajikistan assembling Ababil-2 drones for Iran, Kyrgyzstan manufacturing its own Turkish drone variant, the SAARA-02, and Kazakhstan producing direct copies of ANKA drones under licence from Turkey. With the effectiveness of these drones having already been repeatedly demonstrated on the battlefields in Libya, Karabakh, Batken, and Ukraine, all of the Central Asian militaries recognise the transformative impact these cost-effective drones can have on the modern battlefield. Consequently, each of the republics, but especially Uzbekistan, are taking the production and integration of these UAVs into their force structures very seriously, even if that integration comes at the expense of other modernisation or procurement programs.

4.8: ALLIANCES AND FOREIGN DEPLOYMENTS

Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan stand out in Central Asia as the only two countries without foreign military bases or installations on their territory. However, while Uzbekistan does not host foreign bases, it does engage in military agreements and cooperative deployments with other nations.

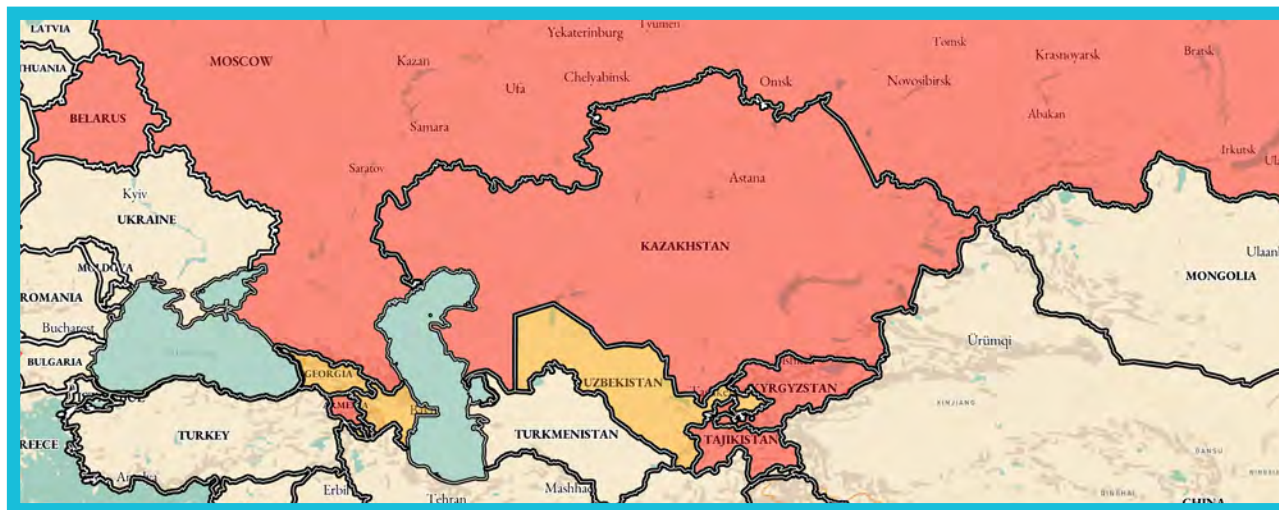


(Figure 4.8.1: A diagram illustrating the organisational overlaps in the region, including the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS), the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO), the Collective Security Treaty Organisation (CSTO), The Organisation of Turkic States (OTS) and the Eurasian Economic Union (EEU), with Uzbekistan being a member of the CIS, SCO and OTS)

4.8.1 - Alliances and Partnerships

At present, Uzbekistan is not a member of any formal military alliance. However, there are several key organisations with which Tashkent either formally or currently chooses to collaborate with:

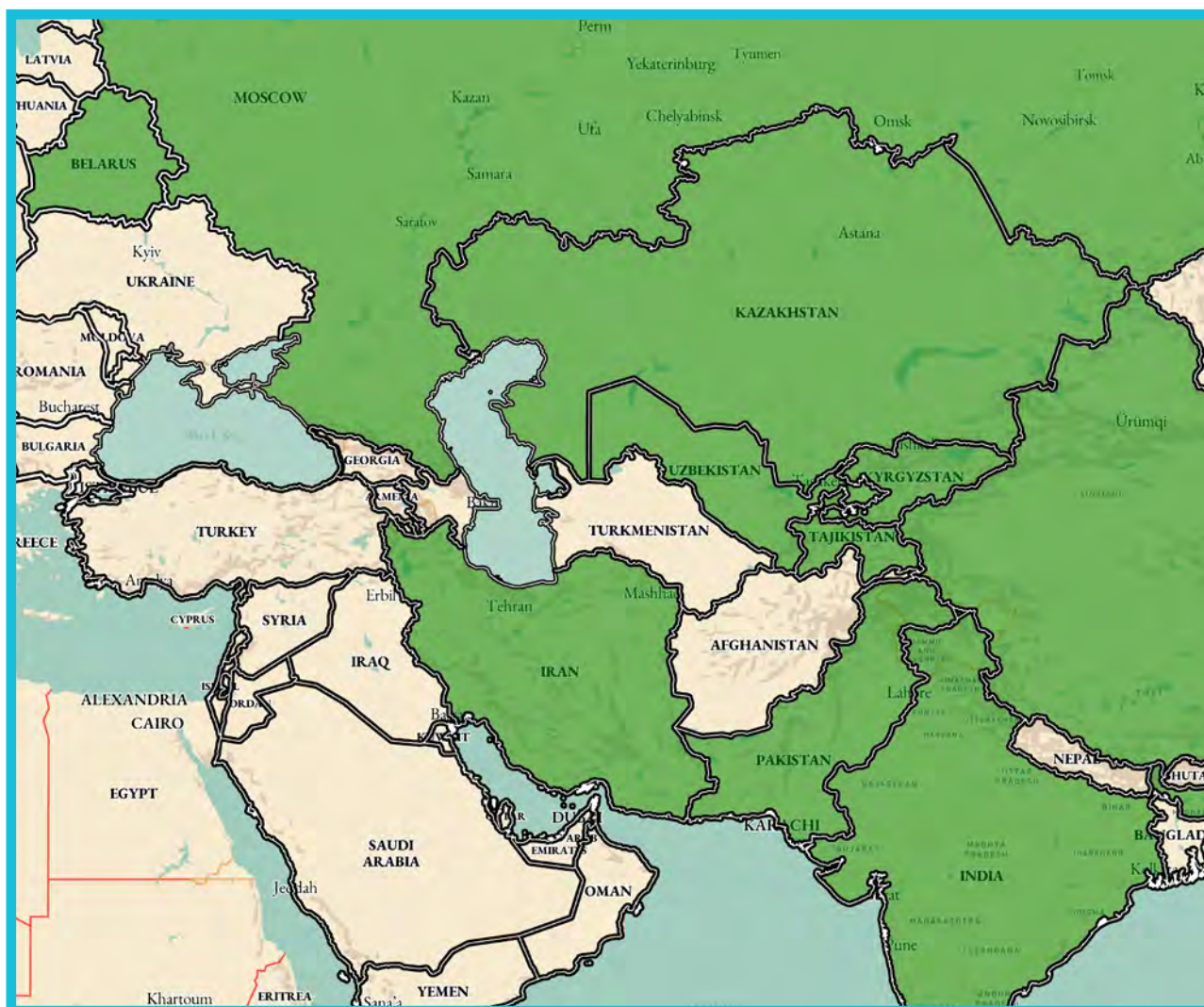
i) - Collective Security Treaty Organisation



(Figure 4.8.2: A map showing the current CSTO member states Armenia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Russia, and Tajikistan (red), and the organisation's former members Azerbaijan, Georgia, and Uzbekistan (orange). However, Armenia's continuing participation within the organisation has been put in question recently, with Yerevan announcing intentions to leave)

Uzbekistan was previously a member of the Russian-led security alliance, the CSTO, as well as its predecessor, the Collective Security Treaty (CST), during two distinct periods, from 1994 to 1999 and again from 2006 to 2012. Uzbekistan had initially joined the CST in 1994 alongside most of the former USSR states, at the time, still being highly dependent on military aid and support from Moscow. However, over the 1990s, where Uzbekistan began to gain its own military sufficiency, President Karimov began distancing the country from the Moscow-led alliance in an attempt both to assert greater national sovereignty over Uzbekistan as a whole, as well as to strengthen ties with the US and NATO. However, it was only after the subsequent resurgence of Islamic radicalism towards Russia and its partner states, as well as Moscow's growing momentum toward a second war into Chechnya, that Uzbekistan (along with Azerbaijan and Georgia) would officially exit the CST in April of 1999. During this period and into the Global War on Terror (GWOT), Uzbekistan would greatly increase its ties with the US and NATO, even going as far as to host multiple NATO bases within its territory. However, after the Bush administration's criticism of Tashkent's handling of the events in Andijan, Karimov would quickly pivot away from its Western partners and back toward Moscow and its allies, with Tashkent rejoining the CSTO in 2006. Moscow helped facilitate Uzbekistan's return to the organisation by extending generous economic and political support packages as well as offering Tashkent highly preferential loans and pricing on Russian arms and equipment. However, Tashkent's renewed membership into the CSTO proved brief, as Uzbekistan once again withdrew from the organisation in 2012, this time in protest of the establishment of the Collective Rapid Reaction Force (CRRF). In reality, though, despite Tashkent leaving the CSTO to pursue a more neutral foreign policy, Uzbekistan still maintains a highly collaborative relationship with the alliance, regularly participating in joint exercises and sharing information with its various security apparatuses.

ii) - Shanghai Cooperation Organisation



(Figure 4.8.3: A map of the SCO member states (green): Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan, and Uzbekistan)

Established in 2001, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) has undergone significant evolution since its inception, with Uzbekistan, as a founding member, playing a key role in supporting the organisation's original mandate and subsequent expansions. The SCO's primary objectives include promoting regional stability, combating terrorism, and enhancing economic cooperation among its member states, with Uzbekistan benefiting from both the economic agreements, as well as the strengthened security collaboration facilitated by this grouping. One of the key benefits for Tashkent being the SCO-established Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS), which aims to coordinate cross-border counterterrorism analysis and operations between each of the member states. However, to date, the organisation scope of the RATS group is still somewhat limited, only facilitating some intelligence sharing on terrorist groups, and not functioning as a regional military task force. In addition to its limited mandate, there have also been some controversies present within the organisation, particularly regarding China's use of the framework to monitor Uyghur activists in other SCO member states. So for now, due to several of the organisation's member states having contradictory foreign policy goals and the limited organisation scope set by Beijing, the SCO is likely to remain a predominantly financial and soft-power alliance, rather than any sort of official military partnership.

iii) - The Organisation of Turkic States



(Figure 4.8.4: A map of the OTS member states (blue): Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Turkey, and Uzbekistan)

The Organisation of Turkic States (OTS), headquartered in Istanbul, was established in 2009 with the primary aim of enhancing multilateral cooperation among Turkic-speaking nations. The founding members, Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Turkey, have used the organisation to collaborate with one and other through a biennial summit of heads of state, a council of foreign ministers, and various committees and working groups focused on specific areas of cooperation. Uzbekistan joined the OTS in October 2019, hoping to both bolster its political and economic relationships with other Turkic-speaking countries, as well as capitalise on shared cultural and historical ties to attract greater interest and investment. While the OTS has yet to achieve the same levels of military, political, or financial clout that organisations like the CSTO or the SCO enjoy, it does serve as a useful platform for regional communication between these member states. To date, Turkey and the OTS have only been able to effectively leverage the platform to promote limited investment initiatives, facilitate some basic cross-governmental exchanges among members, and enhance cultural interactions within the region, and while these initiatives are commendable and have been well-received by the member states, it still remains somewhat uncertain whether the organisation will evolve beyond being anything more than just a vehicle for advancing Turkish investment programmes and basic cultural exchanges.

4.8.2 - Foreign Deployments by Uzbekistan

Since gaining independence in 1991, Uzbekistan has consistently maintained a conservative approach to the deployment of its armed forces beyond its borders, engaging in overseas operations only when national security interests are directly implicated. This restrained posture is underscored by a limited history of foreign deployments, with the most significant being Uzbekistan's involvement in the Tajik Civil War during the early 1990s, but even then, Tashkent's engagement in the intervention was not only undertaken in coordination under the CSTO framework, but Uzbekistan's contributions to the intervention were deliberately limited to logistical support, the provision of materiel, arms, and supplies. This instance, aimed at preventing the establishment of a radical Islamic government in Tajikistan, being one of the few occasions when Tashkent deemed the threat to be significant enough to warrant an intervention. Beyond this operation, Uzbekistan's overseas military activities have remained minimal, and aside from a brief cross-border incursion into southern Kyrgyzstan in 2010, Uzbek deployments abroad have been confined to only non-combat roles, primarily focused on military exercises and humanitarian assistance missions. This trend was exemplified in 2023 when Uzbekistan dispatched search-and-rescue teams to Turkey following a major earthquake, highlighting Tashkent's preference for international engagements that enhance regional goodwill without entangling the armed forces in extended combat operations.

4.8.3 - Foreign Deployments into Uzbekistan

Historically, Uzbekistan has hosted bases and substantial deployments of troops from actors such as Russia, the US and Germany, providing basing for Russian units from 1867 to 1999. However, once those Russian units had left the country, and in the aftermath of the 9/11 attacks, the United States, NATO, and Germany somewhat replaced Moscow by establishing military positions within Uzbekistan. The United States securing a lease on the Qarshi-Khanabad airbase in southern Uzbekistan, (commonly known as K2), and the Germans basing themselves closer to the Afghan border near Termez. At its peak, K2 served as a major hub for US military operations in Afghanistan, hosting military transport aircraft, combat aircraft, and more than 1,300 American personnel, making it the largest US airbase in Central Asia at the time. However, with the governments in Tashkent and Washington falling out in 2005 over the events in Andijan, the Uzbek government expelled the Americans, citing their alleged support for local radicals and international terrorism. Contrastly, while the US forces quickly vacated their positions at K2, with the last US soldier leaving the base in November of that year; the small German garrison of approximately 300 personnel deployed to the southeast were allowed to remain functioning within the country right up until the beginning of the Afghanistan wind down in 2016. Under Karimov, Uzbekistan pursued a policy of mostly distancing itself from military alliances and basing agreements, culminating in 2012, when Tashkent announced a ban on any future foreign military bases within Uzbekistan. Years later, President Mirziyoyev would subsequently introduce a whole new series of military doctrines, that significantly altered Uzbekistan's foreign military policies. However, rather than drastically divert from Karimov's stances, like he had for the UIT and national trade policies, he instead chose to maintain his predecessor's stance against permanent foreign military deployments on Uzbek soil, stating that Tashkent is in no hurry to reopen foreign bases. Since then, lower-ranking American representatives have voiced some interest in returning American armed forces to Uzbekistan. However, it appears that little progress has ever been made on this front.

4.9: POTENTIAL FLASHPOINTS

Although we consider the likelihood of a major interstate conflict within this region to be relatively low, analysing possible military flashpoints through the results of wargaming exercises can provide valuable academic insights into the capabilities and vulnerabilities of the Uzbek armed forces, with this report identifying two hypothetical scenarios that may challenge Uzbekistan's defence. The aim of this analysis is not to suggest these scenarios are likely to occur, but to explore how the Uzbek military might respond or prepare for such situations.

4.9.1 - Islamic State Incursion into Southern Uzbekistan

In the first scenario, we examine the events following an insurgent attack on the southern Uzbek city of Termez, and the subsequent response by the Uzbek armed forces.



(Figure 4.9.1: Map of Uzbekistan, highlighting Termez (the site of our hypothetical IS invasion), Qarshi (the home of the SWMD headquarters), and Tashkent, the capital)

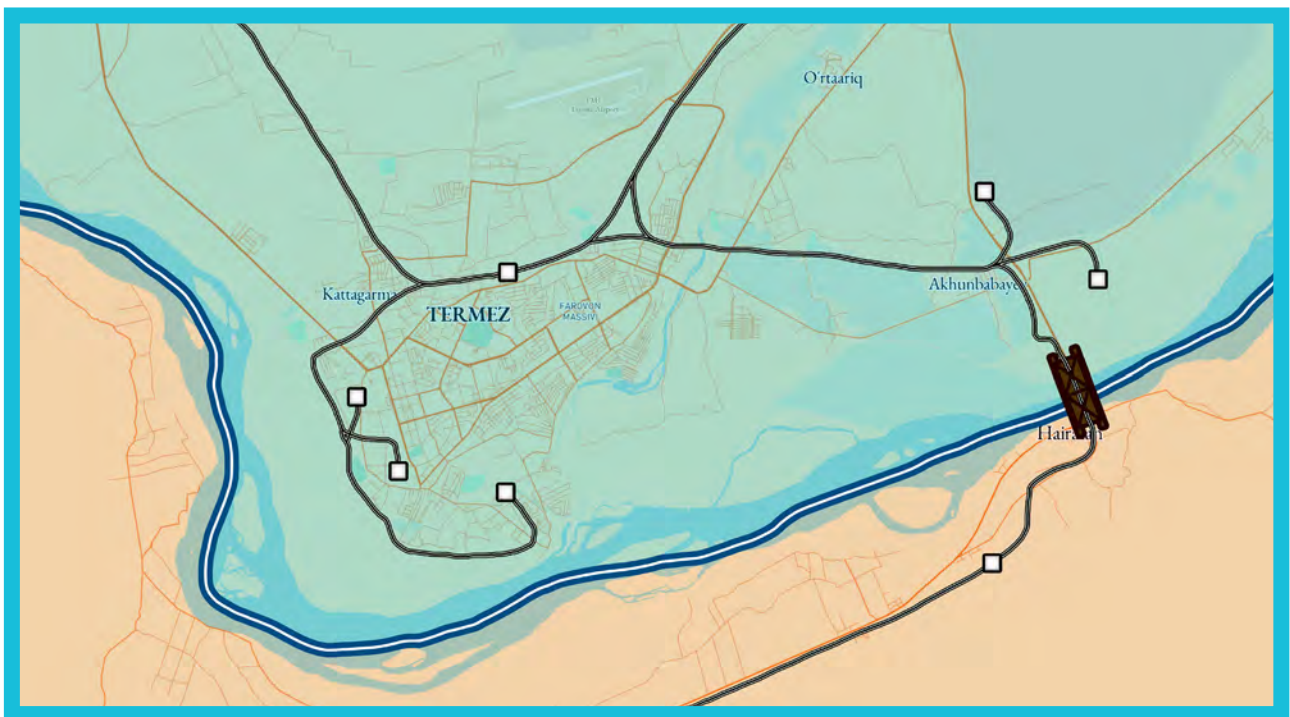
i) - Termez

Termez occupies a strategically vital position within Uzbekistan's national defence infrastructure, serving as a chokepoint for the movement of goods, people, and power infrastructure between Uzbekistan and Afghanistan, with the city's geographic location enabling Uzbekistan to effectively funnel and control all cross-border transit between the two countries. A key strategic feature of the city being its proximity to the Uzbek-Afghan Friendship Bridge (UAFB), the main crossing point for road and rail cargo entering Afghanistan.

*(Figure 4.9.2: The Uzbek-Afghan Friendship Bridge.
Source: Eurasiatravels)*



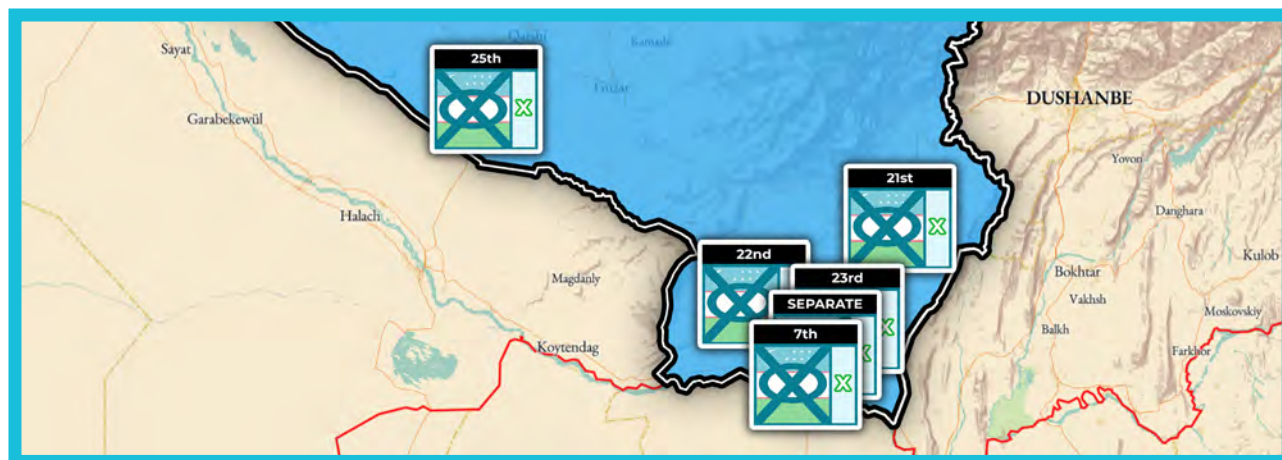
At present, the Uzbek military maintains a relatively extensive and well-prepared garrison here in the city. The contingent based here in the city being tasked with maintaining enough local capabilities and force strength to be able to effectively counter any potential threats launched from Afghanistan into Termez, as well as provide logistics and support to any military operations launched from Termez into Afghanistan. The garrison here includes some of Uzbekistan's best-supported troops alongside dedicated railheads, storage bunkers, armoured contingents, SAM-batteries, and better equipped command and control centres than most other contingents in the country.



(Figure 4.9.3: Map of Termez, with the locations of existing rail lines (black), the location of the Uzbek-Afghan Friendship Bridge (brown), and the border with Afghanistan (blue and white). Afghanistan's territory is on the bottom (orange) and Uzbekistan is along the top (cyan))

Due to the strategic importance of Termez, Uzbekistan maintains permanent garrisons of ground forces, UNG, and UIT here in the city. The city also hosts the URF base at its southern end and several border patrol posts along the Amu Darya River. These garrisons are well equipped with weapons, ammunition, and independent communications systems. This ensures that if any outpost comes under attack, all other garrisons in the city can be immediately alerted and begin coordinating an appropriate response.

The city is currently defended by garrisons from the SSS, the UNG, the MIA, and the MOD, with a significant number of other motor rifle, artillery, engineering, air support, and SOF units also positioned within 150 km of the city. This greatly facilitates the rapid and robust reinforcement of the Termez garrison if it were ever to be seriously threatened.



(Figure 4.9.4: Map showing the locations of Uzbek units stationed in the south of the country)

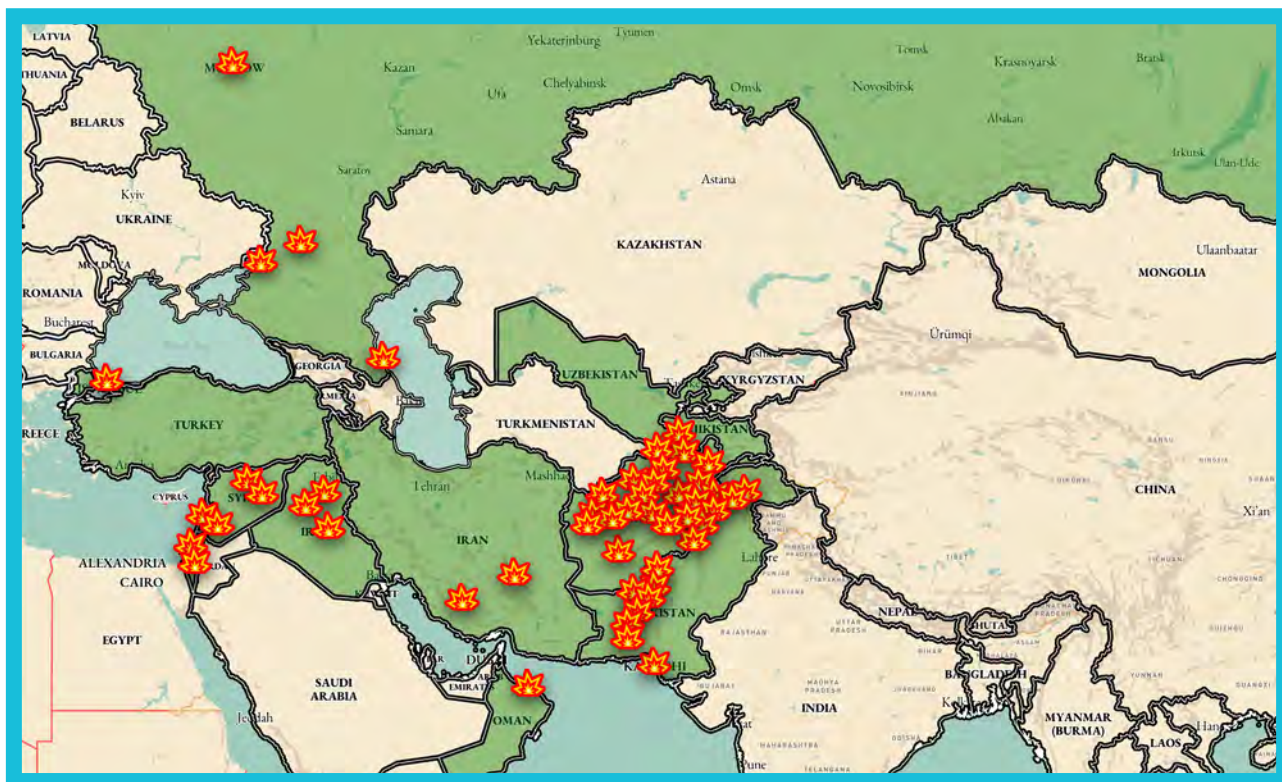
However, despite the relative strength of the garrison here in Termez, the city has still found itself coming under sporadic attack by ISKP forces in the recent past, with the group even firing rockets into Uzbekistan from Afghan territory as recently as 2022.

ii) - Islamic State Khorasan Province

The likelihood of an attack by Taliban-led forces into Uzbek territories is assessed to be exceeding low, as Kabul not only uses Uzbekistan as a bridge to the outside world, but Kabul is also highly reliant on Tashkent for electricity and inbound consumer goods. However, there are other groups operating within Afghan territory that pose some concerns for Tashkent. Non-state actors, including ISKP, IS, HUT, and previously the IMU, all remain significant concerns for defence planners across most of the Central Asian capitals. While IS-affiliated groups have been active in the region since 2015, recent years have seen an escalation in the scale and intensity of their operations here in Central Asia, particularly in northwestern Afghanistan. Since 2015, these groups have carried out hundreds of attacks across the region, including high-profile strikes in Russia, Pakistan, Turkey, and Iran. However, when limiting these attacks to just those carried out by ISKP, the majority of the group's activities have been somewhat geographically contained within Afghanistan, Pakistan and Central Asia, with the group instead often simply claiming responsibility for attacks executed by other IS affiliates. Regardless of who actually carried out the attacks though, this has raised the alarm among Eurasian defence planners, as ISKP's prominence appears to be expanding both in terms of media presence and operational reach. This is a concern for Uzbekistan, as these groups have all been calling for the overthrow of the governments in Kabul, Dushanbe, Ashgabat and Tashkent.

While there have been numerous attacks right across the region, the most notable in Central Asia took place in:

- Rudaki, Tajikistan (6 November, 2019)
- Termez, from Afghanistan into Uzbekistan (18 April, 2022)
- Saryk, from Afghanistan into Tajikistan (7 May, 2022)



(Figure 4.9.5: Map depicting the locations of IS, ISIL, and ISKP attacks across Eurasia since 2019, illustrating the concentrated pattern of activity in Afghanistan and Pakistan, while also highlighting the groups' expanded capabilities to strike further abroad. Countries impacted by these attacks have been shaded in green, with explosion icons marking the locations of cities targeted during this period)

These developments, coupled with a number of other high-profile incidents like the recent Crocus Hall attack, underscore the expanding operational reach of these IS-affiliated groups, with IS making continued efforts to recruit and deploy Central Asian nationals for terrorist operations across the region. According to reports, IS recruiters often directly target disaffected Uzbek and Tajik individuals living across Russia and the wider Eurasian region, using various methods ranging from pro-IS magazines to direct personal approaches. However, as notable as the Crocus attacks were though, at present, most of these IS strikes are still predominately limited to Afghanistan and Pakistan, as most of the IS affiliates currently lack the internal cohesion or military capacity to mount any sort of a significant conventional assault against a fortified city. Regardless of that though, these groups are still considered by Tashkent to be one of the more capable, and potentially dangerous, organisations operating here in Central Asia.

iii) - Tashkent's proactive defence

Having already faced significant challenges from Islamic extremist groups throughout the 1990s and 2000s, Tashkent is leaving no room for complacency in the defence of Termez. So in response to a range of perceived threats emanating from Afghanistan, the Uzbek government has adopted a notably proactive defensive posture across much of the SOC and SWMD. Tashkent's strategy here in the southern regions includes the enhancement of physical fortifications around critical infrastructure and C2 centres, as well as a marked increase in the deployment of drones, motorised platforms, and advanced surveillance and intelligence-gathering systems to support the units stationed in and around Termez.



(Figure 4.9.6: Satellite photography of the UAFB, with the Uzbek Frontier Service base in the north (bottom left) and the Afghan city of Hairatan in the south (top right))

For many years, the Amu Darya River has been Termez's most dependable barrier against any potential incursion from the south, with the river making crossings difficult and limits an attacker's options for crossing to just the UAFB. However, due to the Amu Darya's falling water levels and a progressively weakening current, the river's defensive utility has begun to diminish in recent years. During the summer months, specific stretches of the river can now narrow to just a few hundred meters in width, with the current also being slow enough to render some crossings potentially viable. The concern from Tashkent being that these now narrower sections of the Amu Darya could potentially create opportunities for lightly armed insurgent groups to bypass the defences around the UAFB, and instead directly strike into Termez using small personal watercraft. This brings us to our wargame scenario:

iv) - Assumptions and caveats

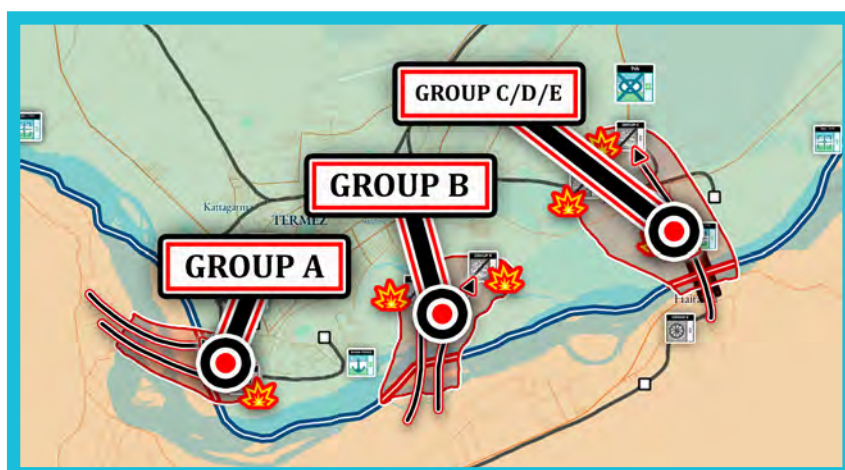
The scenario analysed here centres around a hypothetical attack on Termez by ISKP forces, with the assault originating from positions across the Amu Darya River in Afghanistan. For the ISKP team, the objective of such an attack would be to capture the city and establish a territorial foothold north of the Amu Darya, with hopes that victory here would grant the organisation additional credibility, as well as inspire sympathetic Islamic uprisings elsewhere in the region. However, to date, ISKP has shown limited success in assaulting, occupying, and defending urban areas, and are still yet to attempt anything like a cross-river invasion. Therefore, for the modelling of this scenario, our ISKP team will instead adopt the tactics and methods employed by their counterparts in the Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant (ISIL) as a basis and general framework for ISKP's tactics, techniques, and procedures (TTPs). Under normal circumstances, Uzbekistan's local aerial, naval, and electronic surveillance capabilities would likely detect any ISKP force buildup across the river in its earliest stages. This means that as soon as these concentrations began to form on the Afghan side of the Amu Darya, local Uzbek commanders would presumably begin preemptively repositioning additional reserve units closer to the riverbanks, redeploying additional rotary-wing and unmanned aerial assets toward forward airfields, and intensify their riverine patrols along that section of the river, all in effort to locate and monitor these new ISKP staging areas.

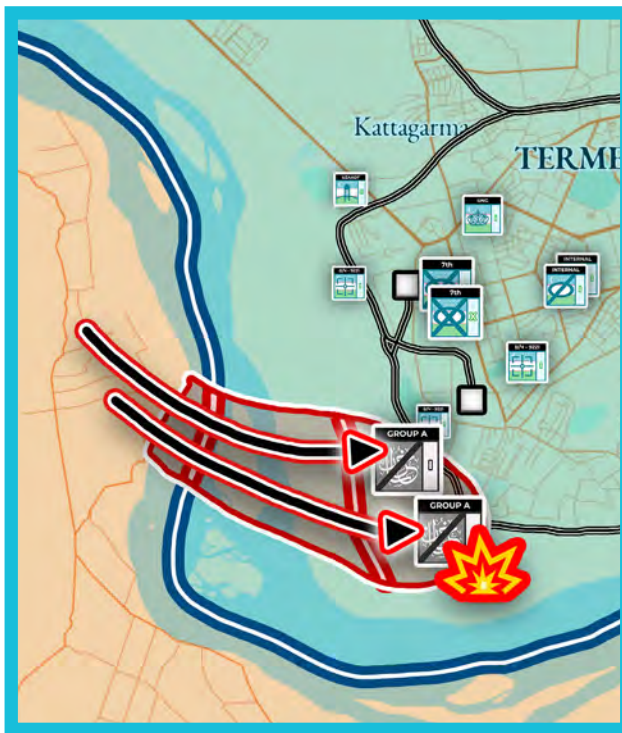
Once those positions were confirmed, or if ISKP were to attempt a crossing of the river, the now alert and pre-prepared Uzbek defenders would be well-positioned to easily repel any river crossing or incursion. Whether preemptively or in the wake of a failed crossing attempt, Tashkent would likely coordinate with Kabul to seek authorisation for strikes on Afghan territory. Once approved, Uzbekistan would deploy air assets, drones, short-range artillery, and precision missiles to directly engage the remaining ISKP forces on the southern banks. Such strikes would likely inflict significant losses on the now geographically concentrated group, and potentially cripple the organisation for the foreseeable future. However, for the purpose of this exercise, we will place our thumb on the scale and assume that the central command in Tashkent, the regional command in Qarshi, and the local commanders in Termez are all taken completely by surprise, and no troop movements or defensive preparations are made prior to the attack. To also make the scenario more feasible for the ISKP forces, we will assume that the attack takes place during the summer when the river flow is much lower, that the ISKP insurgents have all received some level of basic military training, and that they all have access to automatic rifles, light shoulder-fired rocket launchers, portable machineguns, and basic communications equipment that would grant them the ability to centrally coordinate their movements. Additionally, we also included the assumption that the ISKP forces faced no initial resistance from the local Taliban forces patrolling the area, and that these ISKP groups were allowed to build up on the Afghan side of the river completely unhindered. Combined, these assumptions grant the ISKP team an extraordinary set of advantages that would be highly unlikely to materialise under real-world conditions, but do help us to better examine the Uzbek's local defensive capabilities.

v) - The invasion of Termez

Prior to initiating the river crossing, ISKP units would consolidate from multiple locations across Afghanistan, assembling at staging areas near the city of Hairatan. The operational plan then dictates a two-pronged approach: the first two groups would cross the river using small recreational boats, while the third, fourth, and fifth groups would attempt to force their way across via the UAFB. Given that the initial boat crossings represent the most vulnerable phase of the operation, they would likely be conducted prior to any gunfire or direct assault on the bridge, in an effort to maintain the maximum element of surprise. The objective for these first crossings would be to quietly secure two footholds on the Uzbek side of the river, enabling ISKP to ferry additional waves of fighters and munitions across, establish rudimentary stockpiles, and consolidate their forces on the northern bank of the river. Once sufficient personnel and materiel are positioned on Uzbek territory, then the main offensive on the city would commence, leveraging the pre-established footholds to maximise operational momentum.

(Figure 4.9.7: ISKP forces (black) carry out nighttime incursions across the Amu Darya into Uzbekistan, exploiting the reduced frequency of riverine patrols at night to achieve tactical surprise and secure initial bridgeheads on the Uzbek side. ISKP-occupied areas are illustrated in red)



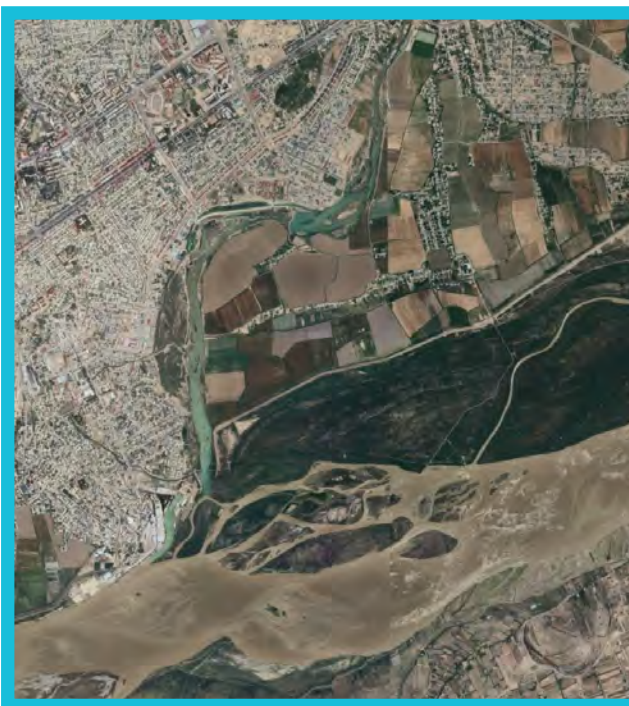


(Figure 4.9.8: Map of western Termez (left). The first group of insurgents (Group A) crosses the river into the marshy areas west of the city using small boats. Once a few groups have crossed, they begin their assault on the southwestern suburbs of Termez. These forces are lightly armed and carrying minimal supplies)

(Figure 4.9.9: Satellite imagery (right) of western Termez)

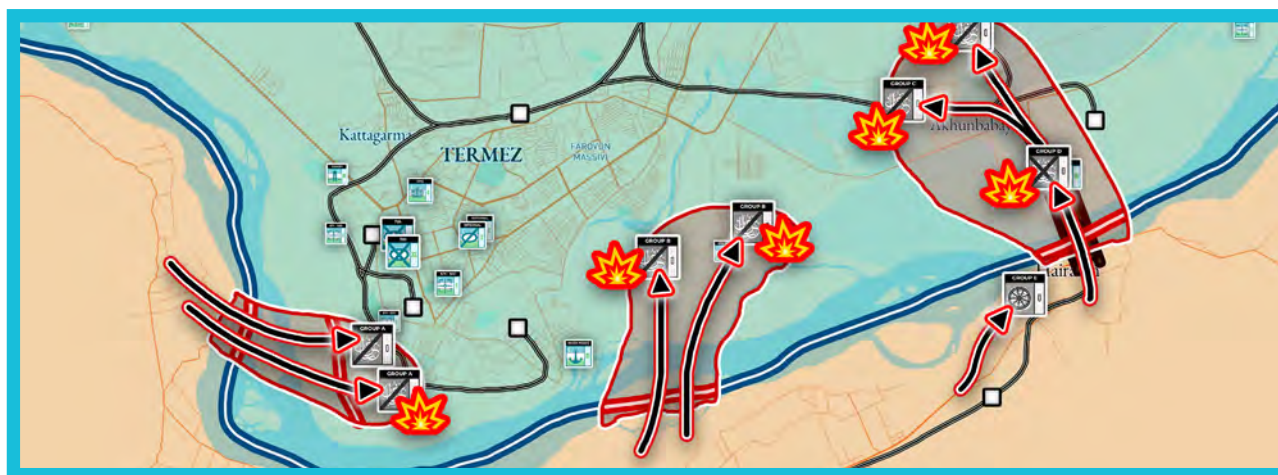
The initial group of insurgents (Group A) benefits from shorter crossing journeys and the relative cover provided by the small islands scattered between the opposing banks of the river. However, they face significant challenges once they reassemble on the Uzbek side. Crossing any body of water limits the amount of supplies and ammunition that can be brought into battle, meaning that the insurgents fighting on the Uzbek side of the river will only have access to the ammunition they could carry across in the boats with them, or what can be brought across from Afghanistan in subsequent river crossings. This is particularly problematic for a force like the one posed in the scenario, who would be expecting their cross-river supply lines to be cut off by the Uzbek Riverine Force as soon as the fighting starts. Under these limitations, Group A will find itself beginning their offensive into Termez, already running low on ammunition and supplies.

For Group A to have any hope of resupply, they will need to link up with Groups C, D, and E once they have crossed the bridge and can bring in trucks with supplies from Afghanistan. If this coordination proves unfeasible, Group A's only other alternative is to seize control of a small base or border patrol post, aiming to commandeer any weapons, food, or supplies stored there. However, should they deplete their limited ammunition before achieving this, the insurgents will be forced to abandon the operation altogether. Strategically, Group A's primary objective is not to occupy the entire city or any of the central bases but to create enough disruption and threat within the western outskirts of the city so as to divert the attention of the Termez garrisons westward. This manoeuvre is simply intended to try and hold these MOD, UIT and UNG forces within the city, preventing them from moving to counter the more critical assault groups crossing the bridge to the east.

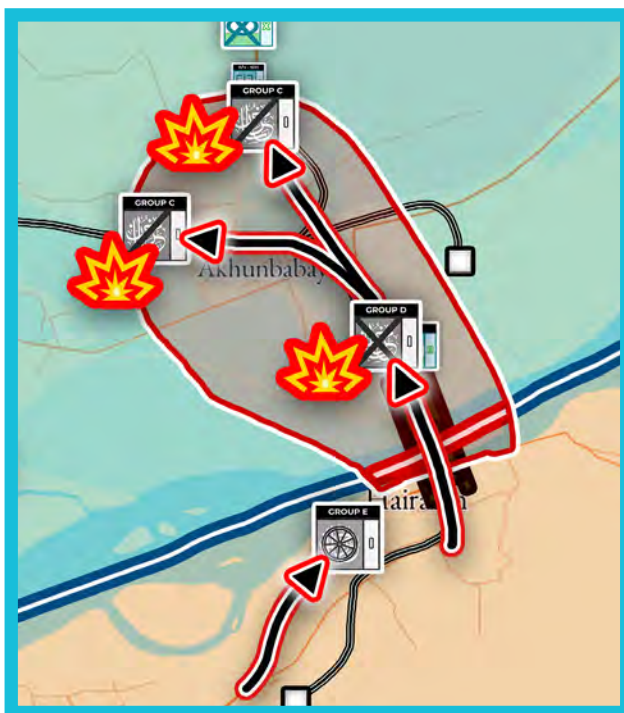


(Figure 4.9.10: Map of southern Termez (left). Simultaneously, Group B carries out a nighttime crossing of the river into Uzbekistan, reassembling in the marshy areas southeast of the city. Again, these forces are lightly armed and carrying minimal supplies)
(Figure 4.9.11: Satellite imagery (right) of southern Termez)

Similar to Group A, Group B can also make use of the smaller islands in the river to facilitate their crossing. However, like the first group, they will encounter significant limitations on the amount of weapons and supplies they can carry across. Therefore, Group B's primary objective is to secure enough ground to provide the main thrust across the bridge with the additional time required to establish a defensible foothold around the UAFB. This diversionary attack might involve attacking key facilities in Termez from the east, while the Uzbek forces are focused westwards on Group A's actions. Overall, Group B would still be regarded by most strategists as a diversionary force or raiding party, designed simply to dilute the enemy's response until they can be reinforced by the ISKP forces crossing the bridge to the east.



(Figure 4.9.12: Map of southern Termez illustrating the distances Groups C/D/E would have to travel in order to link up with Groups B and A)



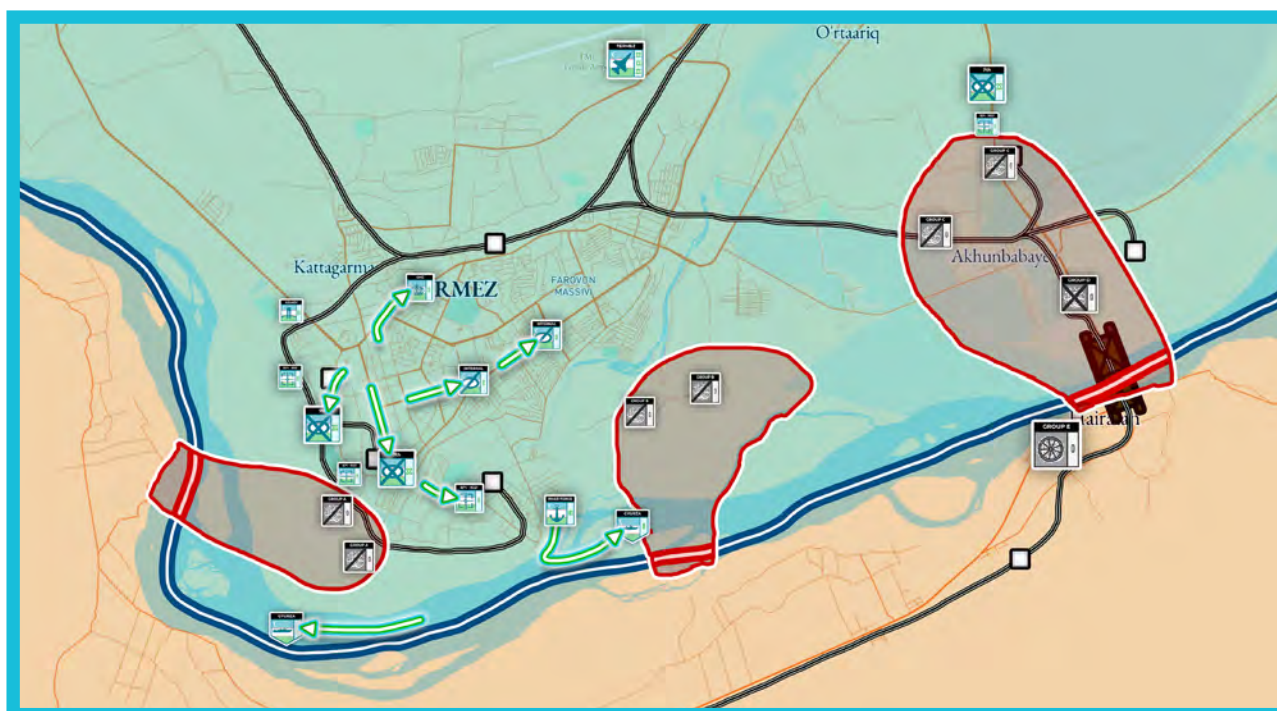
(Figure 4.9.13: Map of eastern Termez (left). East of Termez, Group D forces its way across the UAFB and begins its assault on the border outpost on the opposite bank. Meanwhile, Group C bypasses the UAFB outpost and attempts to widen the bridgehead. Group E then assembles on the Afghan side of the bridge, preparing to bring supplies across once the UAFB can be secured)
(Figure 4.9.14: Satellite imagery (right) of the UAFB bridge)

The primary ISKP offensive is anticipated to be spearheaded by Groups C and D. In such a scenario; Group D is likely to be comprised of the insurgents' best-equipped and most capable soldiers, operating a handful of light vehicles, such as technicals or stolen APCs. To stand any chance of success, these groups will need to force their way across the UAFB as swiftly as possible, aiming to leverage the element of surprise and quickly overwhelm the small garrison of frontier troops stationed at the facility. As if they were successful, it would then allow them to both control access to the bridge, as well as seize the weapons and supply caches stored at the base. Once the outpost is under attack, the comparatively lighter armed forces of Group C would then attempt to push out from the bridgehead created by Group D, aiming to push out and prevent the UAFB base from being reinforced by other Uzbek garrisons. Upon establishing a secure bridgehead on the northern bank, Group E's unarmed, and more vulnerable logistics convoys can then begin transporting additional supplies into Uzbekistan from Afghanistan.

This eastern thrust across the river is the most critical of the three planned operations, as it is the only one that provides a guaranteed land crossing for the ISKP forces. However, precisely because of its importance, this grouping is expected to encounter the most substantial resistance from the Uzbek defenders. ISKP commanders participating in the eastern thrust also face a unique challenge that does not affect Groups A and B. Unlike those groups, which have no direct route to withdraw back into Afghanistan, the forces nearer to the bridge still have that option open to them. Given the likely untrained and undisciplined nature of these insurgents, it means there is a significant risk that elements of the eastern force may break ranks and retreat across the river when confronted with the Uzbek's heavy vehicles, especially if they believe their escape route is about to be severed. Consequently, this eastern thrust is simultaneously the most crucial of the three operations, but also the one most at risk of collapse and rout.

vi) - The Uzbek response

Once the first shots are fired and the bridge is crossed, the UFS outpost will swiftly alert the other military branches based in Termez, ensuring that local commanders are fully aware of the situation unfolding in the east. These commanders will then begin coordinating with their counterparts in the city, as well as with the district command in Qarshi, the OC commanders in Termez, and the security officials in Tashkent. From here, each branch will then be tasked with a specific set of objectives, initially focused on stabilising the situation, before then transitioning toward eliminating the incursion. While these initial hours may feel chaotic for the residents of Termez, the Uzbek military's coordinated response, as it stands today, should be able to quickly impose order on the unfolding crisis.



(Figure 4.9.15: The various Uzbek forces, based here in Termez, all begin carrying out their respective tasks across the city, undertaking efforts to first stabilise the situation)

vii) - Ground Forces



Upon receiving orders, The 7th Motor Rifle Brigade will provide the bulk of the combat strength here in Termez. The 7th MRB's initial mission will be to both hold off and repel the eastern incursion across the bridge, and from there, move to sever the insurgents' supply lines from Afghanistan. While the 7th's primary base is located in the west of the city, they do have a number of other facilities and vehicles located at the training ground north of the UAFB, allowing for a rapid counterattack southwards toward the ISKP forces. To achieve this, the 7th will likely deploy a significant portion of their tanks, IFVs, and heavy weaponry while coordinating with other nearby MOD brigades for additional support and reinforcements. However, during these first few hours, the ground forces will likely rely on other branches to maintain the initial internal control of the city.

(Figure 4.9.16: Symbology for the Uzbek 7th Motor Rifle Brigade based in Termez)

viii) - National Guard



Despite the relatively small detachment of National Guard soldiers stationed here in Termez, these troops are highly trained and well-suited to the type of engagements anticipated in this urban environment scenario. During the early stages of the conflict, the National Guard will have two primary objectives. First, they must secure the city's administrative buildings. This would be done to ensure that command centres remain operational and that they can continue to serve as hubs for interdepartmental coordination.

Second, they will engage insurgents within the city, focusing on neutralising these threats as swiftly as possible while minimising damage to infrastructure and civilian casualties. Given their specialised training and equipment, these soldiers are expected to be particularly effective against insurgents who lack heavy weaponry or armoured vehicles.

(Figure 4.9.17: Symbolology for the Uzbek National Guard detachments based in Termez)

ix) - Ministry of Internal Affairs



In this scenario, the Ministry of Internal Affairs will coordinate two types of personnel within the city: the local police and the UIT. The local police will focus on maintaining public order, sealing off roads to civilians, evacuating residents where possible, and providing real-time intelligence on insurgent movements back to central command. The Internal Troops, however, will play a more direct combat role, as these troops are both better trained and equipped for such situations. Initially, UIT forces will likely work to prevent

insurgents from advancing further into the city, aiming to minimise their damage and footholds. Once the insurgents are contained, the Internal Troops will then shift to a more aggressive approach, actively engaging the enemy, reducing their area of control, and ultimately working to push them out of the city.

(Figure 4.9.18: Symbolology for the Uzbek Internal Troops based in Termez)

x) - State Security Service



Much like the MIA, the SSS will also be required to coordinate multiple categories of units within the city. The first of these being the UFS which, in this scenario, would have been the first to come under attack as insurgents crossed the UAFB. Although the border outpost on the Uzbek side of the bridge is more fortified than standard outposts elsewhere in the country, the UFS garrison stationed here is likely to be less combat-effective than other units within the city. This is primarily because

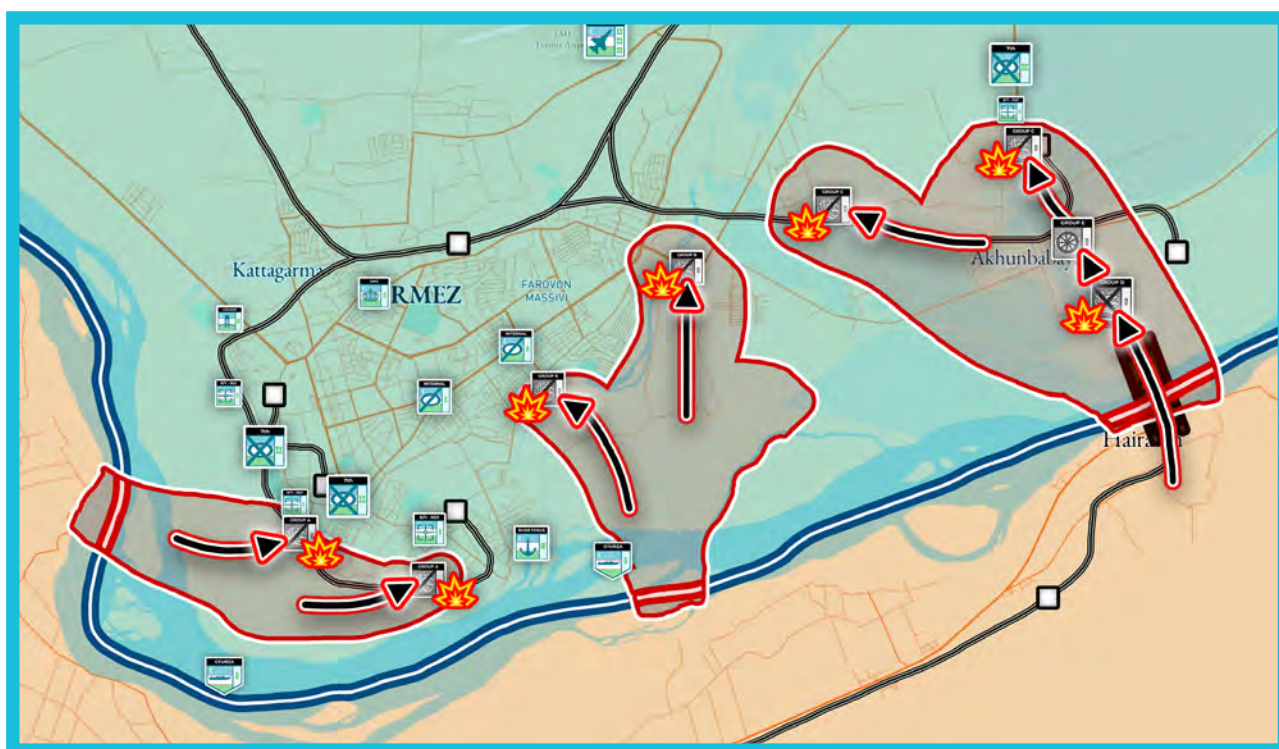
the UFS personnel spend more of their time operating the border checkpoint and inspecting vehicles, rather than training for conventional combat scenarios. Ideally, the UFS would be able to repel any force attempting to cross the bridge using the personnel and weapons at their disposal. However, given the severity of the scenario being examined, it is likely they would request additional support from other branches.

(Figure 4.9.19: Symbolology for the Uzbek Frontier Service troops based in Termez)

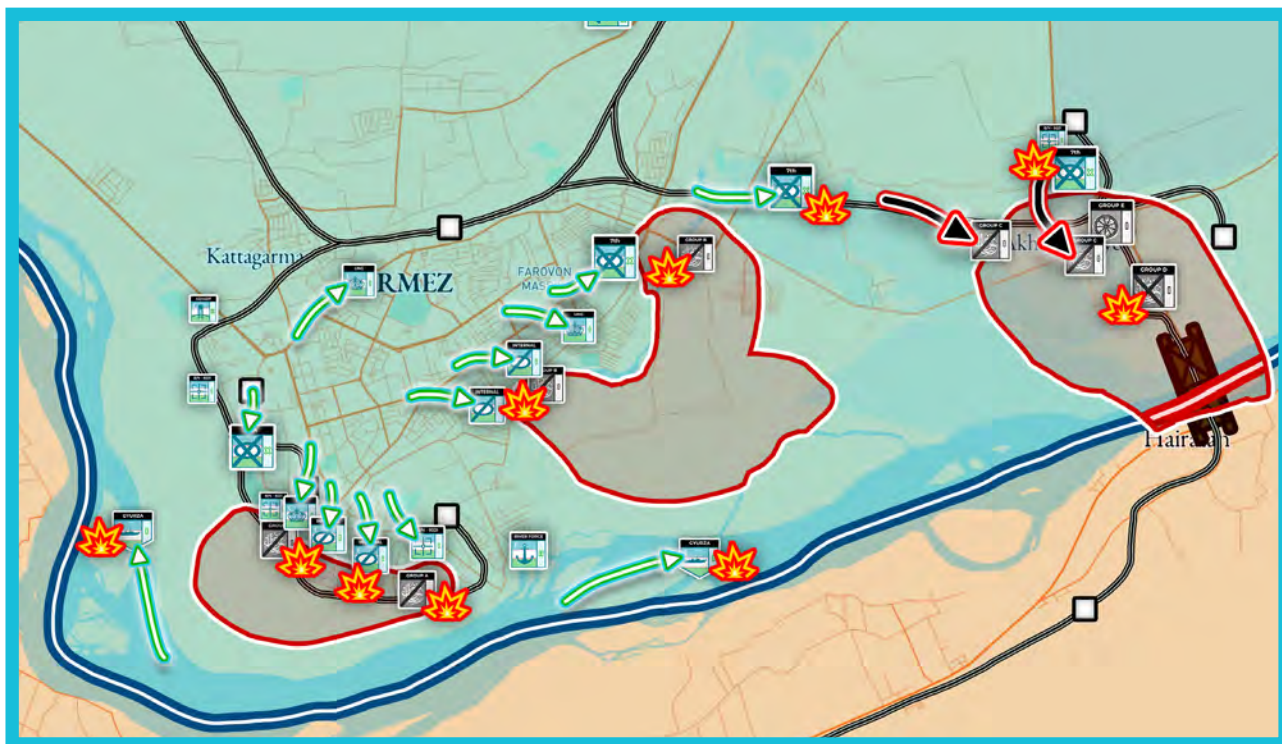
In addition to their ground-based personnel, the UFS also operate an extensive fleet of drones and ships here in the south. In response to such an attack, these drones would likely be deployed to loiter over the city and surrounding areas, locating insurgents, providing real-time tactical information, and potentially carrying out limited airstrikes on targets or vehicles. However, more significant aerial support and ground strike missions may fall under the responsibility of the UZAADF stationed at the Kakaydy Airbase, just north of Termez, rather than the Uzbeks solely relying on the UFS's UAV fleet. In addition to personnel and drones, UFS also commands the URF, which would likely be deployed to assist in such a scenario. In Termez, the URF operates a small fleet of gunboats capable of engaging unarmoured targets and other small river vessels. While these gunboats are not well-armoured and would require the force to exercise some caution, they would still likely be ordered to leave their port and provide additional fire support against any ISKP insurgents or supplies on the riverbank. If implemented, these measures could both deny additional ISKP boats or supplies from conducting subsequent river crossings and enable direct engagement of any caches or stockpiles positioned along the riverbanks.

xi) - Counterattack

Even in a worst-case scenario, if ISKP forces manage to establish a foothold on the Uzbek side of the river and then advance into the southern and eastern suburbs of the city, their position will rapidly deteriorate as their ammunition rapidly depletes. From here, the better-trained and better-equipped Uzbek forces will begin increasingly inflicting disproportionate losses on the insurgents.



(Figure 4.9.20: In a worst-case scenario, ISKP forces have managed to solidify and push out from their respective footholds. Group A is now engaged in firefights throughout the southern end of the city. While Group B, facing little opposition, advances into the eastern suburbs. Group D, despite significant losses, has occupied the UAFB outpost and successfully commandeered some of their weapons. Group E has also successfully crossed the river and is using Afghan or commandeered vehicles to transport ammunition from its central caches towards the front)



(Figure 4.9.21: The Uzbek counterattack is now well underway, aiming to dislodge and roll back all of the ISKP forces currently fighting on the Uzbek side of the river. The National Guard and Internal Troops are continuing to push Group A further south. Meanwhile, Group B now begins finally encountering significant resistance, and is unable to advance any further into the city.

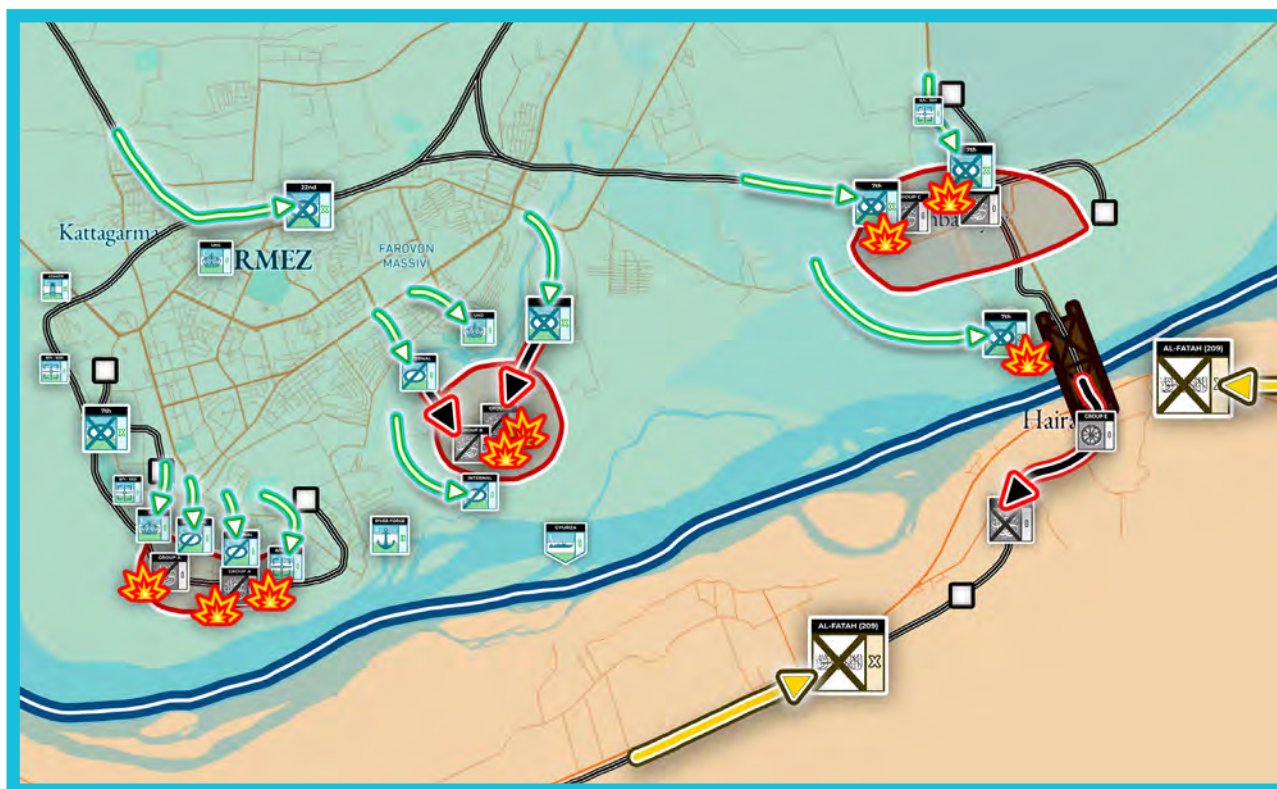
Group C's forces in the north have also now been directly engaged by Uzbek tanks and IFVs, causing some of them to break and retreat towards the bridge. While the URF has effectively cut off any escape routes back into Afghanistan via boat and provided light fire support against any ISKP assets located on the shoreline. Uzbek airstrikes are also likely to prove effective against ISKP vehicles and personnel, with multiple trucks that had been observed crossing the bridge earlier, are now being struck and rendered inoperable. Reinforcements from the 22nd Motor Rifle Brigade are also now beginning to arrive in the city, further bolstering Uzbek positions)

Once the insurgents have been contained and their advance into the city halted, the Uzbek counteroffensive can concentrate on expelling these forces from Termez entirely. Despite being the best-armed of the ISKP units, Group D is likely to be the first to face heavy fire and morale collapse, with both Groups C and D quickly finding themselves under direct assault from tanks and armoured vehicles. Given their positions further from the city centre and away from densely populated areas, the Uzbeks will also have greater flexibility to supplement these armoured advances with airstrikes and artillery to better dislodge the insurgents. This will create significant pressure on both these groups to break ranks and pull back via the UAFB.

In contrast, the UNG and UIT forces engaging insurgents in the western part of the city are expected to receive minimal air support and no artillery backing. Local commanders would likely refrain from using brute force tactics within urban areas, preferring more precise methods to avoid destroying city blocks or causing significant civilian casualties. Consequently, unlike their counterparts in the east, who could swiftly rout the insurgents, the Uzbek forces in the west would need to engage in more painstaking clearing of houses and defensive positions, point-by-point and block-by-block. Taking greater precautions to minimise collateral damage and civilian loss of life here will make for a slower clearing process in the western part of the city.

As observed with groups like ISIL and Boko Haram, irregular forces tend to break and retreat from poorly defensible positions when confronted by heavy artillery and armoured vehicles, often only leaving behind only a small contingent of highly motivated fighters to continue the resistance. While those remaining will likely bring some fanaticism to the fight, they will also be left with little ammunition and insufficient manpower and be overpowered relatively quickly. While the forces stationed in Termez are likely sufficient to counter this level of ISKP attack on their own, reinforcements from the garrison in Sherabad would be called in to help accelerate the situation and reinforce weaker points in the line.

In the event of an incursion from the south, Uzbekistan could also seek assistance from the Taliban-led government. The Taliban administration in Kabul views ISKP as a significant threat to its own national security and relies heavily on Uzbekistan for essential resources, including electricity, gas, and consumer supplies, and this dependency provides Tashkent with considerable diplomatic leverage. Tashkent could pressure the Taliban to permit UZAADF helicopters and other air assets to enter Afghan airspace in support of operations over Termez, causing further damage to ISKP's supplies and retreat path. Additionally, Tashkent could request permission to further pursue the retreating ISKP forces fleeing back into Afghanistan using artillery and aerial assets, with the aim of eliminating more of ISKP's conventional forces. While most governments would typically oppose a neighbouring state carrying out strikes on their territory, under these circumstances, and given Afghanistan's limited air capabilities, Kabul would likely grant Tashkent permission for such operations.



(Figure 4.9.22: The remaining fighters of Groups C and E break ranks and retreat across the bridge into Afghanistan as continued airstrikes hit their withdrawal. Meanwhile, the Uzbek 7th Brigade encircles Group D and recaptures the UAFB. Group B is forced back into a shrinking pocket with minimal ammunition, while the last remnants of Group A are being eliminated in the southern part of the city. Afghan federal forces have now also entered the theatre, intending to cut off and degrade the retreating ISKP forces inside Afghanistan)

As a further setback for ISKP forces, it is highly likely that Kabul would deploy additional units to the region. Even if Uzbekistan conducts the majority of the fighting, the presence of Afghan federal troops would serve a dual strategic purpose: reinforcing the Taliban's legitimacy in the north while simultaneously degrading its primary internal adversary. By this later stage of the scenario, Uzbek forces' primary objective would be to maintain sustained pressure on the remaining ISKP strongholds until they are either forced to surrender, depleted of ammunition, or entirely neutralised. Given the scale of Uzbek operations and ISKP's deteriorating combat capability, full control of the city is projected to be restored within 12 to 36 hours.

xii) - Key findings

Based on the wargaming and analysis of the above scenario, here are our three key findings:

1) - ISKP forces lack the ability to launch a surprise expeditionary attack:

In the context of our wargame analysis, it quickly became evident that the ISKP forces currently lack the necessary capabilities to launch an expeditionary attack into Uzbekistan without alerting Uzbek forces. The exercise revealed significant challenges for the ISKP team, particularly in assembling and concentrating the required forces, boats, and supplies on the opposite bank of the river without also alerting the Uzbek garrison to their presence. We found that the moment ISKP forces began to mobilise on the southern bank, the Uzbek military could either carry out preemptive strikes or quickly redeploy air and ground assets to the Uzbek shoreline; and from there, it would then be fairly easy to neutralise the ISKP forces as they attempted to cross the river. To simulate a credible threat, our researchers had to provide the ISKP team with an unrealistically favourable starting position, and even after being provided with this incredibly generous start, the possibility of the ISKP forces being able to maintain supply lines from across the river and conventionally occupy a city was nearly impossible. Even in some of the alternate scenarios that were run, where the ISKP team would forgo a river crossing and instead concentrate all of its efforts on expanding the bridgehead over the UAAB, the scenario found the insurgents pushed out of the country even sooner than what took place here. Without the simultaneous (and diversionary) amphibious assaults in the south and west, the Uzbek team was able to concentrate its efforts on a single pocket of ISKP fighters, eliminating them even faster than in the river crossing model.

In reality, Uzbek forces maintain extensive surveillance and intelligence operations along this section of the border, making it nearly impossible for a large conventional force to mobilise undetected. This early warning capability allows the Uzbek military to reposition reserve forces, increase air patrols, and reinforce riverine defences, effectively neutralising the element of surprise that ISKP would need to have for any chance of crossing the river in force. Additionally, ISKP's inadequate military training, limited access to advanced weaponry, and lack of experience in executing large-scale conventional attacks, (particularly those involving amphibious crossings), further diminish their ability to carry out such a complex operation without being swiftly countered. The ultimate conclusion is that, at present, it seems highly improbable that ISKP forces could successfully cross the river, let alone achieve follow-on objectives like capturing or holding the city.

2) - Uzbekistan's inter-branch defence network allowed for a faster and more effective coordinated response:

The Uzbek garrison in Termez is bolstered by the presence of multiple units and branches within the city, each capable of providing mutual support. Additionally, nearby installations such as Sherabad and Kakaydy are strategically positioned to quickly reinforce the Termez garrison if the situation demands it. This layered defence ensures that even if the Termez-based forces initially struggle to regain control of the city, reinforcements can be swiftly deployed to strengthen their position. The strategic placement of these additional forces near the Afghan border, combined with dedicated command and control centres both within and outside of Termez, also significantly enhance communication and coordination during an attack. Unlike the situation in Andijan in 2005, where protesters were able to overpower each local garrison in isolation, the modernised communications systems in Termez allow commanders to alert all city units immediately after the first shot is fired at the border outpost. However, it is crucial to recognise that this command and control network is primarily designed to counter below-peer adversaries such as the Taliban or ISKP. If the Uzbek garrisons were to come under attack from an adversary equipped with advanced signal jamming capabilities or precision weapons capable of targeting the city's key power and communication infrastructure, the coordination and response between garrisons could be significantly delayed. In such a scenario, centralised coordination would be required from Qarshi, with orders then relayed to each branch or regional garrison individually, with this process likely to reduce the adaptability and speed of any tactical response. However, with the Qarshi headquarters located 220 km from Termez, it remains outside the range of most low-end weapons, and would likely remain permanently secure and operational even during more intense attacks. Under the current command structure, even if Termez were to be attacked by a force more formidable than anything ISKP (or other non-state actors) could currently muster, and even if substantial damage were inflicted on local infrastructure, the command centre in Qarshi would continue to function. This would enable the coordination of a comprehensive regional response and ensure that the broader defence network remains effective even under scenarios of severe duress.

3) - Future threats and challenges for Uzbekistan's defence network:

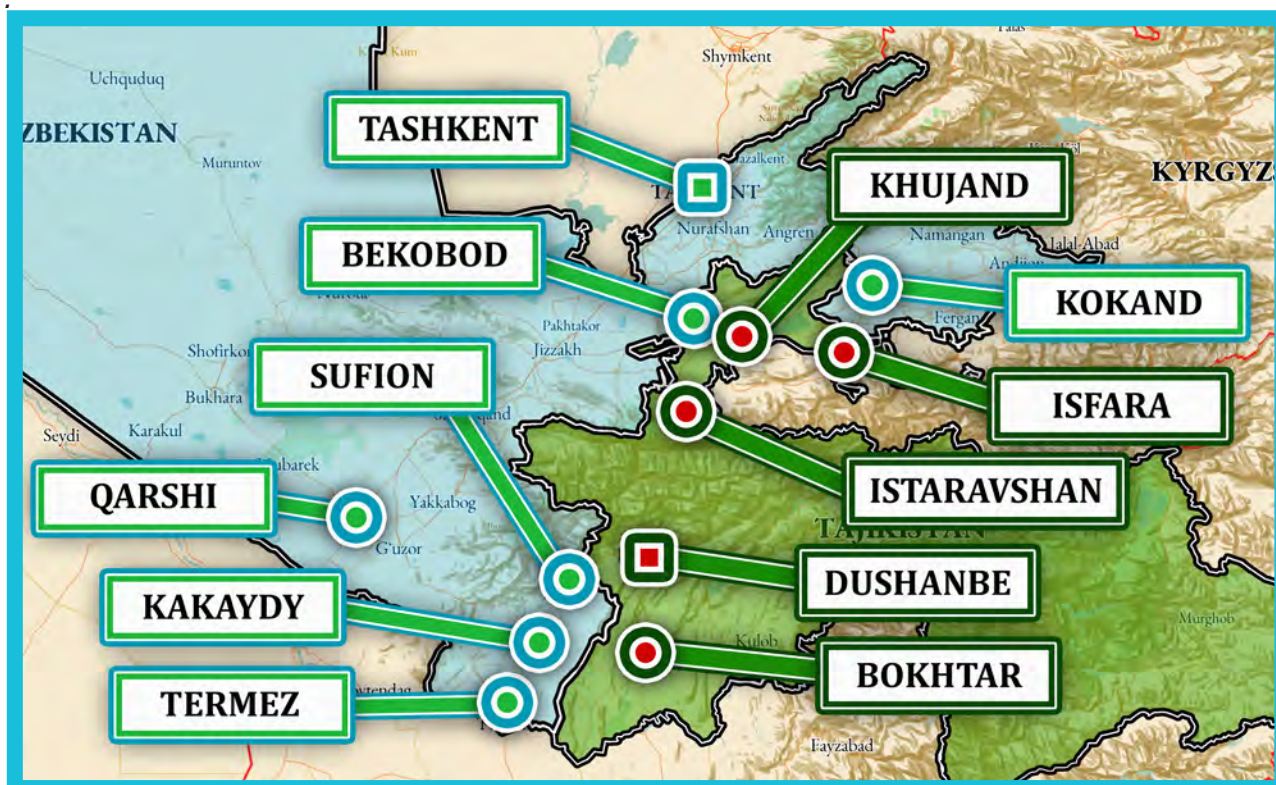
While the current defence plans in southern Uzbekistan are likely sufficient to counter any conventional threat posed by forces such as ISKP or the Taliban, several medium-term challenges should raise concerns for Uzbek defence planners. As ISKP continues to strengthen and expand its capabilities in Central Asia, Uzbekistan will need to invest in bolstering its counterterrorism efforts, border control measures, and regional surveillance capabilities if it hopes to retain its current levels of strategic advantage. However, the ongoing decline in Uzbekistan's real military spending, coupled with the decreasing cost of dual-use military hardware, may narrow the capability gap that currently favours Uzbek forces over such adversaries. The shortfalls in local military budget may also result in less frequent patrols and widened surveillance gaps, potentially enabling more "lone-wolf" attackers to enter Uzbekistan, either surreptitiously by boat or through legitimate entry points. A more porous southern frontier could allow ISKP operatives to infiltrate the country, attempt to recruit local populations, or carry out attacks on civilians.

Furthermore, while current border control and surveillance deployments are primarily focused on the Uzbek-Afghan boundary, they have left parts of the southeastern border with Tajikistan comparatively less protected. Given that Tajikistan's border security heavily relies on international support, any reduction in such assistance could permit insurgents to enter Tajik territory and subsequently cross into Uzbekistan, circumventing the more robust defences currently operating along the Uzbek-Afghan border. Moreover, climate change also significantly amplifies the security challenges along the Afghan border, as rising temperatures, decreased rainfall, and ongoing dam construction in Tajikistan all contribute to reduced water levels in the Amu Darya near Termez. In turn, these shrinking waterways not only diminish the operational effectiveness of Uzbekistan's Riverine Flotilla but also erode some of the geographic advantages currently enjoyed by Uzbek forces.

Presently, the river constitutes a formidable logistical barrier for any potential adversary, restricting the movement of vehicles and heavy weaponry to the UAFB. However, if the river's volume continues to decrease, or, in a worst-case scenario, dries up entirely, it could create multiple, easily crossed points for insurgents and other transnational threats. Such additional crossings could then subsequently lead to a rise in the intensity of attacks from forces operating in northern Afghanistan. Combined with growing domestic grievances, this could increase the likelihood of internal sympathisers aiding or joining insurgent groups once they cross into Uzbekistan. For Tashkent, the most prudent course would be to use the time currently available to invest in improving the lives of Termez's inhabitants. Even if the worst-case scenarios were to unfold, and insurgents launched a large-scale offensive, citizens who are content with Tashkent's governance would be more inclined to resist an incursion, rather than aid the invaders.

4.9.2 - An Uzbek Invasion of Tajikistan

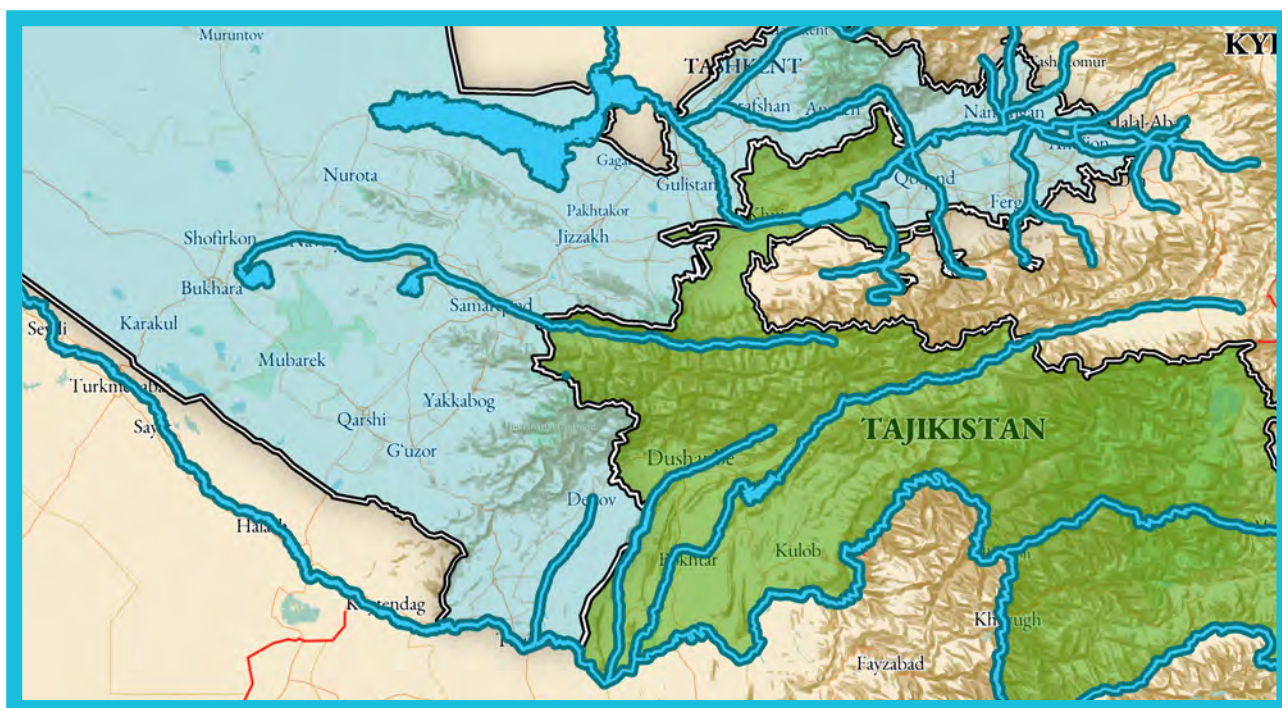
For our second scenario, we conducted a comprehensive wargame simulating a full-scale invasion of Tajikistan by the Uzbek armed forces. This hypothetical scenario posits Tashkent leveraging ongoing disputes over water rights as a pretext for launching an expeditionary strike aimed at capturing and occupying Tajikistan's key centres of power. Although we assess the likelihood of such a scenario unfolding is also exceedingly low, given the strengthening of their relationship since 2016, the wargame provides valuable insights into the current capabilities of the Uzbek forces by highlighting significant vulnerabilities and shortcomings in the country's expeditionary, offensive, and logistical capabilities. It is also essential to clarify that this exercise is not intended to reflect the current state of Uzbek-Tajik relations or imply any imminent threat of conflict.



(Figure 4.9.23: Map of Uzbekistan (cyan) and Tajikistan (green), with the locations of the main Uzbek (blue, white, and green) and Tajik (green, red, and white) cities mentioned within the following analysis)

i) - Background

While the scenario outlined here is entirely hypothetical, the underlying historical tensions between Uzbekistan and Tajikistan are based on real issues, as relations between the two countries have been marked by ethnic, political, resource, and territorial disputes. Although the current rapport between the two presidents is considerably better than it was under Karimov's rule, several geopolitical flashpoints remain unresolved between the two. Chief among these is the dispute over transnational rivers and their associated water rights. While rivers such as the Amu Darya provide vital water resources for Uzbekistan's cotton industry, they actually originate in Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan. Consequently, although Uzbekistan is the principal consumer of this water, Tajikistan exercises control over how much it reaches downstream, potentially enabling Dushanbe to impose artificial water shortages upon the Uzbeks.

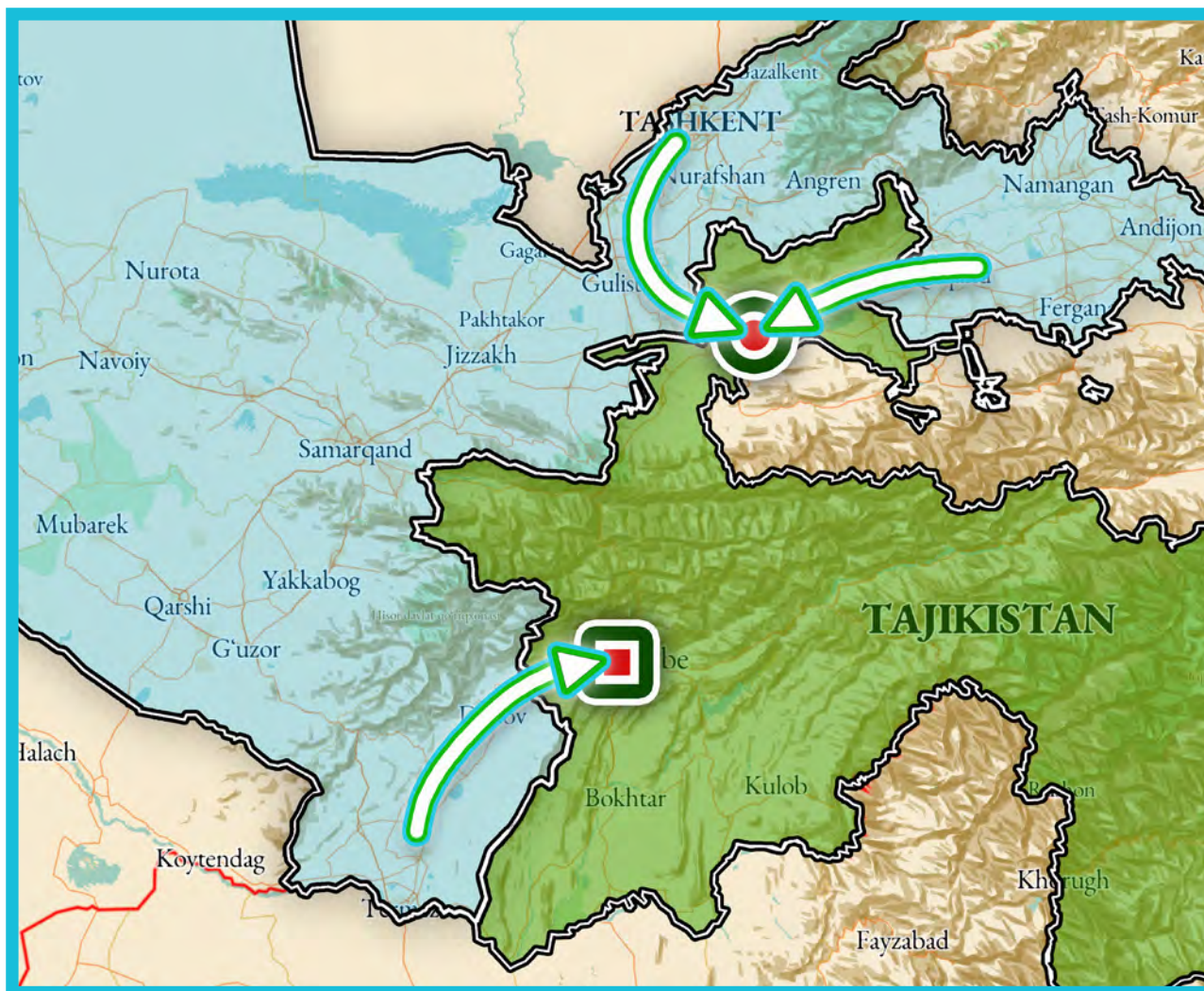


(Figure 4.9.24: Map of Uzbekistan and Tajikistan with the locations of transnational river systems illustrated in dark blue. Within the region, major rivers tend to flow from the mountains in the east towards the flatlands in the west)

As an illustration of just how serious these tensions around water use can be, the construction of the Rogun Dam in central Tajikistan during the late 2000s nearly brought the two states to the brink of war. While Tajikistan viewed the dam as a much-needed renewable energy source, Uzbekistan feared it would significantly reduce downstream water flow and adversely impact Uzbek agriculture. So, in response to the dam going into construction, Tashkent went so far as to impose rail blockades, cut off pledged gas supplies, and lobby other international partners to also impose sanctions on the Tajiks. During the peak of the dispute, things became so serious between the two that there were even reports suggesting that Tashkent was contemplating the use of military action against Dushanbe. In the end though, diplomacy would prevail, and the two sides were able to reach a compromise. However, for our scenario, we will assume that the situation has arisen again, and that this time, diplomatic negotiations have failed. As a result, Uzbekistan has decided to launch a military invasion into Tajikistan, with the objective being to either oust the current government and install a more favourable one, or to exert enough pressure on Dushanbe so as to force Tajikistan into complying with Uzbekistan's demands regarding the dam and water rights.

ii) - Assumptions and caveats

The scenario analysed here centres around a hypothetical expeditionary attack by the Uzbek armed forces into Tajikistan, with the primary objectives being the capture and occupation of Tajikistan's two largest cities: Dushanbe, the capital, and Khujand, the largest city in the north. As a basis for modelling this scenario, we will be using existing military training manuals, contemporary doctrines, data from recent military exercises, and insights gleaned from interviews with military, academic, and government officials. These sources will help us establish the initial parameters and provide a framework for predicting how each side might react and conduct itself in such a scenario.



(Figure 4.9.25: Map of Uzbekistan and Tajikistan, illustrating the two primary targets of the Uzbek invasion, Dushanbe in the south and Khujand to the north)

Under normal circumstances, the conflict would likely either remain a localised border skirmish or simply not occur at all, as Uzbekistan's current economic development heavily relies on continued regional stability. Tashkent is aware that a major war in Central Asia would likely drive away international investment and increase internal discontent among the Uzbek population. So, several alterations and assumptions will need to be made to make this invasion scenario somewhat plausible. Otherwise, the scenario will end too quickly or does not escalate to war in the first place.

The first key assumption in this scenario is that Uzbekistan achieves total surprise in its initial strikes on Tajikistan, successfully repositioning troops and assets into critical staging areas without alerting Dushanbe, Moscow, or Beijing. In reality, large-scale movements of Uzbek forces and materiel would be nearly impossible to conceal, and a substantial buildup along the Tajik border would inevitably draw the attention of regional actors. This poses a problem for Uzbekistan, as once Russia becomes aware of Tashkent's intent to invade Tajikistan, Moscow is likely to exert significant diplomatic pressure to dissuade Uzbekistan from proceeding. For Moscow, Uzbekistan remains an important economic partner and Tajikistan a key strategic ally, so Russia would view any conflict between the two as a lose-lose situation, and therefore, be willing to undertake extensive measures to prevent a conflict from happening in the first place.

Therefore, should Moscow learn of Tashkent's intentions and issue warnings to desist, only for Tashkent to then disregard them and continue massing forces along the Tajik border, Russia might feel it has to respond by imposing significant sanctions on Uzbekistan or by deploying its own forces on the Tajik side of the frontier. If Tashkent then opted to proceed with the assault despite these measures, Uzbek troops would inevitably engage Russian forces, effectively setting Tashkent on a course to declare war on Russia at the outset of the campaign. This outcome would prove critical to the conflict, as a declaration of war against Russia would dramatically shift the balance of power against Uzbekistan. Given that Russia is not only Uzbekistan's principal security partner and leading supplier of military hardware but also plays a substantial role in sustaining the Uzbek economy and military capacity, any attack on Russian troops by the Uzbek would almost certainly trigger severe domestic and regional repercussions.

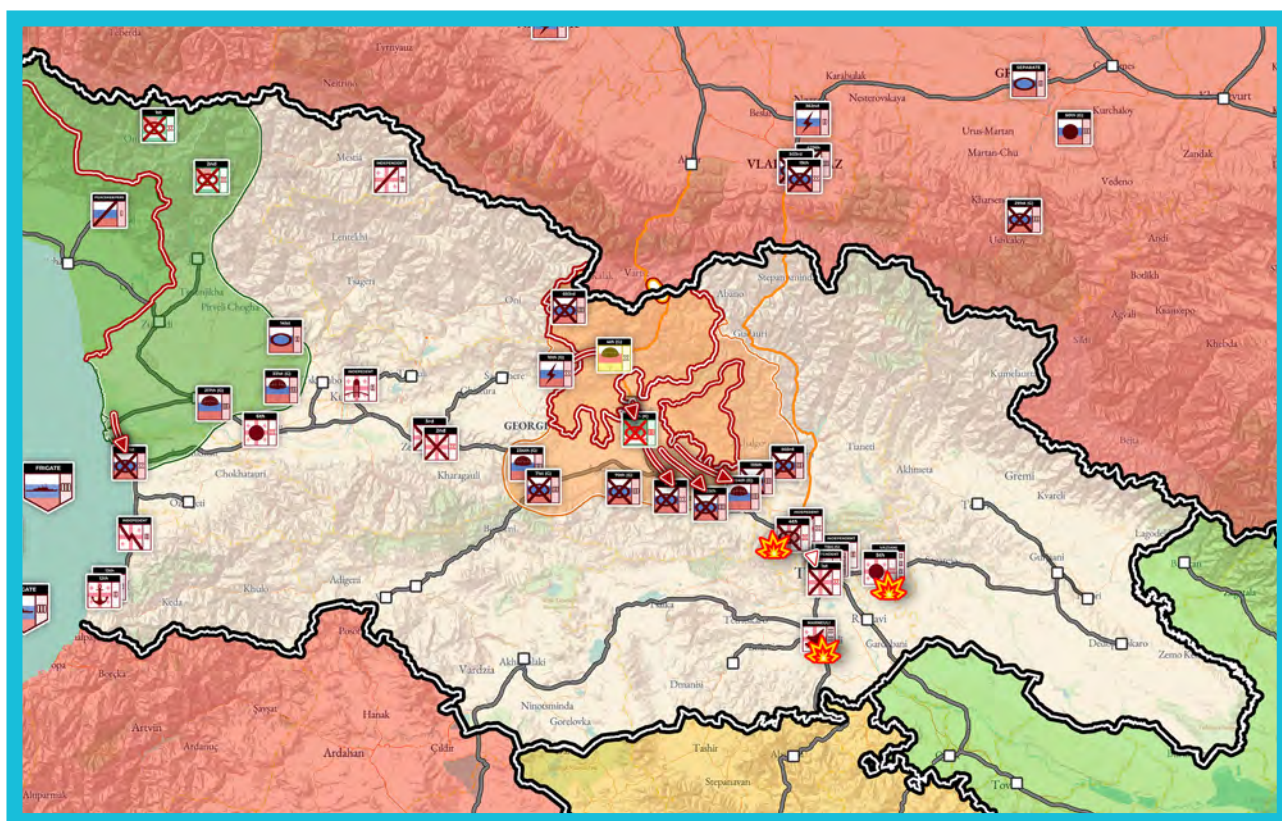
To avoid the two sides immediately going to war, under our scenario here, we are adding the assumption that Russia is also seeking to avoid a direct conflict over Tajikistan. So, as an artificially introduced caveat, Moscow will not only avoid deploying its troops to the Uzbek border, but will instead initially confine all of its forces stationed in Tajikistan to their barracks in Dushanbe, Ayni, Bokhtar and Lyaur. By introducing this caveat, the Uzbek team are given the rule that the Russians will only enter the war, or fire upon the Uzbeks, if the Uzbeks fire upon the Russians first. As a result, Uzbek forces will have to avoid striking installations or targets where collateral damage might inflict casualties upon the Russians. This constraint will drastically reduce the quantity of forces Uzbekistan has to fight, but will also make operating in the theatre much more difficult and complicated. Additionally, we will also assume that once the conflict begins, despite Tajikistan's membership in the CSTO, and the invasion clearly meeting the threshold for a CSTO intervention, Moscow will pressure Dushanbe not to invoke Article IV of the CSTO treaty. Given the current state of regional politics, this is a fairly realistic scenario. With the CSTO as it stands today, Moscow likely realises that even if Dushanbe were to invoke the treaty, its enforcement would falter due to the reluctance of CSTO members to intervene militarily between these two nations, whether for financial, strategic, or geopolitical reasons. Should Dushanbe choose to ignore Moscow's requests and invoke Article IV, and the other CSTO members fail to respond, it would likely result in significant political embarrassment for both Moscow and Dushanbe. Therefore, for this scenario, we will also operate under the assumption that the CSTO alliance will not be called upon and that no member state, aside from Russia, could intervene militarily.

These stipulations and assumptions offer the most instructive framework for examining a hypothetical military conflict between Uzbekistan and Tajikistan, and while they do diverge somewhat from real-world conditions in the lead-up to hostilities, they ensure that Uzbekistan holds a sufficiently advantageous position to feasibly initiate an offensive in the first place. Without these additional caveats, and under strictly realistic parameters, the conflict would either remain limited to smaller localised skirmishes or see Tashkent be dissuaded altogether by external actors exerting enough political pressure to prevent escalation. Although the research team fully acknowledges that certain prerequisite assumptions represent significant departures from the current reality, the analysis that follows will subsequently adhere to realistic assessments of the strategic and operational dynamics that would unfold in such a scenario.

iii) - Pre-offensive manoeuvres and redeployments

While numerous strategic realities will drive the decision-making of Uzbek defence planners, two major factors are likely to outweigh the rest. The first being that Uzbek leadership will likely prioritise domestic stability over the military's offensive capability, especially in scenarios like this, where significant domestic pushback is expected. Consequently, Uzbek military commanders will only have access to a limited number of personnel and equipment for external operations, ensuring that sufficient resources are left behind to maintain the Internal Troops' operational readiness and have sufficient MOD troops available to deploy as reinforcements for the UIT, in the event of large-scale uprisings.

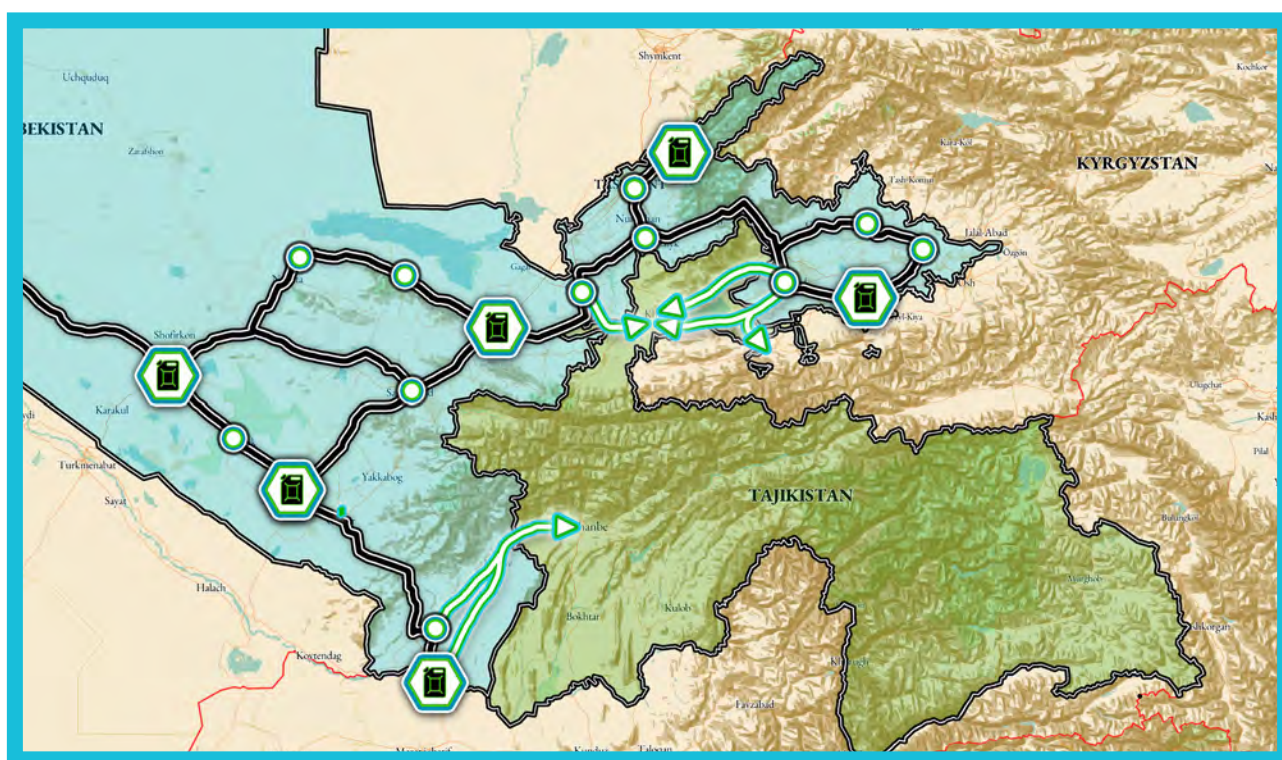
The second critical factor is speed. Tajikistan's two largest cities, Dushanbe and Khujand, are both situated within approximately 50 km of the Uzbek border. This proximity grants Tashkent a considerable tactical advantage, as Dushanbe not only lacks strategic depth, but the minimal distance between the front line and these major cities limits the time available for Tajik forces to react or reinforce. Given these circumstances, the most logical strategy for Tashkent would be to cross the border in overwhelming force, aiming to capture Dushanbe and Khujand as swiftly as possible, even if that places stress on the military's logistics. If successful, this rapid advance could cause panic in the Tajik capital and subsequently induce the collapse of the government. The optimal outcome for Uzbekistan would somewhat resemble the Russian invasion of Georgia in 2008, where Russian forces quickly overwhelmed Georgian defences and began advancing towards Tbilisi, forcing the Georgian government to concede and agree to Russian terms.



(Figure 4.9.26: Map of the 2008 Russo-Georgian War, showing the furthest extent of the Russian advance into Georgia before Tbilisi capitulated to Russian demands. Seen here are Georgia (white), Turkey (bottom red), Armenia (yellow), Azerbaijan (bottom green), Russia (top red), and the two Georgian breakaway territories of Abkhazia (top-left green) and South Ossetia (orange).

To compel the swift capitulation of the Tajik government, Uzbekistan would likely utilise its superior military strength and numbers to launch simultaneous offensives towards both Dushanbe and Khujand. This dual-pronged strategy aims to overextend Tajikistan's military resources while increasing the likelihood of capturing at least one of the objectives in the early stages of the campaign. However, Dushanbe would probably remain the primary objective, as seizing Khujand alone might be insufficient to bring the conflict to a decisive conclusion.

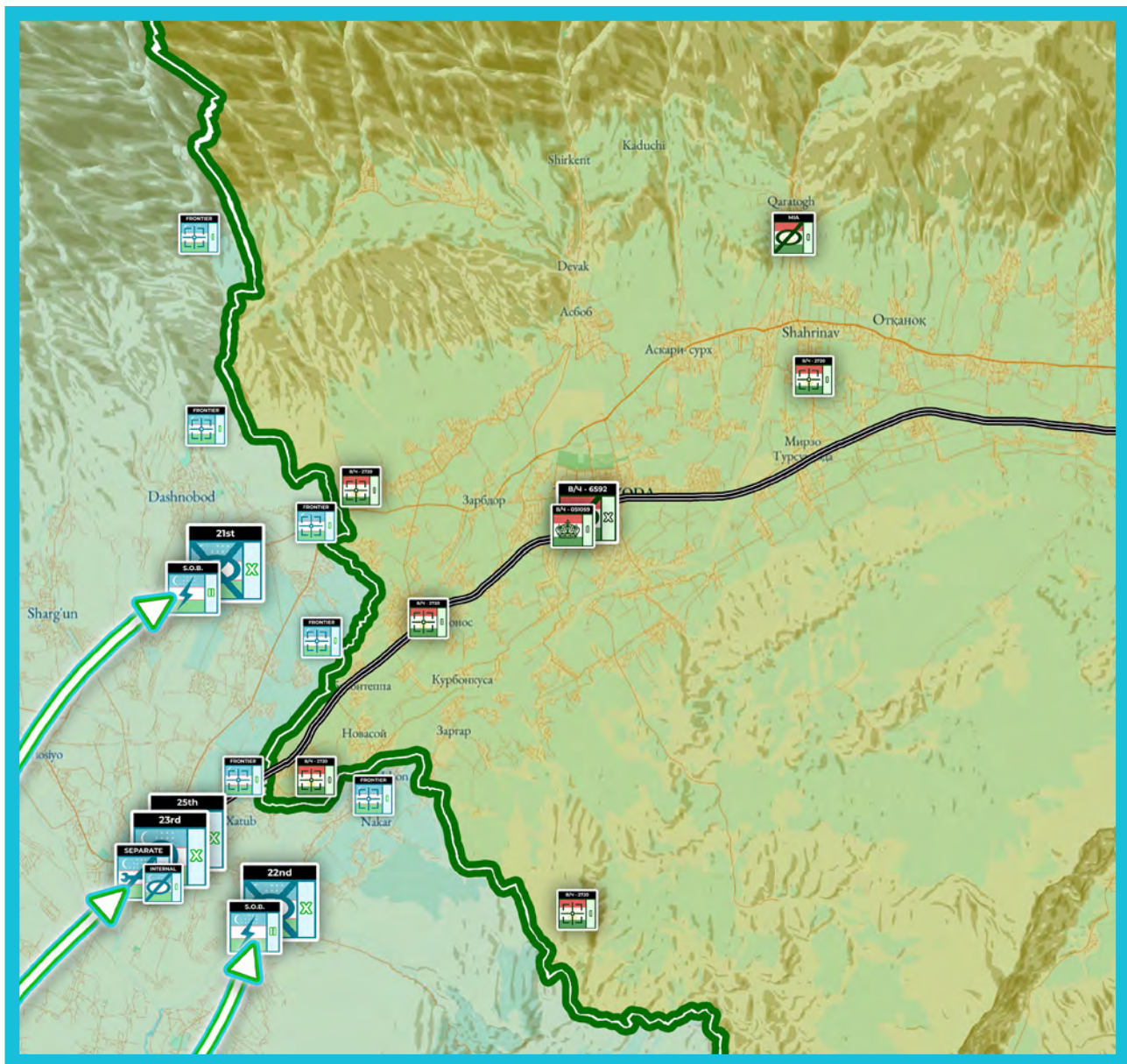
In preparation for such an offensive, Uzbek forces would begin stockpiling and pre-positioning essential supplies closer to the Tajik border. These supplies, which would include critical items such as communications equipment, ammunition, fuel, and medical support, would be moved from depots across the country to key logistical hubs. In this scenario, hubs such as Jizzakh, Fergana, and Termez would be of particular importance due to their substantial railheads, which are essential for efficiently managing the high volumes of supplies required for such an operation.



(Figure 4.9.27: A map highlighting the major Uzbek rail lines (black), the cities with significant railheads (circles), and cities with major supply caches (hexagons with fuel canisters). The white lines represent the road routes that Uzbek forces would need to cover using trucks and other vehicles to transport supplies from their nearest major railhead to the theatre of operations)

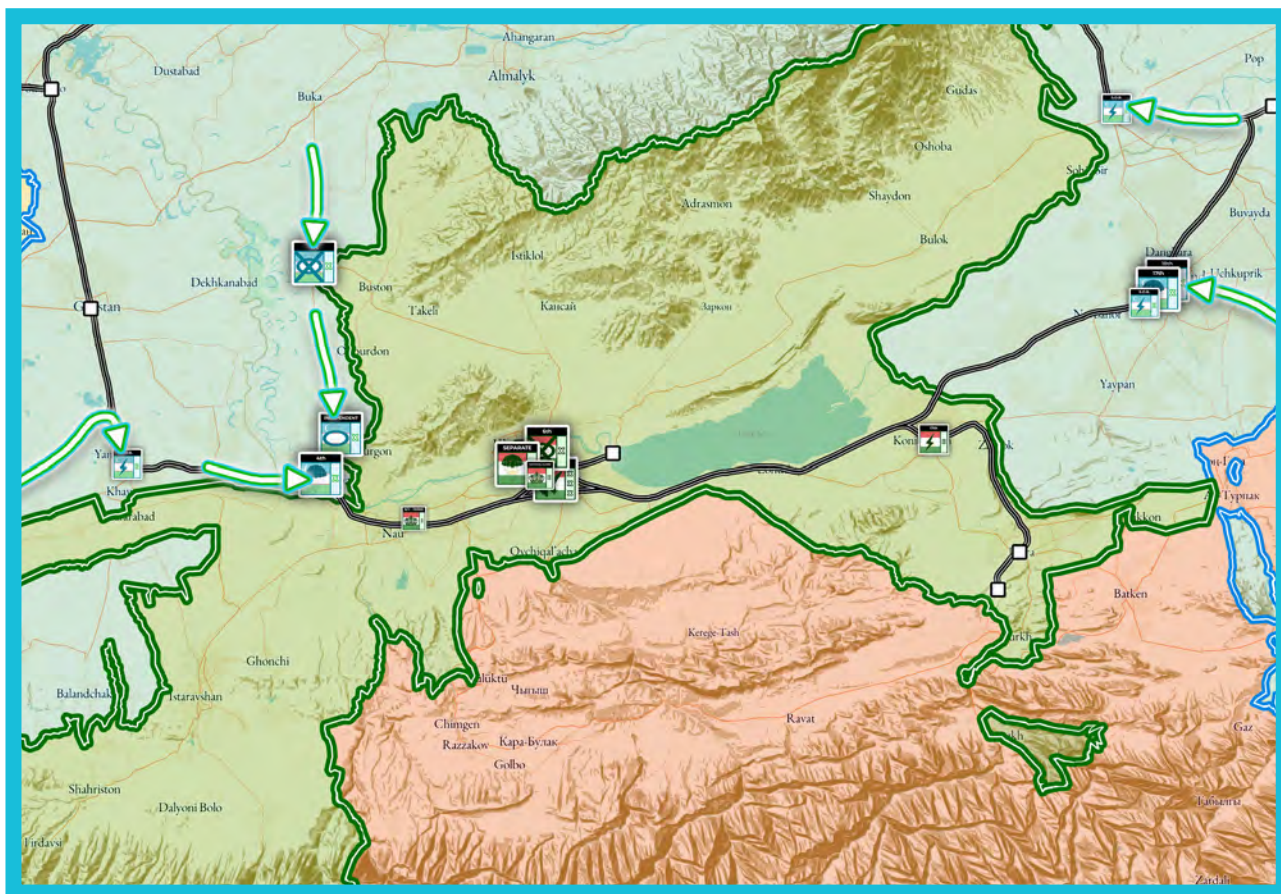
Following logistical preparations, Uzbekistan would establish forward command posts closer to the anticipated frontlines, which would serve as the C2 hubs for each front during the initial stages of the invasion. Potential locations for these C2 facilities include Kokand, Kakaydy Shirin and Saryasia. Once these C2 points are established, it is expected that UAV reconnaissance operations and the deployment of local intelligence assets over the projected invasion area would intensify, aimed at collecting real-time intelligence on enemy positions, movements, and capabilities. Once these preliminary measures are in place, more substantial force redeployments and assemblies can begin, with units being repositioned from across the country toward the forward theatres in preparation for the offensive.

In such a scenario, Uzbekistan is likely to concentrate its forces at strategic locations around Sufion, Bekobod, Chanak, Hovos, Pop, and Kokand, assembling airborne, artillery, armour, special operation, and mountain infantry units in anticipation of the advance.



(Figure 4.9.28: Map of the Southern Front, west of Dushanbe, with the border between Uzbekistan (cyan) and Tajikistan (green) shown. Uzbekistan redeploys the 21st Motor Rifle Brigade, the 22nd Motor Rifle Brigade, the 25th Motor Rifle Brigade, the 23rd Artillery Brigade, two battalions of Special Operations forces, and a Separate Engineering Battalion to their assembly areas around Sufion, 73 km west of Dushanbe. On arrival, the forces begin refuelling and preparing their vehicles and personnel, waiting for the order to begin the offensive)

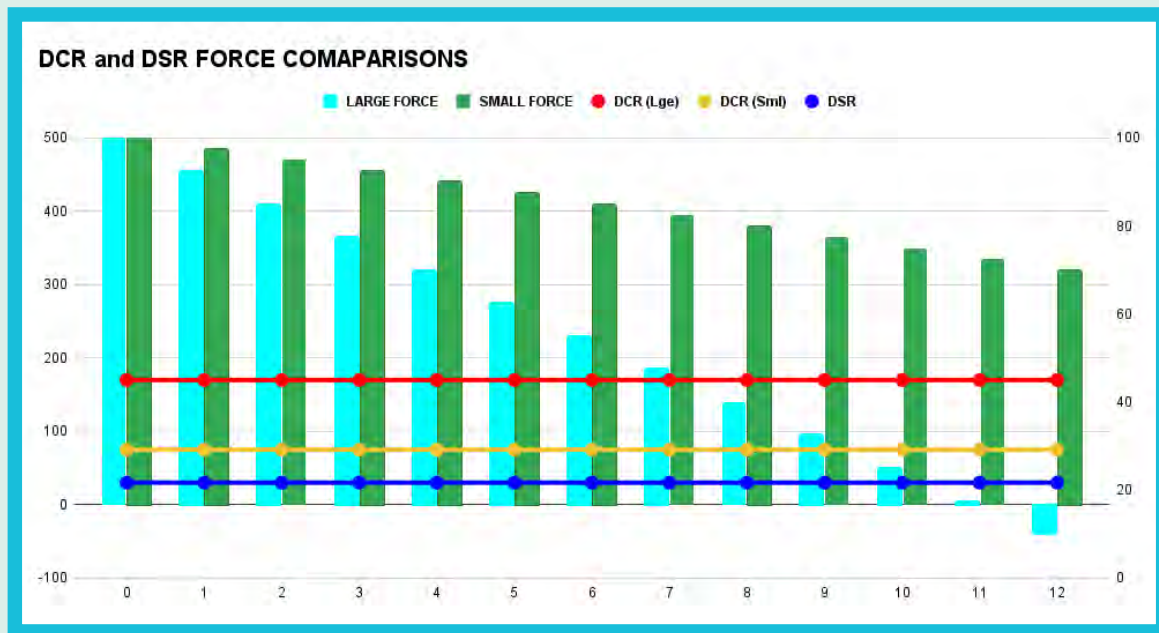
Deploying such a large number of troops into these theatres presents both advantages and challenges for the Uzbek forces. On the positive side, numerical superiority will afford Uzbek commanders the flexibility to either overwhelm each Tajik force they encounter or strategically encircle and bypass resistance points. This latter approach, in particular, would only require a fraction of the overall force to contain such strong points, allowing the remaining units to ignore the bypassed units and advance rapidly towards Khujand or Dushanbe.



(Figure 4.9.29: Map of the Northern Front, centred around Khujand, with Uzbekistan (cyan), Kyrgyzstan (red), and Tajikistan (green). For the assault, the Uzbek's have repositioned the 4th Airborne Brigade and the Independent Tank Brigade into Bekobod, just west of Khujand. The 1st Motor Rifle Brigade into Chanak, tasked with a southward thrust toward Khujand. The 17th Air Assault Brigade and the 18th Artillery Brigade were moved into Kokand and prepared to advance to Khujand from the east. Special Operations Battalions have also been distributed across Hovos, Gurumsaray, and Kokand to conduct specialised missions and complete the encirclement of the city)

However, this model of using overwhelming numbers also introduces significant logistical challenges, particularly concerning the substantial supply chain required to sustain such a large force. At this scale, the daily consumption rate of fuel, food, ammunition, and other essentials will be immense, likely exceeding what Uzbekistan can sustainably provide through their domestic production or secondary stockpiles. As a result, the daily consumption rate (DCR) is likely to far outstrip Uzbekistan's relatively limited daily sustainment rate (DSR), meaning that the Uzbek forces will probably only be able to maintain this level of operational intensity for around 1 or 2 weeks, before then being forced to scale back operations. While Uzbek commanders could opt to deploy fewer forces for the assault, in hopes of lowering the overall DCR, the success of this offensive heavily relies on a quick resolution of the conflict. At its core, Uzbekistan's overarching strategy is to conclude the conflict before international pressures and economic challenges build up, as these are likely to do more damage than the fighting ever will. Therefore, the most appropriate model within these parameters remains a high-intensity deployment structure, similar to the Russian war with Georgia in 2008, or the early stages of the full-scale offensive into Ukraine in 2022. Commanders here will be making a wager that despite their exceptionally high DCR, the Tajik government will capitulate before Uzbekistan runs out of supplies.

Daily Rate of Consumption / Daily Rate of Supply Explainer



(Figure 4.9.30: Chart comparing two forces' hypothetical supply problems)

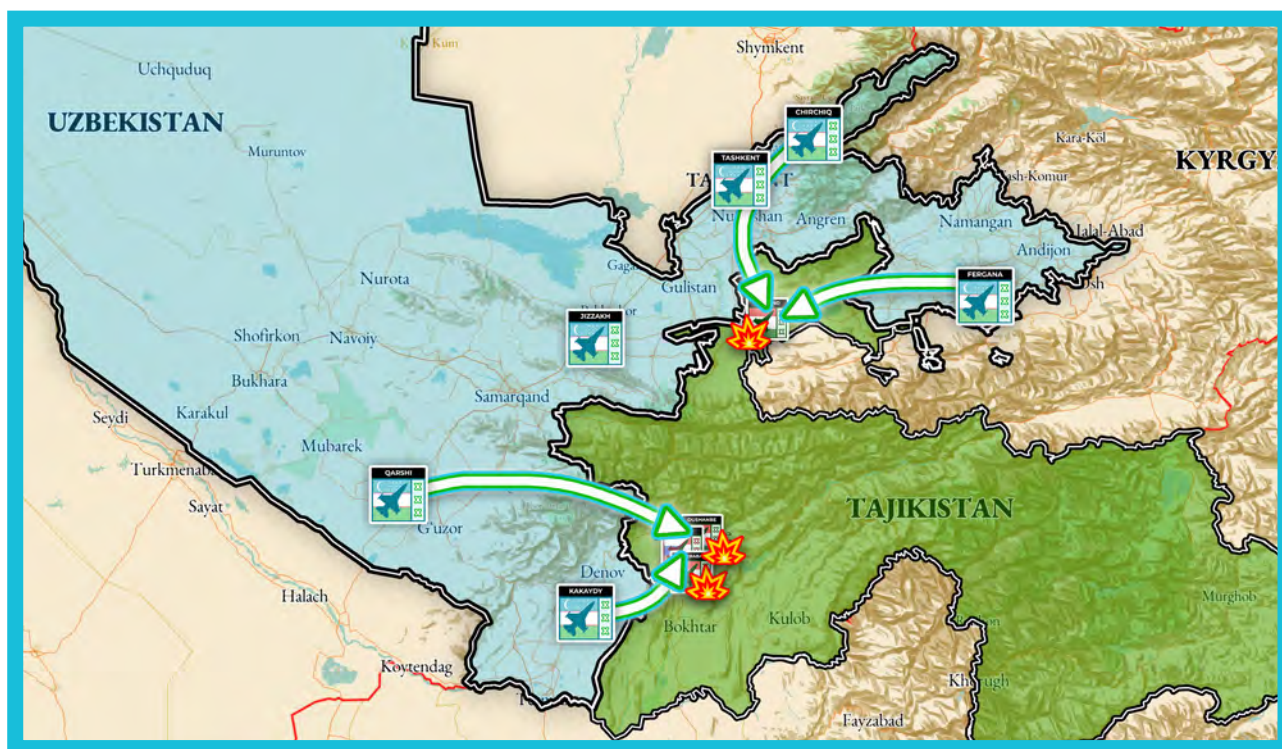
In the above chart, we have a stockpile of supplies (the vertical bars) and two hypothetical invasion forces, one large and one small. Each day, the large force (blue) consumes supplies at the rate indicated by the red line (DCR large), while the small force (green) consumes supplies at the rate indicated by the yellow line (DCR small). The dark blue line represents the daily sustainment rate (DSR), or the amount of supplies that the armed forces' limited logistics network can deliver to the front each day. The graph starts at Day 0 (D+0), assuming that both armed forces have built up a significant stockpile of supplies in preparation for the invasion. In our example, the large force's much higher DCR (Stockpile - DCR + DSR) results in their supply stockpile being exhausted at a much faster rate, eventually running out of supplies by D+12. In contrast, the small force, with its lower DCR, consumes supplies at a much lower rate and therefore does not run out of supplies until D+33. While it might then seem prudent to conduct the offensive with the smaller army and extend operational sustainability, if the attacking forces' offensive strategy necessitates a rapid conclusion to the conflict, a commander might deem that deploying the larger force is an acceptable risk in the short term.

In effect, due to insufficient supplies, commanders are being forced to make a choice between speed and sustainability.

iv) - First strikes

Before the first armoured column crosses the border, specialised detachments composed of reconnaissance and special operations forces will infiltrate Tajikistan under conditions of strict operational secrecy. These advanced elements will be tasked with executing high-priority sabotage and disruption missions aimed at degrading the Tajik military's ability to coordinate an effective response in the initial hours of the operation.

Key objectives will likely include the destruction of critical power and communication nodes, the seizure of vital transportation chokepoints, and the neutralisation or capture of key personnel within the Tajik command structure. Ideally, these first covert actions will be executed discretely, and avoid early detection. The more overt commencement of the invasion will begin a few hours later, when Uzbek forces will initiate a coordinated barrage of long-range artillery and precision airstrikes, striking pre-designated high-value targets. These initial strikes will focus on neutralising critical enemy infrastructure, including C2 centres, integrated air defence systems, and primary logistical nodes essential to the Tajik's defence. The objective being to degrade the adversary's ability to coordinate an effective response, and ensure that the follow-on ground forces encounter minimal organised resistance during their advance.

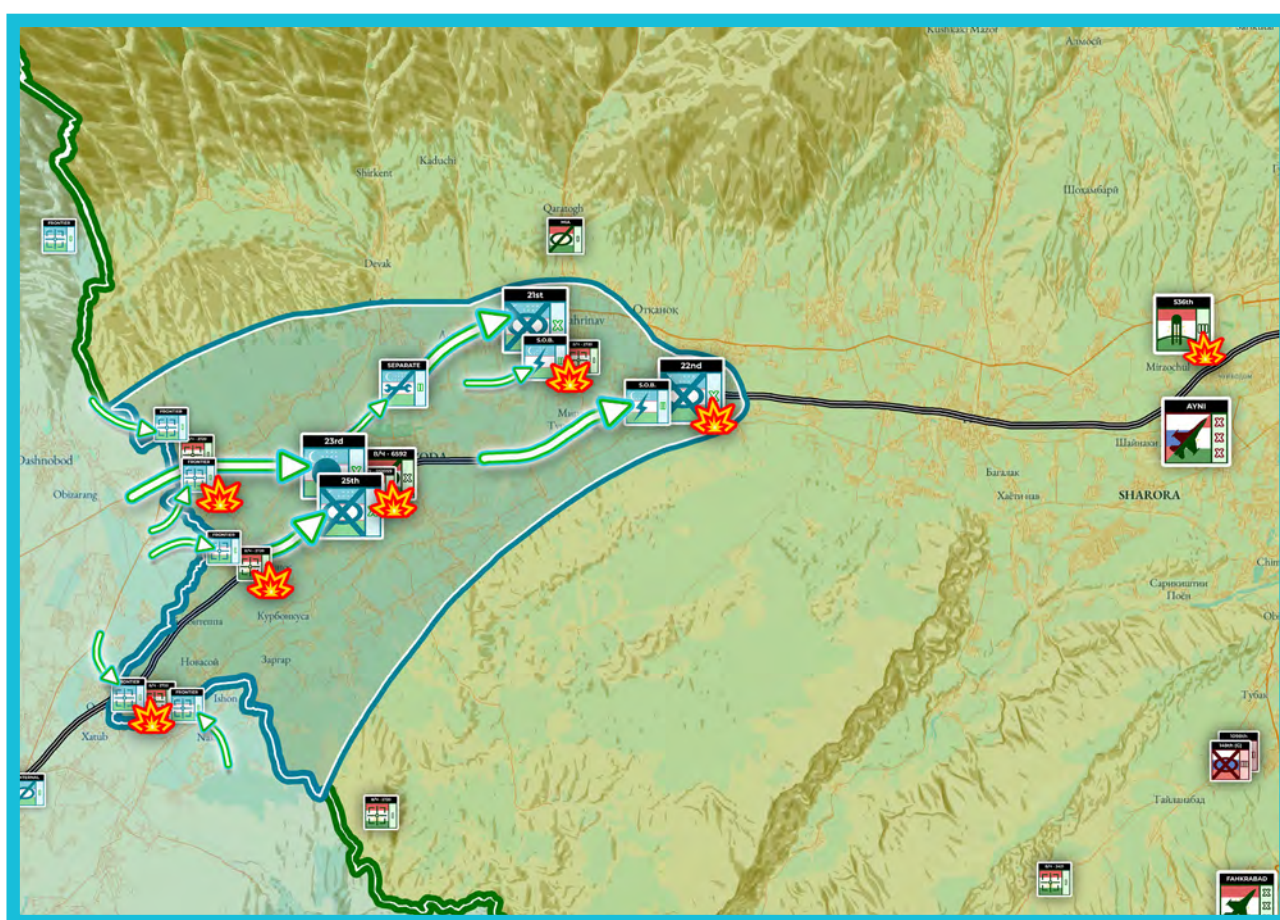


(Figure 4.9.31: Map illustrating the likely airstrike approaches by the UZAADF)

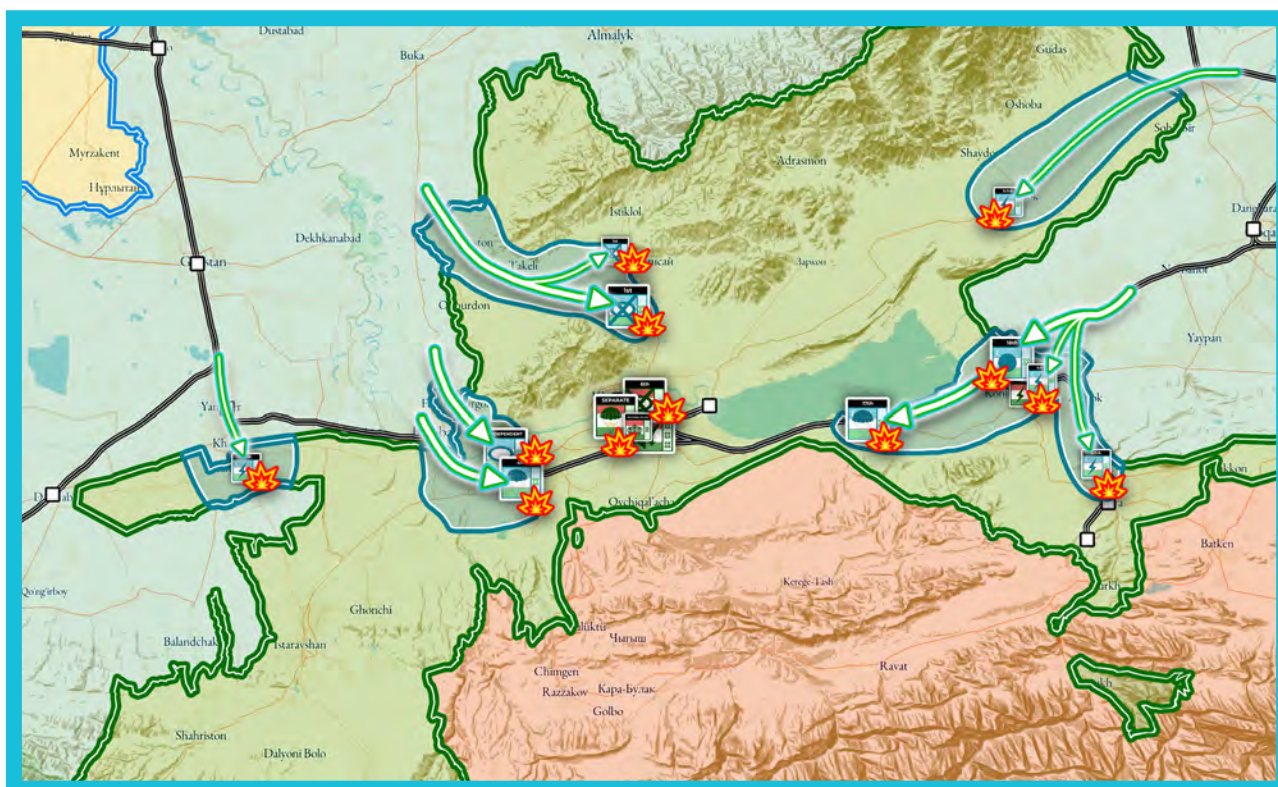
However, remembering our scenario's caveats, Uzbek pilots will not be authorised to strike Ayni airbase, most of the southern air defence batteries, or many of the C2 centres around Dushanbe, as these facilities are often intermingled with Russian forces. So to avoid escalation, the UZAADF will have to instead settle for neutralising what they can of Tajikistan's air assets and bases that are guaranteed to be wholly Tajik. These strikes being carried out through a combination of CAS strikes, precision missiles and air interdiction. This initial wave of airstrikes is expected to substantially degrade Tajikistan's air defence capabilities throughout the northern sector, with a significant portion of Tajikistan's air fleet likely to be rendered nonoperational. However, as the air campaign continues several operational challenges will emerge, particularly in the south. Foremost among these will be the attritional losses sustained by UZAADF fixed-wing and rotary-wing assets, with Tashkent anticipated to incur continued platform depletion throughout the campaign. Across the southern theater, Uzbekistan's ability to maintain air superiority is expected to erode rapidly due to the sustained threats posed by Tajikistan's joint air defence network, the limited combat experience of Uzbek pilots in engaging live targets, and the increasing operational strain on UZAADF airframes, many of which have been in service for over three decades.

For helicopters and CAS though, these attritional losses will stem primarily from the Tajik's shoulder-fired surface-to-air missiles (MANPADS), mobile anti-aircraft artillery, and any remaining SAM batteries that were not neutralised during the opening phase of the campaign. As these attritional losses mount, another critical long-term vulnerability in Uzbekistan's air operations will come into effect. Noting Tashkent's reliance on Belarus and Russia for the majority of its spare parts and maintenance, any Uzbek aircraft sustaining damage in combat will require external servicing. With both Minsk and Moscow also unlikely to support Uzbekistan's war effort, it means that damaged airframes sent away for repair will, for all practical purposes, be rendered inoperable for the duration of the conflict.

Following the initial wave of airstrikes, Uzbek Ground Forces will commence their offensive into Tajikistan, seeking to secure key objectives before Tajik forces can regroup and establish a coordinated defence. The operation will unfold along two primary axes of advance: in the south, forces will push eastwards through the valley toward Dushanbe, while in the north, the Ground Forces will advance from the west, north and east toward Khujand.

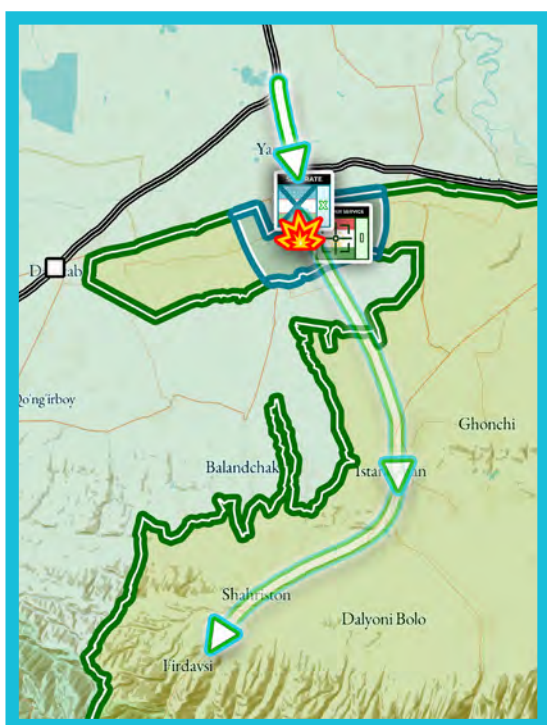


(Figure 4.9.32: Map of the Southern Front. The 25th and 23rd Brigades initiate the offensive by breaching the Tajik border and advancing 10 km northeast to neutralise the ITT and TNG facilities in Tursunzoda. Concurrently, the 21st and 22nd Brigades bypass the strongpoint, and instead begin advancing eastward along the highway toward Hisor and Dushanbe. Supporting elements, including engineering and SOF battalions, closely follow the main thrust, tasked with securing rear areas and countering potential resistance. Meanwhile, UBS garrisons mobilise to seize and secure the Tajik border outposts along the frontier. At this stage of the operation, with Dushanbe taken by surprise, Uzbek forces are unlikely to encounter significant coordinated resistance from Tajik defenders)



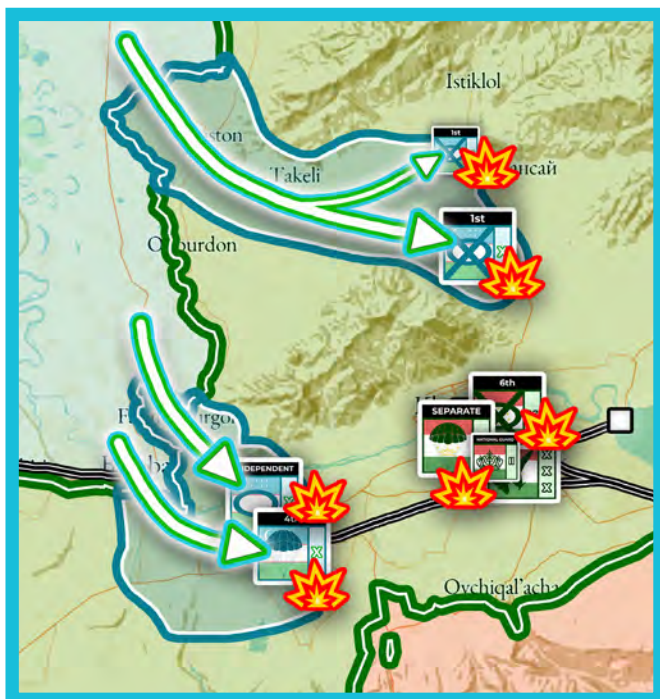
(Figure 4.9.33: Map of the Northern Front as Uzbek forces advance into Sughd, Tajikistan)

In the initial phase of the Northern Front's operations, the Uzbek invasion is expected to be organised along three distinct axes, though the front is likely be coordinated under one or two centralised commands.



The westernmost axis, the smallest of the three, has three critical objectives. The first being to cross the border and rapidly seize the Tajik Border Service base in Zafarobod, as if left unchecked the Tajik Border Service troops could easily target the vital rail lines just north of the city. These rail lines will be crucial for the Uzbek forces in the north, as they connect the frontline to Jizzakh and Tashkent. Once the western SOB has secured Zafarobod though, the unit will then be tasked with advancing southwards towards the Tajik city of Istaravshan, and from there, continue further south to block the entrance to the mountain passes connecting Khujand to the rest of the country. If the SOB can successfully reach these passes, they will effectively seal off the land lines of communication between the north and south of Tajikistan, carving the war into two isolated theatres for Dushanbe.

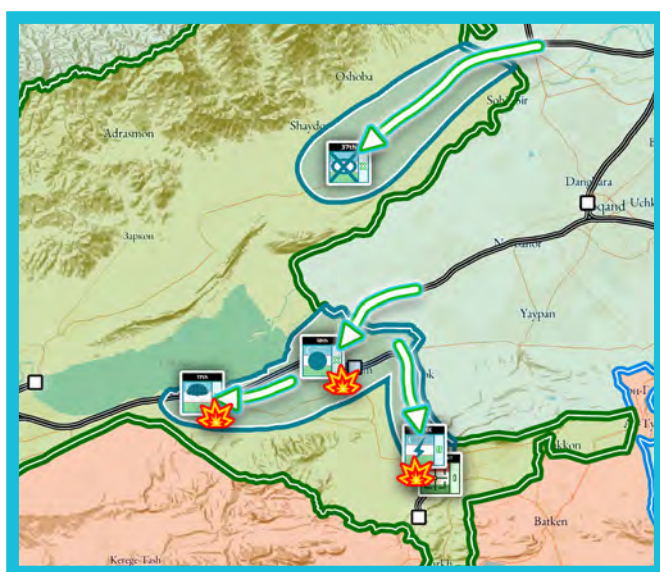
(Figure 4.9.34: Map of the Northern Front. The Special Operation Battalion attacks and seizes the Tajik Border Service outpost in Zafarobod)



toward moves north toward Istikol, while the rest of 1st bypass the area and continue along the highway)

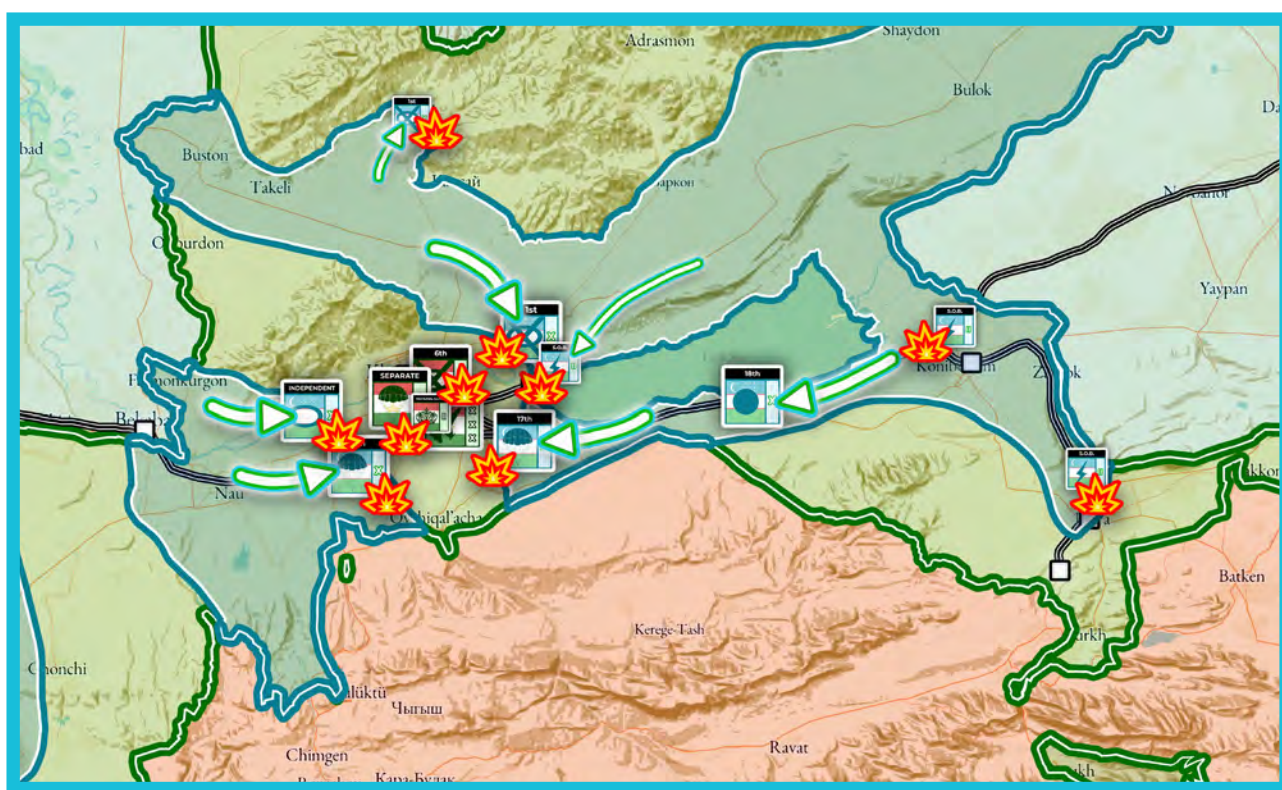
The northern advances have the most straightforward objectives among the three axes. The 4th Brigade and the Independent Tank Brigade (ITB) crossed into Tajikistan just 42 km west of Khujand. Meanwhile, the 1st Brigade crossed the border near Buston, with some of its force breaking northward to guard against any Tajik forces based in the mountains.

(Figure 4.9.35: Map of the Northern Fronts, western axis (top). The Uzbek 4th Brigade and the ITB cross the bridge southeast of Bekobod and begin advancing along the southern bank of the river towards Khujand. Meanwhile, 40 km to the north, the 1st Motor Rifle Brigade cross the border near Buston, with elements of the 1st moving north

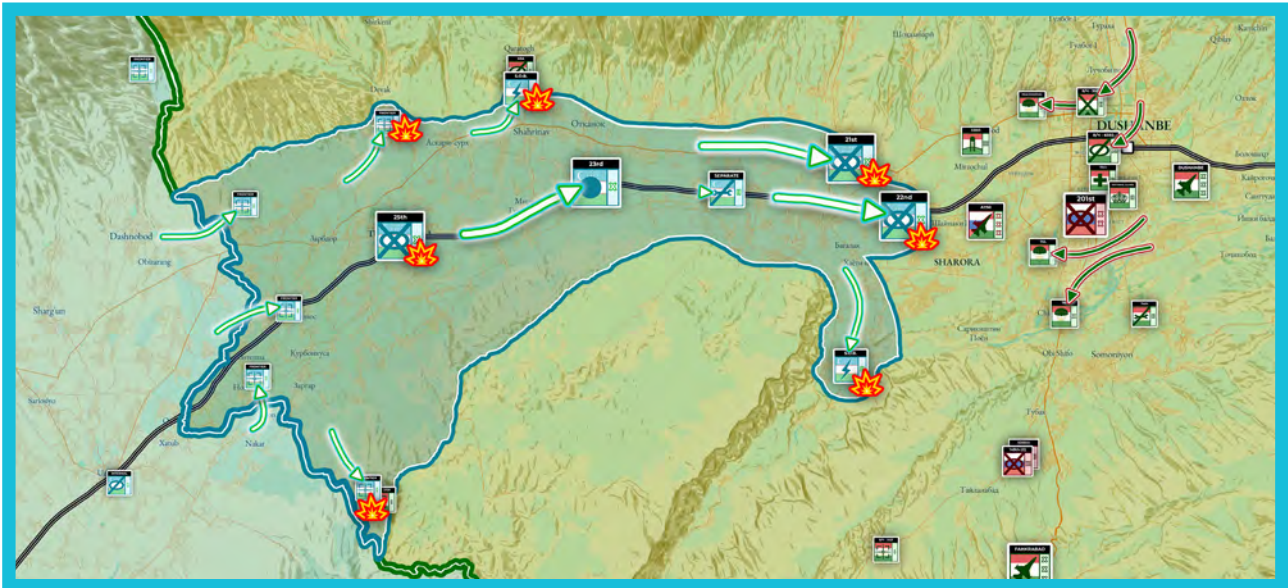


(Figure 4.9.36: Map of the Northern Front's eastern axis. The Uzbek 17th Air Assault Brigade, the 18th Artillery Brigade, and two SOB battalions initiate their advance into Tajikistan from positions southwest of Kokand. The 18th Artillery Brigade, accompanied by one SOB battalion, moves to secure the base at Konibodom, while the second SOB battalion advances south along the railway toward Isfara, tasked with preventing Tajik garrisons from interdicting Uzbek supply lines between Kokand and the forward elements. Given the operational emphasis on speed, the 17th bypasses Konibodom, advancing westward along the highway toward Khujand to maintain offensive momentum. This thrust is then reinforced by a secondary eastern crossing, 50 km to the north in Gurumsaray, where an additional SOB battalion advances along the secondary highway toward Khujand. This additional manoeuvre out of Gurumsaray being there to help complete the encirclement, and prevent Tajik forces from withdrawing into the mountains)

Acknowledging their numerical disadvantage in the north, Tajik forces will likely execute a tactical withdrawal from all positions outside Khujand and north of the river, consolidating defensive positions at key strategic locations within Khujand and Chkalovsk. These strongpoints include the river crossings, the airport, the dam, the western approaches between the river and the radioactive waste site (indicated by the radiation symbol in Figure 4.9.38), and the fortified installations of the Airborne and 6th Brigades in the southern sector. This defensive strategy is intended to channel the advancing Uzbek forces into narrower engagement zones, mitigating the effectiveness of their numerical superiority, and preventing the more mobile Uzbek armoured units from being able to execute flanking manoeuvres. By consolidating their positions, the Tajik's will force the Uzbek's into urban combat, a theatre where the Uzbek armour will be significantly more vulnerable to anti-tank ambushes and close-quarters engagements, and the Tajik's have more historical experience. In such a scenario, where Uzbek forces are closing in on the city from multiple axes, Tajik commanders are also likely to be directed to hold their positions for as long as possible, operating under the assumption that prolonging the conflict will increase the likelihood of favourable external intervention.



(Figure 4.9.37: Map of the Northern Front. While most of the Tajik garrisons close to the border have either surrendered or stopped resisting, the Uzbek ITB, 1st, 4th, and 17th, along with the third SOB, have all now reached the other suburbs of Khujand, with the slower 18th Artillery Brigade, expected to arrive within the next day or two. Upon reaching the city's perimeter and confirming that Tajik forces have withdrawn into fortified positions within the urban center, the Uzbek columns will be compelled to halt their advance. This operational pause is necessary to allow for refitting, resupply, and force consolidation in preparation for the urban assault phase. As given the defensive advantages of the Tajik positions and the inherent risks of urban warfare, any immediate attempt to seize the city from the march would likely result in unacceptable losses for the Uzbeks. Beyond Khujand, the western, 2nd, and 3rd SOBs continue to secure rear areas against any remaining Tajik resistance, while continuing to engage the isolated garrisons in Isfara, Istaravshan, and Konibodom)



(Figure 4.9.38: Map of the Southern Front. The 21st and 22nd Brigades continue their rapid advance eastward toward Dushanbe, halting in the outer suburbs to refit and consolidate before initiating the urban assault. In the rear, Uzbek SOB and UBS detachments conduct clearance operations against the remaining Tajik border outposts in the west and secure key valley entrances to prevent enemy forces from regrouping or launching counterattacks. Meanwhile, the 25th Brigade accepts the surrender of Tajik garrisons in Tursunzoda and establishes defensive positions in the city, holding until the arrival of the first supply convoys from Termez. To the east, the 23rd Brigade, along with an attached engineer battalion, advances out from Tursunzoda to link up with the forward brigades, in preparation for the assault on Dushanbe)

By this stage of the conflict, both Uzbek and Tajik casualties are likely to remain relatively low, as the advancing columns have so far primarily encountered lightly armed border outposts, overwhelmed garrisons, and sporadic attacks from Tajik drones and partisan forces. The more pressing issue for the Uzbek's is likely to be the rapidly increasing consumption of supplies and the growing number of vehicle breakdowns within these advancing columns. During peacetime, Uzbek armoured vehicles rarely undertake such long-distance travel under their own power, typically relying on rail transport for most of the journey. As a result, the Uzbek's older tanks and IFVs are likely to struggle with the demands being placed on their transmissions and engines. These breakdowns, coupled with ongoing shortages of fuel trucks and engineering vehicles to keep the armoured columns operational, would almost certainly compel Uzbek commanders to pause and regroup before launching any further offensive thrusts.

This operational pause grants Uzbek field commanders a few crucial days to procure and fit spare parts for the damaged vehicles, provide the less-experienced units with some much-needed rest, and begin establishing smaller frontline stockpiles of key munitions and supplies. However, having captured neither major cities, nor their rail terminals, at this point in the scenario, the majority of Uzbekistan's supplies and reserves are still being transported into the forward theatre via truck from depots in Termez, Fergana, Jizzakh, and Tashkent, all of which are hundreds of kilometres away. While an operation pause would allow for more supplies to be stockpiled closer to the front, and equipment to be repaired, it does also come with drawbacks. A delay of a few days would also afford the Tajik forces a critical window of time to better strengthen their defensive positions, mobilise additional volunteers, gather more accurate intelligence on the strength of the Uzbek invasion, and lobby international partners for support.

v) - International response

In the event of a surprise Tajik invasion by Uzbekistan, numerous international actors are likely to be highly critical of Tashkent's actions, with many almost certain to call for an immediate ceasefire. Even if not publicly, influential actors such as Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, India, Iran, and China are likely to exert behind-the-scenes pressure on their contacts within the Uzbek administration to end the conflict or, at the very least, enter into negotiations with Dushanbe. For the Central Asian states in particular, an invasion of this nature would likely cause significant financial and reputational damage to the region, potentially even deterring further foreign investment into the Central Asian markets. Currently, the region's relative stability is one of the region's main selling points to international investors. However, if the region were to then descend into conflict, or if large numbers of refugees began fleeing Tajikistan into neighbouring states, Central Asia's positive international reputation could quickly disintegrate. This dynamic creates a strong incentive for Russia, China, and the neighbouring Central Asian states to seek a swift resolution to the conflict, aiming to prevent further regional destabilisation.

At this point in the scenario, Uzbek forces would likely still be regrouping and replenishing in the outer suburbs of the targeted cities, far from achieving the sort of rapid and decisive advances seen in Russia's campaigns of 2008. Much of the Uzbek campaign strategy would have hinged on concluding the war within three days. The significance of this 72-hour mark lies in the fact that this period of time typically represents the point at which international groups and alliances often begin to issue joint statements, announce sanctions packages, or initiate armed responses to such events. Therefore, in this hypothetical exercise, this is when international pressure would begin to start impacting the Uzbek war effort. By this time, international partners would likely have had the opportunity to convene, discuss, and agree on joint responses to address this Uzbek aggression. Moscow, in particular, would strongly advocate for a coordinated regional response to the crisis. A joint agreement among regional partners would not only bolster Moscow's image in the region but also provide the other Central Asian leaders with a unified front for implementing measures against Uzbekistan. Based on consultations with regional experts and academics assessing the most probable response to such a crisis, the prevailing consensus suggests that within the first 72 hours, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, and potentially Iran or China, would move to implement a coordinated set of measures, including:

- *Temporary closures of their borders with Uzbekistan*
- *Increased security along their borders with Tajikistan*
- *A suspension of all military sales to Uzbekistan*
- *A temporary halt to all flights between their countries and Uzbekistan*
- *A pause and review of all joint development projects with Uzbekistan*

Additionally, Russia would likely issue a warning that if military actions were not halted by the 120-hour mark, or if Tashkent fails to initiate ceasefire negotiations with Dushanbe, Moscow will consider additionally implementing the following measures:

- *A review and consideration of rolling back visa-free travel for Uzbeks*
- *An increase in the deportations of illegally employed Uzbeks residing in Russia*
- *A halt to outbound financial transactions between Russian and Uzbek banks*
- *A reassessment of the purchasing price of Uzbek cotton, gas, and minerals*
- *Preparations for the deployment of an intervening Russian peacekeeping force*



(Figure 4.9.39: A map illustrating the countries likely to impose temporary punitive measures against Uzbekistan. Depicted are Uzbekistan (cyan); the initial states imposing sanctions (red), including Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan; and states with a high probability of joining the agreement (orange), namely Iran and China)

While the enforcement of these initial measures would require minimal effort from the four primary participating states, and could be legally justified under the pretext of regional security concerns, for Tashkent, their impact on the war effort would be immediate and devastating. These border closures would have profound consequences for average Uzbek citizens, as the majority of Uzbekistan's imported food and consumer goods enter the country via road or rail from one of these neighbouring states. While some goods would almost certainly continue to be smuggled into Uzbekistan through black and grey markets, the overall supply available to the general public would contract significantly. Supermarket shelves would empty within days, while refined goods such as fuel, electronics, and pharmaceuticals would see sharp declines in availability. Even before these restrictions take full effect, the mere announcement of impending sanctions would likely trigger widespread panic buying and stockpiling of essential commodities. The resulting surge in demand, coupled with the anticipated supply shock, would result in rapid inflation and severe price volatility throughout the country. Which, if not addressed, could quickly lead to souring support for the war.

While some more nationalistic Uzbek citizens may be willing to endure the additional costs in a *“rally around the flag”* effect, sectors of society already less supportive of the administration, will likely seek ways to end these sanctions unilaterally. In particular, Russia’s announcement of a potential second round of sanctions involving severing banking ties between Russia and Uzbekistan will likely cause significant distress among Uzbekistan’s more affluent and influential population. The second round of sanctions also proposes that Moscow begin deporting Uzbeks working in Russia back to Uzbekistan. While Moscow would generally prefer these workers to remain in Russia, as they provide a much-needed source of labour for the Russian economy, Tashkent has an even greater need for them to remain abroad. As these workers and their remittances not only make up 20.8 per cent of Uzbekistan’s overall economy, but Tashkent would also be concerned that Russia may adopt a strategically selective approach to its deportations, as it would be within Moscow’s power to begin its deportations with individuals most likely to actively demonstrate against the government and the war. At this juncture, with sanctions looming, wealthier Uzbeks are also likely to begin transferring their assets out of Uzbek bank accounts, and converting their som into more stable currencies. This behaviour, reminiscent of what occurred in Russia following the imposition of sanctions in 2022, would likely lead to a devaluation and rapid sell-off of the Uzbek som, significantly weakening it against other currencies. This devaluation would then exacerbate a number of the growing financial problems being inflicted upon the less affluent segments of society, as the weaker som would inflate the already rising prices of scarce imports. This sell-off could also create a negative feedback loop: where as the som depreciates, so more citizens might panic and convert their savings into other currencies, which in turn, would further devalue the som, prompting even more people to exchange their currency. If unchecked, this could lead to significant issues for the Uzbek’s central bank, and force Tashkent to stabilise the som using its limited foreign currency reserves a move that would have significant short-to-medium-term repercussions for the Uzbek economy.

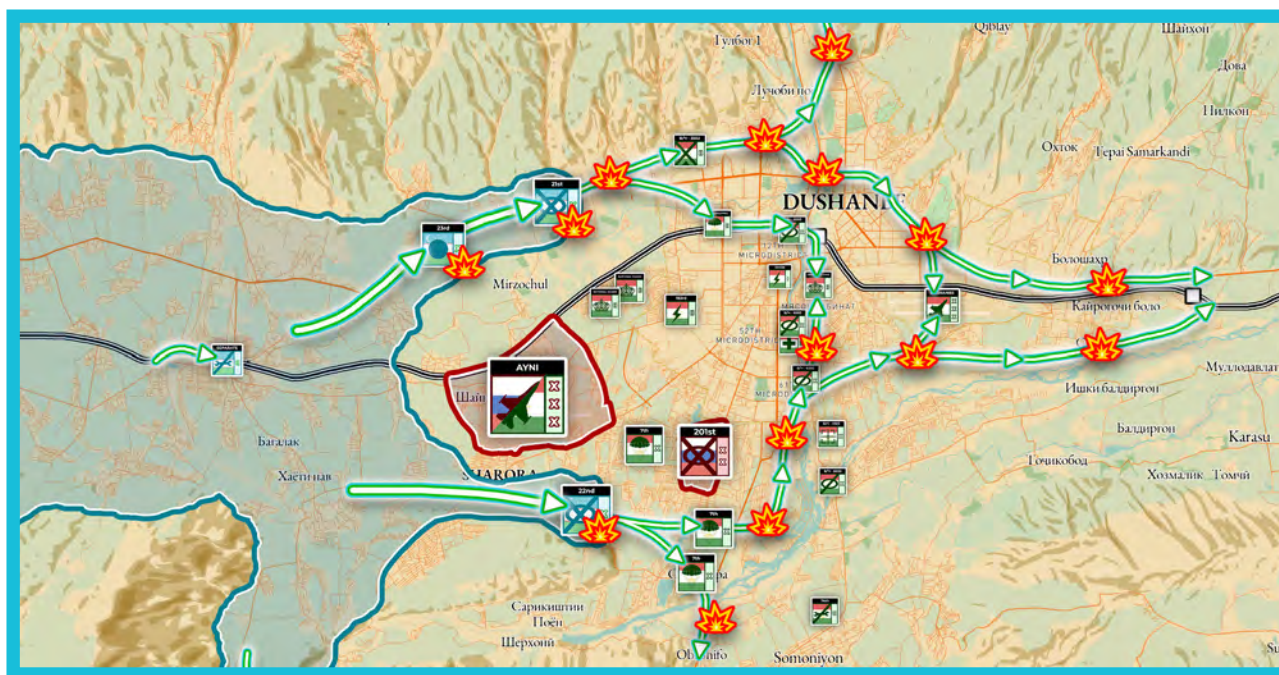
However, if Moscow senses that Tashkent might already be regretting its decision to go to war, it may opt for a more strategic and calculated approach in its response. Where instead of overtly condemning the Uzbek president during the announcement of sanctions, the Kremlin could shift responsibility onto select senior officials within the Uzbek administration, individuals it deemed to be politically expendable in Tashkent’s power structure. For example, if Russia were to blame the war and resulting sanctions solely on the Uzbek defence minister, it could redirect some of the national frustration away from the president and provide him with a political scapegoat, all while preserving a pathway for the two presidents to restore their previously cooperative relations post-conflict. By attributing the responsibility for the war to specific cabinet members, Moscow and Dushanbe could also offer the Uzbek president a more attractive path to resolving the conflict. Where instead of prolonging a costly and increasingly untenable war, the president could dismiss these scapegoated individuals and recall his troops to Uzbekistan.

This approach would likely appeal to the wider Uzbek administration as well, as it could temporarily ease domestic tensions, interrupt the negative economic feedback loop, and allow the military and security services to refocus their efforts toward preventing any potential domestic uprisings or coups. While this strategy does not guarantee that the Uzbek president would take this course of action, and it does not ensure that the population would accept the narrative if he did, it does provide a readily available off-ramp from the crisis. Overall, Moscow’s objective in this scenario would always be to engineer the situation so that the path of least resistance, and therefore the one most likely to be chosen by the Uzbek president, is also the option that best aligns with Moscow’s strategic interests. Which in this case, would be a swift return to the regional status quo.

vi) - End of the war

At this stage, the president will be receiving increasingly alarming assessments from the Ministry of Defence regarding the strategic challenges of the war, alongside escalating reports from the SSS and MIA on a deteriorating internal situation brought on by the war. Compounding these pressures, the additional prospect of the Kremlin spearheading a broader Eurasian sanctions initiative against Uzbekistan, now places the administration at a critical crossroads, where Tashkent is forced to choose between one of two strategic paths:

Option A) Intensification of the war effort

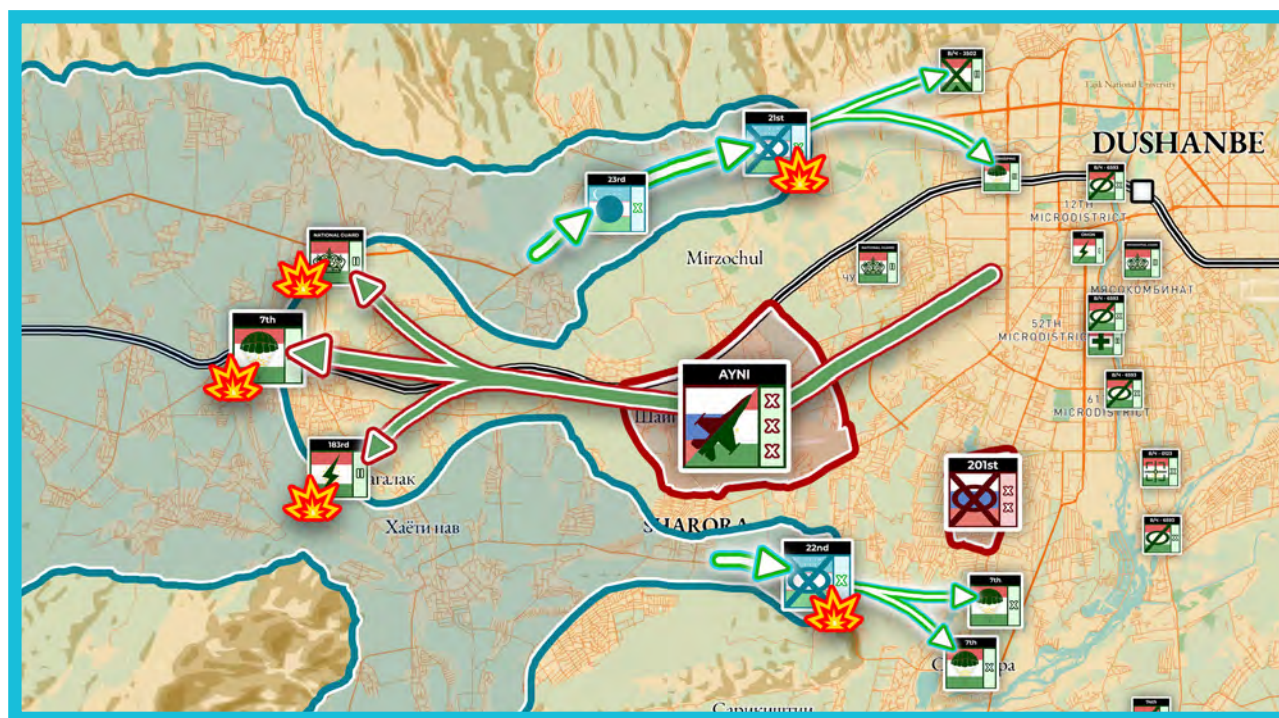


(Figure 4.9.40: Map of the Southern Front around Dushanbe. After regrouping and refitting in Hisor, Uzbek forces prepare to launch their operation to seize Dushanbe. However, due to the stipulation of avoiding direct engagement with the Russian garrison stationed in the city (marked in red), the Uzbek forces must choose between two approaches. They can either concentrate their entire force along a narrow 4-km front between Ayni and the northern mountains, or, as illustrated above, split their forces into two groups, with the 21st and 23rd Brigades advancing north through the narrow gap, while the 22nd Brigade manoeuvre south through the foothills of Dushanbe, with the intention of converging in the city centre to complete the operation)

If the Uzbeks are determined to press on with the war, their next major objective on the Southern Front will be to forcibly seize Dushanbe. According to the scenario's stipulations, the Russian forces will attempt to maintain military neutrality, remaining confined to their bases in Ayni and southwest Dushanbe, and will only engage the Uzbeks if directly attacked. While the neutrality of the Russian garrison offers some strategic advantages to Uzbek commanders, enabling them to avoid direct conflict with the Russians and their upgraded T-72B3Ms, the physical placement of these bases poses a geographical challenge. As due to their positions, the Tajiks can not only continue to use these positions as forward observation and artillery spotting points, but the physical locations of these bases also severely limit the routes available for Uzbek forces to enter Dushanbe.

The Uzbek forces have two tactical options, each with distinct challenges. The first option is to concentrate their troops northward between the Russian base and the mountains, effectively narrowing their advance to a roughly 4 km-wide corridor where the Tajik forces can focus their defences. Advancing along such a constrained front would not only diminish the numerical advantage held by the Uzbeks, but it would also force all resupply convoys to traverse down just one or two roads, making them highly vulnerable to Tajik drones, artillery, and MLRS platforms.

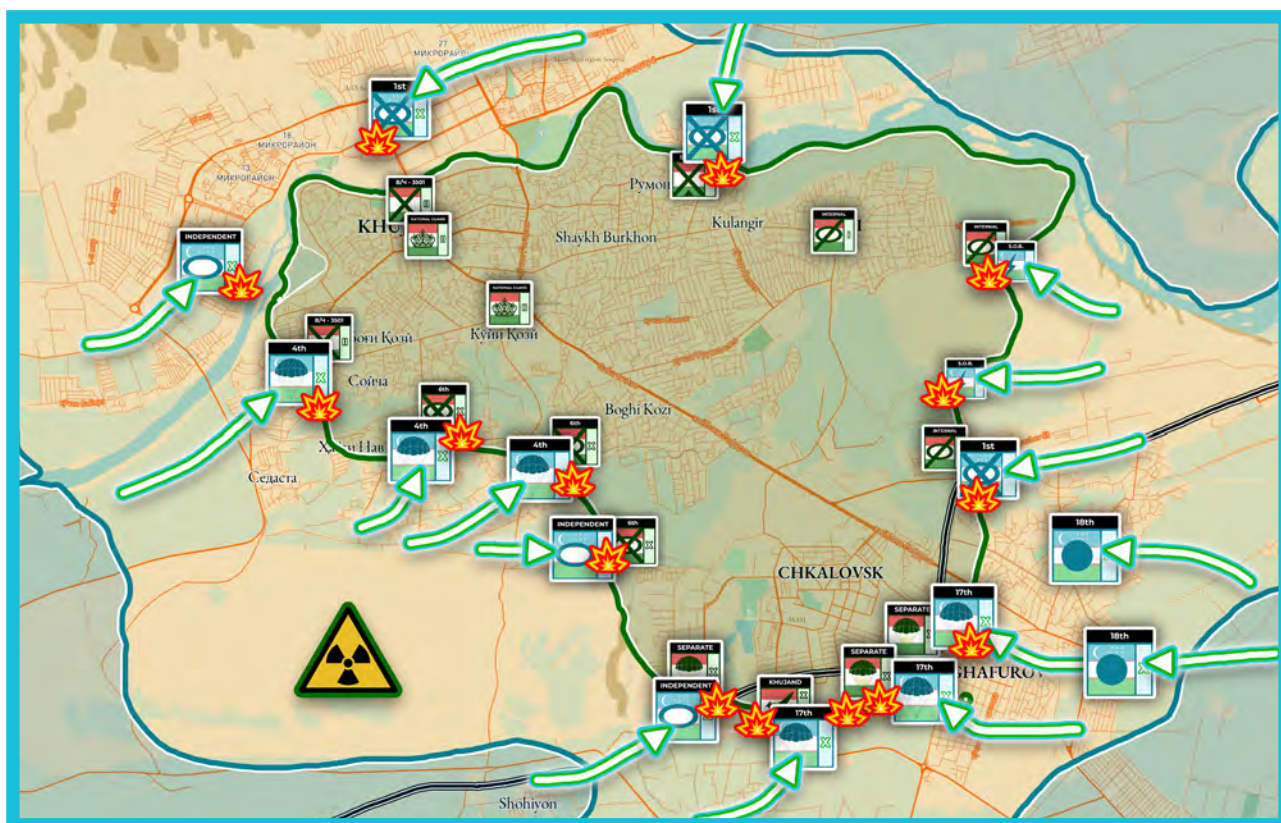
In the second option, the Uzbeks could choose to split their forces in an effort to outflank Dushanbe by advancing from the north and the south simultaneously. While this approach would prevent the Tajiks from concentrating all their forces along a single section of the front, it introduces a new set of significant challenges. Splitting the forces creates a 15 km-wide gap between the northern and southern advances, necessitating the establishment of two separate supply lines and making mutual support between the fronts almost impossible. Additionally, this division of forces also dilutes the numerical superiority of the Uzbek troops at the forward thrust, and leaves their increasingly stretched flanks more vulnerable. More critically though, this option also exposes a substantial vulnerability in the Uzbek rear areas, particularly around the likely forward command and supply zones in Hisor. As while the Uzbeks are compelled to manoeuvre around the Russian-controlled area at Ayni, the Tajiks would likely face no such restrictions. This means that if the Uzbek forces were divided and engaged on both the northern and southern fronts of the city, the Tajiks could then easily exploit the Russian-controlled zone in the centre to move their rapid reaction forces directly into the Uzbek rear. This manoeuvre would not only allow the Tajiks to target supply caches and effectively isolate the forward-deployed Uzbek units, but for the Uzbeks, the only viable counter to this potentially catastrophic threat would then be to then further divide their forces, leaving a brigade behind in the centre to secure the gap. The end result being a now even further diminished forward advance into the outer suburbs of Dushanbe.



(Figure 4.9.41: Map of the Dushanbe Front. This map highlights the risk of a Tajik incursion through Ayni into the Uzbek rear, as well as the lengthening frontlines that the Uzbeks will be compelled to defend as they advance deeper into the capital along two separate axes)

In addition to the Ayni problem, the Uzbek lines would also quickly expand from a concentrated 4 km width, to now being over 30 km in width, and the situation only worsening as the operation progresses. This substantial extension of the front would not only dilute troop concentrations but also intensify logistical challenges and heighten the risk of Uzbek forward units being cut off and surrounded by Tajik air assault forces. As the advance into Dushanbe continues, the fighting will also likely become increasingly attritional, with Uzbek forces becoming bogged down in block-by-block urban combat. This would see Uzbek forces compelled to undertake costly direct assaults on an increasing number of well-prepared defensive positions throughout the city. This sort of fighting, coupled with a likely hostile local population and the exponential strain on the logistics networks, will cause the Uzbek DCR to rise significantly.

Simultaneously, the Uzbek's DSR is likely to decline as well. This figure being driven down by a rising number of operational vehicles and drivers being lost to drone attacks, enemy artillery, and routine mechanical failures. At this stage of the scenario, Uzbek forces will also still be heavily reliant on supplies being trucked in from Termez and Kakaydy, now over 250 km away, and this dependency will endure until they can capture the Dushanbe railway and secure the rail line between Dushanbe and Termez. However, for Tashkent, the railway remains a distant objective in central Dushanbe, well beyond the Uzbeks' current reach. Therefore, this reliance on overextended supply lines, coupled with the country's likely rapidly depleting reserves of fuel, logistics vehicles, and ammunition, will create an increasingly precarious situation for the Uzbek commanders in the south. Meanwhile, the northern front commanders will grapple with their own set of challenges.



(Figure 4.9.42: Map of the Northern Front, zoomed in to Khujand. This map depicts the likely situation after a week of intense battles as Uzbek forces advance through the suburbs. Despite sustained efforts, Uzbek forces are anticipated to still be short of securing the bridges over the Syr Darya or the railway at Chkalovsk)

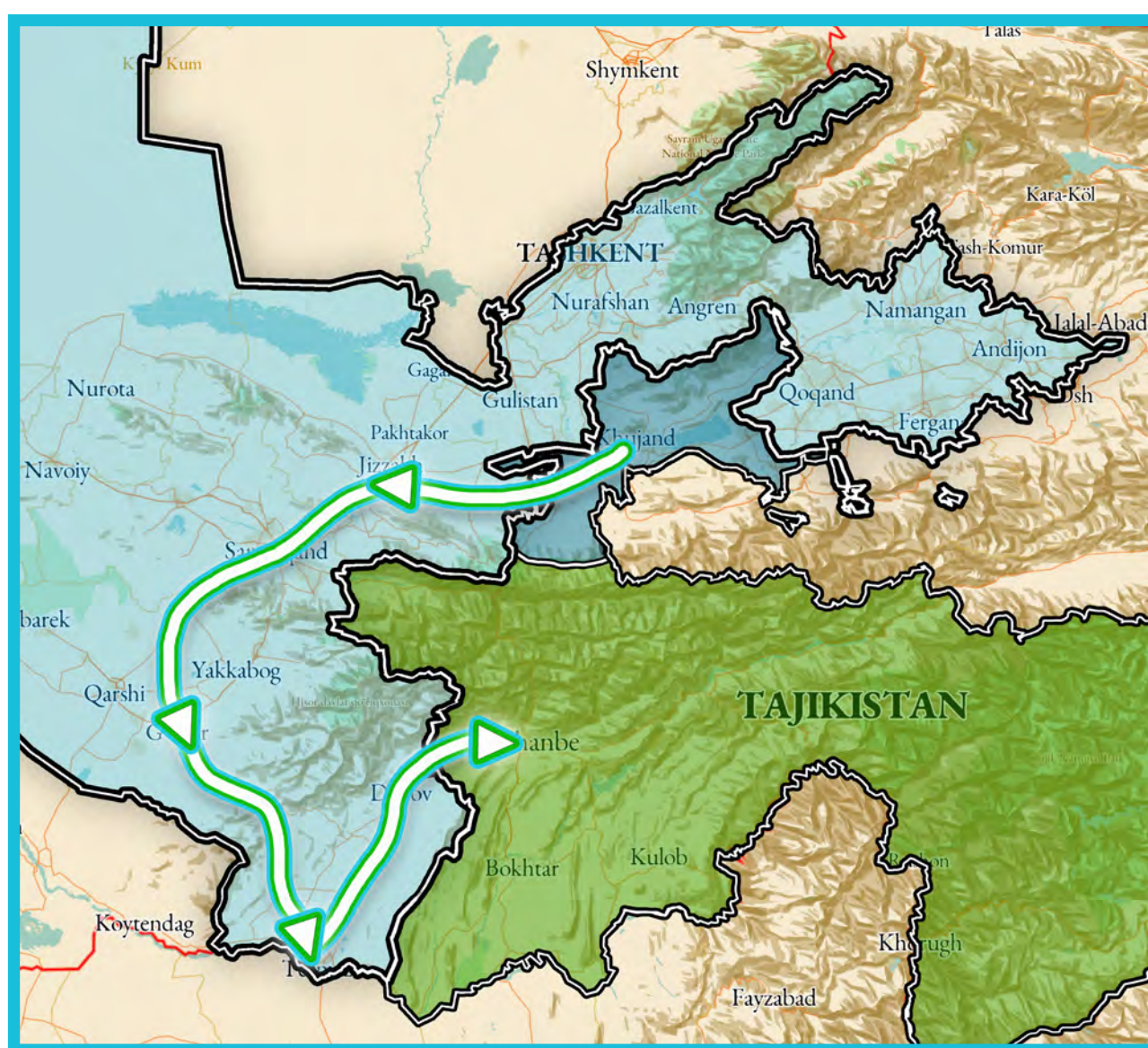
While it is entirely possible, and indeed likely, that with sufficient manpower and materiel, the Uzbeks could systematically demolish their way through Khujand, the costs of doing so would be catastrophic. The estimated time required for the city to fully fall could be as high as 2-4 weeks, during which both sides would likely incur significant losses in manpower, ammunition, and vehicles. By the 2-3 week mark, heightened international scrutiny of Uzbekistan's conduct will also become inevitable as more journalists and observers arrive into the region to document the fighting. Footage of devastated suburbs will likely continue to surface online, and Russian-language Telegram groups would become breeding grounds for misinformation about the conflict. With the Uzbek government also possessing limited global or social media presence to counter these emerging narratives, Tashkent will struggle to control or influence regional and international perceptions of its actions here in Tajikistan. This means that as the conflict grows increasingly bloody, calls from Uzbekistan to halt its offensive will only intensify, and the risk of additional nations imposing sanctions on Uzbekistan will only rise.

By this point, the originally proposed sanctions from Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan will already be inflicting a significant toll on the homefront, leading to a worsening quality of life for the majority of the population. Simultaneously, by now, casualty lists will also begin to circulate on social media and other channels, with the numbers likely to be much higher than first anticipated. Tashkent will remember the backlash suffered by the Soviet government during the Soviet-Afghan war, likely worrying that these growing lists pose a risk of similarly catalysing resentment within the Uzbek population. However, even if these national costs were deemed acceptable, and the administration was prepared to endure the growing public dissent to achieve a complete victory over Khujand, the city's fall would not necessarily ensure the collapse of the Tajik government or an end to the conflict. From here, policymakers in Tashkent would be faced with a series of tough questions.

For one, if Khujand is finally captured, potentially at the cost of 5,000 to 10,000 Uzbek soldiers, would the government then be prepared to replenish and maintain these forces in the north for the occupation phase? On top of that, given the scale of losses sustained, would Tashkent also then be willing to further deplete its domestic garrisons to achieve a decisive resolution in the south? As a full-scale campaign to secure the southern front would not only necessitate the redeployment of substantial reserve forces but also require a commitment of troops that the administration may later need to suppress internal unrest. More critically, it would also involve transferring battle-fatigued and depleted units from the northern theater to the south, further stretching the country's already broken logistics. Such a manoeuvre would compel exhausted soldiers, fresh from a gruelling campaign in the north, to undertake a long and arduous redeployment across the country to Dushanbe, where they would be tasked with launching a second offensive against a city that, by then, would likely be even more heavily fortified and reinforced.

A significant portion of Uzbekistan's vehicle fleet and combat platforms are also likely to be in a deteriorating condition by this stage as well, as sustained operations accelerate wear and tear on the vehicles internals. Large portions of the UZAADF will probably no longer be capable of providing the same level of air support as they did during the initial phase of the conflict, and attrition among experienced personnel from earlier engagements will necessitate their replacement with fresh recruits. Replacing trained veterans with conscripts who are likely to lack the combat proficiency and battlefield cohesion of their predecessors. The ongoing logistical constraints will also be further exacerbated by the depletion of ammunition and essential supplies. As if Russia remains unwilling to provide weapons and ammunition to Tashkent, and

the weakened som makes black market purchases untenable, it leaves Uzbek commanders to either draw from their remaining national stockpiles, potentially pushing 40+ year-old ammunition and shells into service, or commit their forces to combat operations with severely limited or nonexistent ammunition reserves. Moreover, while Uzbekistan will likely be unable to procure the necessary weaponry and consumables from Russia, Tajikistan will probably face no such restrictions. Instead, Dushanbe will likely be permitted to import new arms and fortify its defences, with external actors potentially even providing long-term material support to sustain their war effort. For Tashkent, there is also a risk that major powers like the United States, Russia, and China, may even adopt the view that sending military assistance to Tajikistan would serve as a deterrent to other states considering similar invasions in the future. If Tashkent were to disregard these considerations and just push ahead with its offensive in the south, policymakers would also need to assess whether public support could be sustained in the face of an additional 10,000–15,000+ casualties. As for the government, the political and social ramifications of such losses could further strain domestic stability and raise the risk of internal dissent, particularly for a conflict where Uzbekistan is clearly perceived as the aggressor.

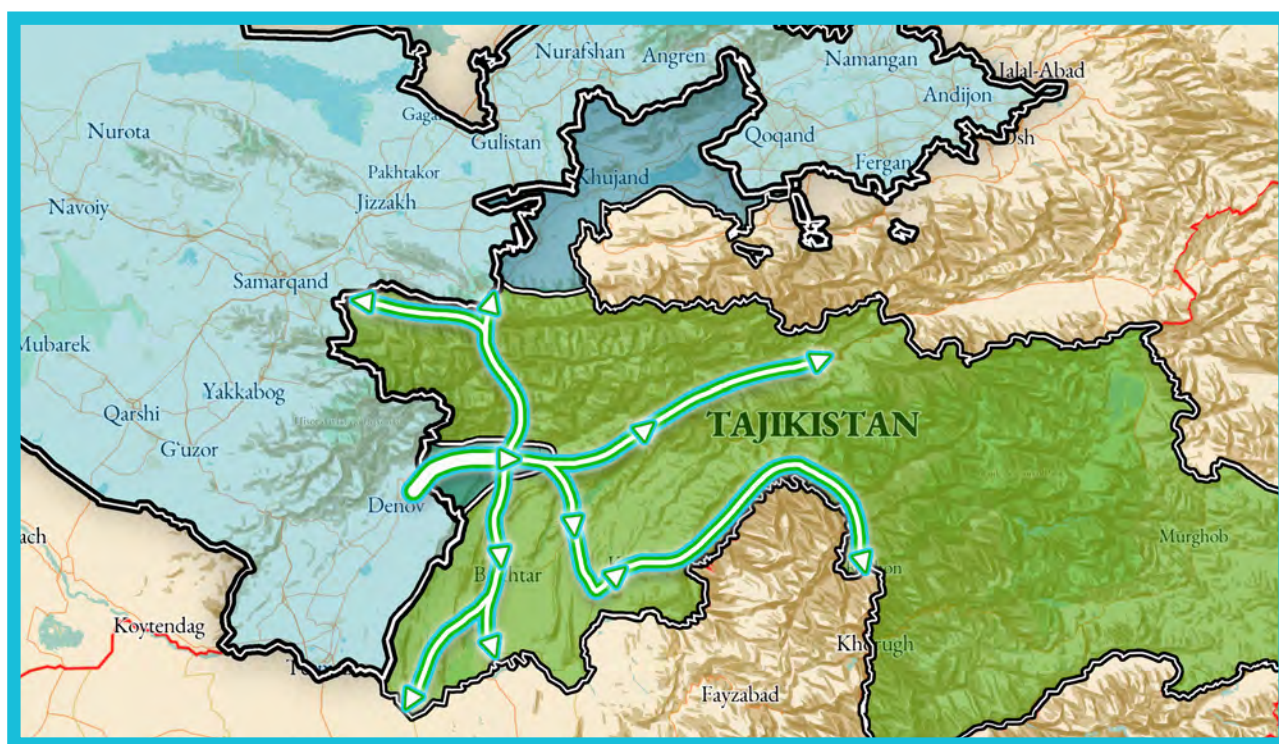


(Figure 4.9.43: Map illustrating areas of Tajikistan now under occupation by Uzbek forces (blue) and the proposed train route for soldiers being redirected to the Southern Front)

Yet, as dire as the situation may be, simply halting Uzbek forces at their current positions, having secured only Khujand and a limited foothold west of Dushanbe, would neither constitute a strategic victory nor compel Tajikistan to recognise any territorial concessions. From a political standpoint, concluding hostilities without a complete victory or tangible gains to justify the heavy losses already sustained would also be equally disastrous. However, with the current position becoming increasingly untenable, Tashkent would be forced to confront the largest dilemma: where they either have to accept the political humiliation of withdrawing its forces back into Uzbekistan, or choose to escalate the conflict in an attempt to salvage the situation, doubling down on existing losses, in the hopes that a decisive victory would retroactively justify the administration's miscalculations.

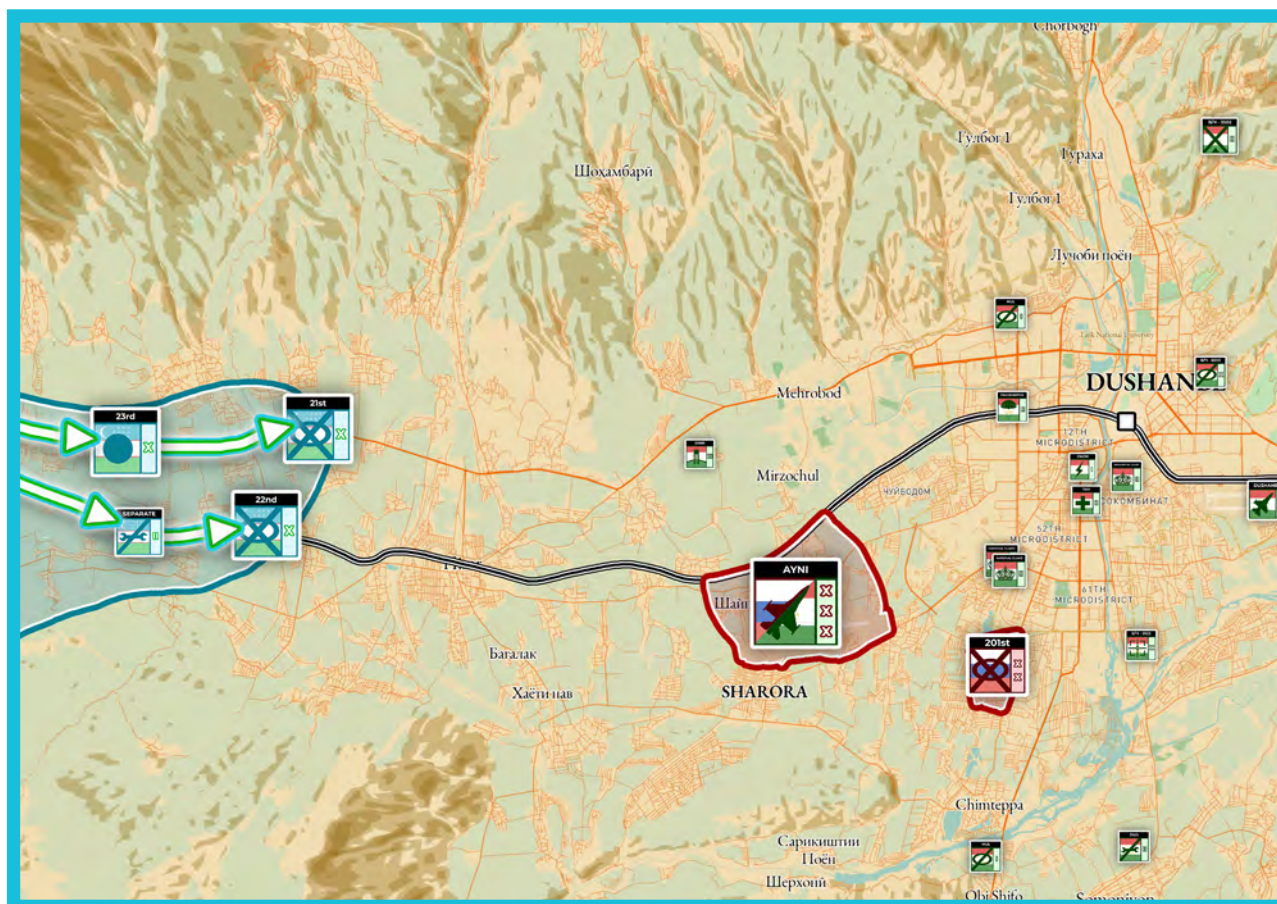
Furthermore, even if the Uzbeks were able to pull off a miracle on the battlefield by capturing Dushanbe, a decisive strategic victory over Tajikistan still remains highly unlikely. Even if the Uzbek forces were to take control of Dushanbe, the Tajik leadership could simply relocate the government to another city, such as Bokhtar, Kulob, or Danghara, shifting the conflict towards a prolonged insurgency. At that point, would the command be willing to launch another campaign into southern Tajikistan to seize these southern cities? Would they be willing to embark on additional campaigns into the treacherous central valleys toward cities like Gharm or Vahdat? Would they also be willing to march eastward into the mountains toward Panj or Khorog? In reality, Uzbekistan's prosecution of that war would likely require Tashkent to continue fighting for several years, using an army that realistically only possesses months' worth of supplies. All of which would have to be fought while the domestic economy implodes, and international sentiment turns against them. Given these harsh realities, at the D+3 stage of the campaign, the administration is only realistically left with one viable option for how to proceed.

Likely Result: Stalemate/Pyrrhic Victory for the Uzbek Armed Forces



(Figure 4.9.44: Map illustrating the additional campaigns the Uzbek forces may have to launch if the Dushanbe government relocates)

Option B) Strategic withdrawal back into Uzbekistan



(Figure 4.9.45: Map of Dushanbe and surroundings, with the Russian bases marked in red. By D+3, with both sides having sustained minimal casualties, Uzbek forces reach the Tajik city of Hisor and pause their advance. From here, a temporary ceasefire is declared as peace negotiations between Dushanbe and Tashkent begin)

Much like Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine, if the Uzbeks fail to achieve all their objectives within 3 days, including forcing the Tajik government to capitulate, the operation could likely be considered a failure. At this juncture, the Uzbek leadership would be faced with three options: either doubling down and preparing for a prolonged and potentially catastrophic conflict, consolidating their current territorial gains, or initiating peace negotiations with the hope of eliciting concessions. As previously outlined, prolonging the war would likely lead to a military and economic disaster for the Uzbeks, making it an undesirable path to pursue. Consolidating the limited territory captured would also result in a net loss for the Uzbek government, as holding a few small towns on the fringes of Tajikistan would not offset the economic damage from border closures, sanctions, capital flight, and reputational harm. Consequently, Tashkent is realistically left with only one viable option: to open dialogue with Dushanbe and seek a diplomatic resolution to the conflict.

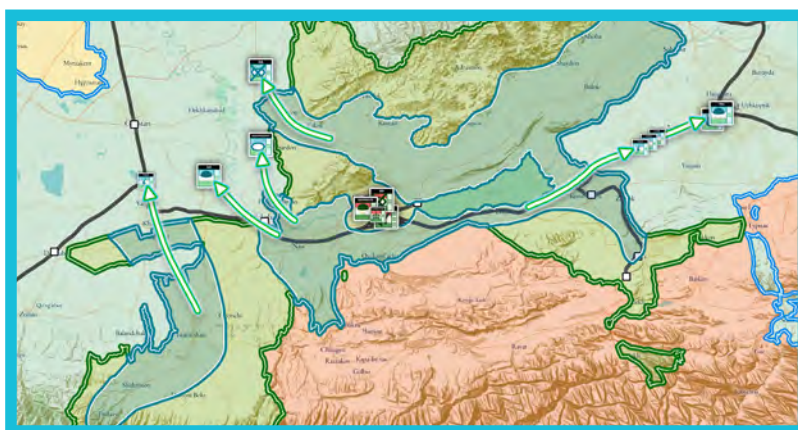
If negotiations with Dushanbe commence early enough, both sides will likely be more inclined to approach the negotiating table constructively and seek a diplomatic resolution to the crisis. At this stage, both governments would face considerable pressure from Moscow, Astana, and Beijing to end the conflict and restore regional stability. Both leaders have significant incentives to prevent the war from escalating and arrive at a solution acceptable to both governments.



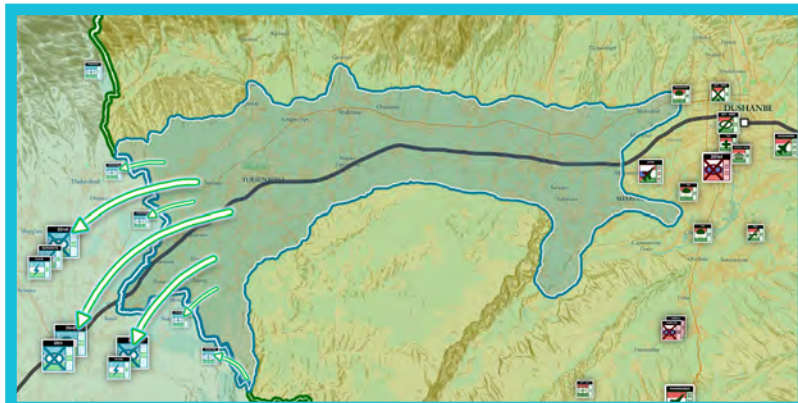
(Figure 4.9.46: Map of the Northern Front, at D+3, Uzbek forces reach the outskirts of Khujand and halt their advance. A temporary ceasefire is declared as peace negotiations between Dushanbe and Tashkent commence)

Given the parameters outlined in this scenario, the most plausible outcome would be for Uzbek forces to encounter minimal resistance as they advance toward their primary objectives, reaching the outskirts of Dushanbe and Khujand by D+2 or D+3. However, upon securing forward positions, the operational necessity to refit and refuel would likely compel Uzbek forces to pause before attempting further offensives. At this stage, diplomatic channels would likely be activated as both sides face the prospect of protracted urban combat. These initial negotiations could lead to a temporary ceasefire, with Uzbek forces maintaining their positions overlooking the cities. Ideally, by D+4 - D+6, the two sides would reach a provisional agreement that solidifies both parties' water use rights and provides a framework for de-escalation. With a settlement in place, both sides would then ideally move toward disengagement, allowing Uzbek forces to withdraw before the conflict escalates into high-intensity urban warfare.

(Figure 4.9.47: Map of the Northern Front (right). Following negotiations, Uzbek forces withdraw back home along their respective axes)



(Figure 4.9.48: Map of the Southern Front (bottom). Following several days of negotiations, Uzbek forces withdraw west of Tursunzoda)



Peace remains the most economically, strategically, and reputationally advantageous option for both sides, as both administrations' current strategic doctrines prioritise the continuation of regional trade and domestic stability. For Tashkent and Dushanbe, major urban fighting risks domestic unrest and economic hardships for their entire population. By pursuing an early peace settlement, Uzbekistan may secure slightly better terms for water rights than what Dushanbe would have been willing to offer before the conflict. However, any improvements in these terms are unlikely to compensate for the lives lost or the severe risks associated with launching such an operation in the first place. Given their respective domestic audiences, if war were to break out, both governments would have strong incentives to craft an agreement that allows their respective leaderships to claim some form of victory. Recognising that this outcome could have been achieved just as effectively through peaceful negotiations underscores why it is unlikely that Tashkent would pursue a military solution to this issue in the first place. If Uzbekistan acknowledges that a decisive victory on the battlefield is unattainable, it must also recognise that negotiations will be inevitable.

Likely Result: *Tactical Defeat / Forced Withdrawal*

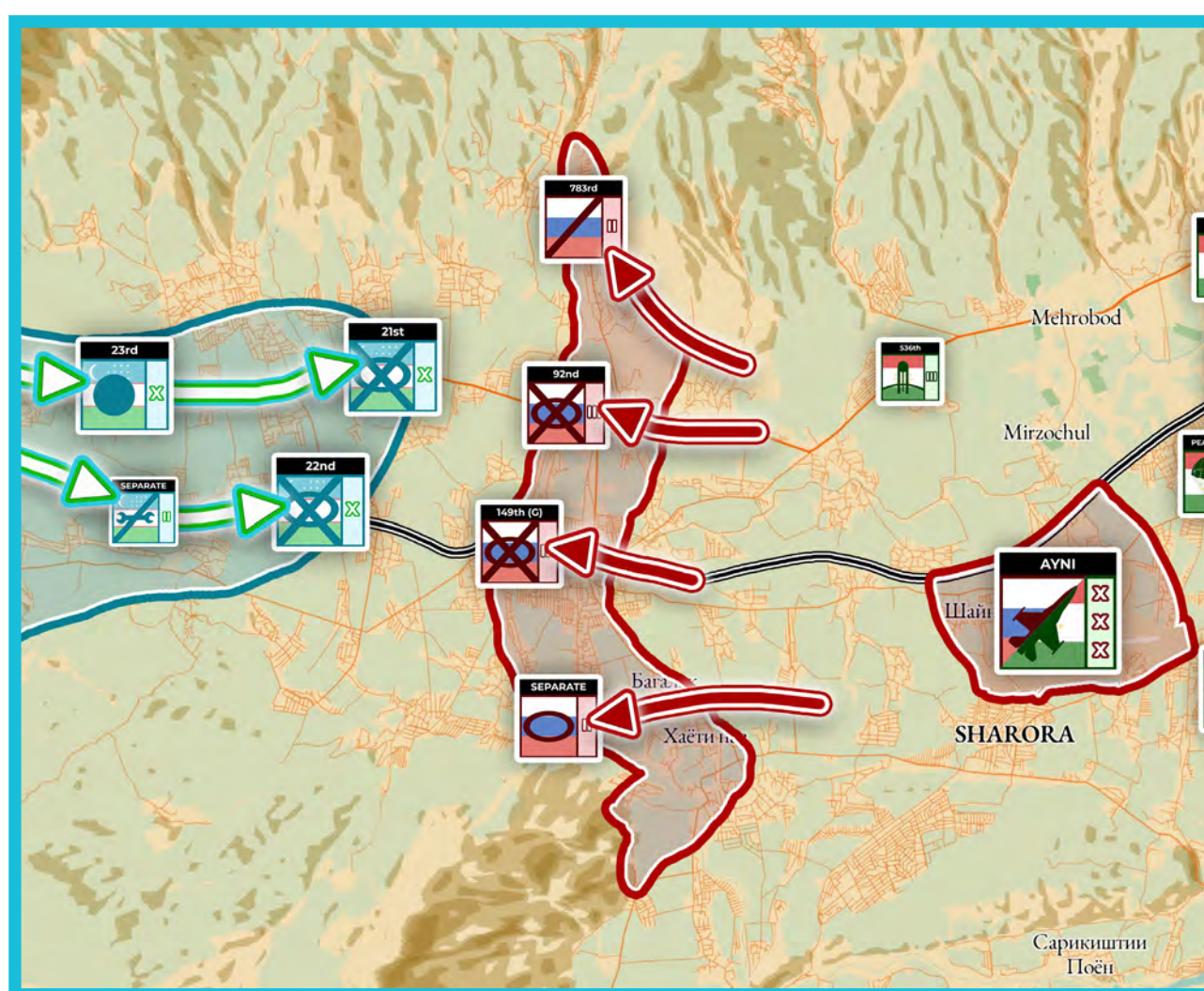
vii) - Key findings

Based on the wargaming and analysis of the above scenario, here are our three key findings:

1) - Russia will have significant influence over the conflict's outcome:

Even without the backing of the CSTO, as illustrated throughout this analysis, Russia remains a pivotal actor in determining the trajectory, duration, and outcome of this hypothetical conflict, regardless of its direct military involvement. Firstly, Russia serves as the primary supplier of military arms to both Uzbekistan and Tajikistan. Meaning that in the event of a prolonged campaign, Moscow could significantly influence the outcome by selectively channelling arms and military support to one side or the other (or feasibly both). Secondly, both nations are currently heavily dependent on Russia for the stability of their economies, with Tajikistan relying on remittances from its workforce in Russia for approximately 50 per cent of its national income, while Uzbekistan's reliance stands at just over 20 per cent. These substantial levels of economic dependency grant Russia the ability to exert considerable economic pressure on either country with minimal effort. Should Russia decide to support one side over the other, it could trigger severe economic repercussions, potentially even causing double-digit recessions overnight in the targeted state, simply by squeezing visa and banking permissions. While the current administration in Moscow would undoubtedly prefer to maintain stable leadership in both Uzbekistan and Tajikistan, Russia possesses significant economic leverage and messaging capabilities that could make governance increasingly difficult for either administration. Russian economic sanctions or disruptions to remittance flows would also have a devastating impact on Uzbekistan's short-term warfighting capability. If such measures were to be undertaken by Moscow, it could potentially incite domestic unrest and undermine the broader war effort by both slowing down supply lines from railheads within Uzbekistan or forcing Tashkent to divert troops back toward major cities within Uzbekistan for crowd control operations. In extreme cases, if the population suffered severely enough or viewed the war as unjust, enough Russian pressure could even lead to the possible overthrow of the administration by popular unrest.

It is also crucial to note that within this scenario, it was the imposition of the Russian-led sanctions and the establishment of border closures around Uzbekistan, that represent the point at which the war truly begins to turn against Tashkent. Even though Russia didn't directly involve itself in the fighting here, it was the one that made the Uzbek war effort untenable. Moscow spearheading the sanctions response also has a dramatic impact on how the rest of the region reacts as well, as in interviews conducted for this report, experts and academics consistently indicated that in this particular scenario, Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan would only likely sign onto such a severe economic response if Russia or China were to be the ones leading it. Without the Kazakh and Kyrgyz leaderships being able to deflect the blame for these sanctions onto Moscow after the conflict or being able to access emergency loans and funding to stabilise their own domestic banks and consumer markets, these nations would be far less likely to impose the significant punitive measures on Uzbekistan envisaged in the exercise.



(Figure 4.9.49: Map of the Southern Front, D+3, around western Dushanbe. As Uzbek forces cross into Tajikistan, Russia's garrison at the 201st Military Base redeploy to establish military roadblocks along all the Hanaka River crossings. Moscow claims to be acting in a peacekeeping capacity, aiming to prevent the two sides from engaging in further hostilities. The practical outcome, however, is that the Uzbeks would now be unable to continue their advance eastwards towards Dushanbe without directly engaging Russian soldiers)

Although the likelihood of Russia declaring war on Uzbekistan in this scenario remains minimal, there are still several ways in which Russian military forces could be deployed to inhibit or actively forestall the Uzbek offensive. Once the Uzbeks cross the border without targeting any Russian facilities in their initial strikes, it would signal to Moscow that Tashkent is keen to avoid drawing Russia into the conflict. Therefore, seizing on Tashkent's evident reluctance to engage with Russian forces, Moscow could choose to swiftly redeploy its existing garrisons to establish roadblocks along key chokepoints and crossings over the Hanaka River, an action that could likely be completed within just a few hours. Once these Russian units are in position, the Uzbeks would be confronted with a lose-lose decision: where they either have to carry out direct attacks upon the Russian "peacekeepers", thereby providing Russia with the justification to take whatever actions it deems necessary against Tashkent, or they would be forced halt their advance west of the river as there are no other crossing points, an outcome that seems far more likely. The stark reality is that even if Uzbekistan were to gain all the initial advantages posited in this scenario, a simple series of connected Russian roadblocks across the Hanaka River could effectively force the Uzbeks to abandon their attack 17 km short of Dushanbe. While in most scenarios, Moscow is more likely to intervene only when it deems it to be absolutely necessary, more likely opting to instead act only as a mediator and facilitate negotiations between its two allies (like in the case of the 2022 conflict in Batken), in the event of such a major campaign being launched, Moscow would likely feel compelled to act more decisively to end the fighting.

2) - The army is not logistically ready for such an operation:

Uzbekistan's logistical challenges are likely to be its Achilles' heel in any prolonged conflict, as the Uzbek armed forces lack the necessary quantities of infrastructure and resources, such as fuel trucks, mobile fuel stations, transport trucks, field kitchens, portable generators, and dedicated field communications units required to sustain an operation of this scale. Part of these weaknesses arguably stem from the UGF's continued reliance on outdated Soviet-era equipment and doctrines, most of which require relatively high DCRs to function effectively. However, unlike the Soviets, the Uzbeks do not possess anywhere near the levels of comprehensive support systems, including widespread integration of dedicated rail troops, large-scale logistics coordination units, practical material-technical support brigades (MTSBs), and ample reserves of protected supplies, mobile fuel trucks, and mobile repair facilities to be able to sustain the required DCR levels that these doctrines prescribe. Throughout the exercise, we also noted that the Uzbek team's already fragile logistics network was highly vulnerable to attack, sabotage and mismanagement, with the Uzbek supply lines being susceptible to attacks from partisans, drones, and long-range strike weapons. Even minimal efforts by the Tajik teams caused the Uzbek team consistent delays, shortages, and reduced supply rates throughout the southern campaign. The situation also becomes even worse for the Uzbek forces if Russia were also to grant the Tajik forces access to their cache of drones and precision strike weapons stored at the 201st bases in Dushanbe and Lyuar, as these could also be used to not only target critical Uzbek weapon caches, radar sites, or rear coordination centres but also to prevent the Uzbek's from being able to safely rely on fixed or rotary wing air support throughout the south, leading to further shortages of forward supplies and major handicaps in frontline support and reconnaissance. If such an invasion were

ever launched in reality, the Uzbek forces would face significant operational delays waiting for supplies to be brought up from distant bases and railheads in Termez or Kakaydy, while their frontline forces would suffer disproportionate losses from aerial, artillery and raiding attacks.

3) - The UGF are not trained for large-scale conventional warfare:

While late Soviet-era Uzbek commanders may have been trained for large-scale battles on the plains of Europe, today's Uzbek forces are neither designed nor equipped for such conventional wars. These days, the modern Uzbek military's primary focus has instead shifted to counterterrorism and internal policing operations, emphasising the importance of rapid deployment rather than being able to sustain offensives involving multiple divisions over extended periods of time. Most of these Uzbek units have also not been trained for the kinds of concentrated assaults against defensive positions likely to crop up in such a conflict. In a scenario similar to the one proposed here, Uzbekistan's substantial number of fast-moving armoured vehicles could enable Tashkent to acquire some significant early gains. However, the subsequent transition from rapid incursions along relatively uncontested rural highways to prolonged and often asynchronous urban combat operations would pose a considerable challenge for the UGF. Dense urban environments, especially those with pre-prepared defences, are likely to nullify many of Uzbekistan's quantitative and operational advantages, with most of the Uzbek massed or armoured units becoming ineffective in such contested urban settings. Furthermore, given Uzbekistan's inevitable reliance on conscripted personnel to carry out such assaults, the likely resulting high casualty rate and the difficulty of concealing such large casualty figures in today's media environment would significantly increase the risk of quickly souring public opinion towards the overarching war.

Comparable scenarios, such as the Battle of Grozny in 1999 or the Battle of Mosul in 2016–2017, highlight the immense challenges that conventional forces face in carrying out prolonged urban warfare campaigns. Even in these scenarios, where the attacking force succeeded in achieving initial air superiority, as well as possessing a greater quantity of armoured vehicles and better-equipped troops for the assault, the attacking forces were still forced to endure gruelling, house-by-house fighting, regularly encountering improvised explosive devices, sniper fire, and fortified positions throughout their campaign into the city. Furthermore, the geographic reality of Dushanbe means it would be practically impossible to surround or cut off the city prior to the assault, allowing Tajik supplies and reinforcements to continue flowing into the city from the south and east throughout the battle as well. Also notable for this particular scenario, is the fact that many of the senior commanders in the modern Tajik military gained their initial battlefield experience fighting in urban and mountainous theatres during the Tajik Civil War, bringing a level of firsthand experience to their side that Uzbek commanders may lack. Ultimately, if such a campaign were to be launched, Uzbek forces would face a series of difficult scenarios in both Dushanbe and Khujand, where the Tajik's well-prepared defensive positions would force Tashkent to repeatedly engage in costly and prolonged fighting, ultimately underscoring that for Uzbekistan, it would almost always be in Tashkent's strategic interest to avoid declaring war on in Tajikistan in the first place.

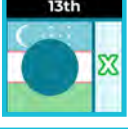
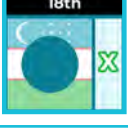
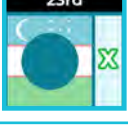
4.10: CONCLUSION

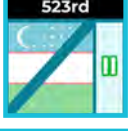
As Uzbekistan embarks on a pivotal stage in its regional defence strategy, it is confronted with the imperative to modernise its armed forces in response to evolving power dynamics across Central Asia. The transition from legacy Soviet-era systems to a more technologically advanced and capable military framework is not merely a matter of national security but a strategic necessity to uphold regional stability and deter potential threats. However, for Tashkent, executing this modernisation poses substantial challenges. Financial limitations, technological disparities, and entrenched logistical inefficiencies present formidable obstacles, each requiring precise strategic planning and resource allocation to ensure the success of this transformation in the coming years. Uzbekistan's approach to military modernisation, though measured, adheres to a strategically sound framework characteristic of a force recalibrating itself for both present and future operational demands. By prioritising the enhancement of existing Soviet-era systems, procuring advanced weaponry, and integrating modernised communication and reconnaissance systems, Tashkent is bolstering its combat capabilities while remaining aligned with its core defensive doctrine. The emphasis on upgrading armoured and mechanised units, air and air defence forces, and special operations units demonstrates a deliberate effort to forge a force structure capable of countering both conventional and asymmetrical threats across its diverse operational environment.

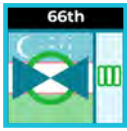
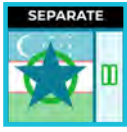
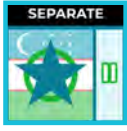
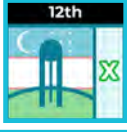
However, despite notable advancements in deployment efficiency and command structures, Uzbekistan faces critical challenges in the logistical domain. Effective force projection and sustainment hinge on investments in transportation infrastructure, robust ammunition supply chains, and modernised maintenance facilities. Addressing these deficiencies will not only enhance the rapid mobilisation of forces, but also ensure operational resilience and reduce dependence on external suppliers. Additionally, fostering partnerships with international defence firms to facilitate technology transfers remains a key component in Uzbekistan's effort to transition towards a more self-reliant and technologically advanced military posture. Uzbekistan's military is currently well-positioned to maintain internal stability and effectively counter potential uprisings or limited external incursions. While this provides a solid foundation for national defence in the near term, reclaiming its status as the region's preeminent military power will require a far more ambitious reform agenda. Achieving this objective would likely necessitate surpassing Kazakhstan's rising defence expenditures, expanding Uzbekistan's network of financial and military partnerships, and diversifying its resource and supplier base to reduce dependency on a limited number of providers. However, such ambitions are also inextricably tied to Uzbekistan's broader economic trajectory. For the Uzbek Armed Forces to achieve their modernisation goals, sustained funding and long-term reform efforts will ultimately depend on Tashkent's ability to foster economic growth and maintain regional stability.

4.11: USEFUL MAPS AND CHARTS

GROUND FORCES		LOCATION
	Independent Tank Brigade	Angren
	1st Motorised Rifle Brigade	Chirchik
	2nd Motorised Rifle Brigade (Reserve Unit)	Samarkand
	3rd Motorised Rifle Brigade	Navoi
	7th Motorised Rifle Brigade	Termez
	21st Motorised Rifle Brigade	Khayrabad
	22nd Motorised Rifle Brigade	Pashkurt
	25th Motorised Rifle Brigade	Nuriston
	34th Motorised Rifle Brigade	Andijan
	Independent Motorised Rifle Brigade	Buhkara

	Independent Motorised Rifle Brigade	Nukus
	4th Rapid Reaction Airborne Brigade	Chirchik
	17th Air Assault Brigade	Fergana
	6th Separate Mountain Rifle Brigade	Bakhmal
	13th Artillery Brigade	Kattakurgan
	18th Artillery Brigade	Margilan
	23rd Artillery Brigade	Kakaydy
	Separate Rocket Artillery Brigade	Jizzakh**
	15th Independent Special Forces Brigade	Chirchik
	Special Operations Battalions	Various
	Separate Engineering Regiment	Gulistan**
	Separate Engineering Regiment	Kakaydy**
	520th Mobilisation Battalion	Kakaydy

	521st Mobilisation Battalion	Qarshi
	522nd Mobilisation Battalion	Bukhara
	523rd Mobilisation Battalion	Navoi
	524th Mobilisation Battalion	Jizzakh
	525th Mobilisation Battalion	Syrdarya
	526th Mobilisation Battalion	Samarkand
	527th Mobilisation Battalion	Kattakurgan
	528th Mobilisation Battalion	Andijan
	529th Mobilisation Battalion	Fergana
	530th Mobilisation Battalion	Pop
	531st Mobilisation Battalion	Chirchik
	532nd Mobilisation Battalion	Akaltyn
	533rd Mobilisation Battalion	Nukus

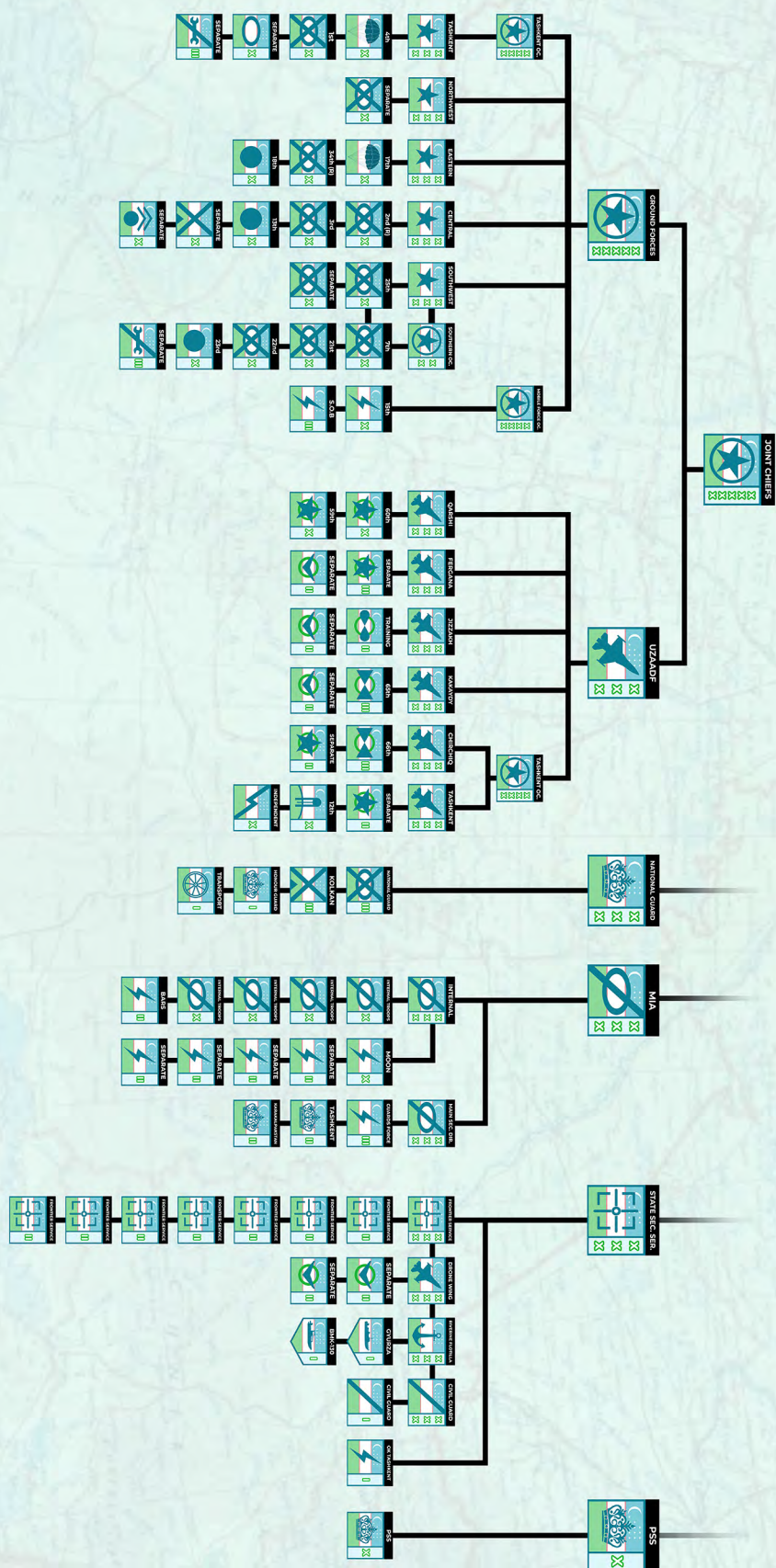
UZAADF		LOCATION
	59th Separate Mixed Aviation Brigade	Qarshi
	60th Separate Mixed Aviation Brigade	Qarshi
	65th Separate Helicopter Regiment	Kakaydy
	66th Separate Helicopter Regiment	Chirchiq
	Separate Mixed Aviation Regiment	Fergana
	Separate Mixed Aviation Squadron	Chirchiq
	Separate Mixed Aviation Squadron	Tashkent
	Separate Drone Wing	Fergana
	Separate Drone Wing	Kakaydy
	Higher Military Aviation School Training Squadron	Jizzakh
	12th Anti-Aircraft Rocket Brigade	Tashkent

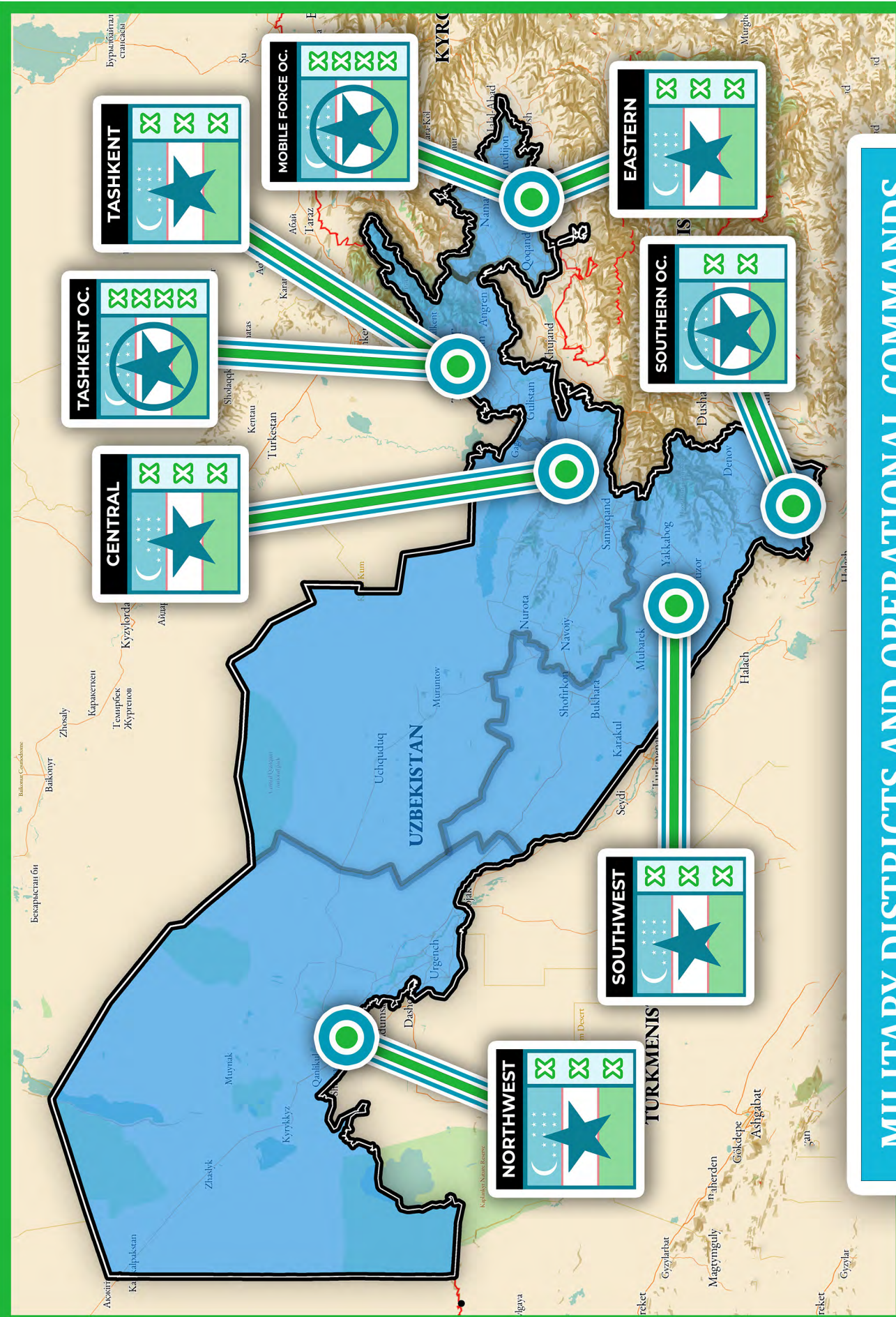
(** = Location acquired from only one source)

	Independent Radio-Technical Brigade	Tashkent**
---	--	-------------------

*(** = Location acquired from only one source)*

UZBEKISTAN'S ORDER OF BATTLE





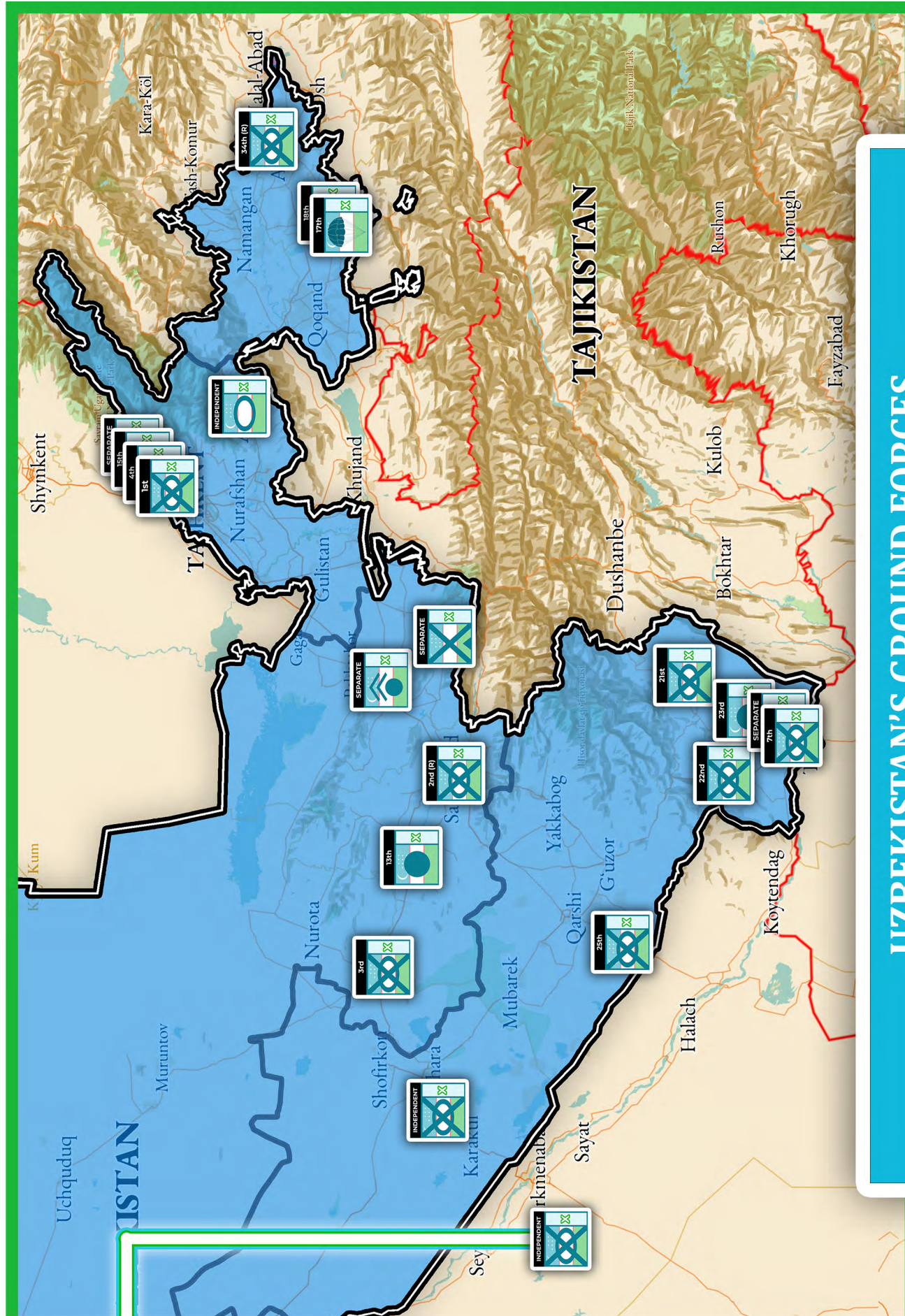
MILITARY DISTRICTS AND OPERATIONAL COMMANDS

The map displays the borders of Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, and Kyrgyzstan. Key cities and regions labeled include:

- Uzbekistan:** Uchquduq, Murotov, Nurota, Navoiy, Shofirkon, Bukhara, Karakul, Seydi, Turkmenab, Sayat, Halach, Koykendag, Yakkabog, Samargand, Gulistan, Angren, Namangan, Andijon, Lailabad, Kara-kol, Talas, Shymkent, Chirchiq, Tashkent, Jizzakh, Qashqadaryo, Qashqadaryo, Qashqadaryo.
- Tajikistan:** Dushanbe, Bokhar, Kulob, Khuson, Khojurg, Fayzabad.
- Kyrgyzstan:** Bishkek, Issyk-Kul, Naryn, Cholpon-Ata, Issyk-Kul, Naryn, Cholpon-Ata.

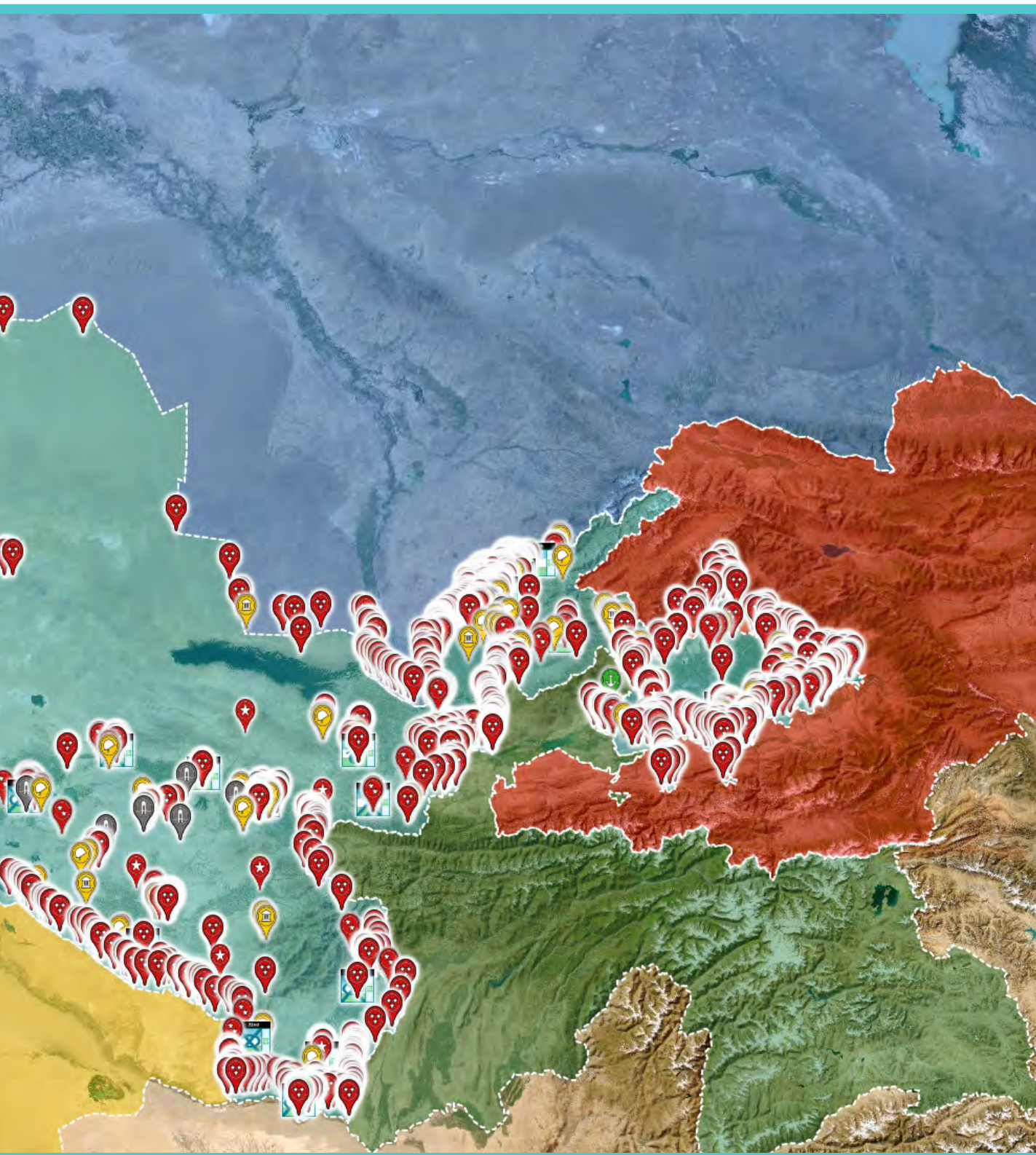
The map also shows the Caspian Sea to the west and the Aral Sea to the east. The borders of Russia are visible to the north and east.

UZBEKISTAN'S GROUND FORCES





MILITARY LOCATIONS VISIT G/VIZ/MILITARY-UNITS





**THE OXUS SOCIETY FOR
CENTRAL ASIAN AFFAIRS**



THE ARMED FORCES OF CENTRAL ASIA

CHAPTER III: KYRGYZSTAN



III: KYRGYZSTAN

THE ARMED FORCES OF CENTRAL ASIA:

CHAPTER III: *KYRGYZSTAN*

COMING SOON

APPENDIX

SECTION 1: GLOSSARY

ABBREVIATION	BREAKOUT OF TERM	EXPLANATION
A2AD	Anti-Access/Area Denial	Strategies and technologies preventing or limiting enemy access to critical areas.
APC	Armoured Personnel Carrier	Armoured vehicle used to carry infantry into battle but without offensive capability.
ATGM	Anti-Tank Guided Missile	A precision-guided weapon designed to destroy armoured vehicles and fortifications, offering enhanced lethality and range compared to unguided anti-tank weapons.
BCM	Billion Cubic Meters	Standard unit for measuring large natural gas volumes.
BTR	Brontransportyer	Brontransportyer, acronym comes from Russian for armoured personnel carrier
CACGP	Central Asia–China Gas Pipeline	Major pipeline network exporting Central Asian gas to China.
CADRE	Cadre	A core group of trained military personnel responsible for forming and leading units during expansion.

CAS	Close Air Support	Aircraft delivering precise air strikes in close proximity to friendly ground forces.
CBRN	Chemical, Biological, Radiological, Nuclear	Hazardous materials or weapons requiring specialised protective and response measures.
CCTS	Close Combat Training Simulation	Advanced virtual training systems that replicate battlefield conditions.
CIS	The Commonwealth of Independent States	A regional organisation formed by former Soviet Republics to facilitate cooperation in political, economic, and security matters post-USSR dissolution.
COGS	The Chief of the General Staff	The highest-ranking military officer in the armed forces, responsible for overseeing military operations, strategic planning, and the overall command and control of the military forces.
CRDF	Collective Rapid Deployment Forces	Selected forces of the CSTO that contribute to alliance missions and participate in multilateral training; units are relatively well trained and equipped by their respective nations.
CST	The Collective Security Treaty	Is a defence pact among several former Soviet Republics, including Uzbekistan, aimed at mutual defence and regional stability, operating under the framework of the Collective Security Treaty Organization (CSTO).

CSTO	Collective Security Treaty Organisation	Russia-led military alliance including Armenia, Belarus Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Russia, and Tajikistan; Armenia has suspended participation
C2	Command and Control	The authority and capability to direct military forces in the execution of missions.
DCR	Daily Rate of Consumption	The average amount of resources used by military units per day during operations.
DSR	Daily Rate of Supply	The average amount of resources provided to military units per day to sustain operations.
EEU	Eurasian Economic Union	A regional economic integration organization comprising several Post-Soviet states for economic cooperation.
EKT	Electronic Switching Centre	A system managing automated, high-capacity communications switching in military networks.
EUR	The Euro (Currency)	The official currency of the Eurozone, used by 20 of the 27 European Union countries.
FDI	Foreign Direct Investment	Overseas entities investing directly in a country's defence or strategic industries.
GBAO	Gorno-Badakhshan Autonomous Oblast	A strategically significant, mountainous region in eastern Tajikistan.

GDCD	The General Directorate of Civil Defence and Rescue	Turkmen emergency agency responsible for civil defence, disaster response, and rescue operations.
GDP	Gross Domestic Product	Measures the total economic output of a country, indicating its economic health and capacity to fund defense expenditures.
GWOT	Global War on Terror	Refers to international military operations targeting terrorist networks and state-sponsored terrorism post-9/11.
IED	Improvised Explosive Device	A makeshift bomb used by insurgents, often triggered remotely, for asymmetrical warfare.
IFV	Infantry Fighting Vehicle	Armoured troop transport that is able to fight in the field.
IMU	Islamic Movement of Uzbekistan	Militant Islamist organisation from Uzbekistan, historically linked to insurgency, terrorism, and regional destabilisation.
IMV	Infantry Mobility Vehicle	An armoured vehicle designed to transport infantry troops safely across various terrains.
IRPT	Islamic Renaissance Party of Tajikistan	A banned political party formerly advocating Islamic governance in Tajikistan.
ISIL	The Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant	A militant extremist group aiming to establish a caliphate, posing significant regional and global security threats.

ISKP	The Islamic State Khorasan Province	A regional affiliate of ISIL, operating in central and south asia, involved in terrorism and insurgency.
ITT	The Internal Troops of Tajikistan / Turkmenistan	The main MIA-controlled gendarmerie force, providing internal security, riot control, and critical site protection.
JOC	Joint-Operational Command	Temporary multi-service headquarters coordinating joint planning, command, and control of combined operations.
JRADS	The Joint Regional Air Defence System of the CSTO	The Joint Air Defence System of the CSTO coordinates member states' air defense capabilities.
KBS	The Kazakh Border Service	National security force guarding borders, managing checkpoints, and countering cross-border crime and threats, commanded by the NSC within Kazakhstan
KGADF	The Kyrgyz Air Defence Force	Kyrgyzstan's air and air-defence branch, providing air policing, surveillance, and integrated missile defence.
KGNG	The Kyrgyz National Guard	A Branch of the Kyrgyz Armed Forces operating under the MOD.
KGF	The Kazakh / Kyrgyz Ground Forces	Primary land warfare branches in Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan, conducting manoeuvre, defence, and readiness operations.
KNSC	The Kazakh National Security Council	Kazakhstan's principal intelligence and security service, responsible for counterintelligence and internal security.
KNV	The Kazakh Naval Forces	Caspian-based MOD naval branch defending Kazakhstan's maritime flank and offshore energy infrastructure.

KZADF	The Kazakh Air Defence Force	Kazakhstan's air and air-defence branch, providing air policing, surveillance, and integrated missile defence.
KZNG	The Kazakh National Guard	The MIA-controlled internal security force conducting public order, facility security, and rapid response operations.
MBT	Main Battle Tank	A heavily armoured and armed combat vehicle designed for front-line engagements.
MES	The Ministry of Emergency Situations	Is responsible for disaster response, civil defence, and emergency management in Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Uzbekistan and Tajikistan.
MIA	Ministry of Internal Affairs	Government ministry overseeing policing, internal security forces, public order, and law enforcement, across all five republics.
MD	Military District	A regional command structure responsible for the administration, training, and operational readiness of military forces within a specific geographic area.
MLRS	Multiple Launch Rocket System	Military unit capable of long-range massed rocket fire.
MMRB	Mountain Motor Rifle Brigade	Specialised motorised infantry for mountainous terrain and operations.
MNS	The Ministry of National Security	Turkmenistan's main state security and intelligence service, responsible for counterintelligence and internal control.

MNT	Mountain Rifle Brigade	Infantry unit trained for mountainous warfare operations.
MOD	Ministry Of Defence	Government department in charge of the armed forces; the defence minister is the most important defence official in peacetime.
MOU	Memorandum of Understanding	A formal agreement between parties outlining mutual commitments and cooperative actions without creating legally binding obligations.
MRAP	Mine-Resistant Ambush Protected Vehicle	Vehicle is designed to withstand improvised explosive device (IED) attacks and ambushes, enhancing troop safety in conflict zones.
MRB	Motorised (Or Motor) Rifle Brigade	Military unit of perhaps, very roughly, 1,000-4,000 personnel.
MRD	Motorised (Or Motor) Rifle Division	Military unit of perhaps, very roughly, 2,000 - 12,000 personnel.
MRR	Motorised (Or Motor) Rifle Regiment	Military unit of perhaps, very roughly 600 - 2,000 personnel.
M/U	Military Unit (B/Ч)	An organised group of soldiers structured for specific missions, varying in size and capability.
NCO	Non-Commissioned Officer	A military leader responsible for training, discipline, and management within enlisted ranks.
NSC	National Security Council	Senior advisory body coordinating national security policy, strategy, and interagency crisis decision-making.

OBLAST	Oblast	An administrative region in certain post-Soviet states, often with significant autonomy and governance structures.
OBOR	One Belt, One Road	China's strategic initiative for global infrastructure development and economic integration.
OMON	Otryad Mobilnyy (Or Militsii) Osobogo Naznacheniya	Police special purpose mobile detachment that fills an anti-riot or rapid response function, somewhat akin to American SWAT capabilities, acronym comes from Russian; sometimes also referred to as Spetsialnyy Otryad Bystrogo Reagirovaniya (SOBR) .
OPC	Operational Command	Responsible for planning, directing, and executing military operations within a specified theater or mission.
OTS	The Organisation of Turkic States	An IGO promoting cooperation among Turkic-speaking countries in various sectors, including defence.
PAP	The People's Armed Police	A Chinese paramilitary force focused on internal security, counterterrorism, and disaster response.
PAP	The People's Armed Police	A Chinese paramilitary force focused on internal security, counterterrorism, and disaster response.
PBF	Patrol Boat Fast	Small, fast patrol boat used for riverine or coastal security and interdiction.

PBFG	Patrol Boat Fast, with Guided Missiles	Fast patrol boat armed with guided missiles for maritime interdiction.
PCGM	Patrol Craft, with Guided Missiles	Patrol boat armed with guided missiles for maritime interdiction.
PDPT	People's Democratic Party of Tajikistan	The ruling political party in Tajikistan, dominating national governance and policy.
PLA	People's Liberation Army	China's armed forces, encompassing land, sea, and air capabilities.
PMC	Private Military Contractor	Mercenary troops that maintain a thin veneer separating themselves from official government forces.
PRC	The People's Republic of China	The official name for the Chinese state led by Beijing
PSC	Private Security Contractor	Firms providing armed and unarmed security services globally.
PSS	Presidential Security Service	Responsible for ensuring the protection and security of Uzbekistan's president and other high-ranking officials.
RATS	Regional Anti-Terrorism Structure	Organ of the SCO tasked with coordinating counterterrorism efforts across member states; can also serve as a tool of transnational repression for its participating states

ROE	Rules of Engagement	Rules of engagement defining authorised use of force, escalation thresholds, and tactical constraints.
RMB	The Renminbi	Official currency of China, also known as the Yuan (CNY).
RUB	The Ruble	The official currency of Russia.
RWS	Remote Weapons System	Weapon mount operated remotely, enabling protected, stabilised aiming and engagement from cover.
SAG	Surface Action Group	Naval task group centred on surface combatants, conducting sea control and strike missions.
SAM	Surface-to-Air Missile	A guided missile designed to be launched from the ground to destroy aircraft or other aerial targets.
SARH	Semi-Active Radar Homing	A Missile guidance system that relies on radar signals reflected from the target.
SBGS	State Border Guard Service	SCNS-controlled Kyrgyz border force securing frontiers, checkpoints, and countering cross-border threats.

SBS	State Border Service	Turkmenistan's border service guarding land borders and coastline, controlling checkpoints, and countering smuggling.
SCDA	State Committee for Defence Affairs	The former Kyrgyz defence ministry-equivalent overseeing armed forces policy, procurement, and strategic planning functions, before being disbanded by the Japarov administration.
SCNS	The State Committee for National Security	The national intelligence agency handling counterintelligence, counterterrorism, and national security threats in Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan.
SCO	Shanghai Cooperation Organisation	A Eurasian political, economic, and international security organisation established by China
SRB	Special Reconnaissance Battalion	Conducts covert intelligence gathering, surveillance, and target acquisition behind enemy lines.
SSPB	Separate Special Purpose Battalion	An elite military unit focused on specialised missions, including counterterrorism and unconventional warfare.
SSS	The Uzbek State Security Service	Uzbekistan's primary intelligence agency, handling counterintelligence, counterterrorism, and national security operations.
S2S	Surface-to-Surface	Surface-to-surface: weapons or fires delivered from land/sea platforms against ground targets.
TBS	Tajik Border Service	The SCNS-controlled Tajik border force securing frontiers, checkpoints, and countering infiltration and smuggling.

TCM	Thousands of Cubic Meters	Standard unit for measuring large natural gas volumes.
TDZ	Territorial Defence Zone	A designated area for organizing local defence, utilizing reserve forces and civilian resources for security.
TECHNICALS	Technicals	Civilian vehicles modified with mounted weapons, used for military and paramilitary operations.
TGF	Tajik / Turkmen Ground Forces	Primary land combat branches in Tajikistan and Turkmenistan, responsible for territorial defence and manoeuvre.
TJAADF	The Tajik Air and Air Defence Forces	Tajikistan's air and air-defence branch, providing air policing, surveillance, and integrated missile defence.
TMAADF	The Turkmen Air and Air Defence Forces	Turkmenistan's air and air-defence branch, providing air policing, surveillance, and integrated missile defence.
TMIT	The Turkmen Internal Troops	MIA-controlled gendarmerie force providing internal security, riot control, and key facility protection.
TNG	The Tajik National Guard	An elite force tasked with protecting the president, key state facilities, and maintaining internal security.
TNV	The Turkmen Naval Forces	Caspian-based MOD naval branch defending Turkmenistan's maritime flank and offshore energy infrastructure.
TPP	Tactical Planning Process	A structured approach used by military units to develop and implement mission-specific strategies and operations.

TTR	The Kazakh Territorial Troops	Reserve-oriented territorial defence force supporting mobilisation, rear-area security, and local infrastructure protection.
UAFB	The Uzbek-Afghan Friendship Bridge	The strategic bridge across the Amu Darya river linking Uzbekistan and Afghanistan.
UAV / UAS	Unmanned Aerial Vehicle / Unmanned Aerial System	Common term for uncrewed aircraft in previous decades; in recent years, terms such as drones have been popularised
UCG	The Uzbek Civil Guard	Paramilitary organization tasked with maintaining internal security, under the command of the UFS.
UFS	The Uzbek Frontier Service	Responsible for protecting and securing Uzbekistan's borders against illegal crossings and external threats., Under the command of the SSS.
UGF	The Uzbek Ground Forces	The primary land-based military branch, responsible for national defence, territorial control, and ground operations.
UIT	The Uzbek Internal Troops	An MIA-controlled gendarmerie force conducting internal security, riot control, and critical site protection.
UNMISS	United Nations Mission in South Sudan	Peacekeeping mission supporting stability, governance, and civilian protection in South Sudan
URF	The Uzbek Riverine Flotilla	The UFS-controlled river force patrolling waterways, securing crossings, and supporting border interdiction operations.

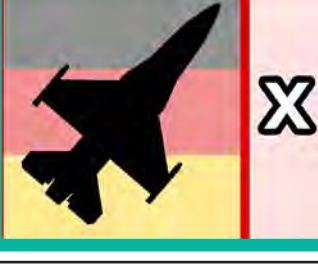
USD	United States Dollar	The state backed currency of the United States, and primary global reserve currency used in international trade and finance.
UTO	United Tajik Opposition	Was a coalition of anti-government forces in Tajikistan during the civil war, seeking political reform.

SECTION 2: SYMBOLOLOGY

SYMBOL	COUNTRY OF ORIGIN
4th 	KAZAKHSTAN
2nd (G) 	KYRGYZSTAN
1st 	UZBEKISTAN

1st 	TAJIKISTAN
11th 	TURKMENISTAN
131st 	RUSSIA
P.A.P. 	CHINA
ITFH 	INDIA

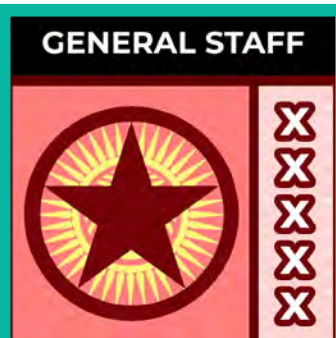
1st 	ABKHAZIA
AL-FATAH (209) 	AFGHANISTAN (UNDER THE TALIBAN)
12th 	ARMENIA
1st 	AZERBAIJAN
103rd 	BELARUS

CSTO 	CSTO
DUSHANBE 	FRANCE
11th 	GEORGIA
TERMEZ 	GERMANY
4th 	IRAN

GROUP D 	ISKP
PROTESTERS 	PROTESTORS
4th (G) 	SOUTH OSSETIA
MANAS 	THE UNITED STATES

SYMBOL

SIZE OF UNIT



“XXXXX”
MAJOR COMMAND
(EST: ~10,000 - 500,000+)



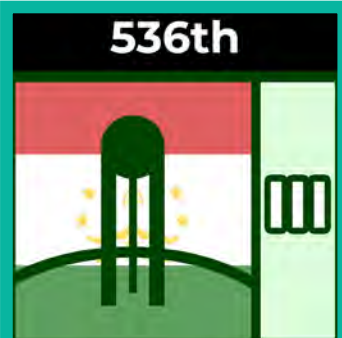
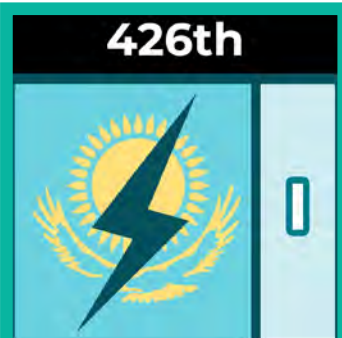
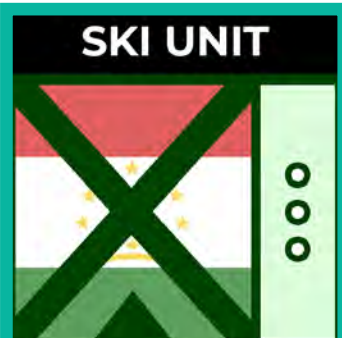
“XXXX”
ARMY/FRONT/COMMAND
(EST: ~5,000 - 300,000+)



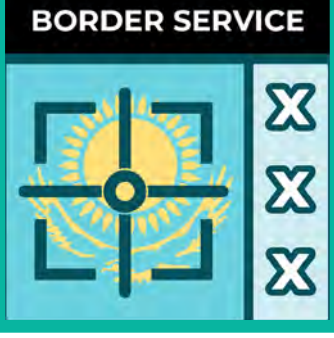
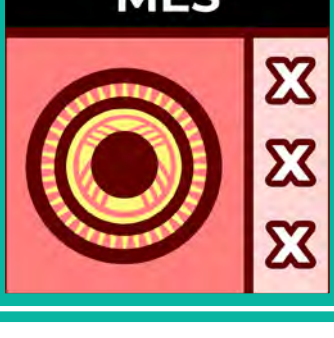
“XXX”
ARMY/BRANCH
(RUS: 30,000 - 50,000+)
(CA: ~ 5,000)



“XX”
DIVISION
(RUS: ~ 10,000 - 30,000)
(CA: ~ 2,500)

	“X” BRIGADE (RUS: ~ 2,000 - 8,000) (CA: ~ 1,500)
	“III” REGIMENT (RUS: ~ 900 - 2,000) (CA: ~ 500 - 1,000)
	“II” BATTALION (RUS: ~ 250 - 1,000) (CA: ~ 250)
	“I” COMPANY (RUS: ~ 50 - 200) (CA: ~ 100)
	“ooo” PLATOON (RUS: ~ 10 - 50) (CA: ~ 35)

	FORCE TYPES
	OPERATIONAL COMMAND
	GROUND FORCES COMMAND / MILITARY DISTRICT
	AIR COMMAND / AIRBASE
	NATIONAL GUARD / PSS / PRESIDENTIAL SECURITY UNITS

	INTERNAL FORCES
	SECURITY SERVICES / BORDER FORCES / FRONTIER FORCES
	RIVERINE FLOTILLA / NAVAL PATROL
	CIVIL GUARD / RESERVE UNITS
	EMERGENCY SITUATIONS COMMAND / UNITS

GROUND / MOD / PARAMILITARY FORCES

SEPARATE



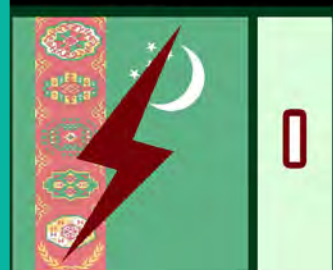
MOTOR RIFLE UNIT

1st



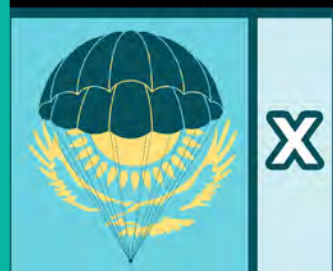
**MOUNTAIN
MOTOR RIFLE UNIT**

OMON

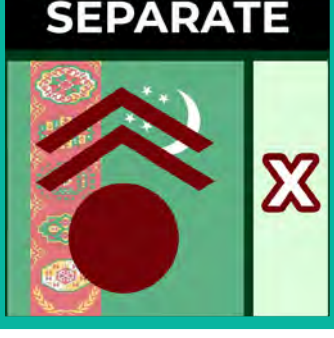
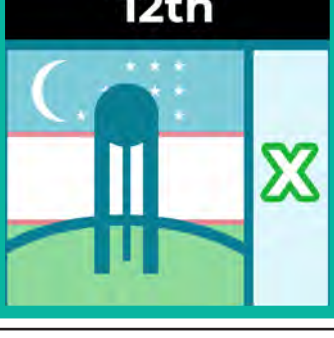
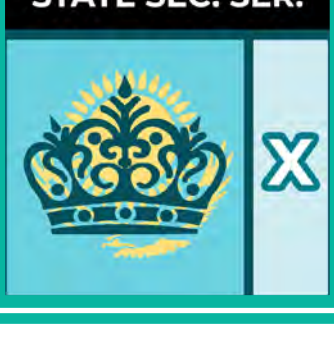


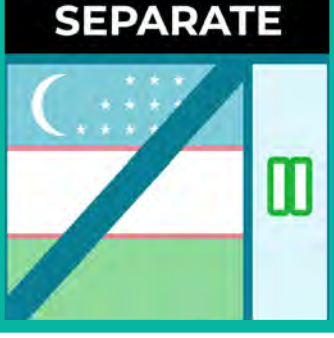
**SPECIAL FORCES / RECON
RAPID REACTION UNIT**

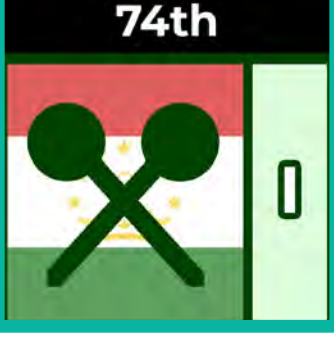
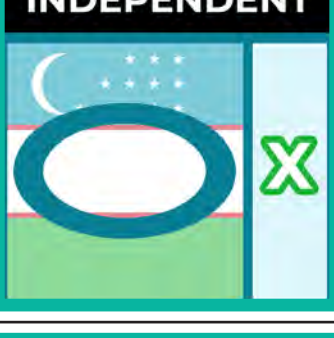
38th

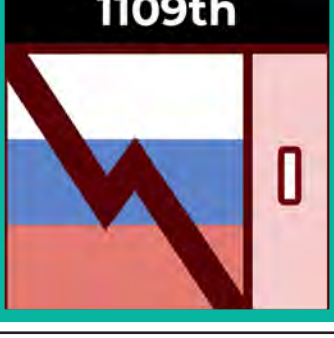
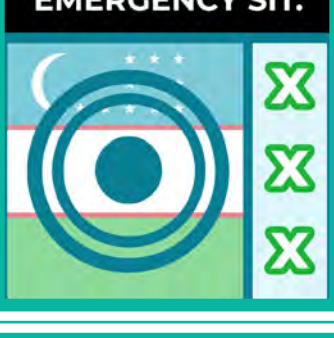


**AIRMOBILE /
AIRBORNE /
AIR ASSAULT UNIT**

	MOUNTAIN RIFLE UNIT
	ARTILLERY UNIT
	MLRS / ROCKET FORCES UNIT
	ANTI-AIR MISSILE UNIT
	CEREMONIAL / PRESIDENTIAL GUARD / NATIONAL GUARD UNIT

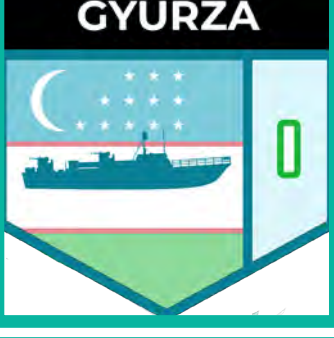
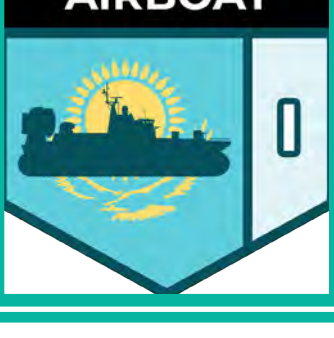
 44th The flag features a red field with a yellow sunburst in the center, crossed by a black diagonal line. A black wrench is positioned horizontally across the sunburst. To the right of the main field is a white vertical stripe with two black rectangles.	ENGINEERING / RADIO-TECHNICAL / SAPPER UNIT
 SEPARATE The flag features a light blue field with a white crescent and star in the upper left corner. A diagonal blue stripe runs from the bottom left to the top right. To the right of the main field is a white vertical stripe with two green rectangles.	LIGHTLY ARMED UNIT / MILITIA / CIVIL DEFENCE / RESERVE UNIT
 COAST GUARD The flag features a light blue field with a black anchor in the center, surrounded by a yellow sunburst. To the right of the main field is a white vertical stripe with two blue rectangles.	RIVERINE FLOTILLA / NAVAL PATROL UNIT
 B/4 - 6592 The flag features a green field with a white sunburst in the center, crossed by a green diagonal line. A green 'X' is positioned to the right of the main field. To the right of the main field is a white vertical stripe with a green 'X'.	INTERNAL FORCES UNIT
 B/4 - 2025 The flag features a red field with a yellow sunburst in the center, crossed by a black diagonal line. A black crosshair is positioned over the sunburst. To the right of the main field is a white vertical stripe with a black rectangle.	SECURITY SERVICES / FRONTIER FORCES UNIT

	HOSPITAL / MEDICAL UNIT
	CHEMICAL / BIOLOGICAL / RADIOLOGICAL AND NUCLEAR (CRBN) UNIT
	INFANTRY UNIT
	TANK / ARMoured / MECHANISED UNIT
	TRANSPORTATION / LOGISTICS / AGRICULTURAL UNIT

	MARINE INFANTRY UNIT
	ANTI-TANK UNIT
	SIGNALS / RADAR COMMUNICATIONS UNIT
	EMERGENCY SERVICES UNIT
	SPACE FORCES UNIT

	AIR UNITS
SEPARATE 	MIXED AIRWING (ROTARY AND FIXED WING)
TRAINING 	FIXED WING UNIT
INDEPENDENT 	ROTARY WING UNIT
DRONES 	DRONE UNIT

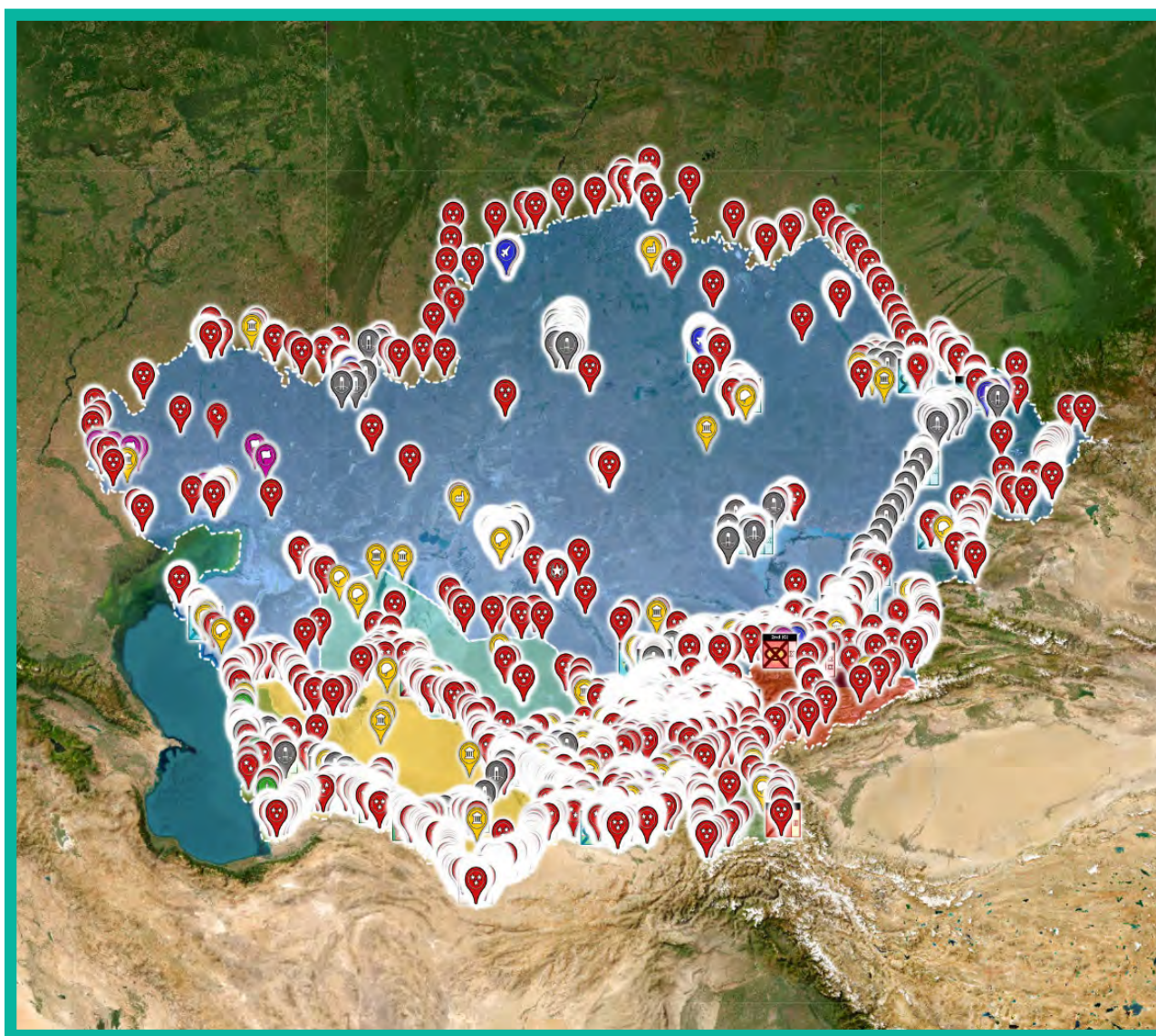
	NAVAL UNITS
 The emblem for the Moskva-class missile cruiser features a black silhouette of the ship on a blue sea, set against a white background. The emblem is divided into three horizontal bands: white at the top, blue in the middle, and red at the bottom. A large white 'X' is on the right side.	GUIDED MISSILE CRUISER
 The emblem for a frigate features a black silhouette of the ship on a blue sea, set against a white background. The emblem is divided into three horizontal bands: white at the top, blue in the middle, and red at the bottom. Three white vertical bars are on the right side.	FRIGATE
 The emblem for a Kilo-class submarine features a black silhouette of the submarine on a blue sea, set against a white background. The emblem is divided into three horizontal bands: white at the top, blue in the middle, and red at the bottom. Three white vertical bars are on the right side.	SUBMARINE
 The emblem for a corvette features a black silhouette of the ship on a blue sea, set against a white background. The emblem is divided into three horizontal bands: white at the top, blue in the middle, and red at the bottom. A crescent moon and stars are on the right side.	CORVETTE

	MISSILE BOAT
	PATROL BOAT
	COASTAL DEFENCE / RIVERINE PATROL
	FAST ATTACK BOAT
	AIRBOAT

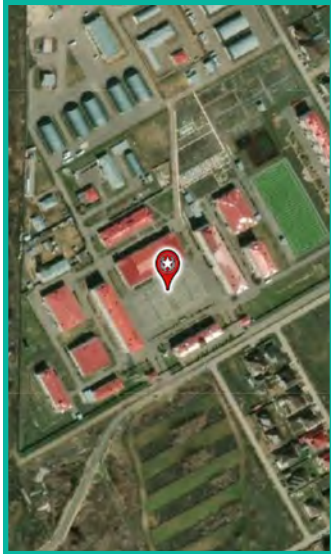
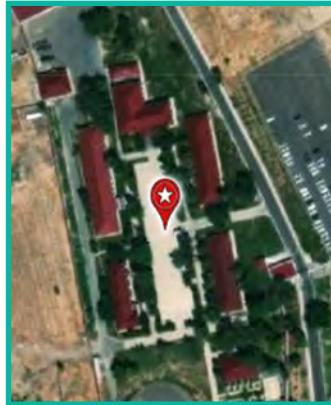
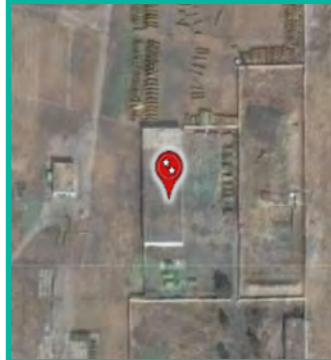
	MINESWEEPER
	AMBULANCE / HOSPITAL SHIP
	LANDING CRAFT

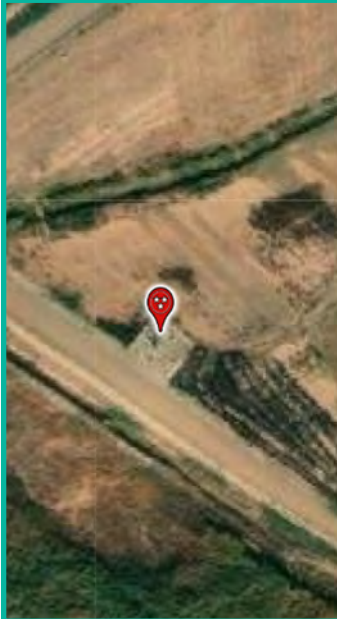
SECTION 3: MAP GUIDE

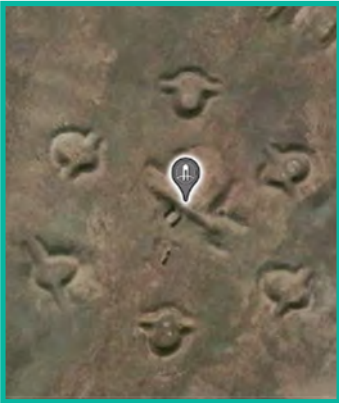
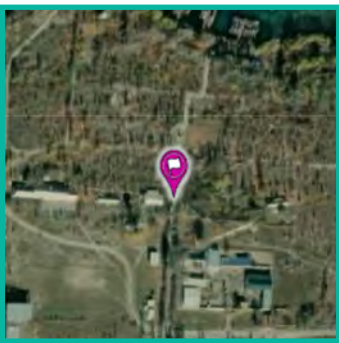
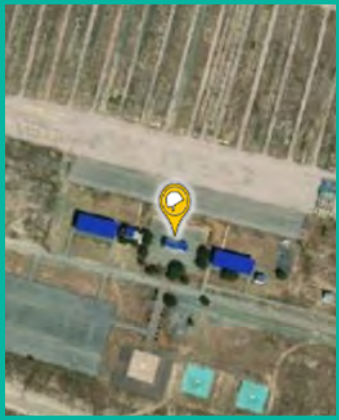
As part of this project's mapping initiative, more than 5,000 military and security installations across the region have been geolocated and integrated into the Oxus Society's Military Units & Tracker Map, accessible via this link. The following annexe section serves as a legend and explanatory guide to assist in interpreting the map's pin and marker system. While the classification schema aims to maintain a consistent regional framework, certain designations and descriptions have been adapted to reflect each nation's specific organisational structures, relative force composition, and operational realities unique to each nation's armed forces.

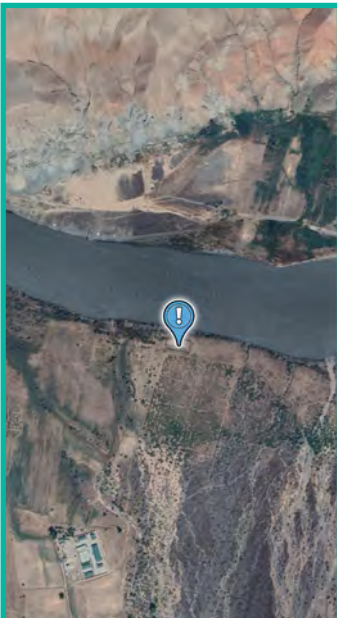


*(Figure A.3.1: A screenshot of The Oxus Society's Military Units Map
Available at this link: <https://oxussociety.org/viz/military-units/>)*

ICON	CATEGORY	DESCRIPTION	EXAMPLE
	Core Base (Brigade)	Core Bases represent the principal installations associated with each country's Ministry of Defence controlled formations. In most cases, entries in this category are limited to major formations at the brigade level and above.	
	Major Base (Large)	Major Bases refer to large military installations typically hosting formations at the regimental or brigade level and above. However, some entries may fall slightly below this threshold or belong to branches of the armed forces operating outside the direct control of the Ministry of Defence. These sites are generally characterised by their substantial infrastructure footprint, often including more than six to eight parade grounds, and serve as key operational or administrative hubs within their respective commands.	
	Standard Base (Medium)	Standard Bases typically host formations at approximately the battalion level and are generally large enough to operate as independent installations. This category is reserved for sites of notable operational or administrative importance within the national force structure, and as a general guideline, usually contain roughly three to eight drill boxes.	
	Forward Base (Small)	Forward Bases typically host formations at the company or detachment level. These facilities generally operate independently but remain relatively small in scale, often serving as outposts or forward operating positions. As a general indicator, Forward Bases usually feature between one and three drill boxes.	

	Outpost / Support (Minor)	Outpost and Support Pins serve as a broad catch-all category for the smallest installations. They account for more than half of all mapped sites and are primarily included to provide completeness of the data, while also allowing users to easily filter out non-essential locations when needed. These entries generally consist of minor administrative facilities, small outposts, forward operating positions, watchtowers, motor pools, and other limited support structures, sites roughly considered important enough to be mapped, but not necessarily significant enough to warrant detailed analysis.	
	Air Defence Site	Air Defence Site pins are used to denote active air defence positions, primarily missile batteries and related firing units. To maintain the clarity and usability of the map, this category is limited strictly to the active battery sites themselves. The broader air defence infrastructure, such as support units, bases, and garrisons, is instead marked using the standard red pin classification, so as to ensure that the distribution of active air defence batteries remains clear and immediately interpretable by the user.	
	Airbase	Much like the Air Defence pins, Air Base pins are restricted to marking the locations of the air bases themselves. Associated support units, air wings, and adjacent infrastructure are represented using standard red pins to preserve overall map clarity and readability. In addition to dedicated military airfields, this category also includes select civilian airports that are regularly utilised by military aircraft or dual-use operations	

	Former Air-Defence Site	Former Air Defence Site pins are fairly straightforward, marking the locations of decommissioned air defence batteries, most of which date back to the Soviet period. These sites allow users to toggle between active and former air defence positions, providing a clearer picture of the historical distribution and subsequent degradation of regional air defence infrastructure over time.	
	Foreign Base	Once again, this is a fairly straightforward category, representing bases operated by foreign actors. Each entry specifies which nation or organisation manages the site, along with details on whether the facility is operated solely by that actor or under a joint arrangement with local forces.	
	Industry	Industry Pins mark key facilities within each country's defence-industrial complex, including military production plants, tank factories, aircraft repair centres, and other major industrial installations supporting national defence capabilities. Each entry includes a brief description of the facility, the operating company, and details of its known production or maintenance activities.	
	Training Ground	Training Ground pins refer to both field training areas and academic institutions used for the education and preparation of military personnel. This category includes locations like live-fire ranges, tactical training centres, military schools, and academies where soldiers undergo professional development and advanced instruction.	

	Point of Interest / Admin	Points of Interest and Administrative Pins are grouped together due to their frequent overlap in relevance and function. This category includes key sites of strategic or planning significance for those examining regional defence or military strategy, such as presidential palaces, government compounds, or critical infrastructure highlighted in the report (e.g., the Qamchiq Tunnel). Administrative sites typically refer to headquarters and planning offices that play an important role in national defence management but do not host active military equipment, instead serving primarily administrative or command functions.	
	Naval Location	Naval Locations, much like Air Base pins, mark installations used by each country's naval or maritime forces. These facilities may function as dedicated military naval bases or serve as dual-use ports shared with civilian operations.	
	Breaking News	The breaking news pin does not appear on the standard public maps, as it is a specialised feature available only to users who have subscribed to that option. This service is added to private maps and geolocates military and security incidents across the region in near real time. As incidents emerge, members of the AFOCA team provide initial insight and analysis as the situation unfolds, then update the associated pin with links, confirmations, and further specialised analysis as additional information becomes available, enabling your team to view developments directly within their private map login.	

SECTION 4: WARGAME OUTCOME SCALE

Throughout this report, we have conducted several war games and assessed the likely outcomes of each scenario, or course of action taken by the government in focus. These outcomes have been assessed through a combination of key-indicator scoring, expert analysis, and predetermined parameters, and then simplified onto a scale ranging from total victory to total defeat for the country of focus. The purpose of this scale is to indicate whether an operation, taken as a whole, can be considered successful, and to apply a uniform reference point that allows audiences to compare and contrast outcomes across different nations and operations within the report. While these ratings are in no way definitive, they help simplify our overall assessment of the potential for victory in each case. To clarify where outcomes sit on that scale, the rating framework below sets out the principal parameters that shape each assessment, and is intended as a reference guide when interpreting results across the scenarios examined in this report.

	(+5) Total Victory	• The opposing force is totally demilitarised, and friendly forces exercise unchallenged control over the entire theatre of operations and airspace. • The enemy state accepts an unconditional surrender, with its existing government dismantled or entirely subordinated. • Neighbouring states and neutral powers rapidly align with the victor, and long-term regional security architectures are rewritten to favour friendly interests. • The victor gains control over the enemy's economic engines (e.g., energy sectors, ports), securing decades of economic advantage. • The historical narrative of the conflict is successfully dictated by the victor, and international bodies validate the intervention as "just" and necessary. • Domestic support for the war is nearly universal, and the current administration secures a large positive boost in domestic public opinion.
	(+4) Decisive Victory	• Key military objectives are achieved with sufficient force that the enemy cannot mount a counter-offensive for the remainder of the campaign. • The defeat triggers immediate fracture within the enemy's political leadership, leading to coups, resignations, or civil unrest. • Victory forces compel the enemy to sign unfavourable trade or transit agreements (e.g., ceding control of pipeline routes) to ensure their survival. • Domestic support for the war effort remains high, and the current administration secures a large positive boost in domestic public opinion.
	(+3) Major Victory	• Primary military targets are secured, and enemy forces are pushed back significantly, even if they retain some cohesion in rear areas. • The enemy is forced to the negotiating table from a position of weakness, conceding major diplomatic points to preserve their remaining military. • Enemy strategic projects (e.g., joint gas ventures, foreign investment) are weakened due to instability. • Domestic dissent is suppressed by the scale of the victory, and the "rally 'round the flag" effect limits most political opposition. • Victory is declared, even if the gains are largely tactical and the enemy prevents the capture of wider strategic objectives.

	(+2) Tactical Victory	- Specific terrain or unit objectives are achieved, but the wider operational map remains largely unchanged. - The government gains a short-term media win, useful for passing immediate budgets or quieting minor dissent. - The victory prevents the enemy from gaining leverage but does not fundamentally alter the geopolitical balance. - In most cases, the international community treats the engagement as a standard border skirmish, with no need for sanction or intervention. - The victory is acknowledged but not celebrated, with the civilian population exhibiting a muted response, signalling a disconnect between the military outcome and the perceived national interest.
	(+1) Pyrrhic Victory	- The focus nation captures at least one subordinate or major objective, but casualty rates are likely disproportionate or unsustainable, rendering the unit or attacking force combat ineffective for near-term operations. - The methods used to achieve the victory likely trigger international condemnation and sanctions. - There is an increased risk that long-term strategic partners withdraw from joint ventures in both states due to “reputational damage”. - While some battles are won, and some territory may be ceded to the focus nation, the political fallout strengthens the enemy nation’s narrative of victimhood and increases its ability to recruit and attain foreign aid. - The victory is somewhat acknowledged but only mildly celebrated, due to the “cost-benefit” analysis of the war being far higher for the focus nation.
	(+0) Stalemate	- Neither side can achieve a major breakthrough, and operations often devolve into static artillery exchanges or skirmishing. - International mediators cease active efforts to resolve the conflict, and the fighting is quickly labelled a “frozen conflict”, deterring further foreign investment into the region. - Bilateral trade between the belligerents greatly shrinks or stops entirely. - Both governments face declining approval ratings as the population wearies of a war with no measurable progress. - In many cases, state budgets are increasingly consumed by maintaining a wartime footing, stripping funding from domestic infrastructure and social programmes and further increasing government unpopularity.
	(-1) Pyrrhic Defeat	- The enemy captures at least one major objective, but casualty rates in achieving this are likely disproportionate or unsustainable, rendering the unit or attacking force combat ineffective for near-term operations. - The methods used to achieve this victory likely trigger international condemnation and sanctions for the enemy. - There is an increased risk that long-term strategic partners withdraw from joint ventures in both states due to “reputational damage”. - While the focus nation loses some battles, and some territory may be ceded to the enemy, the political fallout strengthens the focus nation’s narrative of victimhood and increases its ability to recruit and attain foreign aid. - The defeat is acknowledged but somewhat celebrated, with the “cost-benefit” analysis of the war being far higher on the enemy side.
	(-2) Tactical Defeat	- Specific terrain or unit objectives are lost, but the wider operational map remains largely unchanged. - The defeat runs counter to official propaganda, forcing government spokespeople into defensive media postures. - The defeat grants the enemy leverage during negotiations, but does not fundamentally alter the wider geopolitical balance. - Private sector partners pause new initiatives pending a security review. - The campaign timeline is pushed back by weeks, allowing the enemy political opposition time to reorganise. - The defeat is acknowledged, with the civilian population exhibiting a muted response or mild levels of dissent with the government over poor management of the war.

	(-3) Major Defeat	• Friendly forces are in retreat across a broad front, with major units significantly degraded. • Junior partners in the alliance begin to withdraw forces or seek separate peace deals with the enemy. • The defeat signals weakness to others in the region, prompting opportunistic neighbours to violate trade agreements or impose tariffs. • Protests are likely to erupt, with demonstrators calling for the resignation of the military leadership or the cabinet. • The enemy gains the ability to threaten core economic hubs (e.g., capital cities, primary ports), driving capital flight. • Defeated forces are made to sign unfavourable trade or transit agreements to ensure their survival.
	(-4) Decisive Defeat	• The enemy captures some or most operational goals and maintains a dominant position on the battlefield. • The war outcome is likely to worsen for the focus nation, with only surrender terms remaining to be settled. • The government faces a significant risk of losing its parliamentary majority, facing a vote of no confidence, or a revolution or military coup that removes it from power, while state authority in peripheral regions begins to evaporate. • The currency often collapses, with joint projects being cancelled, and assets being seized by foreign partners to cover debts. • The outcome can result in a partial loss of sovereignty, with the state forced to accept humiliating peacekeepers or observers who dictate internal security policy.
	(-5) Total Defeat	• The focus state is forced to accept an unconditional surrender, with its existing government dismantled or entirely subordinated. • National territory is often permanently stripped, and in some cases the state is carved up into annexed territories or zones of control held by the victors. • National resources are directly expropriated by the enemy to pay for the war, plunging the focus country into an economic crisis. • National leadership is, in some cases, arrested and transferred to international courts, either by the victorious state or by members of the domestic populace seeking to punish the government for its failures during the war. • Domestic support for the war is near zero, and the current administration often resorts to major domestic crackdowns or flees to a friendly state. • The military requires a significant number of years to rebuild to a point where it can relaunch major coordinated offensives.

SECTION 5: REFERENCES

To purchase access to the full dataset, including figures, coordinates, references, customised maps and detailed equipment inventories, please visit the official website on the link below to submit an inquiry with the Oxus Society for Central Asian Affairs.

<https://oxussociety.org/projects/the-armed-forces-of-central-asia/purchase/>

Or email Michael Hilliard at michael.hilliard@oxussociety.org for more information.

© [2024] [Michael Hilliard] [The Oxus Society for Central Asian Affairs]. All rights reserved.
No part of this report may be reproduced or transmitted in any form or by any means,
electronic or mechanical, including photocopying, recording, or any information storage and
retrieval system, without permission in writing from the lead author Michael Hilliard.